



PALGRAVE STUDIES IN THE HISTORY
OF EXPERIENCE

Sources and Methods for the History of Experience

Edited by Reetta Eiranen
Riikka Miettinen · Raisa Maria Toivo



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Palgrave Studies in the History of Experience

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This series, a collaboration between Palgrave Macmillan and the Academy of Finland Centre of Excellence in the History of Experience (HEX) at Tampere University, will publish works on the histories of experience across historical time and global space. History of experience means, for the series, individual, social, and collective experiences as historically conditioned phenomena. 'Experience' refers here to a theoretically and methodologically conceptualized study of human experiences in the past, not to any study of 'authentic' or 'essentialist' experiences. More precisely, the series will offer a forum for the historical study of human experiencing, i.e. of the varying preconditions, factors, and possibilities shaping past experiences. Furthermore, the series will study the human institutions, communities, and the systems of belief, knowledge, and meaning as based on accumulated (and often conflicting) experiences.

The aim of the series is to deepen the methodology and conceptualization of the history of lived experiences, going beyond essentialism. As the series editors see it, the history of experience can provide a bridge between structures, ideology, and individual agency, which has been a difficult gap to close for historians and sociologists. The approach opens doors to see, study, and explain historical experiences as a social fact, which again offers new insights on society. Subjective experiences are seen as objectified into knowledge regimes, social order and divisions, institutions, and other structures, which, in turn, shape the experiences. The principle idea is to present a new approach, the history of experiences, as a way to establish the necessary connection between big and small history.

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Introduction: How to Study the History of Experience from Any Source Material

Reetta Eiranen , *Riikka Miettinen* ,
and *Raisa Maria Toivo* 

In recent years, the history of experience has become a burgeoning and vibrant field of study, one that sets out to comprehend the manifold roles and meanings of experience in history. Revisiting the concept of *experience* has opened up fresh insights into the dynamic interplay between the individual, community, society, and historical phenomena.¹ Moreover, the

¹ E.g., Annola, Lindberg, & Markkola 2023; Boddice & Hitzer 2022; Boddice & Smith 2020; *Digital Handbook of the History of Experience*; Haapala, Harjula, & Kokko 2024; Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022a; Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2025; Kivimäki 2019; Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021; Kivimäki & Toivo 2022. See also the other volumes in the book series *Palgrave Studies in the History of Experience*.

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concept appears in a growing number of titles of scholarly publications as well as theses and conference papers. This proliferation of interest in the history of experience calls for a volume that provides methodological tools for analysing experience in different types of historical sources.

This volume tackles the question of how to use historical sources to study and analyse the history of experience. What kinds of primary sources does the history of experience need, and how can sources that have previously been used for more traditional historical analyses be turned into sources for the history of experience? The chapters discuss the variety of primary source types that can be used in the history of experience, what we need to consider in order to use these source materials, and how it can be done. The collection introduces the practices and “making of” the history of experience to historians and scholars whose main expertise may lie elsewhere but who are interested in trying out or understanding what the history of experience means and what it can offer. Crucially, the book develops practical methodologies for the history of experience and offers hands-on tools and ideas for scholars and students who want to utilise the approaches and methods of the history of experience in their studies.

WHAT DO WE MEAN BY THE HISTORY OF EXPERIENCE?

It has been claimed that all history is the history of experience, because actions and events must be somehow experienced. To adopt that view would make it difficult to claim that the history of experience brings anything new to the field. Perhaps it would be more pertinent to say that any history *can* be a history of experience if the study and analysis of that experiencing is placed at its centre. That, then, is a choice of approach and focus that the scholar makes, rather than something that self-evidently arises from the sources or something that any history of a certain topic ontologically “must be”.

This choice, then, can be made in various ways. A fairly simplistic view of the possible choices would be to present them in three different strands, as in Fig. 1.1. In this understanding, experience in past societies and cultures is, first, the topic or subject of historical study, but second,

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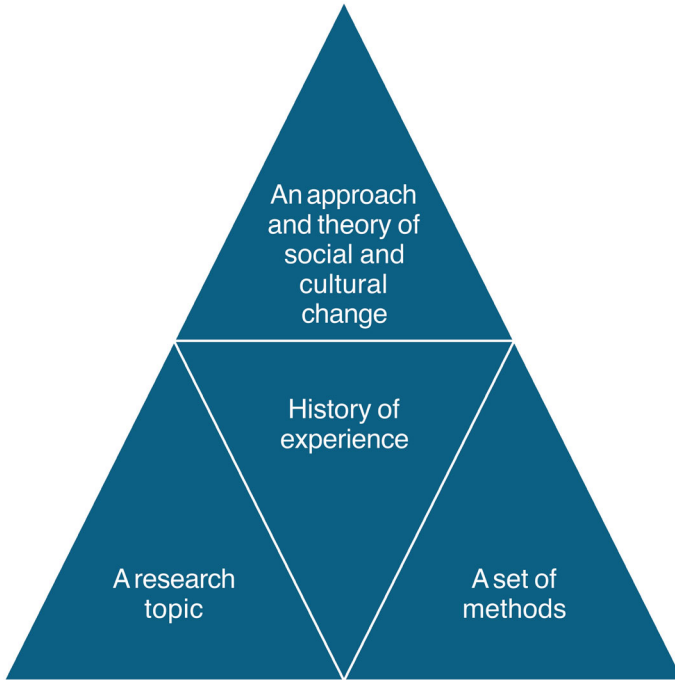


Fig. 1.1 Centring experience in historical research

it can also be an approach to history and a theory of how social, societal, and cultural change emerges and drives history. As a research topic, the historian could explore how some event or encounter—for example, a recession, a new diet, or commuting—was experienced by historical actors, examining its analytically separated although ultimately entangled dimensions (e.g., sensory, emotional, material), and how that experience is formed, or how the experience of something might change over time. The latter, the approach and theory, will be partly overlapping with the research topic, but will widen the scope—and thereby possibly also the impact—of the research. Third, (the history of) experience can be understood as a set of methods or tools that is adopted to discover new things either about past experiences or about the ways they have shaped societies or changed and driven further change across times and cultures. Without forgetting the first of these angles—self-evident as it is as a topic

for any discussion of the history of experience—this book emphasises the last two points, aiming to identify ways by which experiences can be not only traced and followed, but rather interrogated, questioned, put into context, and analysed in past sources, which, like most historians' sources, were not originally meant to benefit such endeavours.

Since many of the methods in one way or another derive from the definitions of the first two dimensions—the research topic and the approach/theory—it is pertinent to take a brief glance at them. As a research topic, the meaning of experience as a concept varies culturally. In the *Oxford English Dictionary*, the word *experience* is recorded as being used from the high medieval period onwards. It has connotations ranging from putting to the test, experimenting, and observing to proving by trial and learning by practice, and even religious conversion.² Many chapters in this volume use examples of source materials in the Swedish and Finnish languages, some in German or Latin. In these languages, the appropriate word for *experience* has rather similar connotations to the English word.³ The main difference is that English makes no conceptual distinction between mediated, socially shared experience and more simple, immediate, and often sensory encounters with the world. Swedish, Finnish, and German do make this distinction: Swedish and Finnish talk about *erfarenhet* and *kokemus*, respectively, when they mean experience as a processed, understood form of gathered knowledge. The meaning is roughly similar to the German *Erfahrung*. Swedish and Finnish have a different word, *upplevelse* and *elämys*, respectively, when talking about the more sensual and immediate experience, roughly corresponding to the German *Erlebnis*. These are, and have at least in these cultures historically been, overlapping concepts, and it may not always be fruitful to attempt to separate them from each other—both the bodily and the cognitive were always present, dynamically interacting with each other. On the other hand, French discussions on experience flow through the verb *vivre*, which denotes both to experience and experienced and to live or lived.⁴ Lived histories have been important in the recent wave of history

² *Oxford English Dictionary*: 'Noun: an experience; Verb: to experience.' <https://www.oed.com/>. See also Walsham 2025, 97–120.

³ *Svenska Akademiens Ordbook*: "erfara", "erfarenhet", and "förfara", "förfarenhet". *Svenska Akademiens Ordbook* www.saob.se. Ganander 1937–1938 [1787]: "kokemus". Kotus: <https://kaino.kotus.fi/vks>

⁴ Nagy & Biron-Ouellet 2020.

of experience, too, though the lived and the experienced should not be conflated.⁵ Given the current hegemony of the English language and Anglo-American culture, it is all the more important to bring forward and consider the conceptual finesse and rich variety that can be found in many other languages. Considering these differences can offer conceptual clarity also to English-language theoretical discussions. The languages used here serve as an example of cultural differences in experiencing and in expressing experience around the world and across time.

As an analytical category, experience encompasses three fundamentally inseparable stages that take place more or less concurrently: (1) ways in which individual people and communities encounter the world (experience as an event); (2) the simultaneous relational, intersubjective process of making sense of those encounters, gathering them to form knowledge, and testing one's understanding of them against one's own and other people's existing explanations (process of experiencing); and (3) the social and physical structures that are born from repeating the above processes as knowledge of the "real" world (structures of experience).⁶ (See Fig. 1.2).

The first category can be understood as the first level of experience in analytical usage, emphasising experience as individual interpretations of singular events. The "authenticity" and "immediacy" of these experiences have been questioned by other scholars, like Joan Scott. Feminist, postcolonial, and "new social history" historiography have argued that individual subjective experiences were ultimately little more than coincidental, chance stories, and their value as evidence suffered if they were not properly scrutinised in terms of their representativity as well as the type, context, convention, and origin of the production of these stories or descriptions in the source materials.⁷ This critique is taken into account in the next phases or levels of experience, the processes which in turn

⁵ Boddice & Smith 2020; Toivo 2025.

⁶ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo, 2022a and 2022b. See also Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021.

⁷ Scott 1991, 773–797; Lepedit 1995; Jones 1998, 383–394; Jay 2005; and a more recent retake by Hunt 2009 and finally by Scott herself in Hesford & Diedrich 2014. For fuller historiographical discussions from different perspectives, see Nagy & Biron-Ouellet 2022; Boddice & Smith 2020, 18–22 or Haapala & Markkola, 2017, 403–416. On the anthropology of experience, see Turner & Bruner 1986.

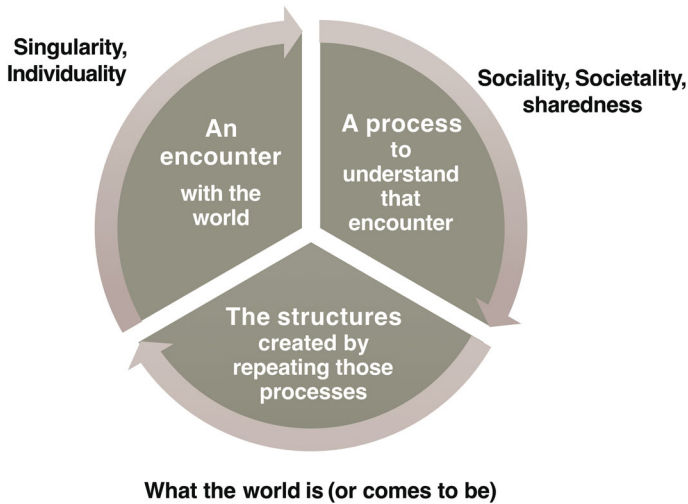


Fig. 1.2 Experience as an encounter, process, and structure (*source* Adapted from Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 11)

emphasise the communicational and interactive parts of creating experience, and the societal, cultural, and even physical norms and structures created by experience.

Experiencing—or meaning-making or meaning-construction (the process of experiencing)—is unavoidably a social process, as making sense of the world cannot happen in a vacuum. Previous norms and expectations of the prevailing culture offer models and frameworks (structures of experience) that shape how we experience situations, events, and other things, but they are also always re- and de-constructed by experience. Therefore, experiences change as society and culture change, and society and culture change as experiencing changes.⁸ They can, for example, create a welfare state, as took place in the Nordic countries after the Second World War, or they can lead into war, as happened after the Reformations in Europe. As experience creates and destroys structures in order to produce new experiences, it can even cause physical changes: the architecture of buildings and cities has for thousands of years followed

⁸ See also, e.g., Kane 2000, Hunt 2009, and Nagy & Biron-Ouellet 2020.

experiences of safety and danger, from ancient and medieval city walls to the requirements to widen streets and plant leafy trees to prevent the spread of fire in early modern towns, and the heightened need to handle rainwater and heat in modern cities. For the historian, always interested in explaining change and continuity, this ability of experiences to change, disrupt, and maintain societies, physical and natural environments, and perhaps even cosmologies, is crucial. It is easy to see that the connection described above exists—after all, humans seek to maintain and change their world according to what they learn to think is best, although they often end up doing so in very unpredictable ways. It would, however, be even better to be able to show how exactly this process takes place, even if it may sometimes seem that we can only grasp small parts of the process at one time. The point of this book is to suggest ways of analysing experience, and changes and continuities in it in different historical settings and source materials, although of course each researcher will always have to adapt the tools they adopt, discarding bits, inventing new ones, and finetuning the rest according to their questions and aims.

All this builds on social constructionism, positing that social reality and its phenomena, such as concepts, beliefs, norms, values, and experiences, are social constructs formed through interactions and deeply embedded in socio-cultural contexts. Perceptions of reality, including experiences, are outcomes of dynamic processes of construction influenced by structures and cultural norms. Social constructivist understandings of knowledge formation highlight how individuals create meaning through their interactions with others while interpreting their world through a subjective lens relative to their personal backgrounds but also based on internalised norms and cultural narratives and scripts.⁹ Existing structures, including norms, cultural narratives, and scripts, provide the framework for agency, making sense of the world and ascribing meanings to events and sensations—that is, experiencing. The sociological understanding about the dynamic interplay between structures and agency, or individuals,¹⁰ also allows room for change; experiences, like social practices, beliefs, and behaviours, can take “new” forms and transform when the existing models are challenged, and can institutionalise into new structures of experience. These views have inspired various theoretical approaches to

⁹ See, e.g., Berger & Luckmann 1966; Elder-Vass 2012; Vygotsky 1986 [1934].

¹⁰ E.g., Giddens 1984.

conceptualising experience and the process of experiencing across most fields of the humanities and social sciences.¹¹

CONCEPTS FOR THE HISTORY OF EXPERIENCE

As the history of experience has expanded as a research field, the conceptual work has advanced as well, largely influenced by, among others, the history of emotions, hermeneutics, conceptual history, sociology, and social anthropology. In the following, we present the key terms used and discussed in the chapters of this volume that are fruitful for the analysis of the history of experience.

Community of experience is a promising concept that ties into Barbara Rosenwein's emotional communities and Karl Mannheim's generational experience. As Kivimäki, Malinen, and Vuolanto have introduced the concept of community of experience, it refers to a group of people who recognise a shared experience, which can be sudden and transformative but also processual. The supposed sameness is negotiated by the people involved, and this process creates bonds and a sense of shared identification to some degree. As time passes, communities of experience may function as memory communities, which can entail inclusions and exclusions, a sense of unity, and also tensions. The concept shares the same premise with generational experience—something that is recognised by the group members themselves and is formative for the group. Then again, emotional community has been defined as a social group that shares certain norms, ideas, and preferences with regard to emotions and their expression, not necessarily consciously but as defined by the researcher.¹²

The originally phenomenological and hermeneutical concept of *horizon*, deriving from the tradition of German philosophy, has also

¹¹ E.g., phenomenological approaches have been influential in the conceptualisations of experience and experiencing, e.g., Carr 2014; Perttula 1995; Perttula & Latomaa 2008; Toikkanen & Virtanen 2018. For classics, e.g., Heidegger 1996 [1927]; Merleau-Ponty 2012 [1945].

¹² Kivimäki, Malinen & Vuolanto 2023. Cf. Mannheim 1928; Rosenwein 2010. From the field of the history of emotions, also William Reddy's discussion on the concept of 'emotive', drawing from J.L. Austin's speech act theory, is interesting for the history of experience. Emotive as self-exploratory and self-altering have parallels to the theoretisation on experience as constructed. See Reddy 2001, also Eiranen 2023. In addition, Monique Scheer aims at overcoming the dichotomy of inner experience and its outer expression through her concept of "emotional practices". See Scheer 2012.

inspired historians of experience. Phenomenologist Edmund Husserl introduced the concept of “intentional horizon”, meaning anticipation of future experience based on past experience.¹³ Hermeneutic philosopher Hans-Georg Gadamer theorised the concept of “horizon”, roughly meaning the scope of the possibility of what a person can in their current spatiotemporal situation understand or grasp in their reality. The horizon includes past experiences, with our prejudgement (*Vorurteil*), and the anticipation of the future, which affects how we interpret the present in our experience. Again, new experiences affect our horizon, moulding our prejudgement and affecting our interpretation of reality and experience. This is one form of the circle-like hermeneutical movement of interpretation.¹⁴

Historian Reinhart Koselleck introduced the concepts of “horizon of expectation” and “space of experience”. Also here Mannheim lingers in the background with his theorisation of horizons of expectation resting on assumptions of everyday social experiences. In this line of thought, the concepts have also been discussed in their reversed form as “horizon of experience” and “space of expectation”.¹⁵ In a way, the Gadamerian concept of horizon includes these aspects. It is the limit of understanding and experiencing for a spatiotemporal being, offering a framework or shared models for interpreting and giving meanings—that is, for experiencing.

Horizon of experience could be used to describe and interpret the framework of possible or available experiences in a given culture and situation, set by the existing structures of experience and the specific conditions such as the individual’s intersectional positions.¹⁶ In the history of experience, this tradition has inspired concepts like the *scene of experience*, highlighting the situational context of experience and its convergence with the socio-material environment and structures of society, and the temporal *layers of experience*, which relate to the horizon

¹³ Beyer 2022.

¹⁴ Gadamer 1990, 307–312; Tontti 2011, 60–66; Meretoja 2014, 146–147.

¹⁵ Koselleck 2004 [1979], 267–288; Pickering 2004.

¹⁶ For uses and definitions, see, e.g., Harjula & Kokko 2022; Kokko & Harjula 2024; Pickering 2004. Boddice & Smith 2020, esp. 29, 50–53 write about this as the context of possibilities for experience and as the framework of (possible) experience.

of experience and institutionalised structures of experience.¹⁷ The use of these concepts has a long history and multiple origins in, for example, consumer, game, and literature studies: it has also been suggested that the scene of experience is a mental, imagined construct already before the experience,¹⁸ one of the unconscious media of invention of the Freudian self within the shared and communal culture,¹⁹ and a part of the performative economies of experience where stereotypes and individualities are produced.²⁰ As historians often treat concepts and theories selectively, the use of the concepts when studying the history of experience will equally vary according to the purpose of the study at hand. In-depth contextualisation is of course key in understanding how experiences form and are shared. This includes taking into consideration the very specific situation and socio-cultural environment, including spatiality as a physical, material, bodily, and mental feature. *Space* and *scene of experience* serve as useful concepts to highlight also the situational spatiality of experiencing: how the specific material, physical, and mental environment entail elements that shape and even condition experiences.²¹

In narrative studies, experience has been a central concept since the 1990s. Nowadays, experientiality is seen as one of the key elements of the definition of *narrative*. Narrative grasps “what the world is like from the situated perspective of an experiencing mind”, as David Herman, a key theorist in contemporary narratology, has put it.²²

Different kinds of conceptualisations of self-narration have been used for approaching subjective aspects of experience. “Narrative self” refers to narration as constitutive for the self, even on the ontological level. The present self makes sense and imbues meaning to past experiences and future expectations. In this constant process of reinterpretation, new experiences are woven together with them into a comprehensible or at least hopefully bearable whole.²³ In oral history, studying the dynamics

¹⁷ Harjula & Kokko 2022; Kokko & Harjula 2023; Kokko & Harjula 2024.

¹⁸ Kelly 2008, 110–121.

¹⁹ Wilson 2015, 129–150.

²⁰ Boutaud 2019, 61–67.

²¹ See also Barclay 2017 and Kokko & Harjula 2024, from different theoretical perspectives.

²² Herman 2009, 157.

²³ See, e.g., Ricœur 1992; Meretoja 2014, 147–149; Eiranen 2023.

of remembering, narrated self refers to the time of the event that is being discussed and the narrating self to the time of the telling.²⁴

In addition, concepts like *cultural narrative*, *cultural script*, and *master narrative* have been influential and popular in trying to explain how cultural and social context and structures affect experience and how it is possible to share individual experience with others. Often, there is an overlap but also differences in how these concepts are defined in themselves and in relation to each other. Scholars of different fields tend to choose and nuance their concepts according to the traditions of their own fields. Traditionally, cultural script has been used to describe the culturally specific and (widely) shared but often unspoken knowledge and practices pertaining to recurring everyday situations that guide behaviour and thinking, while cultural narrative refers to a frequently repeated story, often passed down through generations, or an expected and sedimented way of interpreting certain events and experiences that individuals and a particular community use to create identity and convey and construct shared values, norms, experiences, and sets of beliefs.²⁵ Broadly speaking, all of these can be used for analysing how people tap into certain cultural resources in interpreting their situations—that is, experiencing—and in sharing their experiences with others. They are learnt and anticipated plots, expected norms and practices, and explanations derived from the available cultural “pool”. Prevalent, learnt, or otherwise adopted and commonly shared cultural narratives and scripts shape experiencing, forming patterns or “collective modes of experience” of how people undergo, conceptualise, and express something.²⁶ They also include a circular principle: the cultural resource—whichever of these concepts we decide to use—offers ways and models for constructing individual experience but, at the same time, the individual experiences and their saturation or tipping point have the power to alter the cultural

²⁴ See Malinen’s chapter in this book.

²⁵ E.g., Quinn & Holland 1987, 19–22; Meretoja 2017. See also Bruner 1991; Herman 1997, 2009; Eiranen, Hatavara, Kivimäki, Mäkelä, & Toivo 2022.

²⁶ As viewed, e.g., in anthropology, see Kleinman 1988; Kleinman & Good 1986; Turner & Bruner 1986. This understanding of experiences being heavily shaped by culture, including its symbols, narratives, and scripts, is integral to most classics in the field, e.g., Benedict 1935; Geertz 1973. There have also been various discourses on “collective emotions”, which have, for some, turned into studies of collective experience. See, e.g., Nagy & Biron-Ouellet 2020.

narrative/script. This speaks to the social constructivist ideas of how experiences and practices sediment into structures and how, in turn, the structures affect the ways people experience their lives.

There are also other important concepts continuously under development for use in the history of experience. As usual in history, most of the conceptual work is being done under the guise of what might be called the practical, empirical.²⁷ While the above seem to be general concepts that underlie this volume, the more specific discussions will emerge in the individual chapters that follow.

STRUCTURE AND CONTENTS OF THE BOOK

With a source-driven approach, this volume is structured around chapters that examine specific source “types” and their use in studying the history of experience. Some of these, such as egodocuments and life-writings, oral history sources, and court records, are in general commonly used primary sources in historical research, and they have relatively often been used in the history of experience. Others, like sermons, photographs, art, literary fiction, and statistics, have so far been more unconventional and less used in the study of historical experience.

All source types or genres discussed in the volume are pan-European and available concerning European history, with most available and used in historical research globally. Although this collection uses European materials as examples, the same methods and tools can be used to analyse sources beyond the Western world. The primary sources used as examples span from the Middle Ages to the 2000s. Certain sources, like interviews and photographs are, of course, only available from relatively recent periods. Alongside already existing historical documents, a historian working on experience can generate fruitful sources and datasets, especially concerning recent periods, as the chapters on memory-based sources and quantitative sources show.

Although the contents, styles, and formulations of one “source type” may change and vary across different periods and differ between geographical areas, there are nonetheless evident shared features: these

²⁷ Practical histories have been written by all of the authors of this volume, most of the authors cited in this volume, and many others, e.g., Eyice 2019; Eyice 2022; Lindblom 2025 and Runesson 2021.

are typically shaped by the specific purpose and aims of those generating the material. For example, sermons, letters, population statistics, and administrative documents, such as court records or institutional documents, have common characteristics based on the established genres and conventions of writing and recordkeeping. Grouping the heterogeneous historical materials together into “source types” is unavoidably a construction and abstraction, and most historians tend to mix and combine several types of sources in their studies in any case. However, the grouping is largely based on historiographical traditions and serves the reader by making it easy to find the relevant section.

Furthermore, the archival sources traditionally used in historical research are increasingly available in digital form. A growing number of historical sources also concerning premodern times are now published in printed form. Ultimately digitisation or other republishing does not significantly change their contents and use as sources for the history of experience, although digitisation opens up ways to use applicable computer-based and digital history methods, such as text mining.

The volume does not discuss all available historical materials. However, while taking into consideration the source criticism, approaches and methodology similar to those presented in the chapters are applicable to most other textual sources, such as newspapers, magazines, school textbooks, and very recent digitally created materials like social media entries. The volume does not include specific chapters on the use of historical objects or places as sources. However, in particular the chapters on art and photographs include discussions about the materiality and material elements of these sources as objects and how to open up fresh insights in using them as sources for the history of experience. Additionally, the chapter on administrative documents from enclosed or residential institutions highlights their informational value concerning socio-spatial practices and material surroundings, which can be fruitful for analysing the spatiality and materiality of experiencing.

The majority of the historical sources presented in this volume are textual, as is traditional in historical research. The basic historical methods of source criticism, contextualisation, close reading, qualitative content analysis, and other textual analysis methods are similarly essential in studying experience as a historical phenomenon.

Traditionally, first-person texts, such as diaries and personal letters, as well as many oral history sources, like interviews and memoirs, are considered fruitful source materials for studying experiences, in particular the

subjective or personal experiences of individuals. However, as the volume shows, nearly all historical materials, from administrative documents to literary fiction, art, and didactic sermons, unavoidably include information about experiencing—from past experiences of individuals to processes and structures of experience, or norms of meaning-making and what is conceived possible to experience.

The chapter by Reetta Eiranen and Sami Suodenjoki discusses egodocuments and life-writings and pays special attention to the “hybrid” nature of sources—that is, the conflation of the traditionally regarded categories of source types. The chapter addresses claims of authenticity, the experience of writing, the dynamic between privacy and publicity, the conflated temporality of the sources, and source narrativity. Empirical examples derive mostly from the nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Finnish *Bildungsbürgertum* and working class but include also samples from other European contexts.

The chapter by Antti Malinen deals with the creation and use of oral history sources from the viewpoint of the history of experience. It emphasises the interactive and dynamic nature of the process of constructing experience and memories in oral history interviews, where the researcher and the research setting has a constitutive role, too. The chapter pays special attention to ethical considerations and power relations in oral history interviews. The empirical examples derive from individual and group interviews conducted with Finnish care-leavers about their experiences in out-of-home care. The aim has been to give a voice to marginalised experiences and investigate the extent of the neglect, abuse, and violence experienced.

This is followed by a chapter on another source type that is relatively commonly used in historical research, especially by historians working on premodern periods. The chapter by Riikka Miettinen and Saku Pihko examines the use of different kinds of court records in studying experience, giving examples from medieval and early modern sources. Although their contents are filtered by clerks and heavily shaped by judicial interests and the practices of legal recordkeeping, court records contain information especially about the dynamic process and negotiative formation of experiences, but also—depending on their meticulousness—about people’s past personal experiences, their transformation over time, and existing structures of experience that influence them. Short and more declaratory entries, or very condensed excerpts of court cases, are of course less fruitful for studying the different levels of experience, while

court records describing more complex cases, requiring a thorough investigation and the hearing of multiple witnesses, can be a treasure trove for historians of experience. Taking into consideration the source-critical features of legal documents, the chapter shows how the information about the trial negotiations, testimonies, and details in the court records can be used, when comprehensively contextualised, to form interpretations about the formation and structures of experience.

Also discussing administrative documents, Johanna Annola's chapter focuses on documents from enclosed or residential institutions and how their information about official socio-spatial practices and material surroundings can be analysed and interpreted to study the potential or available experiences of those living or working in the institutions. Using examples taken from documents from two nineteenth-century Finnish spinhouses, Annola discusses how diverse institutional administrative documents, such as meeting minutes, reports, regulations, and maps, include fruitful information about the spatial and material features, discipline, and routines that can be used to study the restricted scope, or horizon of experience, of the inmates, or, for example, their sensory experiences. As Annola shows, the lack or scarcity of egodocuments or other first-person accounts, as is often the case in particular for pre-twentieth-century institutions, does not mean that experiences cannot be studied; the triangulation of different kinds of institutional sources reveals information about the past worlds of experiencing within the institutions.

The next chapters explore how experience can be teased out even from normative or didactic, literary, and statistical materials that do not necessarily describe real events or individuals at all. Sari Katajala-Peltomaa explores a set of sermons from the medieval monastery of Vadstena to show how sermon materials and other religious didactic materials can be used to interrogate experience. While the materials themselves are obviously made up of archetypal stories of imaginary rather than real-life experiences meant to influence lay audiences with normative ideals, they must also contain experiences that are recognisable and familiar enough to be convincing. Indeed, they can be used to interrogate what parts in experience were, in any given culture, generalisable, and to reveal the structures that guide and are guided by experience, like time, space, and community.

Similarly, other fictional writings can be used as a source in the history of experience. Jussi Lahtinen and Mikko Kemppainen's chapter explores

the possibilities of literary fiction as a source for the history of experience. They argue that literary fiction can be a very fruitful source also for historical research and especially for the history of experience. They provide examples from the point of view of the author's experience, the text as an interpretation of its time, and fiction's ability to affect its readership and challenge master narratives in society. The empirical focus is on early twentieth-century working-class Finnish literature. The chapter applies the concepts of community of experience, layer of experience, and scene of experience.

Moving beyond purely textual documents as historical sources, the volume also includes chapters on the use of numerical statistics, photographs, and art in the study of the history of experience. Quantitative and visual materials inspire the application of analysis methods from other fields that can be fruitful when adapted to historical research (of experience).

The chapter by Pirjo Markkola and Ilari Taskinen opens up innovative new avenues for the source base and methodology for the history of experience. It explores different kinds of quantitative sources and records, like population records, national statistics, and individual-level databases, and it proposes ways in which they can be read as and appropriated into sources for the history of experience. The authors also discuss the opportunities provided by new digital methods, like text mining and automatic handwritten text recognition (HTR).

Visual materials are another as yet less used source type in the study of the history of experience. The last two chapters focus on the use of historical imagery in analysing experience. Tanja Vahtikari's chapter discusses photographs as autobiographical sources that can be used to examine the photographers' historically situated experiences and the spatio-material conditions of experience. The chapter discusses photographs as sources containing information about the material world, including its material and spatial practices, which are essential to experiencing. Vahtikari highlights the act and practice of photographing as a form of experiencing and as a way of marking and producing meaningful experiences. Photographs also manifest the entangled relationship between experience and memory and serve as an important source when exploring the ways of re-experiencing past events. Serving as both emotional and memory objects, the study of their varied usage as material objects can likewise be of interest to historians of experience.

The final chapter by Karen E. McCluskey scrutinises artworks to lay out how a researcher can draw evidence of experience from visual materials. She uses the 4E cognition (embodied, embedded, enacted, extended) framework to show how artworks act on and with humans in the world of experiences. The chapter explores how visual perceptions create experiences as imagery perpetuates stereotypes and ideals that the viewers feel compelled to live up to. The chapter also emphasises how space and bodily action influence visual experience.

In the Conclusion, we discuss the common trends in using different source materials for doing history of experience based on the various chapters of this volume. We suggest that while this book cannot exhaust all possible sources or source types for history of experience, the chapters here offer a selection of methodological examples that can be used to turn any materials of the past into sources that testify to some kind of experience. The key question then is not whether the sources directly describe experience, but whose perspectives they represent, what power relations or social and material conditions shaped them, and where the inevitable gaps lie between what we want to know and what the sources reveal. As in all historical research, sources rarely tell us everything we hope to find, but that is not a reason to stop examining them. It is our methods—not the sources themselves—that make historical research possible or limit what we can discover.

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Egodocuments and Life-writing as Sources for the History of Experience

Reetta Eiranen  and *Sami Suodenjoki* 

In historical research, various kinds of egodocuments have been popular sources for trying to reach individual experience. The issue that traditionally has been discussed is the question of whether or not letters, diaries, memoirs, and other egodocuments and life-writings are somehow a privileged channel to the individual's thoughts or reveal the “authentic” experience. In more recent discussions, the focus has shifted towards a more multifaceted analysis of sources as constructing experience and shaping relationships between the writer and the audience.

Our chapter will address egodocuments and life-writings in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Europe. The terminology surrounding these

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sources has been widely debated, and these terms represent just two among many proposed alternatives. Egodocuments makes the cut here despite criticism that it carries connotations of “masculine ego”. We see the ego, or rather the self, as relational. The “document” angle is important because it encompasses sources that are not intentional and/or first-person writings by the research subject. This category may even include documents of the self produced by someone else or non-textual material objects. Life-writing, for its part, emphasises the self who is constructing itself by producing (usually) first-person texts pertaining to itself. We discard terms referring to narration such as “personal narrative” or “life narrative”, because we want to preserve methodological clarity when it comes to terms like “narration” or “narrative”. When used too loosely, they lose their theoretical edge and methodological usefulness, hence we want to treat as narratives only texts that fulfil specific definitions of narration/narrative and not any text whatsoever.¹

In addition to the conventional array of egodocuments and life-writings, we will direct our attention to “hybrid” features in the sources that combine different genres of writing and do not fall straightforwardly into a clear category. For instance, letters written by the nineteenth-century upper classes may exhibit characteristics of diaries or travel writing, like self-reflection and journey descriptions. Also, diaries and memoirs can be conflated, with a diary serving as the basis for a memoir published years later. In addition, our focus will turn to genres of writing that are not conventionally regarded as egodocuments, yet may equally contain personal accounts of experiences. Petitions and pauper letters will be discussed in greater detail, while newspapers and social media receive more cursory attention. With regard to the history of experience, hybrid sources are more varied, for instance, in terms of their temporality and audience.

The chapter will begin with a discussion of self-construction and alleged authenticity in the sources. We will address how the self and experience are constructed in the sources. To elucidate the concept of authenticity, we will introduce the notion of “truthfulness” into the analytical framework. We will proceed to address writing as an experiential practice, discussing the class-related differences in writing cultures and abilities, while also contemplating the methodological implications of

¹ Concise introduction to the terminological debate, see Summerfield 2019, 4–6; Mascuch, Dekker & Baggerman 2016, 11–13.

mediated authorship—particularly how the involvement of intermediaries complicates the use of such texts for analysing historical experience.

Another pivotal viewpoint in this chapter is the dynamic between privacy and publicity. We will address the issue of how the assumed confidentiality of the text affects the construction of experience and its interpretations. This ties also into the relationality of the sources and to the question of the intended audience and imagined reader of the text.

Then, we will consider the limits of a source material consisting of a single type of egodocument or life-writing, as opposed to the potential for cross-examination of texts by the same author intended for different recipients or audiences and serving divergent purposes. We will proceed to cover the temporal aspects and differences between sources, and after that we will cover some narrative approaches and concepts like experiential narration and cultural narratives. In our conclusion, we will draw together the main issues raised in the chapter and tackle the complicated issue of whether it is possible to differentiate between sources or their characteristics with regard to how close the source is to the writers' experience. We will also take a glance at the future possibilities in the research field, namely at digital methods and their affordances in studying egodocuments and life-writings.

Our examples are drawn primarily from nineteenth- and twentieth-century Finland, which has constituted the main focus of our empirical research. However, we also enrich the analysis with comparative examples from other contexts. The Finnish *Bildungsbürgertum* and working classes—central to many of our cases—were influenced by shared European cultural and ideological currents that shaped their mindset and way of life. Consequently, the observations presented in this chapter have a broad applicability to other European contexts of the time, albeit with the caveats that are customary for any historian when contextualising and critically evaluating their work.

SELF-CONSTRUCTION AND AUTHENTICITY

Egodocuments and life-writings, such as correspondence and diaries, produced by the upper echelons of society have been a self-evident source for historical research interested in personal experiences. In these texts, the author writes from their personal point of view and often reflects on their self, life events, experience, and emotions. The analysis of this type of sources has been rather popular in the fields of cultural history and

the history of ideas, which often focus on individuals and their life course from a biographical perspective. While these fields intersect significantly with the history of experience, the latter distinguishes itself by explicitly foregrounding experience as both an object and aspect of research, thereby contributing novel theoretical and methodological tools to other research fields as well. Above all, the history of experience provides a framework for finegrained analysis of how experience is constructed and for critically examining the assumption that such sources provide direct access to “authentic” experience.

The authenticity of experience can be contested and rethought from many angles. The hermeneutical tradition, making a distinction between *Erlebnis* and *Erfahrung*,² states that experience always takes place in time and space—that is, within spatiotemporal conditions of being. Hence, it is always conditioned by its contexts, be they historical, social, cultural, and so forth. Consequently, “authentic” experience does not exist in the sense that it would exist as completely unaffected and unmediated—like taking place in a void. Furthermore, if “authentic” experience is understood as “pure” and “untainted” by any influences, what does this even mean? In this sense, the purest and most authentic experience would be found in beings whose ability to reflect is as minimal as possible. In the case of human beings, this would probably mean an intoxicated person or a very young child. Lastly, historians are probably not even interested in this experience in the void, since the craft usually is to study human beings in relation to their reality and circumstances.³

We propose the notion of “truthfulness” as more useful than “authenticity” for trying to tackle this issue. Truthfulness here means, in our definition, that the person recounting or expressing their experience has the intention of being truthful and they themselves think they are. This does not, of course, mean that their account would be simple “evidence of experience”⁴ or that the expression of experience would be “true” from all other perspectives. As words or other expressions can never cover the totality of any experience or situation, they are, fundamentally, always lacking and a result of choices.⁵

² About the concepts, see the introduction of this volume.

³ Eiranen 2015, 2023.

⁴ Scott 1991.

⁵ Cf. William Reddy’s analysis of sincerity, Reddy 2001, esp. 108–110.

In their effort to integrate the fields of the history of experience, emotions, and the senses, Rob Boddice and Mark Smith have challenged the statements often made in research that emphasise the impossibility of reaching authentic experience or filtering sincere feelings from cultural conventions. According to them, it is possible to shed light on the emotional and sensory experiences of the past, provided that the statements left in the archives are taken seriously and literally. This, in turn, means reconstructing the linguistic and cultural context around the sources, and of course, considering the biases and gaps in these sources. At the same time, Boddice and Smith emphasise that formulaic language and authentic experience do not exist as separate categories but are intertwined in the archival traces. Pure experience cannot be separated from the cultural situation and the related linguistic, gestural, and conceptual categories and other modes of expression. No source is free from conventions, as culture is present everywhere. In this perspective, the idea of authenticity as something that remains unaffected by culture can be completely discarded when studying the lived experience of people in the past.⁶ Nevertheless, contextualising the sources and considering their limitations is the bread and butter of any historical inquiry.

The possibility of reaching experience is approached somewhat more moderately, but not necessarily in contradiction with Boddice and Smith's stance, by Sari Katajala-Peltomaa and Raisa Toivo. Their view runs along the lines that, without taking a position on whether pure experience exists, we can think that the historian who studies egodocuments and life-writings typically works with discursive experiences. The further back in time we go, the more impossible it becomes to reach pre-discursive experiences. At the same time, they point out that egodocuments or other sources produced closer to the present are just as subject to the influence of conventions and cultural patterns as those produced centuries ago. For example, the conventions of letter writing influence the way people express their emotions and sensory perceptions. The passage of time also has an impact on the process of meaning-making, as not all everyday experiences become memories: some are forgotten, while others become the subject of active reminiscing. Thus, Katajala-Peltomaa and Toivo conclude that the understanding of the unattainability of "immediate experiences" (perhaps referring to *Erlebnis*) is essential for the study

⁶ Boddice & Smith 2020, 31–33.

of experience. All experiences become entangled in social and cultural conventions when these experiences are interpreted, remembered, and narrated. And the experiences of other people are only accessible to the historian through different forms of articulation, accessibility being further limited by temporal distance.⁷

WRITING AS AN EXPERIENCE

Setting aside the question of reaching pure or “authentic” experiences, egodocuments and life-writing can be used in numerous ways to think about the experience of the authors of the texts. One of these is to direct attention to the act of writing as an experience. The ability of individuals to express their experiences in personal writings has been shaped by varying levels of literary competence, resulting in diverse narrative strategies and communicative repertoires.

The nineteenth century has been deemed the heyday of writing that dealt with and reflected on the self. During this period, letters were admired as an authentic means of self-expression. The nineteenth-century letters of upper-class families, rich in their depictions of close relationships, display a profusion of emotional expression that is striking to the twenty-first-century reader. For the upper classes, prolific self-reflection and the expression of emotion also served as a means of distinguishing themselves from the lower classes, whose emotional lives were often regarded as less cultivated. A subtle and deep ability to feel was considered a marker of a finer disposition and sophistication, intrinsic to people of their social standing. Notably, this deep ability to feel was not gendered but expected of both men and women. However, there was a certain ambivalence to it. While sensitivity was admired, excessive sentiment or a lack of emotional control was viewed critically.⁸ The temporal and cultural distance between the historian and their subject poses a challenge for research: how should one interpret a source in which the emotional register appears overwhelmingly intense to the twenty-first-century reader but was considered by the writer to be an emanation from their deepest inner self and experience? It might be precisely because of their emotional expressiveness that this type

⁷ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 25.

⁸ See e.g. Jalava 2005, 63–65; Shields 2007.

of source has drawn so much scholarly attention from cultural historians and literary scholars.

In the nineteenth century, when people were separated, a letter often served as the only tangible link between loved ones. The culture of correspondence among the upper classes was lively and frequent. Letters were not only a means of conveying news but also an emotional tool for maintaining and strengthening relationships. The content of the letter was important, but merely receiving a letter from a loved one—before even opening or reading it—could instigate a strong reaction. It was important to receive a letter from a loved one, who had used time and effort in writing, but also to know that the loved one had held the paper in their hands and written the words with their own hand and handwriting. A letter could take on a talismanic quality and be carried close to one's body. In this sense, the letter served as an emotional object, constructing and maintaining the emotional bond between the writer and the recipient.⁹

While self-reflective writing flourished among the upper classes, literacy and writing skills were gradually spreading to broader segments of the population, at least in Western countries. This democratisation of writing during the long nineteenth century is evident, first, in the rise of pauper letters—petitions written by ordinary people seeking aid from state officials or other authorities (Fig. 2.1). These letters often included elements of self- and life-narration, not as a result of personal impulse, but due to institutional demands. In order to access welfare benefits or navigate the legal system, individuals were compelled to provide written accounts of their lives.¹⁰ Second, the massive wave of overseas migration between 1860 and 1920 significantly expanded the writing practices of common people. Millions of migrants maintained ties with family and friends through letters, many of which were preserved within families before eventually entering archival collections. Third, the First World War triggered what Martyn Lyons has termed a “writing bulimia”, a phenomenon marked by the exchange of billions of letters between soldiers at the front and their loved ones at home.¹¹

A common thread across these three developments is that they drew into the sphere of writing individuals who were often barely literate

⁹ See e.g. Lyons 2010, 171–179; Stanley 2004.

¹⁰ Ashplant 2018, 15, 18–20.

¹¹ Lyons 2023, 7–9; Ashplant 2018, 15.

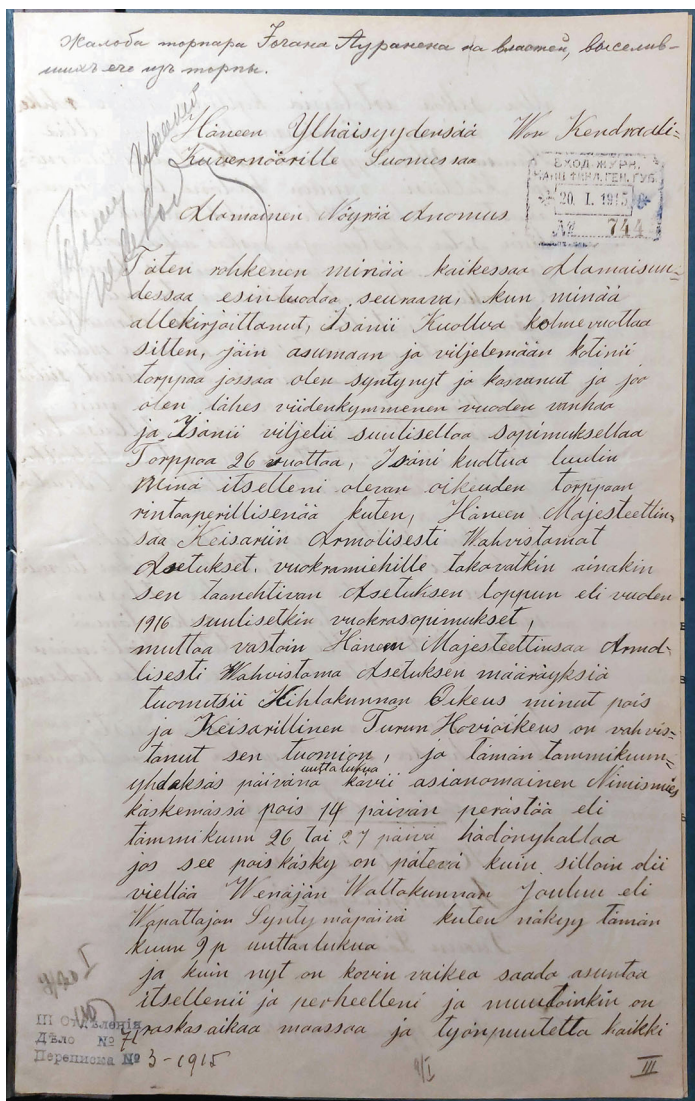


Fig. 2.1 Petitions from ordinary people often addressed pivotal experiences in the senders' lives. In a letter dated 17 January 1915, tenant farmer's son Johan Auranen appealed to the Governor-General of Finland to revoke his family's eviction from the farm he had lived on all his life. The underlined phrases indicate the sender's age, the period he claims to have cultivated the farm under an oral agreement, and the short notice given for the eviction. These underlinings were most likely added by the receiving authority, and together with the marginal notes, they indicate that the recipient took the appeal seriously. *Source* Governor-General's Office 1915, Fb:1125, d. 71:3, National Archives of Finland

and unfamiliar with written expression, yet were compelled to write by extraordinary circumstances.¹² As historians, literary scholars, and sociolinguists have become interested in these rich materials in recent decades, these materials have also begun to be approached as egodocuments, life-writing, and sources for the history of experience.

The writings of unschooled people were often more formulaic and limited in vocabulary compared to those of upper-class writers. For many working-class individuals, writing was not only intellectually demanding but also physically strenuous. Even holding a pen could have been difficult for a ploughman, let alone forming precise strokes.¹³ These physical and mental challenges made writing a time-consuming process, and frequently irregular in spelling and punctuation. Unschooled writers were often acutely aware of their limitations and openly acknowledged their lack of skill and confidence in their writing. While such self-deprecation may have followed formulas borrowed from the writings of others in similar positions, it can still offer valuable insights into the writers' sense of civic efficacy, or lack thereof. When non-elite writers reflected on their relationship to writing, many also reflected on how their writing activities were perceived in their communities. Their accounts suggest that it was not rare for common writers to experience social exclusion or to be regarded as eccentric within their local environments or workplaces during the long nineteenth century. Such experiences are echoed in sources from many different regions.¹⁴

The ways in which the laboriousness of writing shaped how lower-class writers represented themselves and their lives is also evident in pauper letters from nineteenth-century Britain, examined by Steven King. What characterised these letters was the way their authors associated writing to truthfulness and honesty. Simply putting the pen to the paper was presented both as evidence of their sincerity and as a moral obligation to tell the truth. Appeals to respectability were also common: writers stressed that the effort required for composing a letter, and their persistence in doing so under difficult circumstances, attested to their integrity. Yet pauper letters also contain expressions that highlight the plain pleasure of writing. King interprets this as an indication that the ability and

¹² Lyons 2013, 22.

¹³ Kuusmin 2013, 103.

¹⁴ Lyons 2008; Stark 2008; Kauranen & Virtanen 2010; Kuusmin 2013, 103–104.

opportunity to write offered poor people a creative act that helped them protect their selfhood amid the pressures exerted by authorities.¹⁵

Recounting incidents in personal life was a typical reason for common people to take up the pen during the long nineteenth century, and not only out of necessity, as in the case of pauper letters. The urge to record an injustice, falling in love, or losing the object of love often served as a powerful catalyst for writing, as evinced in the diaries of unschooled men studied by Kaisa Kauranen. Kauranen's research reveals a rich emotional landscape within the diaries produced by non-elite writers in Finland. In this respect, her findings differ from some studies from Sweden, which suggest that nineteenth-century peasant diaries and autobiographies focused on practical matters of family and daily life and rarely touched on emotions.¹⁶ Therefore, it would be misleading to generalise straightforwardly that the egodocuments or life-writings of common people lacked introspective engagement with experiences and emotions.¹⁷ At the same time, it would be equally misleading to claim that self-reflection or emotional expression was as prevalent and similar in quality in the writings of unschooled ordinary people as in those produced by members of the upper classes.¹⁸ From the perspective of studying experience, this means that in the writings of lower-class individuals, experiences often need to be traced through brief, suggestive, and linguistically simple expressions.

THE CONFLUENCE OF PRIVATE AND PUBLIC

A central distinguishing factor among egodocuments and life-writings is whether they are private or public in nature, or rather, where they fall on the sliding scale between private and public. Private writings, such as intimate letters or personal diaries, are often perceived as expressions of the writer's personal experience. Public writings, such as individual petitions addressed to authorities or published memoirs, by contrast, more readily invite questions about the truthfulness of the experiences expressed in the text. Can these texts give insight into how historical actors experienced

¹⁵ King 2023, 55–58.

¹⁶ Kauranen 2009, 11. Cf. Liljewall 2012, 55.

¹⁷ See also Kuismin 2013, 115.

¹⁸ Keravuori 2017, 230–231. See also Lyons 2008.

and felt, or do the sources merely shed light on discourses, representations, or formulaic patterns? Researchers, even those engaged with the history of experience, have very different views on this.¹⁹ At the heart of the debate lies the issue of the intended audience: who does the writer have in mind when they are composing their text? This question is central to understanding how the level of publicity or privacy shapes the construction of experience within egodocuments and life-writings. Writers construct themselves differently depending on their audience. Hence, the construction of the self and experience is relational.²⁰ Consequently, as established earlier, the search for an “inner” experience that is unaffected by social influences is not a productive approach to egodocuments and life-writing.

In diaries, the intended audience might be just the writers themselves—or their future selves, to be precise. However, also here the genres can conflate. There are various examples of politicians who have published their diaries, or alleged diaries. On the other hand, the diaries of many politicians are like memos or notebooks, recording key events, negotiations, and moods. As such, they often serve as an aid to the writing of future memoirs and are thus available for posterity. Also, travel diaries have often been intended not only for the writer but also for friends and relatives, if not for publication.²¹

A memoir or an autobiography is more obviously intended for a wider audience, sometimes for the author’s descendants, sometimes for circulation within the literary market. For instance, during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the Finnish Literature Society received numerous autobiographical manuscripts from self-educated writers. For many of them, the Society provided a forum for the exploration of a novel genre of writing, with many perceiving the Society’s personnel as their intended audience. Moreover, many writers anticipated that the Society would carefully archive their contributions and aid them in publishing their stories. Some of these writers even used a pseudonym and a feigned

¹⁹ For a discussion of this in relation to petitions, see Ben-Bassat 2013, 22–23. One factor that complicates the interpretation of petitions as historical sources is that, in many cases, they have not been written by the petitioners themselves but by intermediaries.

²⁰ See also Fulbrook & Rublack 2010.

²¹ Eiranen 2015, 83; Sjö & Leskelä-Kärki 2020, 24–25.

writing style, believing that such measures would enhance the publishability of their work.²² However, some writers may have felt deeply uncertain about the worthiness of their texts. Such details can be revealed in the accompanying letters or remarks, where the autobiographical writer offers the text to the recipient. The way in which writers addressed the receiving institution and described the significance and value of the personal account can reveal much about how they experienced the literary world and their own place within it.

In a letter, the obvious audience is the recipient and often that is indeed the only person for whom the text is meant. This is especially the case in romantic correspondence or intimate letters to close friends. Such letters occasionally included requests to be burned after reading. This, obviously, has not happened if the researcher can find the letter in an archive. In nineteenth-century letter culture, some letters can be dubbed family letters, meaning letters that were addressed to one or all family members, for instance by a son on his travels, but intended to be read aloud to the family members, perhaps even to neighbours and acquaintances. It did not make sense to use time and effort to write the same news separately to different family members. This highlights another function of the nineteenth-century letter: it was an important means of transmitting news. Aware of the potential broader audience, the sender could explicitly mention in the letter that it was only meant for the family and was not to be shared with the wider social circle.²³

Silences—what is left unsaid in a text—can tell a lot and vary depending on the audience. Letter writers frequently concealed or filtered information, either unintentionally or as a deliberate strategy to avoid full disclosure. For instance, migrants writing to their families across distances frequently withheld or filtered information in order to avoid eliciting sympathy and pity when their plans failed or contradicted family advice. In the context of migration and subsequent dislocation, the decision to remain silent and refrain from disclosing emotional distress, including feelings of pain and loneliness, could be made in the interest of safeguarding the well-being of loved ones left behind. The choices of when,

²² Kuusmin 2013, 113.

²³ Eiranen 2015, 83. About burning letters, see, e.g. National Library of Finland (NLF), J.V. Snellman's archive, Evelina Schmidt to Jeanette Snellman, s.a. (2540), s.a. (2547). About restricting the audience of a family letter, see NLF, Kellgreniana, Robert Tengström to J. J. Tengström, 11. July [1844].

to whom, and why the writers disclosed or withheld information are equally significant and reveal much about how they structured their personal lives and social relations.²⁴ A notable example of this can be found in Ilari Taskinen's study of correspondence from Finnish soldiers during the Second World War. In letters to fellow men, soldiers often described their wartime experiences with striking frankness and graphic detail—an openness notably absent in letters addressed to their parents.²⁵

As for letters from ordinary people to those in power, sometimes described as a form of public letter writing, the question of privacy and publicness is not straightforward, either. Although the addressee may have represented a public authority, the authors often treated highly personal matters and intended their letters to remain confidential.²⁶ For example, it may have been very important to the writer that the intended recipient, a person in power, read the letter personally and that it did not fall into the hands of outsiders. This is illustrated by citizens' letters addressed to the Governor-General of Finland at the beginning of the twentieth century. Many of the writers of these letters expressed their dissatisfaction as they received a response to their preceding letter from someone other than the Governor-General himself.²⁷ The assumption of personal communication, in turn, influenced how the writer described their life and experiences to the recipient. Typically, in these cases, the writer did not know the recipient personally, but they may have assumed that the recipient would respond sympathetically to their message or at least be personally invested in it.

The assumption by senders that their messages were confidential did not always align with how those in power treated these letters. For example, senders may not have anticipated that their letters would eventually be preserved in official archives and become publicly accessible. In some historical contexts, the authorities also used letters from ordinary people as propaganda tools by publishing them in print. For instance, in 1937, the Fascist regime in Italy printed an extensive volume compiled of letters sent to Mussolini by the families of fallen soldiers. Since only

²⁴ Chávez-García 2021.

²⁵ Taskinen 2021.

²⁶ Fitzpatrick 1996, 79–80.

²⁷ E.g. National Archives of Finland (NAF), KKK 1901, Fb:39, d. 16, Juho Koskela to the Governor-General 19 November 1900. For this correspondence more generally, see Suodenjoki 2022.

letters that served the regime's purposes were selected for publication, it would be problematic to use the published letters as evidence of how the masses felt about the Fascist regime. However, as Anne Wingenter, who has studied these letters, points out, the letters do shed light on the priorities that people brought to their interactions with the administration. These priorities were rooted in people's everyday lives and therefore did not necessarily always align with the prescriptions of the Fascist state.²⁸

In the Italian case, ordinary people did not know that their letters would be published by the authorities, but in other cases people knowingly wrote letters for publication in order to communicate with those in power. In the early Soviet Union, the Communist Party-affiliated *Krestinskaia gazeta* (Peasant Gazette) received a massive number of letters from its readers, only a small fraction of which were published. These letters addressed a wide array of economic, political, social, and personal issues, sometimes including detailed biographies and accounts of hardship experienced by the writers or their families. The writers' belief in the power of the written word heightened their sense of the importance of writing to the newspaper, especially considering that many of them recognised letter writing as one of the few means available to them to voice their grievances to authorities.²⁹

Overall, the genre of readers' letters, or letters to the editors, often contain material bearing the characteristics of egodocuments or life-writing. As such, they offer a rich source for studying the history of experiences and emotions.³⁰ However, it is essential to consider the editorial process by which the letters to be published were selected and edited.³¹ If the available source material consists only of published letters, it is worth asking whether some narrated experiences have been systematically left out of the contributions offered to the readers. For instance, the editorial staff may have preferred certain emotional templates in relation to particular topical issues. Consequently, they may have been inclined to publish the kind of readers' letters that corresponded to these templates. In this instance, the sources offer insights into the frames of experience that the editorial staff sought to present to the readership rather than

²⁸ Wingenter 2007, 172 and *passim*.

²⁹ Storella & Sokolov 2013, 9, 21.

³⁰ See Kokko 2022; Sorvali 2023.

³¹ Wahl-Jorgensen 2019.

illuminate collective experiences of the general public. If the researcher also has access to unpublished letters, it may help in considering what experiences were deemed inappropriate by the editorial staff or what kind of frames of experience were set, allowed, and favoured by the editors. Sometimes, readers' letters can reveal the authors' experiences of the editorial line and how they may doubt the eligibility of their own views for publication.³²

Examining the recipient of egodocuments and life-writings is an essential part of contextualising the text and discerning why the author is recounting their experiences the way they are. In writing about their lives and selves, the writer inevitably anticipates the reader's reactions. The presence of an audience in the text may be expressed through forms of address or rhetorical questions, but the presumed audience is also indicated by what the author assumes the readers know and what is explained to them. It should be noted that, in addition to the reader explicitly mentioned in the text, other audiences can sometimes be identified between the lines.³³

CROSS-CHECKING SOURCES TO CONTEXTUALISE EXPERIENCE

The opportunities for using an egodocument or life-writing to shed light on the experiences of historical actors are shaped by the availability of other sources concerning these individuals and their environment. Some scholars, such as Alain Corbin, have of course skilfully constructed historical narratives about individuals of whom there is minimal source information, and in doing so they have effectively outlined the *context of possibilities* for experiencing in a particular historical context.³⁴ Clearly, however, the starting point for tracing the experiences of the author of the text is fundamentally different when the researcher has only a single egodocument or life-writing at their disposal compared to cases where a number of sources, directly related to the same person or situation, can be compared and mirrored with each other. This challenge is generally less

³² Storella & Sokolov 2013, 278.

³³ Kuismis 2013, 31.

³⁴ Corbin 2001. For the notion of context of possibilities, see Boddice & Smith 2020, 50.

pronounced for scholars of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries than for those studying earlier periods, though it also depends on the social background of the individuals under examination.³⁵ Members of the elite are typically documented through a more varied body of sources than those from lower social strata. However, recent scholarship has shown that non-elite people, too, may have engaged in far richer and more diverse scribal practices than once assumed.³⁶

Cross-checking an egodocument or life-writing against other sources is not always possible even for historians of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries who enjoy an abundance of material. Moreover, as historians Mary Fulbrook and Ulinka Rublack point out, interpreting personal writings can prove challenging even if these writings can be well contextualised. To illustrate this point, they consider the memoirs of a former Nazi, in which the author claims to have always opposed the policies of the Nazi regime. Should this account be read as post-war self-exculpation, in which the narrator seeks to absolve himself of responsibility? Or does the account reflect the narrator's genuine internal conflict between his past actions and the feeling that he had been forced to act against his will? Or had the narrator's views and feelings undergone a transformation that had made it impossible for him to identify with his past motivations and the meanings he had previously assigned to his actions? It can be extremely difficult for a researcher to determine the most appropriate interpretive framework within which to place the subject's account, even when the researcher has many different types of sources against which to analyse the account.³⁷

When a researcher has access to egodocuments or life-writings produced by the same individual at different times, for varying purposes and audiences, cross-referencing these sources can offer rich insights into the history of experience. The writings of Finnish cobbler Vihtori Lindholm (1868–1918) illustrate this potential. Despite having no formal education, Lindholm became an active writer around the turn of the twentieth century, initially compelled by legal disputes to produce written witness statements and complaints. In 1901, he expanded his literary activity by publishing a broadside ballad recounting his life course. Soon

³⁵ von Greyerz 2010, 278.

³⁶ Lyons 2013; Lyons 2023.

³⁷ Fulbrook & Rublack 2010, 266.

after, he joined the labour movement and began contributing articles to a socialist newspaper, documenting his activity as a socialist agitator and local social tensions. In 1909, he wrote an autobiographical letter to the printers' union, referencing his earlier texts (Fig. 2.2). Examining these materials in relation to each other allows for a more nuanced understanding of Lindholm's experiences and the meanings he assigned to them than any single source could provide.³⁸

In Lindholm's writings, the problems in his marriage and the ensuing legal proceedings appeared as a pivotal life experience, shaping his relationship with the local community and authorities. However, the meanings he assigned to this experience varied across texts. In his broadside ballad, for example, the cobbler linked the failure of his marriage to the class distinction between himself and his wife—he being of lower social standing than her—as well as her suspicions of infidelity.³⁹ When treating broadside ballads as a form of life-writing, it is important to consider their distinctive features—particularly their need to be emotionally engaging and commercially appealing in order to attract potential buyers. Even so, previous research has shown that some of these songs do reflect the life stories of biographical persons, with the protagonists themselves often selling and performing these songs.⁴⁰ This appears to be the case with Lindholm's broadside ballad as well, although not all details of the narrative can be corroborated from court records or other sources. Quite likely the cobbler sold the song print in his locality and used it to tell his version of events and counter community rumours.

Compared to the broadside ballad, Lindholm's autobiographical letter from 1909 presents a markedly different version of his marital problems and subsequent prison sentence. Addressed to the printers' union, the letter frames his life through the lens of ideological awakening, linking his hardships to class conflict between the poor and the capitalist elite. As part of this framing, Lindholm claimed to have been sentenced to prison by a jury with a conservative bourgeois mindset that disapproved of his political views.⁴¹ At the same time, he remained silent about the actual

³⁸ Suodenjoki 2010.

³⁹ NLF, Broadsheet Collection, V. L., "Yksi aivan uusi huvilaulu Urjalasta: Hämmäläisen suutarin elämänvaiheista", 1902.

⁴⁰ Strand 2018, 36–38.

⁴¹ Finnish Labour Archives (FLA), the archive of Urjala workers' association (AUWA), Vihtori Lindholm, "Elämän Raunioilla", 1909.

sivu 1

Elämän Ruuilla

Sosialismi on vieläkin Muukalainen nimi
 Hyvin monelle uskattelun alla olevalle!
 Mästä herrat tuntee sosialismia! Urjalan pitäjäs-
 sä alkoi Poron porssareille suuri porssarien
 toimesta kova kiire V. 1899. Että täytyy ottaa koko
 kansa mukaan köyhemmätkin kehdestä mandan par-
 taalla oleviin väkkäns siihen suureen atressiin.
 Tietysti itsenäistää porssareita jaloitella porssari-
 ta. Sitte perustettiin Luikuturia joka kylään
 Että köyhätkin saivat porssarien sanomalehtiä
 y m kirjoja isivät enää uskonn rukoukseen kun ei
 atressittauttami suutari V. Lindholm tuli silloin huo-
 matuksi porssareilta kuin uskalsi pitää yhäkkeitä
 ole täyppelista antaa nimeensä atressiin kun ei ole
 ehtoja hallitvalta silloin V. Lohi isänmaan puolesta
 joka olisi ollut pois potkettavasta kaikista porssarien
 kokous paikoista kuin Melolan kylässä Asimiyös
 Joka saarinen joka rikamiehisesti kiikatti V. L.
 Vaimoa särkeen V. L. nuoreen lasia tai pistään
 tulta nurkan alle tästä V. L. haastatutti saarisen
 oikeuteen saarinen toimi Väinää y m että sai entise-
 ä lautamiehiä y m asruukseen ja sitte virallisista
 lautamiehiä ja kirkon palveliaita ja toimittivat
 V. L. Vaimon kantaan asia rikaksesta minkuin
 Eräissä hämäläisen suutarin laulussa kuuluu.
 Niin sellain V. L. asiamies Touko K. V. 1900
 ajettiin ulos ja Lindholmia omia yhäkkeitä ei

Fig. 2.2 The opening page of Vihtori Lindholm's autobiographical letter to the Printers' Union, 1909. The title, "In the Ruins of Life", and the first sentence, "Socialism is still an alien name for many who are under the influence of traditional beliefs!", immediately frame the letter as a narrative of hardship and ideological awakening. Notably, the writer refers to himself in the third person, using initials, a practice sometimes encountered among authors without formal schooling. Source Archive of the Urjala workers' association, FLA.

reasons for his conviction, namely, assaulting his wife and committing perjury.⁴² This omission becomes evident when the letter is read against court records, which likewise include Lindholm's own voice.

The comparison of sources highlights how Lindholm's later ideological transformation provided a new cultural frame through which he reinterpreted and redefined his experience of the judicial process. In his autobiographical letter, the cobbler presented the case in a markedly different light than before, filtering the judicial process through his political identity and recasting the events in line with his ideological convictions. This does not mean that the experience recounted in the letter was fabricated or deliberately distorted. Rather, it reflects the nature of the autobiographical memory as an active process of meaning-making shaped by contextual influences, including cultural narratives.⁴³ Memory, in this sense, acts as a generative force that mediates how historical actors interpret and make sense of their experiences.

Titled "On the Ruins of Life", Lindholm's autobiographical letter blends elements of an empowering conversion narrative with a tale of personal suffering. As such, it fits within the genre of autobiographies written by unschooled common people, which have been uncovered in Finnish archives in recent decades.⁴⁴ It also aligns with the broader European tradition of workers' autobiographies, particularly the "militant" type, which typically emphasise the self-liberation, persecution, and ideological commitment of the protagonist.⁴⁵ Lindholm's framing of his experiences in the letter was clearly shaped by its purpose. Although addressed to the Printers' Union and centred on personal hardship, the letter makes no explicit requests, suggesting it was not written primarily to seek financial aid. Rather, writing the letter appears to have been driven by the cobbler's desire to be recognised as a writer. He presents writing as central to his personal and ideological development, portraying his literary awakening as a direct result of legal struggles and social conflict. As he puts it, "In the lull of the bourgeoisie, L. learned to be a writer".⁴⁶ In

⁴² Suodenjoki 2010, 94.

⁴³ Pihko 2024.

⁴⁴ Kuismä 2013, 102, 105.

⁴⁵ For the characteristics of these writings, see Ashplant 1998, 102–104; Maynes 1995, 4–5; Lyons 1995, 235; Lyons 2008, 131–132.

⁴⁶ FLA, AUWA, Lindholm, "Elämän Raunioilla," 1909.

this and other passages, Lindholm refers to himself in the third person, which was not totally unusual for lower-class writers of the time. Another notable feature in the passage is the use of the term *bourgeoisie*, which introduces a dimension of class consciousness that was entirely absent from the autobiographical broadside ballad Lindholm had written earlier in the same decade, prior to his socialist conversion.

In sum, cross-reading texts written for different audiences and purposes offers valuable insights for researchers. It helps to identify literary conventions and patterns of expression that might be overlooked when analysing a single type of source. Thus, cross-reading can prevent simple misinterpretations—such as taking for granted the cobbler’s insinuation of the political grounds for his imprisonment—and reveal how and why individuals reinterpreted their experiences over time. Cross-reading also highlights what aspects of the self and one’s experiences are emphasised or omitted depending on the intended audience, whether trade unionists or the local community. Even subtle differences in word choice or the layout of a handwritten text—an aspect that cannot be explored in detail here—can offer important clues about the shifting ways in which an author organises their experiences.

MULTIFACETED TEMPORALITY AND SPATIALITY

Different forms of life-writing have different temporal relations to the events and issues they are treating. Letters or diary entries are often composed temporally very close to their subject matter, whereas memoirs and autobiographies may be written years or even decades later. This creates a difference in interpreting them in the study of experience, but also in historical research more broadly. The time elapsed between the event and the act of writing affects the writer’s interpretation of their experience. Later events and experiences can cast earlier ones in a new light. Much of this happens unconsciously and automatically. In Gadamerian terms, new experiences affect and change the writer’s *horizon*, within which their understanding is embedded. This horizon is in constant flux as life progresses.⁴⁷ As pointed out in memory studies, sources construct the experience at the time of their composing, not the experience at the time

⁴⁷ See Gadamer 1990, 307–312.

they are talking about.⁴⁸ For instance, a diary entry written immediately after the events it describes evidently possesses a different temporal nature than a memoir that is written years after the event. However, writing a diary may have served as a conscious way for individuals to record themselves and their lives, and to build their persona for future generations. Still, it can be argued that a source composed temporally closer to the event or issue it describes is—indeed—closer to the experience, since it was closer to the time it was lived through.

Sources can also be temporally conflated—temporally hybrid, that is. For instance, it is possible that the writer of a memoir or an autobiography used their own correspondence or detailed diary as source material. From a source-critical perspective, it is essential to examine any foreword or introduction, where authors often explain the background and writing process of their text. Clues may also appear within the text itself: unusually detailed passages may suggest the use of earlier writings. An example of a hybrid source where different types and temporalities of life-writing conflate is the memoirs of the Finnish journalist August Schauman (1826–1896). First, in 1886, he published a series of small booklets called *Nu och Förr* (Now and Before), which addressed contemporary issues while also recalling life in Helsinki fifty years earlier. The booklets gained so much popularity that Schauman decided to write his memoirs. In doing so, he effectively conducted biographical research on himself, consulting his extensive correspondence, youthful notebooks, and other materials. The resulting work, *Från sex årtionden i Finland* (From six decades in Finland), was published in 1892–1894.⁴⁹ At times, Schauman quotes his diary directly, and in some parts the description is so detailed that it raises the question of whether the text is drawn from the diary or represents a lightly edited version of it.⁵⁰

Serving as a vital—and often the only—means of transcending geographical and temporal distance in the nineteenth century, letters carried multifaceted temporal meanings for both writers and recipients. For the reader, letters often evoked an experience of being in the same time and space with the writer. Such experience could arise through

⁴⁸ About memory studies see Malinen in this volume.

⁴⁹ Schauman, G. 1924, V–VI.

⁵⁰ Schauman, A. 1924, 177, see, e.g. description of Jeanette Wennberg and J.V. Snellman's engagement party, 190–195.

simple utterances, such as wishing the recipient a good day or night, or stating that the writer was now sitting down to “talk” with them.⁵¹ The temporal dimensions could also conflate. “I have to go soon [...], because it is now tomorrow, I started the letter yesterday”, wrote Jeanette Snellman, young *Bildungsbürgertum* wife and mother, to her husband in 1847.⁵²

In Jeanette Snellman’s letters we can also find a passage where the conflation of time and space becomes very apparent on an experiential level. She missed her husband, who had been travelling in continental Europe for several months. She herself spent the summer of 1847 with their young daughter as a guest at a large vicarage in Iisalmi, Eastern Finland, hosted by family friends.

You write so clearly and brightly that I understand every word. It was so fun to read about the evening you spent on the mountain, it felt like I was standing beside you, and I saw that wonderful nature, I enjoyed and dreamt, but then I felt that someone patted me on the cheek, and I turned, and I saw little Hanna [the daughter], who smiled so sweetly, and when I cried again I took her in my arms, pressed her against my chest, it was an inexpressibly lovely feeling, it felt like both of you were there with me.⁵³

In Jeanette Snellman’s writing, different temporal planes exist at the same time. She herself describes the conflation of time and space where she almost feels like she is on the spectacular mountain landscape with her husband. Here, the romantic admiration of the beauty of the landscape seems to trigger and reinforce the sliding into the daydreamy experience of being there in the company of her loved one. Her daughter is on her lap, but at the same time she feels like her husband is there with her, too. In the phenomenological understanding of time, past and future are diffused into the experiencing of the present. In other words, the experience of time is not clearcut or one-dimensional but a mixture of the three temporalities.

⁵¹ See, e.g. Jeanette Snellman to J.V. Snellman, 14 July 1847, in J.V. Snellman 1995, 697; Jeanette Snellman to J.V. Snellman, 1 August 1847, in J.V. Snellman 1996, 637; NLF, J.V. Snellman’s archive, Josephine Kellgren to Jeanette Snellman, s.a.

⁵² Jeanette Snellman to J.V. Snellman, 3 July 1847, in J.V. Snellman 1995, 690.

⁵³ Jeanette Snellman to J.V. Snellman, 5 September 1847, in J.V. Snellman 1996, 677.

Also for Herman Kellgren, a young student in the mid-nineteenth century, intense longing evoked the experience of transcending time and space to his loved ones. In a letter to his best friend, who was also the brother of his fiancée, he described how hearing a waltz triggered an overwhelming physical reaction of almost fainting, a rush of blood to the chest, heavy breathing, and dizziness. This was followed by a feeling of being transported to a ball in his hometown.

I believe I have mentioned to you before that, being separated from Sofi [his fiancée], it is so devastating for me that as soon as a waltz is played, she appears, or rather dances, before my eyes. [...] the music played an old familiar waltz, to the tune of which I have danced with her a thousand times, and at the very first note, she fell from the skies before my eyes, and not only her but an entire ball in Helsinki [...] I had to close my eyes and completely surrender to the impressions and feelings that overwhelmed me.⁵⁴

The strength of the experience is underlined by physical reactions and the feeling of having to surrender to the impressions invoked by the longing. Instead of trying to be present in the actual time and place where he was, the pull of the vision he evokes in his writing was so strong that he did not even try to resist it but let it take him. In a way, the description underlines the writer's sensibility and ability to feel deeply, which was valued in the romantically influenced culture of the time.

It seems that, in general, corporeality augments the experientiality of the text. Embodied aspects bind the text closer to the specific conditions of space and time, which adds to experientiality, because experience is invariably situated within a particular time and space, that is to say, within spatiotemporal conditions. The spatial dimensions of the situation described in the text affect its experientiality. There is a difference in phrasing "I got married" from the expression "I stood at the altar".⁵⁵ Life-writings often contain descriptions of embodied experience. A university student could write to his closest friend that their friendship "floats like honey in my veins", or a young widow could admit to her sister that external pain could be mild compared to the pain that

⁵⁴ NLF, Kellgreniana, Herman Kellgren to Robert Tengström, 10 March 1846.

⁵⁵ See NLF, Kellgreniana, Natalia Castrén to Sofi Kellgren, 31 October 1853.

“gnawed” at her heart.⁵⁶ A relative described that a young wife had had terrible spasms for two hours after her husband passed away and four people had to hold her down.⁵⁷ There was a perceived connection between the mind and the body, for instance, the illness of the mind appearing also as an illness of the body.⁵⁸ Overwhelming emotion could overflow to embodied manifestations. Accounts of embodied reactions, like tears or fainting, add to the credibility and intensity of the experience that is described.

The capacity of sources composed in close temporal proximity to the events they describe to reflect the multifaceted temporality and spatiality of experience has also been explored in scholarship on wartime correspondence. During the First World War, letters served as the primary means by which couples separated by war maintained their relationships, and it can be posited that this separation was defined more by the experience of time than distance. The letters often reflected the tension between the present separation between the correspondents, their idealised memories of the past moments spent together, and their uncertain, precarious hopes for the future. According to Carol Acton, the war intensified the contrast between objective clock time, evident in the dates and postmarks of the letters, and subjective time, that is, how time felt for the correspondents. The corresponding couples might recount their past experiences of spending time together during the soldier’s leave, or they might anticipate marriage or otherwise imagine their joint future after the war. Waiting constituted a fundamental aspect of the correspondence, whether it pertained to the waiting for letters, for the soldier’s leave, or for the return to peace. According to Acton, the very act of writing letters helped to alleviate the anxiety of waiting, even as the threat of devastating news loomed in the background.⁵⁹

⁵⁶ See NLF, Kellgreniana, Robert Tengström to Herman Kellgren, 20 March 1846; NLF, Kellgreniana, Natalia Castrén to Sofi Kellgren, 1 January 1854.

⁵⁷ Fanny Lagus to Castalia in Constantinople, 11 May 1852, in Lagus 1936, 271.

⁵⁸ Lindblom 2021.

⁵⁹ Acton 2025.

NARRATIVE APPROACHES

One fruitful methodological approach to egodocuments and life-writing is to analyse the narrative construction of the self and experience in the sources. In narratology, the experiential definition of narrative has gained currency during recent years. One of the most influential formulations is by David Herman. In his definition of experiential narration, its key elements include *situatedness*, *event sequencing*, *world making* or *world disruption*, and “what it’s like” (*qualia*).⁶⁰ All these aspects of egodocuments and life-writing are worth considering when analysing the experiential features of these sources.

In Herman’s elements, situatedness refers to the communicative situation of the narration. In the context of historical research, it encompasses source-critical questions, like who is talking, to whom, when, and where. Event sequencing denotes the temporality of the source and the temporal order of things in the totality of the text. Worldmaking refers to the construction of the storyworld in the text, but this does not need to be limited only to fictional worlds. In a way, the author of a letter or a memoir creates the “reality” of their own text, the spatiotemporal framework that constitutes the world of which they are talking about. World disruption means an unexpected or surprising event in the storyworld. In the scale of narrativity, the text needs a disruption in order to be “more narrative”. The disruption, in this sense, cuts through the normalcy and necessitates an explanation and sense-making through the narration. The “what it’s like” (*qualia*) aspect of the narration means that there is a consciousness to whom the events mean something.⁶¹ According to Herman, narration is able to capture “what the world is like from the situated perspective of an experiencing mind”.⁶² In egodocuments and life-writing, the experiencer is the spatiotemporal and embodied self who is in a situation and tells about some (story)world and its events, which carry meaning to the self.

Another useful conceptualisation is *cultural narrative*. Cultural narratives provide a framework through which authors interpret and make sense of their experiences and life events. Cultural narratives also facilitate

⁶⁰ Herman 2009.

⁶¹ Eiranen et al. 2022; Eiranen 2023; Herman 2009.

⁶² Herman 2009, 157.

the sharing of experiences with others and making experiences understandable to an audience. However, cultural narratives are not dictated from the void above, but rather, they are in circular movement with the experiences. The cultural narratives offer frameworks for personal experiences, but they are reciprocally shaped by those experiences. There can also be friction between the expected cultural narrative and the individual experience.⁶³

Especially intense experiences might—or will—resist the frame set by the cultural narrative. In the nineteenth century, the child mortality rate was significantly high. This resulted in the majority of parents facing the experience of losing a child at some point in their lives. The cultural narrative interpreted the deceased child as God’s angel in heaven, who had escaped the sins and perils of the mundane world. Helene Tikkanen, a *Bildungsbürgertum* woman in her twenties, lost her first child when he was one year old. Six months later, she gave birth to another son and the parents felt they had received “recompense”, which was also a typical way of comprehending the situation at the time. However, the second son died at the age of one and a half months.⁶⁴ Subsequently, Helene Tikkanen wrote to her sister:

He had no pain in his final moments but died so exceptionally beautifully that it still brings me great comfort to think about it. We once thought, as he battled with death, that his eyes had closed, but just before he died, he opened them so heavenly beautifully and smiled so angelically (he had never been able to smile before) and looked so happy that I can never forget it; I had never imagined such a beautiful death.⁶⁵

Helene Tikkanen was repeating and living the cultural narrative of losing one’s child. The cultural narrative offered her tools she could depend on in the face of grief. Tragically, the Tikkanens lost a third baby the following year. After so many losses, the power of the cultural narrative started to crumble. It did not make sense to Helene Tikkanen anymore or offer any consolation. She dealt with her grief in various letters and referred to the elements of the cultural narrative several times. This *emotional repetition* can be interpreted as her attempt to reinforce the

⁶³ Meretoja 2017.

⁶⁴ Eiranen 2019, 291–297. See also Davidoff 2013, 309–310.

⁶⁵ NLF, Kellgreniana, Helene Tikkanen to Sofi Kellgren, 6 July 1853.

power of the cultural narrative in order to manage her feelings and try to render them bearable.⁶⁶

The *cultural script* is close to the concept of cultural narrative. Often the definitions of these concepts conflate and fluctuate. However, the cultural script can be defined as a chain of events that people in a specific context expect, but it lacks the narrative quality of experientiality and meaning-making. Hence, the cultural script is a kind of practice that everyone recognises. For instance, when people visit a restaurant, they have a certain chain of events and actions in mind about how the interactions and roles are expected to pan out. They sit down at a table, the waiter comes, gives them the menu, probably first comes to ask for the drinks order, and then brings the drinks, asking what food will be ordered. But this is hardly a narrative.⁶⁷ Hence, cultural narrative is a more useful concept for the study of the history of experience. In contemporary narratology, experientiality is an integral feature of narration, whereas a script describes an expected chain of events and interactions from the surface level and from a detached perspective. If it starts to include experiential elements or meaningful causality (causality that requires narrative meaning-making), it is rather a cultural narrative than a cultural script.

Historians have utilised other concepts inspired by narrative studies as well. *National narratives* and their construction, for instance in politics and historiography, have been of interest in historical research. In the history of experience, scholars have studied how personal experiences intertwine and are constructed in relation to the national narrative and turning points.⁶⁸ Also, some phenomena can be examined as cultural *masterplots*. For example, a Christian conversion story can be detached from its origins and recycled in many ways within culture—as evidenced by the aforementioned working-class autobiographies centred on ideological conversion. The story maintains its power as a moral lesson, but people cease to be aware from whence it comes. The same structure of the conversion story has been found in contemporary social media stories, where they circulate effectively.⁶⁹

⁶⁶ Eiranen 2019, 291–297.

⁶⁷ See Hyvärinen 2020.

⁶⁸ Berger & Lorenz 2008; Haapala 2021; Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021.

⁶⁹ Katajala-Peltomaa & Mäkelä 2022, esp. 17–18.

In the contemporary world, social media and the unlimited relationality of the online world have superseded the more traditional forms of life-writing as a means of self-construction. In social media, self-construction takes visual and audio forms in addition to—or even more so than—writing. The pervasiveness of social media in everyday life can also affect the way people experience things. This phenomenon can be called “life publishing”. When people experience something great or interesting, they might concurrently ponder how this event would look on their social media profiles, should they photograph or film it, and in what manner.⁷⁰ In social media, diverse experiential stories circulate, with the potential to attain narrative authority through the alleged authenticity of the experiences depicted. These stories often lean on certain masterplots or cultural narratives. In an extreme form of this phenomenon, it does not even matter whether the story is true or not if it is compelling and viral enough. “This is how things are experienced” is an unfortunately famous quote from a Finnish populist politician. All this is connected to post-truth politics and the story economy.⁷¹

CONCLUSION

Egodocuments and life-writings are popular sources for trying to reach the inner thoughts, feelings, and experiences of people of the past. The question of authenticity—of reaching the unmediated and “real” experience—has often theoretically haunted the field. However, nowadays the consensus among historians of experience is that experience is always constructed in a cultural, social, and historical context. Hence, egodocuments and life-writings can be regarded as spaces for the construction of experience.

The initial interest when studying egodocuments and life-writings is directed towards the content of the text. For historians of experience, also the experience of writing is of importance. Besides our own theoretical ponderings, we must take into consideration how the writers themselves understood the act of writing and its meaning. For instance, in the nineteenth-century *Bildungsbürgertum* writing culture, the letters were very “real” and part of the mutual relationship, even thought to reveal

⁷⁰ Östman 2015.

⁷¹ Mäkelä & al. 2021; Katajala-Peltomaa & Mäkelä 2022.

the most inner self to the other. Conversely, for a self-taught common writer, expressing oneself through writing could be a very laborious effort, while sending a letter to a person in power or describing one's life to an institutional collector could also be a deeply empowering experience.

These source types are often classified in terms of publicity and privacy. However, we have sought to show that on closer examination, many sources are kinds of “hybrids” containing both public and private features. We argue that the main issue is the intended audience. This relationality defines in what way the writer constructs their experience in the source. Further, contextualisation of different sources from the same author reveals valuably how the writer constructs their experience in different relationships and different times and places. This mutual comparison can reveal how one should weigh different texts.

Egodocuments and life-writings contain different temporal layers. Again, they can be hybrids, for instance, an old diary conflated with a memoir written later in life. The experiences constructed in correspondence often contain temporal fluctuation as the recipient is in a different time and place from the writer, but still the letter brings them together onto the same spatiotemporal plane.

Narrative approaches can offer a lot for the analysis of egodocuments and life-writing. Especially with regard to the history of experience, narrative theories that underline experientiality as part of the definition of narrative can be very fruitful when adjusted to the needs of historical research. Also, when tackling the cultural context, the concepts of cultural narrative, cultural script, and masterplot can help reveal structures of experience present in the writers' life world and text.

While close reading remains essential for the study of egodocuments and life-writing, it can be powerfully complemented by computer-assisted distant reading, which enables the analysis of large corpora and associated metadata. Techniques such as keyword frequency analysis and collocation analysis can provide quantitative support for interpretations derived from close reading and help redirect qualitative inquiry, for example by pinpointing periods of particularly rapid linguistic and ideological change. This type of computational analysis has been used, for example, to mine emotional language or formulaic expressions from large letter corpora and to identify their changes over time.⁷²

⁷² Taskinen, Turunen, Uusitalo, & Kivimäki 2022; Taskinen, Turunen, Uusitalo, & Kivimäki 2021; Suodenjoki 2024.

Looking ahead, scholars of egodocuments and life-writing will undoubtedly turn increasingly to the possibilities offered by artificial intelligence and machine-learning models. These tools perform particularly well, for instance, at identifying semantic equivalences across languages, thus enabling advanced research designs that span linguistic and cultural boundaries. However, the use of these tools also presents challenges, one of which is the mathematical complexity and resulting lack of transparency of machine-learning models. Moreover, most large language models are trained on contemporary data and thus reflect modern understandings of words and concepts.⁷³ These are critical concerns for a scholar whose main aim is to shed light on the experiences of people in a specific historical context.

A fundamental question in the study of egodocuments and life-writing is the relation between the textual description of the experience and the experience that was lived through in the described moment. Firstly, a devil's advocate can raise the question of truthfulness (or "authenticity" if they are not yet over that phase). In a way, if we do not have a particular reason to doubt the writers' sincerity, we should probably take seriously what they are saying. And even when the writer is lying or calculating, their choice to do so may reveal a great deal about how they experienced the world around them. Secondly, the writer's skill and ability to write affects how the lived-through experience can be put into words. It can be a twofold issue: being untrained in writing can lead to an inability for self-expression but also to a more direct and stream-of-consciousness-like expression. Trained writers could be more conscious of how to express themselves, taking away some of the spontaneity of the expression, but it also afforded such writers more resources in their expression. Thirdly, the issue can be nuanced, for instance, by considering what cultural models the writer is utilising in interpreting and textualising the experience. For instance, hints of a romantic worldview and ideals can be detected in many nineteenth-century letters describing powerful experiences. However, this does not make the experience "untrue" or "inauthentic", but rather gives us information about what kind of cultural models affected the writers' construction of their own experiences—what cultural resources they used in making sense of their own personal experience.

⁷³ Turunen & Taskinen 2024.

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Oral History as a Source for the History of Experience

Antti Malinen 

Historians have long recognised the research value of memory-based sources. These sources provide unique insights and perspectives that are often absent from official documents and written texts. As early as the nineteenth century, historians such as Jules Michelet acknowledged the importance of oral testimonies in capturing the lived experiences of ordinary people. In his study of the French Revolution, Michelet contrasted official documents with the recollections of “peasants, townsfolk, old men, women, even children; which you can hear if you enter an evening into a village tavern”.¹ This approach highlighted the potential of memory-based sources to offer a counter-narrative to formal records, adding depth to historical understanding.

During the nineteenth century, however, the professionalisation of historical research under the influence of Leopold von Ranke shifted the discipline’s focus towards written documents and archival sources.

¹ Ritchie 2015, 2.

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Ranke's emphasis on "wie es eigentlich gewesen" ("how it actually was") led historians to prioritise official records, often sidelining oral testimonies and personal recollections as subjective or unreliable.² Nevertheless, even within this document-driven paradigm, certain historians continued to see the value of memory-based materials, particularly in contexts where official records were scarce or silent.

In Finland, for example, the collection of written memory materials has a long tradition rooted not only in the preservation of folklore and working-class traditions but also as part of the nation-building process inspired by romantic nationalism. The Finnish Literature Society (SKS), founded in 1831, and the Society of Swedish Literature in Finland, established later in the nineteenth century, played pivotal roles in gathering folklore, oral history, and personal narratives as a form of "national work", embedding individual stories into the broader national narrative.³

The SKS established a folklore archive in the 1930s, creating a network of memory respondents who contributed to large-scale collections of personal reminiscences and oral traditions.⁴ Initially focused on folklore, these collections evolved to include more personal narratives, particularly from the 1960s onwards, when life history methods gained prominence in both academic and archival contexts. This shift mirrored broader international trends in oral history, where the focus moved towards documenting the experiences of ordinary people and marginalised groups, voices "hidden from history".⁵

An essential aspect of memory-based sources is their subjectivity and interpretative nature. Memory opens a window onto the meanings attributed to experiences, a perspective that Wilhelm Dilthey articulated in his collected works:

The person who seeks the connecting threads in the history of his life has already, from different points of view, created a coherence in that life which he is now putting into words. He has created it by experiencing values and realizing purposes in his life, making plans for it, seeing his past in terms of development and his future as the shaping of his life and of whatever he values most. He has, in his memory, singled out and accentuated the

² Thomson 2000, 55.

³ Kivimäki et al. 2021, 18.

⁴ Kivilaakso et al. 2022, 89.

⁵ Perks & Thomson 2003, ix; Haapala & Markkola 2017.

moments which he experienced as significant; others he has allowed to sink into forgetfulness. The future has corrected his illusions about the significance of certain moments. Thus, the first problem of grasping and presenting historical connections is already half solved by life.⁶

Dilthey emphasised memory as an active process involving the selection and maintenance of significant memories. This aligns with the contemporary understanding of how memories are constructed and reinterpreted over time. However, Dilthey's insights into life histories, memory processes, and the narrative nature of historical research were slow to gain traction in historical practice.

Over the past few decades, memory has become a central concern of historical scholarship. This surge in interest is driven by multiple factors: social historians' efforts to access the experiential aspects of social processes, the methodological advancements of oral historians in understanding the mental and social dynamics of remembering, and the desire of cultural and social historians to explore the intersections of orality and literacy.⁷ Additionally, contemporary historians have increasingly engaged with the representation of the past in political and ideological contexts and sought to address the traumatic impacts of war, genocide, and systemic injustice.⁸

In this chapter, I examine how oral history sources are created through interactive and dialogical processes, where interviewers, interviewees, and sometimes additional participants, such as family members or group members, collaboratively produce narratives of memory. Understanding these dynamics is essential for the history of experience, as they reveal how past events are reframed, shared, and endowed with meaning in the very act of narration. These narratives are not static recollections but are shaped by the conditions of their telling. As Alessandro Portelli has noted, every act of remembering involves a dialectical relationship between the *narrated self* (at the time of the event) and the *narrating self* (at the time of the telling).⁹ In oral history interviews, memories are not simply retrieved but reconstituted within the dynamics of the present moment.

⁶ Dilthey 1914, *Gesammelte Schriften*; translation by Rickman, 1961, 86.

⁷ Cubitt 2007, 2.

⁸ Swain et al. 2018; Malinen, Markkola & Hytönen 2019, 1–2.

⁹ Portelli 1991, 185.

In this process, new experiences may be created through the act of narration, while earlier memories, and the experiences embedded in them, may be reshaped to fit the narrator's current life situation and expectations for the future.¹⁰

Drawing on fieldwork conducted in two research projects involving adult care-leavers, the Finnish Child Welfare Inquiry (2014–2016) and the *Kuulluksi* Forums (2023–2024), I explore how oral history both opens windows into experiences and reflects the conditions of its own production. Especially in the context of sensitive topics related to difficult childhood experiences, oral history interviews are not only discursive but also embodied encounters, where emotions, such as grief, anger, relief, and hope, are expressed through voice, gesture, silence, or even physical reactions. I reflect on the historian's active role as a producer of source material, particularly in settings where memory and oral history serve as tools for enquiry. The sources examined include interviews documented in various forms, written notes, transcriptions, and audio recordings, each presenting distinct challenges and opportunities for historical interpretation.

This reflection also offers insights into how memory-based sources created in interview settings by other professionals, such as social workers, psychologists, and medical practitioners, are similarly constructed.¹¹ In historical research, especially in fields such as the history of medicine or childhood, we often analyse case files or institutional records that include interview material. Like oral history interviews, these documents are co-created narratives shaped by interaction. The performative nature of oral history emphasises that recounting past experiences is not a passive retrieval of memories, but an active reconstruction shaped by the interview context.¹² The historian's role is therefore never neutral: researchers frame the process and shape the resulting narratives.

Finally, I consider what contextual information about the creation of oral history sources may be lost between the moment of the interview and the archived material. Ethical requirements, anonymisation, and technical processes such as transcription inevitably reshape the material. By reflecting on my experiences in the two research projects, I examine how

¹⁰ Thomson 2012, 90.

¹¹ See also Pihko, 2024.

¹² Pollock 2005.

the dynamic nature of memory construction is shaped not only by interaction in the interview setting but also by the material and institutional afterlives of oral history data. From a history of experience perspective, oral history sources not only capture experiences, understood as the meanings individuals attach to their past, but also illuminate how such experiences and the narratives built around them are formed, mediated, and understood over time.

The interpretive challenges and opportunities raised by these dynamics are addressed in four concise “toolkit” sections integrated throughout the chapter. Each toolkit distils key analytical and practical considerations for working with oral history as a source for the history of experiences. They are not intended as comprehensive guides for interview practice, but as concise aids for historians in approaching oral history materials, whether collected firsthand or encountered in archives, with a focus on how experiences are narrated, remembered, silenced, and transformed from live encounters into archival records. Framed in this way, the toolkits support reflexive, context-sensitive interpretation while remaining adaptable to diverse research contexts.

ORAL HISTORY AS A SOURCE: POSSIBILITIES AND CHALLENGES

“Oral history” as a concept refers to both a methodology and a type of historical source. Methodologically, it involves collecting, preserving, and interpreting personal recollections and testimonies, most commonly through recorded interviews, but also through other forms of memory documentation. As a source, an oral history can take the form of spoken memoirs, audio or video recordings, transcripts, or even written responses to archival surveys. According to Alessandro Portelli, oral history is not just about “what the historians hear (the oral sources) and what the historians say or write”, but also about “what the source and the historian do together at the moment of their encounter in the interview”.¹³

While traditionally centred on recorded interviews, the field has broadened to include a wide range of memory-based sources, from autobiographical writings to courtroom testimonies. This expansion reflects a shift in methodological thinking, particularly in the Nordic and

¹³ Portelli 1998, 23.

Baltic contexts, where “memory studies research” (*muistitietutkimus* in Finnish) values diverse personal narratives, even those not produced through formal oral history projects.¹⁴

The methodological and ethical challenges of using oral history sources stem from their very nature as co-constructed narratives. Unlike traditional documents that were created independently of the historian, oral history is produced through a dialogical process between interviewer and interviewee, or in the case of written reminiscences, between archive and respondent, sometimes referred to as the “writing to the archive” genre or “oral history texts”.¹⁵ This means that the historian is not merely a passive recipient of information but an active participant in shaping the narrative. The questions asked, the rapport established, and the responses given all contribute to the final form of the testimony.¹⁶ This dynamic nature of oral history sources is both a strength and a challenge. It allows historians to explore the meanings and interpretations that individuals attach to their experiences, offering a deeper understanding of the process of experiencing and how people make sense of their past. At the same time, this dynamism complicates interpretation, as the narratives are shaped by the narrator’s subjectivity, the relational context of the interview, and the conditions under which they are later documented and archived.

Memory, as the raw material of oral history, is not a static repository of facts but a fluid and reconstructive process. Individuals selectively remember, reframe, and sometimes forget past events, influenced by present circumstances, cultural narratives, and emotional states. This aligns with Geoffrey Cubitt’s (2019) view that memory involves both personal and social dimensions, where individual recollections are shaped by broader societal frameworks of meaning. Memories are not merely retrieved but actively constructed in the act of narration, often blending personal experience with collective cultural stories. This constructionist view of memory highlights the need for oral historians to approach their sources with both curiosity and caution. The narratives collected are not objective accounts of the past but reflections of how individuals understand and articulate their experiences within specific contexts.

¹⁴ Savolainen & Taavetti 2017, 21–22.

¹⁵ Latvala 2016.

¹⁶ Ritchie 2015, 7.

The cultural context plays a critical role in shaping what kinds of stories can be told and how experiences are articulated.¹⁷ This influence is particularly evident when examining the societal conditions that facilitate or hinder open discussions about difficult experiences. For example, in post-WWII Finland, the political leadership encouraged citizens to focus on rebuilding the nation and looking to the future, leaving little room for public discussions about personal suffering and loss. Expressing one's hardships in public was often seen as inappropriate, contributing to a culture of silence surrounding war-related traumas and other sensitive topics.¹⁸

Over time, however, the expansion of “therapeutic culture” and the increasing availability of psychological language in everyday discourse opened new cultural spaces for speaking about difficult experiences. As societies became more attuned to psychological well-being, the act of voicing one's suffering gained cultural legitimacy. For example, the concept of trauma, which originated in medical and psychiatric contexts, began to enter everyday language from the 1960s onwards.¹⁹ This shift was influenced by broader international discussions, particularly those surrounding Vietnam War veterans and the long-term effects of combat stress. By the 1980s, the formalisation of post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) in the DSM-III (1980) solidified trauma's status not only as a clinical diagnosis but also as a cultural framework for interpreting and communicating personal hardship.²⁰

This cultural transformation has also shaped the methodological and ethical considerations of oral history projects dealing with sensitive memories and experiences, including the Finnish Child Welfare Inquiry (2014–2016) and the *Kuulluksi* Forums (2023–2024). These projects, which focus on sensitive topics related to childhood experiences in foster care, operate within a societal context where the acknowledgement of past traumas and the provision of platforms for survivors to share their stories are increasingly recognised as forms of social justice and recognition. They provide concrete examples of how oral history can both illuminate lived experiences and reflect the broader conditions of its own production.

¹⁷ Goffman 1963; Norrick 2005; Savolainen 2017.

¹⁸ Laurén & Malinen 2021.

¹⁹ Malinen 2024.

²⁰ Kivimäki 2018.

Toolkit 1. Preparing and Contextualising Oral history for the History of Experience

Analytical considerations:

- Consider the interview as a situated social encounter: How do spatial arrangements, body language, and the material environment shape the dynamics? (These factors can influence the comfort level, openness, and trust between interviewer and interviewee.)
- Examine relational positioning: How are authority, vulnerability, or solidarity signalled between the interviewer and interviewee? (These dynamics can influence what is shared, how it is framed, and the level of trust established in the encounter.)
- Reflect on interviewer reflexivity: How might the interviewer's background, experiences, or aims (e.g. as a state-commissioned investigator) have shaped the interaction and the resulting narrative?
- Pay attention to the role of non-verbal communication (e.g. pauses, gestures, changes in tone) in shaping meaning. (These cues can convey emotion, hesitation, or emphasis that words alone may not capture.)

Practical advice:

- When conducting interviews yourself, document the physical and relational context alongside the verbal content.
- If working with existing recordings or transcripts, note what contextual details are available and how their absence might affect interpretation.

FROM PRIVATE MEMORIES TO SHARED EXPERIENCES: THE FINNISH CHILD WELFARE INQUIRY (2014–2016)

One fairly recent example of oral history methods being used to recover and to give recognition to marginalised experiences is the Finnish Inquiry into the Failures of Child Welfare, conducted in 2014–2016.²¹ Commissioned by the Finnish Ministry of Social Affairs and Health, the Inquiry had three main objectives: (1) to produce knowledge on the extent and nature of neglect, abuse, and violence experienced in out-of-home care;

²¹ Hytönen et al. 2016; Malinen et al. 2019.

(2) to make visible all forms of neglect, abuse, and violence against children in out-of-home care, underlining that all these forms are, and always were, unacceptable; and (3) to learn from the past and to develop present and future child welfare.²²

The Inquiry formed part of a broader international wave of historical abuse inquiries in the early twenty-first century aimed at uncovering past wrongs and giving survivors a chance to be heard.²³ Its strong moral objective brought the research approach close to the oral history tradition of “giving voice to the voiceless”—bringing forward those hidden from conventional histories.²⁴ Unlike many other inquiries, the Finnish Inquiry examined not only institutional care but also foster homes, providing a broader perspective on out-of-home care.

Investigators did not challenge the truthfulness of interviewees’ narratives, reflecting the Inquiry’s commitment to provide a safer space for survivors to share their stories without fear of disbelief or judgement. This approach aligned with the principle of treating survivors’ accounts as valid on their own terms, echoing practices in truth and reconciliation processes, where bearing witness is valued as a form of justice.²⁵ Despite this approach, the Inquiry sought to place interviewees’ observations, such as those concerning specific forms of abuse, within a broader historical context.

The Inquiry’s interview process revealed a wide spectrum of narrative styles and demonstrated how the dynamics of the interview setting shaped each testimony. Some interviewees were voicing their painful childhood memories for the very first time during these interviews. Their accounts were often halting or fragmented as they struggled to put traumatic experiences into words. In other cases, the participants had told their stories before, perhaps to family members, therapists, or in earlier attempts to seek justice, and thus they provided well-structured accounts that followed a more coherent, sometimes even rehearsed storyline.

²² Malinen et al. 2019, 3.

²³ Swain et al. 2018.

²⁴ Fingerroos & Peltonen 2006.

²⁵ Sköld 2015.

In one such instance, a female narrator brought with her a letter she had written years earlier to her deceased brother.²⁶ Reading the letter aloud during the interview, she expressed a need to make sense of her past and to speak to someone who could no longer answer. She also explained that she had worked through her experiences extensively in therapy. Her contribution to the interview, then, was not a spontaneous act of recollection, but part of a long-term process of emotional processing, meaning-making, and narrative construction. This example highlights how oral history interviews sometimes involve material that has been carefully shaped in advance. What appears to be testimony offered in the moment may in fact reflect years of prior reflection and preparation. Oral history, in such cases, becomes a space where already-formed experiential knowledge is shared, not merely discovered, and where the historian encounters experience as something that has been actively carried, curated, and eventually entrusted to another.

While some participants, like this one, reflected long-term personal processing and a readiness to share, others approached the interview with a different purpose and emotional focus, for example, using the interview as an opportunity to demand acknowledgement and to ask why those wrongs had not been remedied or compensated. This diversity in storytelling highlights the complexity of what might be considered an “authentic” account of experience. Far from being a neutral mirror of past events, each oral narrative was shaped by the interviewee’s prior storytelling (or prolonged silence), by their emotional state in the moment, and by their personal aims in sharing their history.

What interviewees shared in the Inquiry was profoundly influenced by the social and emotional context of the interview itself. Any life story, even a deeply personal and painful one, is narrated using culturally available frameworks and conventions. In the Finnish interviews, for example, some survivors (especially those seeking some form of justice) implicitly adopted a testimony genre: they structured their narratives almost like a witness statement to emphasise the wrongs done to them. Others, speaking about trauma for the first time, lacked such narrative templates and produced more broken or tentative stories.

These contrasting forms of narration are shaped by existing structures of experience: culturally available scripts such as the formalised testimony

²⁶ Woman, born 1960–1964, Finnish Child Welfare Inquiry, 2014–2016, unpublished transcript.

of institutional victimhood, the moral arc of the survivor narrative, and the implicit hierarchies and silences embedded in child welfare systems. Such frameworks influence not only how individuals make sense of their past but also how they present it to others. For historians of experience, recognising these patterns is crucial, as they show how lived events are filtered through shared cultural forms that determine what can be said, how it can be heard, and which meanings are likely to resonate in a given context. In all cases, the interview situation became part of the story: the presence of a sympathetic listener, the knowledge that this was an official inquiry, even the awareness of the recording device—each element influenced how the interviewees constructed meaning from their past.

From a history of experience perspective, such variation is highly significant: it reveals not only what people remember, but how available cultural forms, situational contexts, and institutional settings shape the way experiences are articulated, framed, and made intelligible to others. This, in turn, affects how historians can access and interpret the meanings of past events.

The Inquiry also illustrates how power dynamics are interwoven with interview dynamics, subtly shaping the content of the oral histories produced. Oral history methodologists emphasise that interviews are collaboratively created encounters in which both narrator and interviewer influence the outcome—the interview is a joint effort, not just the narrator's monologue. At the same time, the interviewer's social position and institutional role can create an asymmetry of power that affects what interviewees are willing or able to share. In the Finnish project, the research team was keenly aware of this and attempted to cultivate an informal, empathetic atmosphere to offset the formality and authority they represented.

These power relations are themselves part of the historical process that shapes how experiences are voiced, withheld, or reframed. For historians of experience, attending to these dynamics is crucial for tracing how lived realities are mediated in the moment of narration, and for recognising the interpretive boundaries set by the interview context.

However, archived materials rarely capture the nuanced ways in which interview dynamics are constructed. Many aspects of the interview situations, ranging from the interviewer's choice of clothing to the tone of small talk and the subtleties of greetings and handshakes, often remain undocumented. These seemingly minor interactions can play a significant role in setting the tone for the interview, influencing the

interviewee's level of comfort and openness. By focusing solely on the recorded content, researchers examining archived oral histories might miss the subtle, embodied ways in which trust and rapport are built—or, conversely, how power dynamics might unintentionally reinforce barriers to open communication.

Despite the research team's efforts to create an informal and empathetic atmosphere, many participants still perceived the interviewers as authority figures. The Inquiry's final report noted that the academic and official background of the interviewers lent them an aura of credibility and also power. For many interviewees, this was actually reassuring—they saw the researchers as trustworthy professionals who would finally hear and validate their long-suppressed stories, especially since so many had previously felt dismissed or ignored by officials. This trust, at least in the reading of the research team, often encouraged deeper sharing. On the other hand, some interviewees viewed the interviewers as representatives of the same state system that had once failed or harmed them; those individuals, in turn, shaped their stories more aggressively or strategically, emphasising their suffering and their demands for justice and compensation. In these instances, the narrators calibrated their testimonies in response to the perceived power of the listener—effectively addressing the state through the person of the interviewer.

This interplay shows that who is asking the questions (and under what auspices) profoundly influences oral history narratives. Power dynamics are inherent in any interview: the interviewer typically guides the conversation, and that framing can privilege certain topics or interpretations. Oral history as a discipline has explicitly sought to equalise this relationship by elevating the narrator's voice and perspective.²⁷ This ethos was evident in the Finnish Inquiry's practice of not interrogating or challenging personal testimonies. Even so, the Finnish case makes clear that empowerment is a negotiated process rather than a simple outcome. The authority of the interviewer (as a researcher and as a state-commissioned investigator) never fully disappears; it operates in tandem with the interviewee's agency. The resulting narrative, what actually enters the historical record, is thus a product of both collaboration and tension. The child welfare interviews, taken together, show oral history as a space where survivors' authentic voices were indeed heard, yet those voices were

²⁷ Thomson 2000, 9.

inevitably shaped at every step by the interview format and by the power relations embedded in it.

Toolkit 2. Interpreting Memory and Narrative Construction

Analytical considerations:

- Recognise that memories are reconstructed in the act of telling; they are shaped by present concerns and available cultural scripts.
- Consider the narrative self: How does the speaker position themselves within the story? (This can reveal the roles, identities, and values they associate with themselves and others.)
- Attend to shifts in register, metaphor, and emotional tone as indicators of meaning-making.
- Assess temporal influences on memory: How might the passage of time between the event and its recollection have influenced the memory’s reconstruction and integration of new information?

Practical advice:

- Use concepts such as “narrative self” and “scene of experience” to anchor analysis. (These concepts help situate individual accounts within broader cultural and temporal frameworks, linking personal memory to the social worlds in which it was formed and retold.)
- Compare multiple accounts (if available) to identify consistent themes versus context-dependent variations.
- Trace affective and sensory markers in the telling, as these can highlight how an experience was felt and embodied, adding depth beyond the factual content.

SHARING AND SHAPING EXPERIENCE TOGETHER: THE KUULLUKSI FORUMS (2023–2024)

A more recent Finnish project, the *Kuulluksi* (“Being Heard”) Forums of 2023–2024, offers a contrasting example of how interview dynamics, power, and ethics intersect in a group-based oral history setting.²⁸

²⁸ The forums were a part of the Kone foundation project, “Rejected, Unheard, and Gaining a Voice: Children’s Experiences of Abuse in Foster Care and the Barriers and Opportunities for Disclosure, 1950–2025”, which I lead as principal investigator.

The *Kuulluksi* Forums were a series of facilitated discussion forums for adult care-leavers, people who had grown up in foster care or children's homes, to share and reflect on their experiences of the child welfare system. Conceived in collaboration with the national child welfare organisation *Pesäpuu ry*, the project aimed to support collective storytelling and mutual recognition. Drawing on elements of peer support and focus group interviewing, and integrating arts-based methods, the forums became a hybrid space of historical enquiry and communal meaning-making.

Unlike the individual interview conducted in the 2014–2016 Inquiry, the *Kuulluksi* project centred on dialogue among the participants themselves. The presence of multiple listeners, peers, facilitators, artists, and researchers created a narrative dynamic in which experiences were not only recounted but shaped in the moment through shared reflection. From the outset, ethical and emotional safety was at the heart of the methodology, shaping both the structure of the sessions and the content that the participants chose to share.

The organisers recognised that in a group context, recounting traumatic memories of abuse or neglect could risk re-traumatising participants or causing distress to others in the room. To mitigate this, clear ground rules were established and supported by the careful design of the forum settings (see Fig. 3.1). Facilitators asked participants to avoid sharing graphic details of violence or other intensely traumatic content, especially in the group setting. Instead, the discussions were guided to focus on the impacts of those experiences and the broader life narratives of the participants. This precaution illustrates how ethical imperatives can directly shape the form and content of oral history testimony. By explicitly limiting certain kinds of speech, the *Kuulluksi* researchers inevitably influenced the kinds of narratives that emerged. Indeed, the participants tended to describe their experiences in more general or thematic terms, for example, talking about feelings of being unheard in childhood, or the long-term effects of instability in their lives, rather than giving step-by-step accounts of specific abuses. Certain harrowing aspects of their experiences remained unspoken or only alluded to, given the agreed limits of the forum. In oral history, such silences or omissions can be as revealing as what is openly shared; they remind us that personal testimony always involves choices about what to tell and what to withhold. For the history of experience, such selective narration is highly significant: it shapes the historical record of lived experience, determining which aspects of reality

are preserved and which remain absent, thus influencing how historians can reconstruct and interpret past experiences. In this case, the choice was guided by an ethical stance prioritising well-being (both the speakers and listeners). This reflects a growing awareness in oral history practice that researchers have a duty of care when asking people to revisit painful pasts.

Today, institutional review boards and professional guidelines often require researchers using oral history sources to consider the potential



Fig. 3.1 Forum room at the University of Jyväskylä's facilities. Participants had access to comfortable objects to hold and squeeze during the sessions. These tactile items were designed to support emotional regulation and help participants stay grounded while sharing or listening to difficult experiences. Photo: Antti Malinen

harm an interview could cause, for instance by triggering traumatic recollections or violating privacy, especially when working with vulnerable groups. The *Kuulluksi* Forums put such principles into action: the process of sharing was designed to be as important as the content, and priority was given to creating a supportive atmosphere over extracting exhaustive detail. As a result, the historical narratives collected were shaped by what we might call an ethic of care. As researchers, we intentionally constrained the scope of enquiry in order to ensure the safety of the participants.

The forum format introduced a unique interview dynamic that differs from a standard one-on-one setting. In a group, power dynamics are diffused among multiple participants. Each forum was typically facilitated by two researchers and one psychologist, with around 10–12 participants present. The researcher-facilitator's role was more that of a moderator and supportive listener than an interrogator, aiming to create an egalitarian space where no single voice dominated. In a sense, authority was shared not just between interviewer and interviewee, but by all members of the circle. Participants often addressed one another directly, building on shared experiences. This could be empowering, reinforcing that their personal stories formed part of a collective narrative, not isolated incidents. The camaraderie and mutual validation in these sessions helped individuals feel that their experiences were understood and valued by others who had “been there” too.

One participant described a powerful moment of recognition when another person in the group articulated something they had themselves felt but never been able to express. “It was a strange feeling”, the participant noted, “as if someone had said exactly what I was thinking [...] it was a moment of shared experience”.²⁹ Such instances reflect how meaning emerges dialogically in group oral history settings. Rather than producing isolated individual accounts, the *Kuulluksi* Forums created a space in which participants could mirror, affirm, and elaborate on each other's words. These processes of resonance and mutual recognition are not merely emotional reactions—they actively shape how experiences are remembered and framed.

This illustrates what Kivimäki et al (2023) describe as a *community of experience*, where understanding is constructed in relation to others who

²⁹ Participant comment, *Kuulluksi* Forum 3, 2023, unpublished group discussion transcript.

may not have experienced the same events, but they occupy similar affective or social positions, recognising sameness in the experience. As they argue, such communities begin to take shape when individuals recognise experiential similarity, start to negotiate its meaning together, and in that process form new social ties and a shared interpretive space. In oral history contexts, this can be sometimes observed directly, in action.

However, the presence of peers as an audience also influenced how each person told their story. Narrators might self-censor certain details out of concern for others' feelings, or they might shape their account to resonate with themes that had emerged in the group. As oral historians note, any time a story is told before an audience, an element of performance is present: the storyteller is aware of the listeners and may adjust the tone, emphasis, or content accordingly. In the *Kuulluksi* sessions, dialogue among participants often helped individuals make sense of their experiences through collective reflection—for example, one person's account of feeling abandoned might prompt nods of recognition or a follow-up anecdote from another, creating a shared thread of meaning. Through this interactive process, meaning emerged between—not just within—individual narratives. The group itself, in effect, became a kind of joint narrator, piecing together a mosaic of experiences that highlighted common patterns in how the child welfare system had been experienced.

This dynamic illustrates how experience in oral history is often co-produced in relation to others. In the *Kuulluksi* Forums, the “others” included not only the researcher-facilitator but fellow survivors, which broadened the interpretive community present in the moment of narration. From a power perspective, the group format did help to equalise certain aspects of the relationship between the researcher and the participants. No single interviewee was solely in the spotlight the entire time, and participants could support one another if someone became emotional or lost for words. However, new power dynamics within the group came into play. Some individuals naturally spoke more or guided the conversation, while others were hesitant, requiring careful moderation. The facilitators actively tried to manage these imbalances; in the spirit of the project's name *Kuulluksi*, “being heard”, they strove to ensure everyone got a chance to speak and be heard. Still, the researchers' influence was present in how they guided topics and enforced the ground rules. If someone veered towards a deeply graphic description, the facilitator tried to steer them away for the sake of the group's comfort, with

a subtle exercise of authority with intent of protecting participants but also of directing the narrative trajectory. These interventions highlight the constant negotiation in oral history between free expression and ethical restraint.

While many participants valued the structure and safety of the forums, some also expressed a desire to go deeper or to hear and share more. In the *Kuulluksi* format, most discussions took place in smaller breakout groups, where participants could speak in a more intimate setting. Only at the end of each forum did everyone gather in a joint circle for the concluding discussion. As one participant explained in that final round:

Time always ran out – that’s probably what bothered me the most. I would have liked to hear more, and to hear from others, too. On the one hand, it was nice to be in smaller groups, we could go a bit deeper, but then again, I wish we could have heard more from everyone and, and, and talked just a bit more.³⁰

In one small group discussion, another participant expressed the desire to address more difficult, even disturbing experiences, but held back out of consideration for the group’s boundaries.³¹ These reflections illustrate the tension between depth and breadth, and between the structured facilitation and the organic flow of sharing of experiences. From a history of experience perspective, such dynamics are important because they shape not only what is voiced in the moment but also how experiences are collectively framed, prioritised, and remembered. The wish to “speak a bit more” suggests that even in a carefully constructed forum environment, the desire to articulate lived experience may exceed what time and the context can allow. This points to an important epistemological reality: oral history does not simply elicit testimony; it structures and bounds it.

The ethical framework of the *Kuulluksi* Forums highlights one key point in oral history: the process of gathering memories cannot be separated from considerations of power and ethics. Who gets to speak, in what setting, and about which topics are all filtered through ethical choices made by the researchers. By asking participants to avoid certain subject matters, the organisers effectively delineated the boundaries of narratable experience in that project. This may have limited the completeness

³⁰ Participant, *Kuulluksi* Forum 4, 2024, unpublished group discussion transcript.

³¹ Field notes, *Kuulluksi* Forum 3, 2024.

of the historical record, but it reflects the ethical imperative—central to contemporary oral history practice—of prioritising the participants' well-being.

As the *Kuulluksi* case shows, following ethical requirements can mean purposefully shaping the narrative by excluding certain details. Importantly, this does not invalidate the oral histories produced; rather, it gives them a particular character. The stories that emerged from *Kuulluksi* emphasised coping, resilience, and the felt experience of growing up in care more than the forensic particulars of abuse. Moreover, the ethical restraint likely enabled the participants to engage more openly and thoughtfully in the process, yielding perhaps richer insights into the long-term emotional and social consequences precisely because the environment was psychologically safe.

Toolkit 3. Working with Silences and Omissions

Analytical considerations:

- Treat silences not as absences of data but as potentially meaningful indicators of discomfort, protection, or shared cultural understanding.
- Consider whether omissions reflect the limits of memory, strategic self-presentation, or ethical boundaries.
- Examine the interviewer's role in shaping what remains unsaid (e.g. through topic framing, question wording, or reactions).

Practical advice:

- Compare what is omitted in one interview with what emerges in other sources or contexts.
- Note patterns in silences across interviews to identify systemic factors (e.g. cultural taboos, institutional pressures).
- Respect protective silences while recognising their interpretive value.

FROM ENCOUNTER TO ARCHIVE: DOCUMENTING ORAL HISTORY

A key challenge in using oral history sources for studying the history of experience lies in the variability of the documentation surrounding their creation. This chapter's two examples, drawn from child welfare-related research, demonstrate how ethical requirements, institutional settings, and practical constraints shape what is ultimately recorded and preserved. Those who collect and archive these materials come from diverse professional backgrounds, including historians, social workers, medical professionals, legal investigators, and community organisations.³² Consequently, the quality and depth of contextual information about the interview process, data collection methods, and recording practices can differ significantly. From a history of experience perspective, gaps in contextual detail may limit the ability of researchers to situate testimonies within their social and emotional settings, whereas rich metadata can illuminate how the act of remembering was shaped by its immediate circumstances. Especially in sensitive research contexts, ethical considerations may require the removal of identifying information to protect the participants' privacy, which, while necessary, can also obscure valuable interpretative elements.

The transcription and archiving practices in the two projects were shaped by distinct ethical and institutional frameworks. In the Finnish Child Welfare Inquiry, transcription took place under strict data protection protocols, with audio files later destroyed according to the data management plan. Variations in transcriber experience affected the consistency and detail of the transcripts, and supplementary field notes, produced in some cases, were not preserved. The anonymised transcripts were archived at the Finnish Social Science Data Archive (FSD) with controlled access.

In the *Kuulluksi* Forums, group discussions were transcribed using a secure AI-based service approved for sensitive data. The transcripts are still under review and interpretation. These differing approaches illustrate how ethical requirements, technical tools, and institutional decisions influence what is ultimately preserved and how the lived moment of testimony is transformed into a historical source.

³² Thomson 2007, 9–10.

The interview setting often involves a rich tapestry of communicative elements beyond spoken words.³³ Interviews can include moments of hesitation, silences, or uncomfortable pauses, as well as non-verbal cues such as facial expressions, body language, and gestures. Unlike any other type of primary source, an interviewee can also challenge the researcher's interpretation, walk away, or make coffee during the conversation.³⁴ These elements contribute to the meaning-making process and can provide valuable context for interpreting narratives. In terms of the history of experience, such situational and embodied dimensions are not just background information; they offer insights into the very process of experience, showing how it can be co-created, reshaped, and reframed in the act of sharing and retelling. However, much of this embodied and situational knowledge is difficult to document and may not survive the transition from encounter to archive. For those who conducted the original interviews, embodied memories of the encounter, such as the emotional tone, the interviewee's demeanour, or the atmosphere in the room, can continue to inform their interpretation of the transcript. However, secondary users of the archived material must rely solely on what is captured in the text, making their readings necessarily more detached and interpretively limited.

When interviews exist only as transcripts, the gap between the spoken word and its recorded representation widens.³⁵ The transformation from oral to written form involves processes such as transcription, editing, and selection, which can smooth out the natural rhythms of speech, eliminate repetitions, and reshape the narrative to fit literary conventions. For a historian of experience, this matters because such textual smoothing can erase markers of hesitation, emotional strain, or spontaneity that might reveal how the experience was being re-lived in the act of telling. For example, in the Finnish Child Welfare Inquiry, pauses and changes in tone conveyed difficulty in speaking about certain memories, and they were not always reflected in the written transcripts, making it harder for later readers to grasp the emotional weight of the account.

Therefore, the quality and availability of metadata, such as the information about the interview context, recording conditions, and participant

³³ Portelli Portelli 2005, 64–65.

³⁴ Peniston-Bird 2009.

³⁵ Thomson 2007, 260.

demographics, plays a crucial role in how oral history materials can be interpreted by future users. For instance, knowing whether a care-leaver was interviewed individually or in the presence of peers can alter the historian's interpretation of how candidly certain experiences were shared and how the narrator positioned themselves in relation to others.

Toolkit 4. From Encounter to Archive: Source criticism in Practice

Analytical considerations:

- Analyse how the transition from lived encounter to archived record transforms the material.
- Investigate underlying frameworks: How have the specific ethical guidelines, institutional policies, or legal requirements (e.g. data protection protocols) of the original collection shaped the material's content and preservation?
- Consider how transcription, anonymisation, and editing alter meaning and context.
- Reflect on what is lost (e.g. sensory detail, emotional inflection) and what is retained.

Practical advice:

- Trace the chain of custody for the material to understand its transformations.
- When possible, consult both the raw and processed versions of the material.
- Document your own interpretive decisions to support transparency and reproducibility.

CONCLUSION: WHAT ORAL HISTORY OFFERS TO THE HISTORY OF EXPERIENCE

This chapter has explored the methodological and ethical complexities of using oral history as a source for studying historical experiences. By focusing on two research-based examples involving adult care-leavers, the Finnish Child Welfare Inquiry (2014–2016) and the *Kuulluksi* Forums (2023–2024), it has examined how oral history materials are not merely repositories of remembered events, but dynamic constructions shaped by the conditions of their production.

A key strength of oral history lies in its ability to render visible the social and relational dimensions of experience. When historians themselves are involved in collecting the material, they both receive accounts of past experiences and are present as those experiences are narrated, negotiated, and given meaning in real time. This proximity allows researchers to witness how experiences are shaped dialogically in relation to the questions asked, the presence of other participants, and the emotional and ethical atmosphere of the encounter. The process is never neutral: it is shaped by power relations, ethical safeguards, institutional affiliations, and the expectations that narrators bring to the encounter.

Oral history interviews, especially in group settings such as the *Kuulluksi* Forums, also illuminate the communal and iterative aspects of experience. Participants build upon each other's words, discover shared themes, and co-produce meanings that transcend individual accounts. The concept of "community of experience" becomes more than an analytical tool; it is observable in how stories resonate, echo, or diverge across narrators in shared space. Even in individual interviews, as in the Finnish Inquiry, narrators draw on culturally available genres, testimony, life story, moral argumentation, and other cultural narratives, which shape how their experiences are framed. In this sense, oral history provides historians not only with access to memories but also with insights into the structures of experiencing, the patterns, silences, tensions, and affective layers through which experience becomes knowable and narratable.

At the same time, oral history sources challenge the notion that we can extract direct or unfiltered access to experience. They remind us that what can be said—and how—is contingent on ethical and social conditions. In the *Kuulluksi* Forums, for example, the participants were asked not to recount graphic details of violence to protect the well-being of the others. This ethical framing shaped what became narratable. In the Finnish Inquiry, the interviewer's institutional role affected whether the narrator sought recognition, closure, or justice. Such examples underscore that oral history sources demand epistemological humility: they offer meaningful insights into experience, but those insights are shaped at every level, interpersonally, institutionally, and culturally.

For historians of experience, this means that oral history is not simply a method for collecting "what happened", but a window into how experience becomes shareable and meaningful within particular social worlds. It reveals the interpretive processes through which people understand their lives and communicate them to others, often for the first time. In

this sense, oral history does not only record memory; it performs and transforms it.

Recognising the performative, situated, and ethical dimensions of oral history enhances its analytical value rather than diminishing it. These interpretive possibilities, however, must be understood in relation to how oral history sources are mediated both in the interview encounter and in their documentation and afterlife. As shown in this chapter, transcription practices, ethical restrictions, and institutional frameworks shape what is retained—and what is lost—when memory narratives move from lived interaction to archived material. Historians must therefore approach these sources with attention to their layered formation: they are not only co-created in dialogue, but also re-formed through anonymisation, editing, and archival conventions. Acknowledging these transformations enhances the analytical potential of oral history and grounds its use in a critical awareness of its material and ethical conditions. Yet when approached reflexively, oral history offers historians useful routes into the emotional, social, and cultural textures of experience. It enables us not only to study what people lived through, but how they remember, interpret, and share those lives in relation to others.

This chapter emphasises the need for historians to approach oral history sources with reflexivity and critical awareness. The collaborative nature of interviews, the performative aspects of recounting, and the power dynamics inherent in research settings all contribute to the constructed nature of oral history narratives. By acknowledging the layered and mediated process of memory-making, and of experience itself, historians can better understand how the knowledge embedded in these narratives is produced, framed, and made meaningful within specific social and cultural contexts, and thus appreciate how it resonates with contemporary understandings of the past.

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Court Records as Sources for the History of Experience

Riikka Miettinen  and *Saku Pihko* 

This chapter demonstrates how court records can be used as a source to study experiences in the past. We argue that different types of court records from various historical contexts can be productively approached as evidence of the process through which experiences were constructed and the structures of experience available to historical actors. Court records provide opportunities for the qualitative analysis of experience as the legal processes described in them served as a mediating site where the involved parties (re)interpreted, negotiated, and established the meaning of events and thus produced experiences. Historical court records, however, are

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a diverse body of sources, and each record has its unique form and style pertaining to the type of legal process and court of law from which it originates. Thus, not every court record is equally fruitful for the study of experience. For example, the often laconic and declaratory records of land disputes, probates, and civil cases seldom entail adequate amounts of information to allow for the analysis of historical experience. Nevertheless, court records that describe more complex legal cases that required careful judicial investigation and courtroom negotiations between different parties present opportunities to scrutinise experience as a historical phenomenon.

One of the primary allures of using court records as sources—especially for historians of the premodern era—is the access they seemingly provide to the voices, mentalities, and experiences of “ordinary” people otherwise invisible in the available historical documents. While generations of historians have used various types of court records to explore topics of legal, social, and cultural history, there has been a long-standing agreement on the constructed, mediated, and thus distorting nature of these sources. Historians no longer view court records as unproblematic repositories of the voices of individuals who testified or confessed during a trial. Rather, court records are now approached as complex documents that reflect the historically situated interactions between the legal authorities in charge of the proceedings and the people appearing as defendants, plaintiffs, and witnesses.¹

This methodological emphasis on the constructed nature of court records resonates with recent theoretical developments related to the history of experience. Building on the theories of experience in neighbouring fields and the influential work of Joan W. Scott,² historians of experience criticise attempts to uncover “authentic” experiences from historical sources and reject the non-critical and simplistic use of experience as an explanation for historical phenomena. Instead, they approach experience as something that needs to be explained and emphasise the

¹ See e.g. Arnold & Inquisition and Power 2001, 1–7; Camphuijsen & Page 2019, 2, 9–11; Pihko 2024a, 166; Sabean 2001; Toivo & Willumsen 2022. Famous studies using historical court records to “access” voices, mentalities, and experiences include, e.g. Davis 1983; Ginzburg 1980; Le Roy Ladurie 1990.

² Scott 1991. See the Introduction of this volume.

importance of understanding the inherently constructed nature of experience.³ This chapter follows the tripartite definition of experience as an event, process, and structure. According to this definition, everyday events and occurrences (*Erlebnisse*) are transformed into meaningful, socially shared experiences (*Erfahrungen*) through a contextually situated and intersubjective process of culturally, socially, and materially mediated interpretation and meaning-making. When repeated, these processually constructed experiences crystallise into structures of experience that condition and shape future experiences.⁴

In this chapter, we use examples drawn from inquisition records from medieval Languedoc and secular lower court records from early modern Sweden to show how historians can utilise court records as sources for analysing experience. A typical criminal process, which begins with transgressions and suspicions and progresses towards trial and sentencing, can be understood as a site of mediation where the meaning of past experiences is retrospectively negotiated and constructed through interactions between legal officials, suspects, and witnesses. Thus, a legal process can be taken as a paradigmatic example of how socially shared and legally admissible experiences are produced and how structures of experience are subsequently formed when sentences are communicated to the public. The documentary traces of legal processes, typically consisting of, for example, records of interrogations, confessions, witness statements, and sentences, stand as evidence of the three levels of experience by reflecting their dynamic interplay.

Thus far, the historiographical traditions and methodological discussions devoted to different types of court records have mostly developed on parallel but separate trajectories.⁵ This specialisation has resulted in a dearth of comparative analyses and methodological generalisations. While differences between various types of court records abound, we argue that there nevertheless remains a sufficient degree of similarity between different types of court records and the structure of the legal proceedings

³ Haapala et al. 2024, 1–6; Kivimäki et al. 2021, 10–13; Kivimäki & Toivo 2022, 59–61, 67–68, 70–71. On the conceptual history of experience, see Carr 2014; Jay 2005.

⁴ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022a, 10–15; Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022b; Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2025, 3. See also the introduction of this volume.

⁵ Camphuijsen & Page 2019; Parker & Starr-Lebeau 2017; Pihko 2025, 87, 89–91. See e.g. Einonen & Impola 2021; Koskivirta 2012; Liliequist & Almbjör 2012; Sabeau 2001; Sandall 2012.

that produce them to allow for fruitful comparison and the development of a more widely applicable methodology. In the chapter at hand, we strive to look past the specific details of particular types of court records to extrapolate general methodological guidelines for analysing experience through the documentary traces of legal proceedings. *Mutatis mutandis*, we argue that the methodology formulated in this chapter through the analysis of medieval and early modern court records can also be applied to other types of historical and contemporary court records.

RECOLLECTIONS OF PAST EXPERIENCES

The information content of court records is often retrospective, as they tend to deal with crimes and transgressive activities that took place prior to the trial. Court records mostly document legally relevant facts, such as what had happened, when and where, and who had been present. This evidence, usually garnered from the oral or written testimony given by suspects, plaintiffs, and witnesses, primarily served the agenda of the legal officials, allowing them to map the details of the case, direct further investigations, and reach a legal conclusion. Scribes typically selected and condensed the information heard in the courtroom, transforming and translating it into a written narrative pertaining to the investigative needs and the documentary style of the legal tribunal. Nevertheless, court records, especially those related to criminal cases, sometimes describe events and occurrences from multiple perspectives and in such minute detail that it may seem that they afford glimpses of “lived experiences”. Ultimately, however, no available source allows us to see the authentic, immediate, and non-discursive *Erlebnisse* of historical individuals. Thus, court records, like all historical sources, provide only limited evidence of the first level of experience (experience as event). Even so, at the very least court records tell us about the ways in which people recalled and reported past events and occurrences they had experienced. This was the first step in the process through which experiences were negotiated and constructed during a trial.

Let us now turn to two examples of court records, one medieval and one early modern, which narrate past events related to illicit religious talk and ideation. Both cases are exceptionally detailed, making them well-suited for showcasing the possibilities and limitations of court records as a source for the study of the three levels of experience. First, we will focus on what these documents reveal and what they obscure about the events

and experiences that prompted suspicions and resulted in legal proceedings. These events were recalled, shared, and reshaped during the trial. Later we will show that these written narratives describing past experiences also include evidence of the interpretative processes and structures involved in shaping them.

Inquisition records are a well-known example of medieval court records. From the 1230s onwards, the Catholic Church responded to the threat of heresy by appointing papally mandated heresy inquisitors (*inquisitores heretice pravitatis*) tasked with investigating those suspected of holding heterodox beliefs and participating in illicit religious practices.⁶ Systematic record-keeping played a central role in inquisitorial activities. Every stage of an inquisition process from trial to sentencing was recorded in writing and meticulously archived. The operative efficiency of inquisitorial tribunals stemmed from the active use of these documents.⁷ Inquisition records from the early thirteenth century tend to contain shorter and more formulaic depositions, but the material gradually developed over time so that inquisition records from the later thirteenth century onward provide longer and more detailed depositions.⁸ Thus, the historian of experience is often well-advised to focus on the later sets of records. The pinnacle of this evolution is the early fourteenth-century inquisition register of Jacques Fournier (1285–1342), bishop of Pamiers (and later Pope Benedict XII).⁹ The Fournier register is famous for its long and unusually detailed depositions that dwell extensively on the allegedly unorthodox beliefs of people accused of heresy.¹⁰

One of the many individuals forced to answer for his idiosyncratic religious ideas before the Fournier tribunal was Bernardus de Ortello. In March 1322, Bernardus came to Pamiers voluntarily to confess his transgressions to bishop-inquisitor Fournier. During the hearing, he admitted that he had spoken to certain locals from his Pyrenean home village of Rabat about his doubts concerning the possibility of bodily resurrection.

⁶ On medieval heresy inquisitions, see, e.g. Deane 2011; Given 1997; Kras 2020.

⁷ On the production and use of written documents by inquisitorial tribunals, see Given 1997, 25–51.

⁸ Arnold 2001, 4, 98–99, 102–107.

⁹ On Jacques Fournier, see, e.g. Bueno 2018.

¹⁰ Duvernoy (ed.) 1965 provides an edition of Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, Vat.lat. 4030. For significant works using the Fournier register, see, e.g. Le Roy Ladurie 1990; Arnold 2001; Bueno 2015.

He claimed, however, that this had been a joke and that he, in fact, firmly believed people would be resurrected with their bodies on the Day of Judgement. Despite these excuses, Fournier remained suspicious, and a prosecution ensued after incriminating evidence was obtained from two witnesses in 1323. When Bernardus returned to face the tribunal, now under official suspicion of heresy, he proved uncooperative and declined to add anything to his previous confession. This strategy backfired, as the bishop-inquisitor, armed with witness testimony and the record of the suspect's first confession, concluded that Bernardus was no mere jokester. On the contrary, his words regarding the impossibility of bodily resurrection were pure heresy that stemmed from the errors of the Cathar¹¹ sect. Still neglecting to tell the truth, Bernardus was sent to prison. During his eleven-month imprisonment, Bernardus was questioned on several occasions, but he maintained his silence. In January 1324, Bernardus finally gave in to sustained pressure and provided the tribunal with a thorough confession. He revealed that around seven or eight years earlier, he had been in the cemetery of his local church while graves were being opened to accommodate new burials. Deep in the soil, he saw decomposed bodies, which had been reduced to earth apart from their bones. Based on this observation, he had come to believe that human bodies could never return to life (Fig. 4.1).¹² This record of the legal proceedings against Bernardus provides a telling example of the way in which people were forced to recall and report their prior experiences in the courtroom, and how experiences deemed illicit were subsequently prosecuted.

When we encounter such vivid descriptions of purported experiences in medieval inquisition records, or in any court record, it is important to understand that these documents do not grant direct access to the talk of the deponent or to events prior to the interrogation. The Latin text extant in the Fournier register is not a transcription of Bernardus's oral confession given in the Occitan language. Rather, it is an inquisitorial abstraction of information from his confession. During the hearings, the notary who wrote the minutes selected information based on its perceived legal relevance and later imposed further selection and standardisation when compiling the official record by translating and transforming the vernacular dialogue into Latin and processing it into a coherent, past-tense

¹¹ On Catharism in medieval Languedoc, see Barber 2013; Lambert 1998.

¹² Duvernoy (ed.) 1965, 258–267.

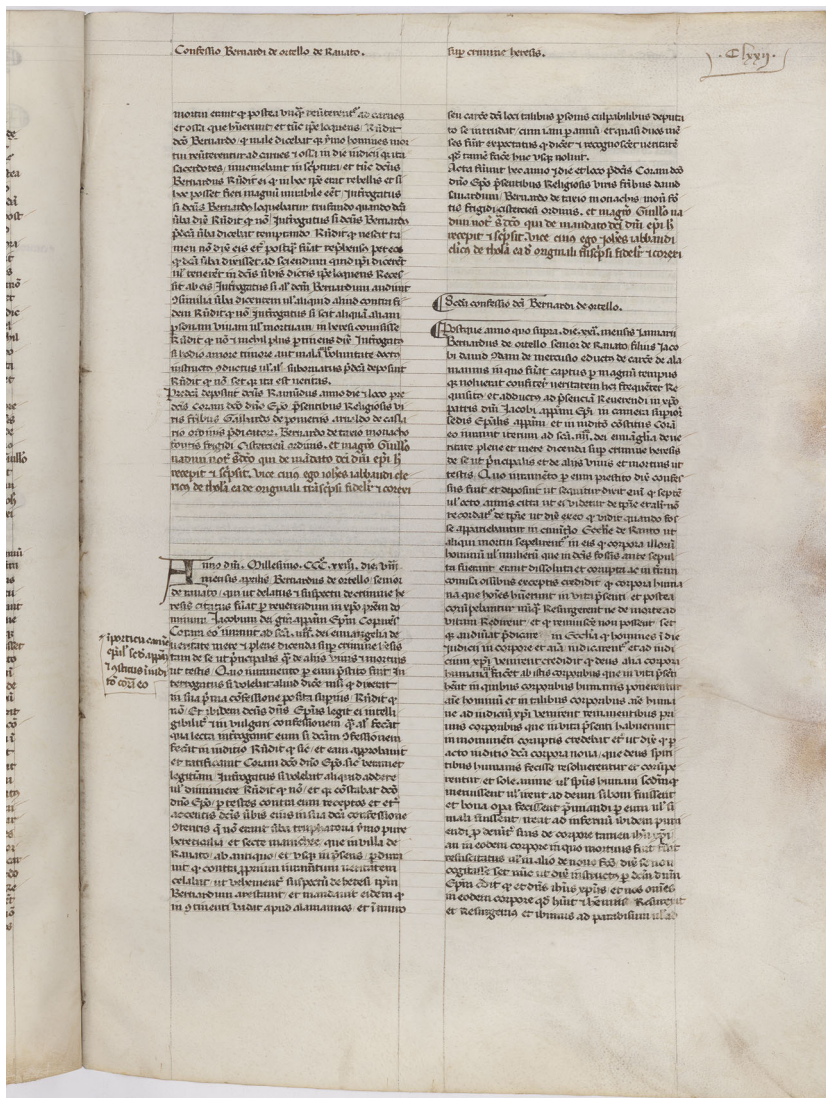


Fig. 4.1 Folio from the record of Bernardus's final deposition, in which he admits the origin of his idiosyncratic beliefs regarding the resurrection of the body. Città del Vaticano, Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, MS Vat.lat.4030, fol. 172r. © 2025 Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana. Reproduced by permission of Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, with all rights reserved

third-person narrative. While the record does not equal Bernardus's talk during the interrogation, the information we are privy to has nevertheless been shaped and conditioned by his confession, the bishop-inquisitor's questions, and the notary's textual practices. Thus, despite the heavily processed nature of the record, it is possible to know at least something of the ways in which Bernardus described his past to the tribunal.¹³

How does this medieval description of Bernardus's startling experience and its implications compare to experienced events and occurrences described in early modern court records? What changes and what remains similar when we move from fourteenth-century Languedoc to eighteenth-century Sweden?

The second example that we use to discuss how experience can be studied comes from early modern Swedish court records. Of early modern judicial documents, the most widely used are the lower court records of rural district courts and town courts. Civil and criminal cases were heard by a judge and a jury, a board of lay members of the court. Cases were heard one by one during the court sessions, with testimonies provided primarily orally by the locals present in the trial. A scribe recorded the minutes (*konceptprotokoll*), keeping track of what took place during the trial and paraphrasing, summarising, and in non-Swedish-speaking areas translating into Swedish what was spoken. Later, he wrote a cleaner transcript (*renoverade dombok*) of the court session minutes that was sent to a respective Court of Appeal to be checked.¹⁴ Generally, the more complex the case or serious the crime, the more detailed and longer are the records. But also, the further back in time the court record dates, the briefer it typically is. Obviously, more detailed records have more potential for the analysis of experience.

The source comes from the lower court records of Northern Ostrobothnia, Finland, where in early 1725 an intricate and lengthy case of blasphemy was brought before the rural district court sessions of Gamla Karleby and Kelviå. As was typical for serious offences, the case was introduced by the county sheriff (*länsman*), who could act as a public prosecutor. Mickel Kerola, a local peasant, had told him about the blasphemous words spoken by Mats Laitinen in a tavern the previous

¹³ Pihko 2024b, 172, 174–175, 178, 181. On source critical issues related to the analysis of medieval inquisition records, see also Arnold 2001; Bruschi 2009; Zbiral & Shaw 2022.

¹⁴ See, e.g. Einoonen & Impola 2021; Koskivirta 2012; Liliequist & Almbjör 2012.

November. At the trial, Mickel described the brief conversation as follows: Mats had said “the eagle flies high”, to which Mickel had asked “where is God when He’s not in Heaven or on Earth?”. Mats then replied “God is in a human’s arse”. Mickel, appalled by these words, had reprimanded Mats, after which Mats had repeated the phrase “the Heavenly army arrives”.¹⁵ The page of the court records describing what Mickel told and including direct quotes also in Finnish is shown below in Fig. 4.2.

Witness after witness came forward to share what they had heard of the blasphemous conversation between the two drunken men. This case turned into a prolonged and complex investigation, spanning several days over two court sessions in January and September and expanding to discuss visions, witchcraft, bestiality, and mental health, among other things. In total, the court records comprise 45 pages, which is exceptional for any court case. As they dealt with a capital offence, the records were immediately copied and forwarded to the Turku Court of Appeal so that it could reinspect them and revise or confirm the sentence.¹⁶

The court records follow an established structure with judicial phrases and modelled formulations especially at the beginning and end of each record and each case. But the main part—information about what happened in the trial, narrative about the crime, dispute, claims or such, and contents of the heard oral statements and testimonies—is the most crucial and fruitful for analysing experiences and their construction process. In this case, the chronology of what (is described to have) happened during and after the offence and during the trials appears very clear-cut. The official situation influenced what was questioned and spoken of in the public trials, and the scribe tried selectively to compile coherent narratives of these and include the relevant evidence to serve the needs and aims of the judicature. As the record was (to be ideally) read out loud at the end of the hearing, the descriptions about the events during the trial and the recorded testimonies and claims can be considered relatively reliable.

¹⁵ National Archives of Finland (NAF): Collection of *renoverade domböcker* (RT) Northern Ostrobothnia KO a 41: 105–111, 7–11 January 1725, Kokkola/Gamla Karleby & Kälviä.

¹⁶ NAF: RT Northern Ostrobothnia KO a 41: 105–111, 7–11 January 1725, and 1810–1849, 10–13 September 1725, Kokkola & Kälviä.

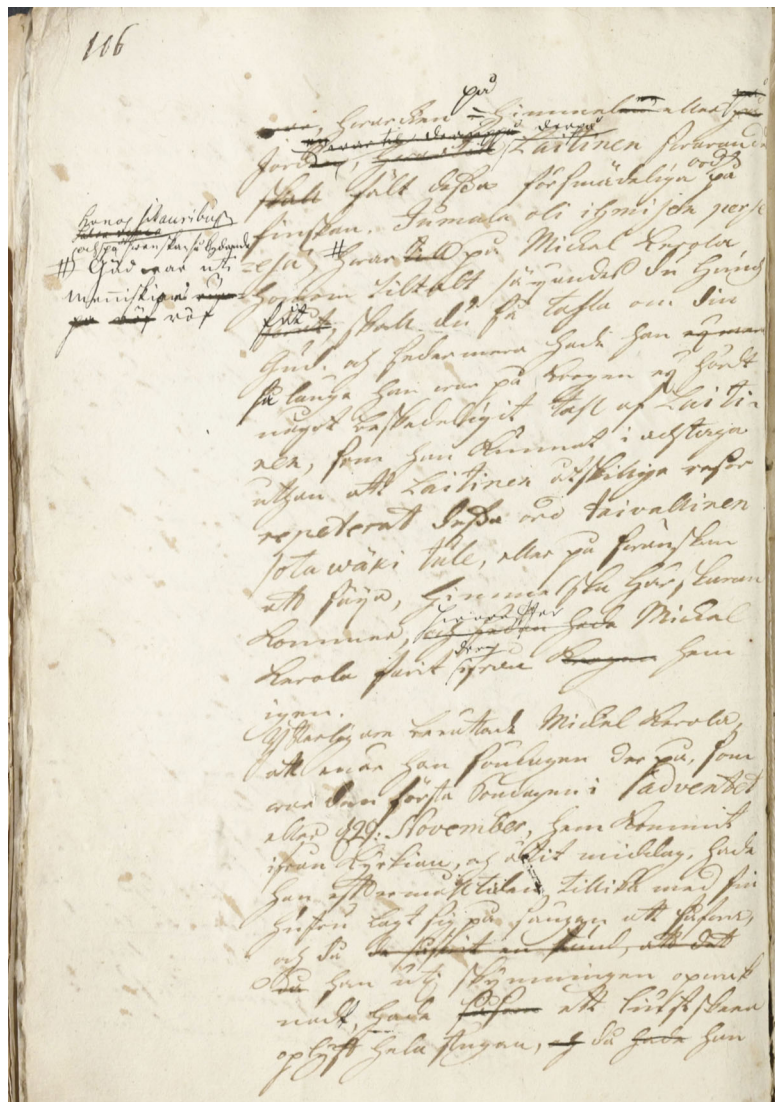


Fig. 4.2 Page of the lower court records that describes parts of Mickel Kerola's first accounts about the conversation in the tavern and the ensuing nocturnal vision. Kansallisarkisto (National Archives of Finland): RT Northern Ostrobothnia (Pohjois-Pohjanmaan tuomiokunnan renovoidut tuomiokirjat) KO a 41: 106, Korkola & Kälviä, 7–11 January 1725. Digitised file 57: <https://astia.narc.fi/uusiastia/viewer/?fileId=6809871755&aineistoId=651463862>

Typically, like in medieval inquisition records, the words spoken were mainly paraphrased by the scribe into past-tense third-person narratives. However, this case also includes one written deposition and short pieces of interrogations recorded in question- and answer-form. Also, the records of this case, due to the severity of the crimes suspected, include direct quotes both in Finnish and Swedish, especially when investigating the blasphemous conversation. The parties and witnesses involved had differing memories about it—the accused Mats vehemently denying that he had said anything of the sort and blaming Mickel's and others' intoxication and bad memory for making up or distorting his words. Throughout the two trials, over a dozen witnesses who had been present in the tavern tried to recall and make sense of what they had heard.

Alongside information about the event, or talk, that Mickel and many others had experienced as blasphemy, the court records include descriptions of various other past, pre-trial experiences of the people involved. Those of most interest were events experienced as witchcraft, supernatural visions, and claims of bestiality, which were further renegotiated in the trials. These will be further discussed in the later sections when exploring the use of court records to study the processes and structures of experience.

Memory is another important variable that influences the formation of experiences,¹⁷ as well as the evidence of past experiences found in court records. When brought to trial, defendants and witnesses had to recall and reinterpret their memories of past events and occurrences. Once people voiced their memories, it became the prerogative of the legal officials to interpret these memory-based reports from their own perspective and to formalise this interpretation into the court record. Psychological research has emphasised the reconstructive nature of memory. While the formation and recollection of memories entails acquiring, retaining, and retrieving information, the act of remembering is best understood as an active and selective process of interpretation with a high rate of inaccuracy and error. Memories are reconstructed from the perspective of the present, and they are extremely sensitive to contextual influences. This is a particularly pronounced aspect of remembering in the context of a trial, as the questions posed by legal officials and the pressures of the courtroom encounter affected how people remembered their past and how

¹⁷ Kivimäki 2019, 9, 17–18, 23–24; Pihko 2024a.

they chose to voice and frame it. It is also noteworthy that in the court records under examination, the defendants and witnesses were forced to remember events and conversations that transpired months or even years before the trial. Memories change and fade over time. Studies suggest that the amount of reconstruction taking place when remembering increases depending on the amount of time that has elapsed between an event and its subsequent recollection. All in all, memory is inherently malleable, and it is best understood as a reconstructive process that cannot be separated from its situational context. When we read historical court records, it is impossible to evaluate the accuracy of the recounted memories. Nevertheless, the historian's source critical outlook ought to be informed by an understanding of how memory works as a psychological phenomenon.¹⁸

By now, it has become clear that our knowledge about the experienced events and occurrences described in historical court records is strictly limited. The information content of court records emerges from a long sequence of interpretations by multiple actors, and it has been heavily influenced by scribal processing and the reconstructive nature of memory. Thus, court records do not grant straightforward evidence of the initial *Erlebnisse* or “pre-trial” experiences of historical individuals. We can only know about the ways in which people spoke about their experiences during the trial. Even so, court records can contain evidence of the process through which meaningful experiences (*Erfahrungen*) were constructed.

EXPERIENCE AS A PROCESS OF MEANING-MAKING

In this section, we turn to the second level of experience: experience as a process of interpretative meaning-making. As explained above, historians of experience conceptualise experience as a contextually situated and intersubjective process of culturally, socially, and materially mediated interpretation and meaning-making. Through this interpretative process, events and occurrences are transformed into socially shared and meaningful experiences (*Erfahrungen*). Historians interested in the process of experiencing can use court records as sources by looking for clues and evidence that point to interpretations made and voiced during a trial. Descriptions of these interpretative acts and related negotiations in court

¹⁸ Pihko 2024b, 179–181. On human memory, see, e.g. Foster 2009.

records provide information that allows us to study the process through which meaning was ascribed to bygone incidents, as well as the elements from which experiences were (re)produced.¹⁹

More detailed court records often include traces of interpretations made by multiple actors, including the suspect or defendant, as well as those made by the witnesses and the judicial authorities. For example, in the inquisition record related to the case of Bernardus de Ortello, both witnesses called by bishop-inquisitor Fournier to provide testimony against Bernardus were asked to interpret what they had seen and heard. In February 1323, Gentilis Macari, with whom Bernardus had spoken, reported under oath that the suspect told her it was neither his faith nor his belief that people return to their flesh on the Day of Judgement. The witness claimed she had rebuked this statement by telling the suspect he had uttered bad words as every good Christian ought to believe they would go to judgement in their flesh. The witness was also asked to evaluate whether she thought Bernardus had intended his words as a joke. She was unsure about this, as she recalled Bernardus speaking laughingly but also in a forcefully affirming manner. Her interpretation did, however, make her suspicious, as she told the tribunal she had revealed Bernardus's words to a local priest without any delay.²⁰ The second witness, heard by the tribunal a couple of weeks later, was Ramundus Pagesii, who, according to Gentilis, had also been present during the conversation. He, too, recalled Bernardus saying it was neither his faith nor his belief that the dead ever returned with their flesh and their bones. Together with Gentilis, he reprehended Bernardus for his words and tried to argue against him. He claimed this was in vain, as he was met by defiant remarks and counterarguments from the suspect. Ramundus was also asked to assess whether Bernardus had spoken in jest, but his evaluation was that this was not the case.²¹

Both witnesses called to testify against Bernardus had to recall an old interaction that had taken place over a year prior to the trial. Moreover, they had to form evaluative interpretations concerning the suspect's mode of speech and the possible intentions and beliefs underlying his

¹⁹ For a similar, more narratological approach to court record narratives constructing experience, see Toivo & Willumsen 2022, 51–53.

²⁰ Duvernoy (ed.) 1965, 259–260.

²¹ Duvernoy (ed.) 1965, 261–262.

critical claims about the impossibility of bodily resurrection. These interpretations, then, fed the legal interpretation of bishop-inquisitor Fournier, who decided to pursue the case further and to prosecute Bernardus under suspicion of heresy.

Bernardus's own interpretations become visible in the latter part of the record, which recounts the full confession he gave after an extended period of imprisonment. The record provides evidence of how he interpreted his encounter with the effects of death and decay at the cemetery, and how the meanings he ascribed to his startling sensory observations led him to doubt the possibility of bodily resurrection. Moreover, the record also contains further evidence showing how Bernardus constructed his experience in relation to cultural information. He told the tribunal that he had heard it preached at church that on the Day of Judgement people would go to receive Christ's judgement in both body and soul. This information sat uneasily with the observations he made in the cemetery, due to which he formulated his own alternative theology of resurrection. From then on, he believed that on the Day of Judgement, God would make temporary bodies for the souls of the dead. The original bodies would remain in their graves, while souls would go to be judged in their new bodies. He also believed that after judgement was delivered, the temporary bodies would decay, and that souls alone would go to heaven or hell.²²

Voicing experiences that were in breach of norms, such as accepted religious discourses and existing structures of experience, was usually met

²² Duvernoy (ed.) 1965, 264: "septem vel octo annis citra [...] ex eo quod vidit quando fosse aperiebantur in cimiterio ecclesie de Ravato ut aliqui mortui sepelirentur in eis, quod corpora illorum hominum vel mulierum que in dictis fossis ante sepulta fuerant erant dissoluta et corrupta ac in terram conversa, ossibus exceptis, credidit quod corpora humana que homines habuerunt in vita presenti et postea corumpebantur, nunquam resurgerent nec de morte ad vitam redirent, et quod reviviscere non possent. Set quia audiverat predicare in ecclesia quod homines in die iudicii in corpore et anima iudicarentur et ad iudicium Christi venirent, credidit quod Deus alia corpora humana tunc faceret ab istis corporibus que in vita presenti habent, in quibus corporibus humanis ponerentur anime hominum, et in talibus corporibus anime humane ad iudicium Christi venirent, remanentibus primis corporibus que in vita presenti habuerunt in monumento corruptis. Credebat etiam [...] quod peracto iuditio dicta corpora nova, que Deus spiritibus humanis fecisset resolverentur et corumperentur, et sole anime vel spiritus humani secundum quod meruissent, vel irent ad Deum si boni fuissent et bona opera fecissent premiandi per eum, vel si mali fuissent irent ad infernum ibidem puniendi pro demeritis suis".

with opposition and rebuttal by the judicial authorities, which effectively demonstrates the power dynamics at play in a courtroom. Once Bernardus had revealed the reason for his idiosyncratic beliefs, bishop-inquisitor Fournier proceeded to map his heterodox ideas in further detail and to persuade him to correct them. Bernardus was questioned on his beliefs regarding the resurrection of Christ and the salvation of unbaptised infants, as well as on his opinion of Cathar errors. He claimed that no one had taught or instructed him and that his beliefs were the result of his own thinking. Apart from his discussion with Gentilis and Ramundus, he denied having spoken about his errors to anyone else. He also stated that after his conversation with the two witnesses, he immediately came to regret his erroneous words and revealed his wrongdoings to the bishop-inquisitor. Asked why he first claimed he was joking when he now admitted to not having believed in the resurrection of the body for a long time, he explained that it was due to his ignorance. Asked whether he still believed in these errors or repented and wanted to recoil from them, Bernardus replied that after being informed by the bishop-inquisitor he no longer believed in them and promised to henceforth believe according to the teachings of the Church. He also stated that he repented believing in such errors and that he was prepared to complete the required acts of penance. After this, he abjured all heresy and was reconciled with the Church.²³

This final section of the record reveals how Bernardus's experience was negotiated and constructed in context. This process began years before the trial when Bernardus saw decayed human remains in the cemetery. He interpreted this observation in relation to ambient theological information, which led him to doubt the possibility of bodily resurrection and to formulate idiosyncratic religious ideas. Later, he processed his experience further by discussing it with other people in his community. The negative reactions of Gentilis and Ramundus seem to have caused a stir, which may have prompted him to go voluntarily to the authorities to confess, even though he initially downplayed the incident as a joke and neglected to give a full confession. Once informed about the incident, bishop-inquisitor Fournier intervened and redirected Bernardus's process of experiencing. He gathered evidence against him from witnesses and used imprisonment to coerce the uncooperative suspect to reconsider his

²³ Duvernoy (ed.) 1965, 264–267.

confession. Once Bernardus began talking, the bishop-inquisitor questioned him in detail about his beliefs and guided him towards correct belief by way of instruction. This ultimate reinterpretation and renegotiation of his experience was firmly situated in the emotionally loaded context of the inquisitorial interrogation defined by an uneven power dynamic that favoured the inquisitor.²⁴ Rebuttals from his peers did not change Bernardus's beliefs, but the bishop-inquisitor, an authority figure who utilised a potent mixture of coercive imprisonment, record-keeping, and verbal instruction, was able to influence Bernardus's ideas and realigned the meanings he had given to his cemetery experience with Catholic doctrine.²⁵

Similar traces of interpretation and meaning-making, or processes of experience, both before and during the trial, are visible in the court records concerning the blasphemy case from early modern Sweden. For example, in the first trial, Mickel told that four nights after the blasphemous conversation in the tavern he had suddenly awoken to his home being lit up in light; to him "the whole room seemed to be full of people, including children and dogs". The latter had started to get up on the bed. Severely frightened, he had woken up his wife, who could not see or hear anything in the room. Unable to sleep, he had gone to rest in the sauna. The next day, he reconsidered what had taken place, and "astonished and in anxiety" wondered what Mats had done in the tavern. He now felt that Mats had inflicted his nightly vision by the outspoken words, through witchcraft and magic. Here is one clear instance of how his process of experiencing, that is, ascribing meanings to these events, transpired: four days later, and now during the trial, Mickel gave new meanings to what Mats had said in the tavern. Rather than considering his blasphemous reply as just talk, Mickel interpreted and experienced that by repeating "the Heavenly army arrives" again and again Mats had bewitched him to encounter this terrible vision.²⁶ As will be discussed in the next section, this interpretation and experience was shaped by existing structures of experience, or cultural narratives and collective modes of experiencing, that we can interpret through contextualisation.

²⁴ On the power dynamics between medieval inquisitors and heresy suspects, see Arnold 2001; Bruschi 2009.

²⁵ On experience and power, see Toivo 2021, 152.

²⁶ NAF: RT Northern Ostrobothnia KO a 41: 106–108, 7–11 January 1725 and further discussed 1819–1821, 10–13 September 1725, Kakkola & Kälviä.

Just as in the medieval example, the negotiation over what had taken place in the tavern continued in the trials. As many people who had been in the tavern were not present in the first trial in January, the lower court decided to postpone the investigation to the following court sessions. The next one did not take place until September. By then, most witnesses had trouble recalling Mickel and Mats' conversation that had taken place nearly ten months earlier—Mickel still held on to his claims while Mats now argued that it had been in fact Mickel who had stated the blasphemous words about God. Mats presented a written deposition by seven locals stating that they had not been able to make sense of his talk in the tavern and that he had a “weak mind and memory” when he had something to drink. However, there were a number of trustworthy locals, including one lay member of the lower court, who testified that they had been Mats' words.²⁷

Interpretations of past experiences could be heavily contested during a trial—the parties' and witnesses' experiences could collide, and officials and experts could impose new interpretations. In court records, the recorded statements and discussions are indications of this negotiation over and reformation of experiences (the process of experiencing) for the purpose of reaching an acceptable “truth”—or meanings that can be declared as the legally admissible, officially sanctioned experience.²⁸

Many such descriptions come up in the court records over Mickel and Mats' blasphemous encounter. For example, while discussing Mickel's previous life and reputation, the county sheriff brought up that in late January, quite soon after the first trial, Mickel had come to the vicarage and told the vicar and the household members there that he had committed bestiality with a horse about two and a half years ago. While visiting the vicarage over some days, he had at times denied it, and had stated, like now in the trial, that he confessed to such an act because of the Devil's temptations and influence. The vicar, and other witnesses, also testified about Mickel's major alcohol problem, and were of the opinion that his talks were a result of “weakness”—Mickel had been drunk and had had other delusions during his visit. After his confessions, he had been imprisoned, during which he continued to experience the Devil

²⁷ NAF: RT Northern Ostrobothnia KO a 41: 1810–1849, 10–13 September 1725, Kokkola & Kälviä.

²⁸ On the power dynamics and negotiation over extraordinary religious experiences in trials, see, e.g. Miettinen 2022.

tempting him. He had finally found peace, according to those guarding him, after he had prayed and been able to sleep. A few days later, he spoke with the vicar, thanking God that his turmoil was over and not remembering a thing about what he had confessed. For some reason, he only connected this to the Devil, rather than experiencing it as another sign of sorcery inflicted by Mats in the tavern. Puzzled by all this, the county sheriff suggested that the lower court could consult a journeyman barber-surgeon who happened to be in the area. Although consulting medical experts was still exceptional at the time, this manifests the increasing significance of medicine for making sense of extraordinary experiences. Medical—and legal—discourses were incorporated in the investigation to (re)negotiate what could be acceptable and credible experiences, and how to sentence them. The next day, the journeyman barber-surgeon Johan Christian Degen shared his view that Mickel had been affected by his consumption of alcohol and had the *physionomie* of those affected by *Delirio melancholicis*. The lower court considered that his confession of bestiality as well as his vision stemmed from delusions and could be the product of imagination caused by his melancholic temperament stirred up by the effects of *spiritus* (use of alcohol).²⁹ Thus, Mickel's experiences were heavily doubted, with medico-scientific discourse offering new meanings for the events.

The cases used as examples in this chapter draw attention to the fact that experiences are always constructed in a particular context. The objective of a criminal process is to establish whether a defendant is guilty. A trial is a multivocal dialogue between numerous actors, due to which the interpretation of past experiences can be heavily contested. More verbose court records usually contain information of such processes of interpretation and meaning-making. Interpretations made during the legal proceedings are usually at the forefront, but, as the court records used as examples here show, it is also possible to find traces of interpretative acts that precede the trial through close reading and contextualisation. The power dynamic that influences interpretations voiced in the courtroom is skewed in favour of the legal authorities, and a court record itself is a crystallisation of their concluding interpretation. However, in both cases at hand, there are also clear signs of the interpretative agency wielded by the people brought to trial. The suspects and witnesses were able to

²⁹ NAF: RT Northern Ostrobothnia KO a 41: 1822–1842 (Degen's testimony 1835–1836), 10–13 September 1725, Kokkola & Kälviä.

formulate and communicate their own interpretations of the events in question. These interpretations reflected their own perspective and served their individual goals—be they, for example, evasion of punishment or the condemnation of a wrongdoer. Acknowledging the shared role of defendants, witnesses, and legal officials in the creation of court records affords the opportunity to use these documents as a source for analysing experience as a collective process of interpretative meaning-making.

STRUCTURES OF EXPERIENCE

Court records also include information that can be used to analyse experience as a social structure. Shared structures of experience are formed when individuals and communities repeatedly experience something in sufficiently similar ways. Once learned or otherwise adopted through socialisation, these structures of experience, which are crystallisations of past experiences, become norms that influence, condition, or at least offer a framework through which people give meanings to and experience events, situations, sensations, and the like.³⁰ Court records reflect structures of experience in two distinct ways. First, when carefully contextualised with information about the surrounding culture, court records can provide evidence of the ways in which the structures of experience available to historical actors influenced their ideas and actions. Secondly, court records, and especially the legal sentences in which trials culminated, functioned as authoritative media that had the potential to reinforce or reshape structures of experience when their content was communicated to the involved parties and the wider public.

Firstly, like most other narrative historical documents, court records provide information about the cultural resources that afford and constrain the meanings that people ascribe to their experiences. These cultural resources, such as norms, traditions, and beliefs, are the building blocks for the structures of experience, offering models and collective modes

³⁰ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022a, 13; Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022b; Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2025, 3; Kivimäki & Toivo 2022, 60–61, 63.

of experiencing a situation.³¹ Alongside individual situations and positions such as gender and wealth, they set the framework of available and expected experiences—or the horizon of experience—in a given culture and society.³²

To give an example, the inquisitorial documentation related to the case of Bernardus de Ortello contains some traces of how the suspect and the witnesses drew on ambient resources to make sense of their world. Above, we already saw how Bernardus combined information from a sermon with his own observations. What he heard the preacher say at church came into conflict with what he saw at the cemetery. In his last interrogation, Bernardus explained that this discrepancy prompted him to challenge Catholic dogma and to formulate an idiosyncratic view on the topic of bodily resurrection.³³ Bernardus's act of critical creativity stands as an example of how structures of experience available in a given context can simultaneously play a negative and a productive role in the process through which historical actors give meaning to what they encounter. Likewise, the record implies that the interpretations of the witnesses were influenced by prevailing ideas about the dangers of heretical dissent. By the early fourteenth century, decades of inquisitorial activity in Languedoc had cultivated an atmosphere of suspicion and surveillance.³⁴ Both witnesses claimed that when they encountered Bernardus's talk about the impossibility of bodily resurrection, they disapproved strongly and voiced forceful rebuttals against his assertions.³⁵ Before and during the trial, inquisitorial ideas concerning speech and conduct that possibly verged on the heretical affected the way in which the witnesses made sense of the event they had experienced.

³¹ See Introduction of this volume, and, e.g. Boddice & Smith 2020, 50–51, who emphasise that events and occurrences are always interpreted in relation to prior experiences and cultural resources. Structures of experience are similar to, for example, what anthropologists studying the cultural variance of suffering have called “collective modes of experience” of how people give meanings to, undergo, and express an illness or suffering. Kleinman 1988; Kleinman & Good 1986.

³² See the introduction of this volume, and, e.g. Boddice & Smith 2020, esp. 29, 50–53; Harjula & Kokko 2022; Kokko & Harjula 2024; Pickering 2004.

³³ Duvernoy (ed.) 1965, 264.

³⁴ Pihko 2022, 100–101, 108–109, 111.

³⁵ Duvernoy (ed.) 1965, 259–262.

Likewise, in the court records concerning blasphemy in eighteenth-century Sweden, Mickel's claims of his nocturnal experience give information about the existing structures of experience that provided him the frameworks and vocabulary to interpret such events and sensations. In this case, experiencing his turmoil and vision as being subject to witchcraft was shaped by a strong cultural model. Although major witchcraft trials were over by the 1720s, and many at least among the educated elite had become sceptical about the phenomenon, beliefs in witchcraft and magic persisted among the populace. Understanding these lines or available modes of experiencing requires a great deal of contextual information about the culture, belief system, and other structures of the society. Mickel's choice to experience this as witchcraft was only one option of many available in the framework of possible experiences. Based on research literature about the mentalities and beliefs of the era, and other experiences of similar sensations and events, he could have made sense and experienced what had unfolded as, for example, God's punishment over their tavern conversation, Devilish forces playing with his mind, or as products of his weak mind, or, simply, as a nightmare.³⁶ To explain *why* he chose witchcraft over the other options would require information that is not available in any documents—in a given setting both the horizon of experiences and this selection are circumscribed by not only the existing structures of experience offering models but also by personal backgrounds and individual situations and identities.

As for the second point, how legal sentences reinforced and had the potential to reform structures of experience, the historian can mostly speculate as the available documents rarely include information about the more widespread or long-term impacts of trial outcomes. Nevertheless, one can interpret that the outcome manifests what legal authorities could accept as a valid experience that conformed to the norms and solidified at least the structures of experience favourable to those in power. By imposing interpretations, declaring them publicly, and enforcing penalties when needed, courts of law consolidated not only behavioural norms but also the correct ways of experiencing things.

For example, in sentencing Mickel and Mats, the lower court rejected most of their claims and experiences and endorsed medico-scientific

³⁶ For contextual information about these belief systems, see, e.g. Malmstedt 2018; Toivo 2016.

ways of making sense of what had transpired. The lower court considered Mickel's visions and confessions of bestiality as delusional, partly produced by the "alcohol left in the brain", acquitting him of bestiality and Mats of witchcraft. As for the blasphemous conversation though, the lower court sentenced both Mickel and Mats to death, as there were plenty of testimonies about the discussion—in the era's religious mentality, even Mickel's question about God's location was itself blasphemous and deserving of the capital sentence prescribed in law. The death sentences are also justified in the court records by citing "God's law" and by the intention to set an example for others (*androm till exempel*).³⁷ By declaring Mickel's experiences as delusional, the authorities proclaimed that drunkenness and folly were dangerous conditions that could produce such experiences, while by pronouncing their discussion as a capital offence, they could reinforce the religious-moralistic norms of the era and deter such behaviour in the future.

The public sentencing of those condemned of blasphemy or heresy, like the people discussed in our court record examples, was an important propagandistic dimension of medieval and early modern courts of law, through which the boundary between right and wrong was communicated to the laity.³⁸ Although the fate of Bernardus remains unknown,³⁹ based on the fact that Bernardus finally agreed to cooperate with the authorities and seems to have demonstrated a sufficient degree of contrition, it is probable that he was sentenced to undergo an assortment of penitential acts as was typical in these trials. For example, he may have been mandated to renounce his erroneous words in public and to wear yellow crosses on his clothing as a sign of penance. Like such sentences, also the execution of capital punishments, like those potentially received by Mickel and Mats, were public and could thus bear influence on people's future experiences. This had the potential to make them more wary of the consequences of holding unusual beliefs and sharing unorthodox experiences, and may have further primed their vigilance

³⁷ NAF: RT Northern Ostrobothnia KO a 41: 1843–1849, 10–13 September 1725, Kakkola & Kälviä. As they were dealing with capital offences, the court records were later checked by the Turku Court of Appeal, whose final interpretation and sentence is unknown due to missing documents.

³⁸ On inquisitorial sentences and penances in general, see e.g. Given 1997, 66–90.

³⁹ The book of sentences related to Fournier's investigations has been lost. Nieto-Isabel 2018, 78.

towards suspicious talk and behaviour.⁴⁰ In other words, the prosecution and sentencing of alleged heretics and blasphemers could leave a lasting impression on a community by revamping available structures of experience.

Court records reflect the structural reconfigurations of experience that took place in the legal interventions and trials. It is up to the historian reading court records to discern what is possible to know about how structures of experience intersect with the experiences of individuals in their historical context. Both of our examples show that court records include information about the structures of experience that influenced the interpretation, meaning-making, and negotiation over experiences. The trial situation itself was a structural context in which past experiences were given shared meaning and legitimised by the conclusions of the tribunals. Furthermore, court records contain evidence of and can even be seen as manifestations of how legal proceedings could reinforce existing structures of experience. Conclusions and decisions made by the court, communicated in speech and writing as sentences and embodied in potential public acts of penance and punishment, drew the line between licit and illicit for the communities to see, offering models for future experiencing, and cultivating a sense of suspicion and surveillance for future events and what the legal implications of illicit religious talk, for example, could be.

CONCLUSION

The enduring appeal of court records as historical sources has much to do with their colourful content, which can seemingly provide intimate glimpses of life in the past. Anecdotal evidence, however, does not suffice for the historian of experience. While court records at times recount events and occurrences in vivid detail, they cannot be understood as simple repositories of experiences. On the contrary, they are complex, heavily mediated documents tied to the context and situation of the legal proceedings that produced them. Nevertheless, when court records are approached with adequate source-critical and methodological rigour, they afford possibilities for investigating the construction of historical experiences.

⁴⁰ Cf. Pihko 2022, 108–110.

In this chapter, we have proposed methodological guidelines for the analysis of court records as sources for the history of experience. Using two examples—an inquisition record from medieval Languedoc and the records of lower court proceedings from early modern Sweden—we have demonstrated that court records reflect the dynamic interplay between the three theoretically distinct levels of experience. Evidence of the first level of experience (experience as event) remains limited. Court records do not grant straightforward access to any “authentic” or immediate experiences (*Erlebnisse*) of historical individuals, but they do tell us how the people brought to trial described the events and occurrences they had experienced. The second level of experience (experience as a process of meaning-making), on the other hand, is especially well-evidenced in many court records, in particular, in those concerning more complex cases and serious offences. These documents allow us to trace the interpretative processes through which the defendants, witnesses, plaintiffs, and legal officials negotiated and transformed memories of past events into meaningful, socially shared experiences (*Erfahrungen*) prior to and during the trial.

The third level of experience (experience as social structure) can also be traceable in court records. Through a contextualising close reading of court-record narratives, it is possible to find information about the structures and horizons of experience available to historical actors. Still, both the power dynamics of the courtroom setting and the individual situations and personal backgrounds of people influenced their interpretations and experiencing. Furthermore, court records and subsequent legal sentences could, in themselves, function as authoritative mediums that consolidated the negotiated outcome of the trial and, in so doing, communicated the official, acceptable interpretations and experiences to the public. However, court records themselves do not enable making interpretations about how these influenced people’s later experiences, or perhaps at times even reformed new scripts and structures of experience; understanding this would require the comprehensive contextualisation and triangulation of different types of sources, which are seldom available.

In other words, a legal trial can be understood as a mediating site where experiences are constructed. Court records describing these trials allow us to discern how the meaning of past events and occurrences was (re)interpreted, negotiated, and produced through the interaction of all involved parties, and how these processually constructed experiences were inspired by existing models, or structures of experience.

A similar approach is broadly applicable to all types of historical and contemporary court records. An important step for the aspiring historian of experience is to acknowledge the impossibility of uncovering any immediate or authentic experiences from court records. Even the “personal” experiences of individuals—while acknowledging that experiencing is always social—are difficult to interpret due to the nature of court records, including their constructedness, aims, formulations, paraphrasing, silences, and biases. Analytical emphasis ought to be placed on what these documents tell us about the interpretative processes through which experiences were constructed in relation to different variables, cultural resources, and contexts. The close reading of court records relies on a comprehensive contextualisation of the phenomena under investigation and a detailed dissection of the source-critical issues pertinent to the material that is used. The historian of experience who reads court records looks for traces and narratives of interpretative acts that took place prior to and during the trial. Of equal relevance to the analysis of experience are the interpretations voiced by defendants, plaintiffs, witnesses, and legal officials. Cases in which the interpretations of different parties come into conflict can be particularly fruitful, as they underscore the processual negotiations and power dynamics over meaning-making and the agency of the individuals involved in the proceedings. The information content of a court record, the conclusion of a trial, and the construction of an experience are the combined result of the interpretations of various historical actors and the negotiations that took place between them. Once available evidence on these dynamics of interpretation and negotiation has been teased out of a court record, the historian can outline wider conclusions about the complex social process through which meaningful experiences were constructed. Understanding the situational intricacies of this process in a given court record serves as a telling reminder of the fact that experiences are always embedded in particular contexts, which makes them subject to change over time.

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Administrative Documents of Institutions as Sources for the History of Experience

Johanna Annola 

INTRODUCTION

For those interested in the history of experiences and experiencing, the administrative documents of different institutions may not appear to be fruitful sources of material. These documents often include official correspondence, reports, meeting minutes, regulations, registers, accounts, and journals produced to serve the administrative and economic purposes of a particular institution. As such, they innately carry a limited amount of information on other things, such as the experiences of those who were controlled by the institution in question, be it a workhouse, prison, asylum, or residential school.¹ It is no wonder, then, that scholars in their quest to catch glimpses of life in an institution have often preferred to excavate and use first-hand accounts by residents and staff, such as

¹ See also Johnston 2024, 5; Petersen & Smed 2023, 242.

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personal letters and diaries, memoirs, interviews, and contributions to staff or resident magazines.²

Sometimes, however, administrative documents are all that are available. In such cases, it may be possible to circumvent the problem by combining different kinds of administrative sources, asking the existing sources new questions, or re-reading the documents in new ways.³ Recently, for example, Helen Johnston has employed a broad array of administrative documents to constitute “life grids” of female convict prisoners—that is, to illuminate their worlds.⁴ David Cox and Susannah Ottaway, in turn, have in their studies used administrative sources to explore the experiences of staff members, such as prison personnel and workhouse masters.⁵ Paul Carter, Jeff James, and Steve King have utilised workhouse punishment records to discuss how residents may have perceived the institution.⁶ By analysing prison wardens’ statements on prisoners, Emilie Luther Valentin has been able to yield information on how prisoners navigated the prison system and its “feeling rules”.⁷

This chapter sets out to explore how administrative documents created by a walled or residential institution can be analysed through the lens of the history of experience. I suggest that rather than focusing on the shortcomings of these documents, it is useful to concentrate on what kind of information these sources contain about experiences, and what kind of past worlds and horizons of experiencing⁸ can be traced in them. By “worlds of experiencing”, I mean here different kinds of entanglements between people and their material surroundings. Building on the

² For a recent overview on research on past institutions, see Annola et al. 2023, 9–10. Examples of studies that use first-hand accounts include Humphries 2013 and Tomkins 2021 (working-class autobiographies and poor law institutions); Annola 2023a (letters of incarcerated women); Hakosalo 2023 (autobiographical narratives and patient magazines of patients in tuberculosis sanatoria); Petersen & Smed 2023 (interviews of individuals in an institution for intellectually disabled). See also Frangeur 2016; Englund 2016; Englund 2019.

³ See also Nilsson & Wallström 2016, 11–36.

⁴ Johnston 2024.

⁵ Cox 2020; Ottaway 2021.

⁶ Carter, James, & King 2019.

⁷ Valentin 2023.

⁸ See the introduction of this book, as well as Harjula & Kokko 2022; Kokko & Harjula 2023.

work of Henri Lefebvre,⁹ I suggest that such entanglements are regulated by socio-spatial practices: groupings, divisions, movements, soundscapes (and the sensory world in general), and routines in a particular space. The official socio-spatial practices usually arose from the ideologies behind a particular institution, but in addition, there were most likely multiple unofficial agendas at play. These overlapping and often contradictory practices set the framework of available and possible experiences, or the horizon of experience, for the occupants of institutional space and likely produced a myriad of experiences in them. The sensemaking and negotiation around experiences could take the form of compliance or resistance, sometimes resulting in a change in socio-spatial practices and thereby also in the worlds of experiencing.

To me, the notion of socio-spatial practices serves as a checklist of the things to keep an eye on when going through administrative sources, which hopefully allows for a deeper understanding of life in a particular institution. Instead of glancing at the floorplan of an institution and merely stating that the institution comprised an infirmary with three small rooms, I look for traces of socio-spatial practices associated with the infirmary, or signs of sensemaking, negotiation, compliance, or resistance around these practices. These help me estimate what kind of experiences were likely to take place in the infirmary, which in turn hints at the existing worlds and horizons of experiencing—or attempts at changing them.

The approach can be applied to a variety of walled institutions and their administrative documents. Here, I will exemplify the approach by discussing two nineteenth-century Finnish institutions that were used to control the poor, the deviant, and the criminal. These so-called spinhouses emerged in northern Europe in the early modern period and continued to exist until the nineteenth century, often slowly metamorphosing into places of incarceration for women.¹⁰ In Finland,¹¹ a spinhouse had been established in the 1730s in the southwestern coastal town of Turku, and another one was opened in 1819 in the southeastern inland town of Lappeenranta. The two spinhouses held vagrant and convict women until

⁹ Lefebvre 1991.

¹⁰ Letto-Vanamo & Ylikangas 1981, 62–65.

¹¹ Until 1809, the geographical area of modern Finland comprised the eastern part of the kingdom of Sweden, and until 1917, Finland was a part of the Russian empire as an autonomous grand duchy with legislative bodies and a central administration of its own.

the opening in 1881 of a new penitentiary and prison workhouse for women.

Documents of a particular institution are usually held as or later collected into specific archival collections. In this case, the spinhouse archives are held by the Finnish National Archives. The main body of surviving sources consists of administrative documents from the 1820s to the 1880s: prisoner rolls, journals, accounts, medical records, communion books, meeting minutes, the correspondence of the Spinhouse Board, and the correspondence of the overseer (governor, warden) of the institution. So far, the spinhouse archives remain rather underused by scholars. This probably pertains, first, to the scarcity of historical research on the spinhouses in general,¹² and, second, to the fact that scholars have preferred to use other kinds of sources,¹³ such as reports, memorials, and regulations issued by the Finnish central administration. It is likely that such documents have provided scholars with enough data in a more compact form. Moreover, one might question whether any significant additions to the current knowledge can be made by arduously wading through the structured and “thin” documents held in the spinhouse archives.

Most documents in the spinhouse archives were produced by the overseer, doctor, or chaplain of the institution, or by the board clerk. Completely absent are documents by regular prison officers or prisoners, who thus exist only through entries made by someone else. In this sense, and especially in the case of the prisoners, the situation resembles what cultural historian Saidiya Hartman writes about the relationship between such entries and power: “the stories that exist are not about them, but rather about the [--] reason that seized hold of their lives, transformed them into commodities and corpses”.¹⁴ In this way, the archive “dictates what can be said about the past and the kinds of stories that can be told about the persons cataloged, embalmed, and sealed away in box files and

¹² The spinhouses are discussed in a couple of master’s theses and in overviews of the development of the Finnish penal system, see Kolehmainen 1985; Henttonen 2019; Virtanen 1944; Letto-Vanamo & Ylikangas 1981; Lilius 2004. In addition, the spinhouses are mentioned in passing in literature on vagrancy and sex work; see Nygård 1985, 106–107, 116–119, 122–124, 126–128; Nygård 1998, 154–163; Pukero 2009; Vainio-Korhonen 2018, 195–198; Vainio-Korhonen & Korhonen 2024, 175–178.

¹³ The spinhouse archives have been utilised in Kolehmainen 1985, Lilius 2004, Henttonen 2019; Viiliäinen 2023; Vainio-Korhonen & Korhonen 2024.

¹⁴ Hartman 2008b, 2.

folios”.¹⁵ Acknowledging this, however, we can still think of ways to make these stories more versatile, and to get as close as possible to hearing the echoes of voices and experiences that once existed. While we may not get first-hand accounts of personal experiences of life in an institutional environment, we can delve into the interplay between individuals and their surroundings, as well as the experiences that arose or may have arisen from them. It may also be possible to find traces of collective experiences or even sketch communities of experience that existed in the institution under scrutiny. This holds true for other residential institutions and their archives as well.

In this chapter, I will discuss the use and potential of such administrative documents of institutions in the study of the history of experience with examples from two types of spinhouse sources. The first set consists of Turku Spinhouse Board meeting minutes, compiled in the 1820s. The second set of sources comprises Lappeenranta Spinhouse punishment journals from September 1871 to December 1881.¹⁶ After analysing the meeting minutes and the punishment journals, I will summarise the findings and ponder how my approach could be supplemented and developed further.

SOCIO-SPATIAL PRACTICES AND EXPERIENCES IN BOARD MEETING MINUTES, 1820S

In the 1820s, Turku Spinhouse Board met approximately once a month. The members were high-ranking local officials and representatives of the local bourgeois elite: the Governor and the Vice Treasurer of the province, the head of the local police, a representative of the town administration, and a representative of local tradesmen. The responsibilities of the Board included executing orders by the Russian emperor or the Finnish Senate, managing the handicraft production in the institution, authorising all purchases, and supervising the spinhouse personnel. In the following, I will use the meeting minutes to illustrate how these and

¹⁵ Hartman 2008a, 17.

¹⁶ The surviving punishment journals of Lappeenranta Spinhouse cover the period starting from September 1871 and ending in December 1884. This indicates that the same journal was used in Hämeenlinna Penitentiary and Prison Workhouse after the closing down of Lappeenranta Spinhouse in 1881.

similar sources in the archives of other institutions can be used to discuss the socio-spatial practices and experiences in an institutional setting.

During my period of interest, Turku Spinhouse was located in a two-storey brick building in the heart of the town. According to a floorplan from the 1790s—one of the few documents that survive from the eighteenth century—the first floor comprised the kitchen, infirmary, bathroom, the overseer's lodgings, storage rooms, a sick room for women, and a smaller sick room for men. On the second floor, there was a church, two larger sleeping halls for a total of 60 women, and a small sleeping hall for men.¹⁷ By the early 1800s, the spinhouse had become a women-only institution, and the spaces originally intended for men had been put to other uses—especially as overcrowding had become a serious problem. In December 1817, the number of prisoners was 144, twice the actual capacity of the building. The opening of a sister institution in an eighteenth-century military fortress in Lappeenranta (see Fig. 5.1) in 1819 ameliorated the situation in Turku: in the late 1820s, the average number of prisoners in December was 73.¹⁸ At that time, most prisoners were vagrant women, because according to the division of labour between the two spinhouses, all female convicts were sent to Lappeenranta.

Board meeting minutes open up a more detailed view on the everyday life in the rooms and hallways inked in the floorplan. The minutes reveal how prisoners were *grouped* and *segregated*, and how the limited space was used to achieve this. For example, while it is apparent that sick prisoners were to be kept apart from healthy ones, there were also more nuanced divisions. In December 1821, following the spinhouse doctor's proposal, the board decided to use “the upper sick room” to confine women who were capable of work but afflicted with “scabies and rash”.¹⁹ In the following summer, the board arrived at the conclusion that it would be “beneficial, in several respects”, to separate the Roma from other prisoners. Henceforth, the Roma would be accommodated “in the so-called Tartar room”, which was previously unheated but would now be

¹⁷ National Archives of Finland (NAF), Archives of Turku Spinhouse, H1, Floorplan, 23 April 1793.

¹⁸ Virtanen 1944, 111, 398–399.

¹⁹ “omedelbarligen efter omständigheterna, låta flytta de med skabb eller utslag behäftade Spinnhushjonerna å öfre sjuk rummet”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 21 December 1821.



Fig. 5.1 One of Lappeenranta Spinhouse buildings was photographed in the 1970s. At this point, the building was two hundred years old, and a century had passed since the events described in this chapter. Photograph: Kenzi Rinno / Lappeenranta Museums

equipped with a heating system.²⁰ While the entries do not reveal where exactly the “upper sick room” and “Tartar room” were in the building,²¹ they show that the interior was adapted to meet the need for everyday categorisations.

In addition, the meeting minutes show an opposite tendency: some of the rooms were, in fact, multipurpose spaces. Simultaneously to (and probably interwoven with) the discussion on the accommodation of Roma women, the board was also in the process of refurbishing the larger

²⁰ “det i flere hänseenden vore gæneligt, att ifrån de öfrige Spinnhus hjonen skilja de å Spinnhuset insatte Zigenare för hvilka senare det i sådant fall blefve nödigt att till varmt rum inreda det förut såsom kallt begagnade så kallade Tartar-rummet”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 10 December 1822.

²¹ In fact, other sources strongly suggest that the “Tartar room” was not located in the main building but in a warehouse next to it.

sleeping halls. The plan was to replace the fixed bunks with movable ones to make more room for the equipment needed for spinning and weaving.²² This clearly demonstrates that the halls were not only used for sleeping but also for working. Another example of a multipurpose room is the bathroom, which was in May 1826 vividly described by one of the board members:

[T]he room, which has in fact been established as a bathroom, is used not only for washing but also for doing the laundry and dyeing the yarn [--] and the contractor responsible for cooking uses [the bathroom] to make around 200 jugs of brew every week, as a result of which not only the room but also the hallway and the stairs are almost every day filled with the steam the never-ending boiling produces. [--T]he wall facing the yard is, despite the dry weather, still green with mould, which seems to reveal that the wall is thoroughly damp.²³

It appears that even though the number of prisoners dropped in the 1820s, the daily life in the spinhouse was nevertheless marked by cramped conditions and impractical spaces, where dozens of spinning wheels or several looms coexisted with beds, mattresses, pillows, and duvets, and where bathers had to take turns with brewers. This, it seems, was a world of hassling and dodging.

The minutes also provide us with rare glimpses of the exterior of the spinhouse building. Old maps of Turku only show how the building was located on the corner of two streets, and since the few surviving photographs are from a later period when the building was used as a school, we do not exactly know how the spinhouse yard was organised. From the meeting minutes, however, we learn that the premises were surrounded by a boarding fence painted with Swedish red paint.²⁴ In the

²² NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 10 June 1822.

²³ “det rum som blifvit inrättadt egentligen till Badstuga jemväl begagnas ej mindre till tvätt än bykning och färgning af det garn, som [--] äfvensom Entreprenuren begagnade detsamma till förrättande af omkring 200 kannors brygd i hvarje vecka; hvaraf hände att icke allenast sjelfva rummet utan ock förstugan och trappan nästan dageligen vore omfyllda med den imma som der genom oupphörlig kokning förorsakades [--M]uren, oackadtadt den fortfarande torra väderleken, på den yttre och gården belägna sidan ännu vore grön af mögel, hvilket syntes tillkännagifva att muren vore af fuktighet genomträngd”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 18 May 1826.

²⁴ NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 20 August 1823.

yard, there was a path between the building and a well, which in the 1820s provided the drinking and domestic water needed in the institution. An entry, dated April 1822, reveals that in wet weather, the unpaved path became muddy because the prisoners tramped up and down it, which then caused “several difficulties” for the institution.²⁵

If we only look at the annual numbers of prisoners, the elegantly drawn floorplan, or an old city map, it may be difficult to understand how the rooms or the yard were actually used and what kind of worlds of experiencing might have arisen in the spinhouse because of these often unorthodox or temporary arrangements. There is much more to be discovered—and this applies to other institutions and their archives as well. For instance, it would be interesting to explore everyday life in poorhouses by comparing floorplans and board meeting minutes or other types of sources. Were the premises used as intended by the planners, or did the local decision-makers resort to makeshift solutions which often abruptly transformed the worlds of experiencing in the poorhouse? What kind of negotiations or conflicts arose in the institution because of such arrangements, and what kind of experiences are possibly embedded in these encounters?²⁶

In the case of the spinhouse, the meeting minutes not only describe the conditions of the sodden yard but also the *movement* that took place in it. The same goes with the notions of movable beds,²⁷ the “never-ending boiling”, and the clouds of steam rolling in the hallway,²⁸ but also prisoners running back and forth to the stairs during the Sunday service in September 1820,²⁹ and perhaps even rats dashing into the building so that a rat trap had to be purchased in January 1829.³⁰ In addition, we find traces of the sensory world in the institution. As mentioned above, there were different sounds, such as that of steps on the stairs, and different

²⁵ “flera swårigheter”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 16 April 1822 and 18 May 1826.

²⁶ I have previously discussed the problems caused by inadequate poorhouse/workhouse premises, see Annola 2021 and Annola 2022. In retrospect, these contributions could have benefited from the approach proposed in this chapter.

²⁷ NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 10 June 1822.

²⁸ NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 18 May 1826.

²⁹ NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 6 September 1820.

³⁰ NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 9 January 1829.

smells, such as those of yarn being boiled and small beer being brewed. In December 1825, the board discussed accusations by some prisoners against the overseer and his widowed mother, who had allegedly been illegally selling drink and coffee beans to the women. The entry hints at sounds of “bickering and disunity and even fighting” among prisoners and allows us to imagine the (forbidden) scent of coffee beans being roasted and coffee being brewed.³¹ Moreover, the meeting minutes point to other sensory perceptions that may have been a part of the everyday life in the institution, such as cold or darkness. For example, in November 1823, the guards approached the board asking for a “necessary quantity of candles for the lanterns [they] must use in their duties during the dark season of the year”.³² Judging by this request, the hallways, staircases, and corners of the spinhouse were rather murky if not pitch black in late autumn and winter.

The observations based on the meeting minutes can be further elaborated by examining other administrative documents, such as the accounts or inventories of the spinhouse. From these sources, we may learn whether candles were indeed purchased for the guards, but also how often the interior walls were whitewashed and the tile stoves repaired. We learn how the church was decorated to mark a holy space within the institution, how the equipment of the infirmary reflected (or failed to reflect) the contemporary advances in medicine, and, simply, how likely it was for a prisoner to share a pillow or a blanket with her fellow prisoner. Again, conditions in other institutions can be traced in a similar way. For example, Ronald Hutton has traced the quantities of wine and candles in medieval and early modern English church ledgers to explore the changing worldview of the parishioners, and Joseph Harley has used late eighteenth- and early nineteenth-century English workhouse inventories to discuss the daily life in the institution.³³

³¹ “kif och oenighet och jemväl slagsmål”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 15 December 1825.

³² “erforderligt qwantum ljus till de lyktor som Sökanderne den mörka årstiden måste begagna via utöfningen af sin tjenst”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 21 November 1823. In an inventory list dated 1825, four candlesticks or candelabras are mentioned among the items associated with spinning and weaving, which suggests that the sleeping/working halls were lit as well. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ga:1, Accounts, Inventory list 1825.

³³ Hutton 1994; Harley 2015.

The worlds and horizons of experiencing in Turku Spinhouse were shaped also by *routines*. The meeting minutes show, first, that life in the institution was to some extent bound to the annual cycle. As mentioned earlier, the board decided to make more room for spinning and weaving equipment in the sleeping halls, so that it would be possible to “keep all Spinhouse inmates busy with spinning in wintertime and to set up several looms again in the summertime”.³⁴ Such periodisation of handicrafts was typical of life outside prison walls as well. Another example of seasonality is, rather self-evidently, the varying availability of food products. Although the dietary plan was fixed, the board sometimes deviated from it. Alarmed of the high price of potatoes in September 1821, the board decided to replace potatoes with swedes until April, after which it would be necessary to switch back, because the swedes “no longer kept”.³⁵ Yet another example would be annual festivities, but rather surprisingly, the meeting minutes contain no traces of such celebrations. This may be because the prisoners would only be allowed to celebrate Protestant Christian holidays, such as Easter and Christmas, and these were the chaplain’s responsibility.

There were also shorter cycles, intended to produce an experience of discipline in the prisoners and keep the institution running. While the daily routine is often mentioned in previous works on the spinhouses, there are few mentions of it in the board meeting minutes—only meal-times seem to have merited the board’s attention. This may pertain to the fact that as the daily routine in correctional facilities was stipulated by the Russian emperor, there was not much room for negotiation. The weekly cycles mentioned in the minutes include the dietary plan, the brew, and the sermon every Sunday. In addition, the minutes reveal that a muster was held at the beginning of each quarter, in the presence of the board, the overseer, the doctor, the chaplain, and the rest of the staff. In the muster, those prisoners who had shown diligence and improvement were rewarded with a small sum of money, whereas those who had misbehaved

³⁴ “att winter tiden sysselsätta alla Spinnhushjon med spånad och Sommartiden åter låta uppsätta flera wäfstolar”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 10 June 1822.

³⁵ “emedan Kåhlrötterne under denna tid icke kunde conserveras”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 29 September 1821.

were punished.³⁶ It is likely that the quartile cycle encouraged the women to strive towards perseverance and avoid acting on impulse, but it may also have periodised their experiences in a way that was alien to their previous environments.

The groupings, other spatial arrangements, movement, the sensory world of the spinhouse, and routines were socio-spatial practices—some official, some unofficial—which generated different kinds of experiences in the people who occupied the institution. As stated in the introduction, there are no straightforward references to these experiences in the meeting minutes. Instead, there are traces of people sharing and negotiating around their experiences, as well as hints of resistance arising from these experiences. One such entry is the abovementioned case of black-market trade in the spinhouse. While the traffic in coffee and perhaps also in drink seems to have resulted in arguments and fights among those prisoners who partook in it, it also appears that those “not partaking” had not dared to report the illegal trade sooner, because they were afraid of “harsh treatment by the Overseer”.³⁷ It was only when an outsider visited the spinhouse that the women found the courage to make their complaint. It appears, then, that there were shared experiences of rough handling behind the strategy chosen by the prisoners.

Similarly, the discussions around food, mealtimes, and the dietary plan reveal traces of shared experiences. In December 1821, the overseer was instructed by the board to supervise that the prisoners would not bring any food to the rooms after mealtimes, because such a practice would lead to “untidiness and disorder”.³⁸ In the same meeting, the board reversed their earlier decision to replace potatoes with swedes, because the women had complained “that they had not been given potatoes after the Dietary plan but in their place only swedes that were less nourishing”. Moreover, the board decided to grant the prisoners’ request of switching the

³⁶ For example, NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 9 October 1820, 23 February 1821, 13 January 1825, 14 April 1825.

³⁷ “utan att likväl de obrottsliga eller icke deltagande af fructan för svår behandling utaf Uppsyningsmannen förut vågat derom hos Landshöfdingen göra anmälan”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 15 December 1825.

³⁸ “osnygghet och oordning”. NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 21 December 1821.

places of some dishes in the Dietary plan.³⁹ These discussions reveal that the prisoners may have had experiences of austerity or even hunger, and that these experiences were then shared and action taken on the basis of the shared experiences. The two examples also hint at the existence of a community (or communities) of experiences among the women.

SOCIO-SPATIAL PRACTICES AND EXPERIENCES IN PUNISHMENT JOURNALS, 1870S

Similarly, other types of administrative sources pertaining to walled institutions include information that can be used to interpret past experiences and horizons of experience. For example, documentation about disciplinary actions, when contextualised, can be fruitful. Next, as an example, I will discuss what the punishment journals of Lappeenranta Spinhouse from the late nineteenth-century offer to study experience.

In the 1870s, Lappeenranta Spinhouse had been functional for over fifty years and held an average of 341 prisoners per year.⁴⁰ As mentioned earlier, the prisoners were both vagrant women and female convicts. For example, in 1875, over half of the women were serving a prison sentence for infanticide, and nearly every fifth had been incarcerated for theft. At that time, only a handful of women had been sent to Lappeenranta for vagrancy.⁴¹

The punishment journals of Lappeenranta Spinhouse are registers of prisoners who had violated the spinhouse regulations or misbehaved in some other ways while in the institution, and who were therefore punished. The overseer of the institution meticulously recorded the name of the offender, the nature of the offence, and the type and date of the punishment issued. Between 1872 and 1881, an average of 94 entries per year was made in the punishment journals.⁴² Every year there were

³⁹ "att de ej erhållit potater efter Spisordningen utan å det stället endast kåhlrötter, som woro mindre spissamma". NAF, Archives of Turku Spinhouse, Ca:1, Board meeting minutes, 21 December 1821.

⁴⁰ NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ba:11, Prisoner rolls, 1870–1879.

⁴¹ NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ba:11, Prisoner rolls, 1875.

⁴² The peak year was 1874 with 118 entries, whereas in 1872, only 32 events were recorded. Depending on the year, circa 7 to 23 per cent of prisoners were punished in 1872–1881. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journals, 1871–1881; NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ba:11–12, Prisoner rolls, 1871–1881.

women whose names appeared multiple times in the journal. For example, in 1875, 17 per cent of the prisoners received a punishment. Among them was Brita K., who had been incarcerated for three years for theft. She was punished five times—for “shamelessness and disobedience”, “indecent talk and conduct in the sleeping hall”, “illegal trade”, “lying to the guard”, and “possession of tobacco”.⁴³

The most common punishment was solitary confinement in a cell—for a day, a couple of days, or for an “indefinite time”, depending on the nature and seriousness of the offence. Additionally, the cell could be either light and dark, and solitary confinement could be combined with confinement on bread and water. Given that the prisoners were normally not accommodated in cells but in common sleeping halls,⁴⁴ solitary confinement probably marked a major interruption to their daily lives. Another strain of punishment was the demotion of prisoner class, which basically pertained to losing the salary and the benefits associated with a specific class—such as the permission to communicate with fellow prisoners or correspond with friends and family.⁴⁵ A third strain was a corporeal one, such as ten strokes with a cane or being put in chains (handcuffs and/or shackles), sometimes for an indefinite time. Similar punishments could be used in workhouses and reformatory schools.⁴⁶

The entries in the punishment journal are very structured and contain extremely little information about the places and situations where the offences took place. Apart from one entry, there is no record of exactly

⁴³ “skamlöshet och olydnad, oanständigt samtal och uppförande i sofsal, otillåten handel, lögn på vakt, innehavande af tobak”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1875; NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ba:11, Prisoner rolls, 1875.

⁴⁴ While the benefits of the so-called separate system were recognised in Finland in the early nineteenth century, such arrangements could only be made in the more modern prisons built from the 1870s onwards. In the case of women, single cells were introduced in 1881 upon the opening of a new women’s penitentiary and prison workhouse in Hämeenlinna.

⁴⁵ The classes were stipulated by the 1866 Act on the Implementation of Imprisonment, which came into force in 1870. According to the Act, there were four prisoner classes. While prisoners in classes 1–2 were, for example, not allowed to speak or gesture to each other, the prisoners in the two higher classes were allowed to do so during the daytime. Keisarillisen Majesteetin Armollinen Asetus wapausrangaistusten toimeen panemisesta, 26 March 1866.

⁴⁶ See, e.g. Green 2006; Vehkalahti & Hoikkala 2013; Carter, James, & King 2019; James 2018.

what had been said in a conflict situation, that is, what kind of derogatory remarks the offender had made, or how exactly she had ridiculed staff members or her fellow prisoners.⁴⁷ In entries pertaining to violence and fights among the women, it is not stated who in addition to the offender had been involved in the activity, either as a target or as a participant, nor what had been the reason for the enmity. How, then, can such journals be used to identify socio-spatial practices or experiences typical of the spinhouse, and, more broadly, other institutions?

Obviously, the mere existence of punishment journals underlines the fact that order and discipline underpinned most socio-spatial practices in the institution in question. The times and places for specific activities were likely fixed, and the scope for permitted or tolerated behaviour was extremely limited. This rendered the horizon of experience narrow and predictable, at least on paper. At the same time, punishment journals may show that the residents broke the rules all the time. By taking a closer look at the offences and by identifying patterns in the data, a more nuanced picture of life in the institution emerges. In addition to those socio-spatial practices that were enforced by the staff, we may reveal unofficial practices that were carried out by the residents year after year. The practices set the residents on a collision course with the staff, but they may also have significantly broadened the horizon of experiencing in the institution in question.

In Lappeenranta Spinhouse—similar to its sister institution in Turku and many other institutions elsewhere⁴⁸—food and eating appear to have been one of those areas in everyday life where conflicts arose. The dining hall was located in one of the four spinhouse buildings, together with some working halls, the infirmary, and the church. Not too many entries in the punishment journals are associated with bad behaviour *in* the dining hall—probably because the staff was always present in these situations. There is, however, a small number of cases where prisoners were punished for indecent behaviour or making noise during mealtimes, sometimes in pairs or in groups of three. In July 1879, Eva H. made

⁴⁷ In March 1879, Anna K. was punished with “two days in a dark cell on bread and water” for “slandering and threatening the guard”. According to the journal, Anna had “asked the guard to get out of the [premises of the prisoner] class” (bad vakten packa sig ut från klassen). NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1879.

⁴⁸ See, e.g. Smoyer & Blankenship 2014; James 2018; Annola 2021.

“untimely statements about food in the dining hall” as well as “threats to the housekeeper”, and was therefore confined to a cell for almost a month.⁴⁹ One particular offence, which possibly had to do with the dining hall, was the smashing of dishes. For example, in January 1877, Sara P. smashed dishes “in anger”,⁵⁰ and in June 1879, Ida L. “intentionally smashed one bowl belonging to the institution”, after being persuaded to do so by two of her fellow prisoners.⁵¹

Instead of behaving badly at mealtimes on a regular basis, the women broke the rules by smuggling food out of the dining hall and trying to eat it elsewhere or hiding it. For example, in April 1879, eight women were punished at the same time for repeatedly smuggling bread into the working halls.⁵² The prisoners were often caught possessing a piece of bread, but there are a couple of references to other food products, such as fat or potatoes, being sneaked out of the dining hall. On one occasion, a prisoner tried to smuggle salt to a fellow prisoner who was undergoing a bread and water punishment. After being caught, the helper was herself put on bread and water for eight days. The relatively high number of smuggling cases indicates that taking food out of the dining hall was a known practice among the women. In addition, it may point to other illicit practices, such as exchanging foodstuffs for pieces of clothing or stimulants such as coffee, tobacco, and snuff, similar to what for example Viktor Englund has noted in the case of late nineteenth-century and early twentieth-century Swedish prisons.⁵³ And more importantly, it is likely that the need to enforce such practices on pain of punishment arose from experiences of hunger and addiction—and maybe even those of sheer boredom.

The prisoners were not allowed to talk to each other in the sleeping halls at night. Nevertheless, the entries in the punishment journals reveal that the women were from time to time disciplined for “indecent” or

⁴⁹ “otidiga yttranden om maten i matsalen, hot emot matvärdinnan”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1879.

⁵⁰ “i vredesmod”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1877.

⁵¹ “sönderslagit med uppsåt en inrättningen tillhörig skål”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1879.

⁵² “itererade gånger fört bröd till arbetssalarne”, NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1879.

⁵³ Englund 2019.

“inappropriate” discussions, or for “indecent” or “bad” behaviour and “unruliness” in the sleeping halls.⁵⁴ Often, it was not just one person who received the punishment but a group who had been caught socialising. As the overseer did not elaborate on what was at any given time meant by “indecenty”—apart from one case where he explained that three women had been “bickering and quarrelling”—it is difficult to know exactly what was going on in the spinhouse at night. It is also hard to know if the entries are just the tip of the iceberg, and if so, how large a proportion of intercommunication between the women went unnoticed and therefore unrecorded. However, the number of entries suggests that while the prisoners were guarded at night (after all, they were caught in the act), the guards were not present at all times (judging from the fact that the women obviously tried to break the rules). It can be asked whether the prisoners had actually developed a practice of using the late hours to share their experiences and make sense of them together, albeit sometimes argumentatively.

Another potential practice is revealed by the entries related to prayers and services. The prisoners were punished not only for behaving badly during religious events but also for doing something else *during* them. In August 1875, Edla A. was caught “procuring unallowed pieces of clothing for an inmate in a cell during service”,⁵⁵ and the following day, Lisa S. received a punishment for an “unauthorised changing of clothes in a cell during service”.⁵⁶ It is not difficult to see what was going on: Edla was helping Lisa, who had three months earlier been confined in a cell for an indefinite time for “indecent communication with a fellow inmate”.⁵⁷ A year later, Maria L. was put in a cell for an indefinite time for “embezzlement of work materials during service”.⁵⁸ While these are isolated

⁵⁴ “oanständigt/otillbörligt samtal”, “oanständigt uppförande”, “dåligt uppförande”, “oregerlighet”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1873–1880.

⁵⁵ “inskaaffande af otillåtna klädespersedlar åt cellfänge under gudstjenst”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1875.

⁵⁶ “otillåtet förändrande af kläderspersedlar i cell under gudstjenst”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1875.

⁵⁷ “oanständigt umgänge med medfänge”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1875. In the end, Lisa’s confinement in a solitary cell lasted six months, as it did for those two women with whom she had been communicating.

⁵⁸ “förskingring af arbetsmaterialer under pågående gudstjenst”. NAF, Archives of Lappeenranta Spinhouse, Ad, Punishment journal, 1876.

cases, they suggest that the women may have learned that the service provided them with an opportunity to do prohibited things without being caught so easily. This, in turn, may point towards many kinds of experiences typical of life in the spinhouse in the 1870s, such as being cold or dirty (hence, the need to change clothes) or experiencing friendship or communality (hence, an urge or perceived obligation to help).

The glimpses of a potential horizon of experience in the institution in question can often be investigated further by resorting to other administrative documents. For example, for those interested in digging deeper into the experiences of hunger or cold, it might be helpful to explore dietary tables or the purchases of food supplies or firewood in the account books. For those interested in friendships behind bars, prisoners' savings books—when available—could be of use. In Lappeenranta Spinhouse, savings books were used by the overseer to record how much money each prisoner had brought with her, how much she earned for her work in the spinhouse, and what she had purchased while in the spinhouse. Judging by the fact that the women bought things for their fellow prisoners or contributed to their funeral arrangements, it appears that friendships were indeed forged (or maintained) in the spinhouse and that there may have existed a collective “us” among the women.

As pointed out by Paul Carter, Jeff James, and Steve King, it is not always clear whether disciplinary infractions were “simple personal reactions to encounters in the institution” or actions with a “wider strategic intent”.⁵⁹ Likewise, we do not necessarily know which unofficial practices (if any) were deliberately passed from old-timers to newcomers or which ones emerged because similar circumstances prompted similar reactions time after time. One could ask, however, whether we even need to know this—after all, by identifying patterns in the data and by tracing the experiences behind the patterns, we may in any case be able to see the life in an institution in a new light.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

In this chapter, I have exemplified how administrative documents can be analysed to map past worlds of experiencing in residential institutions, be they spinhouses, prisons, poorhouses, or reformatory schools,

⁵⁹ Carter, James, & King 2019, 176 n6.

to name a few. I have suggested that such worlds come into being in/as entanglements between people and their material surroundings, which are regulated by socio-spatial practices. As theorised by Henri Lefebvre, socio-spatial practices may include groupings, divisions, movements, soundscapes, and routines in a particular space. Lefebvre's notion can be used as a checklist for things to look for when exploring administrative sources. If we can identify such practices, we can estimate what kind of experiences were likely to take place in the institution in question—in other words, what the horizon of experience was like. We may also find traces of navigations, negotiations, and conflicts around socio-spatial practices—which, in turn, can be read as sensemaking around the experiences these practices produced in people. In the end, then, the pages of a concise minute book or a meticulously kept ledger, often deemed as “thin” or “dry”, may render the past worlds of experiencing open to the scholarly gaze.

To exemplify my approach, I discussed the archives of two nineteenth-century Finnish spinhouses, which were institutions for vagrant and convict women. The examples clearly indicate that when exploring past worlds and horizons of experiencing, the best results are achieved by combining different kinds of administrative sources. For example, the observations based on board meeting minutes or punishment journals can be further explored by analysing inventories, account books, or prisoners' savings books. Moreover, knowledge of prior scholarship and the specific socio-cultural context is essential in order to recognise what was typical of the life in the institution in question, the period in question, or the people in question. A good example is periodic overcrowding in the spinhouses. In the previous literature, which is based on reports by central administration rather than the spinhouse documents, overcrowding is presented as an administrative, moral, and medical problem as perceived by contemporary officials. But how did the prisoners experience overcrowding? Or did they experience it in any particular way, given that most poor people were actually used to cramped living conditions?

There are lots of directions to head towards from here. The proposed approach allows for comparisons between different institutional settings, but also *longue durée* explorations of persistence and change of socio-spatial practices and their interaction with experiences over time. It would, for example, be interesting to analyse whether the unofficial practices impacted the official ones, and if so, what the role of such interplay was in institutional reforms.

As always in historical research, it is also fruitful to draw inspiration from other disciplines.⁶⁰ For instance, carceral geographers write about intermediate zones in modern prisons. Such zones are not private, but they nevertheless allow the prisoners a broader emotional register than the characteristically public zones in the institution.⁶¹ Or, the administrative power can be conceptualised as layers, the density of which varies in different parts of an institution.⁶² While there were hardly any private zones in a nineteenth-century spinhouse or other similar institutions, there may have been intermediate zones or areas where the layers of power were thinner than elsewhere—perhaps depending on the time of the day, week, or year. This notion raises a lot of intriguing questions. Did the unofficial socio-spatial practices flourish in these zones or areas, and how did these differing socio-spatial and material settings shape the horizons of experience? Were the negotiations and conflicts bound to the variations or fluctuations in them? Overall, crossings-over between the history of experience and other disciplines, such as human geography or sociology, can prove useful when trying to find out how the worlds and horizons of experiencing altered depending on where you were in the institution.

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⁶⁰ Annola 2023b.

⁶¹ Crewe et al. 2014.

⁶² Repo 2020.

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Sermons and Didactic Material as Sources for the History of Experience

Sari Katajala-Peltomaa 

Didactic material in general is not composed only of abstract ideas; experiences in different forms are also to be found. Sermons, for example, were a crucial method to disseminate the Church's teaching in medieval Christianity. Theology and dogma comprised the core of sermons, but they were a nexus of the learned and lay worlds. They intertwined erudite theological reflection with everyday religiosity, and they could be seen as a bridge between different worldviews. Sermons were didactic tools written for impact; in the study of the history of experiences, this impact can also be analysed as an intended experience.

Medieval preaching followed the definition proposed by Augustine of focusing on teaching and moving (the soul), *docere et flectere*. A good sermon utilised both the intellect and emotions,¹ but the mental images it put forward needed to be comprehensible to the lay audience. The preacher's message had to resonate with the audience. Originality was

¹ Rosier-Catach 2014b, 555. Also Pellegrini 2014, 21–41.

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not at the core of a sermon; therefore, commonplaces and topoi are regularly found in this material. They reflect the typical rather than the individual; preachers used the same aids, model sermons, in compiling their texts. Sermons were a unifying tool across geographical areas and time periods; similar ideas and the same formulae reached Christians across Western Christianity, and the structure and core of sermons could remain similar for centuries. Therefore, many of the structural details and rhetorical devices scrutinised and arguments presented—elements used to give meaning and create an experience—hold true also for sermons of other eras and Christian churches.²

Sermons were the mass media of the Middle Ages. They both reflected and shaped the worldview of medieval Christians, and the social and cultural surroundings were distilled in the preaching. Sermons were linked to the yearly rhythm; preaching practices included a cycle of Sunday sermons (*de temporis*) that followed the pattern of the Church year. On saints' feast days, specific sermons were preached (*de sanctis*). There were also sermons for specific groups of people, such as pilgrims (*ad status*).³

If sermons were structured by following previous examples, guided by a strong unifying tendency, and utilised as part of the didactic and disciplinary programme of the Church, how can they be of help in the search for historical experiences?

Here experience is approached as an analytical tool, meaning that the intention is not to try to detect the “authenticity” of a lived encounter with the world, which has been coined by Martin Jay as the “simplistic ground of immediacy”. The goal in this chapter is not to determine how listening to a particular sermon felt for an individual listener or what kind of reactions it prompted in the audience. This scope is not chosen because sermons and didactic material cannot give such answers; no historical source material can provide us with a historical actor's immediacy of an experience. As Martin Jay continues, “cultural relations are always mediated and the subject, the bearer of experiences, is instable”.⁴ Therefore, experiences are always mediated and situational. It is the mediated, collective, and shaped nature of experience that can be teased out of the didactic material as well. At stake in this chapter is the process

² D'Avray 1994, 3–29.

³ D'Avray 1994, 8–17.

⁴ Jay 2005, 3.

of experiencing—from the past daily occurrences of an individual to the shared meaning-making process—as well as structuring experience and experience as structure.

A POSSIBLE EXPERIENCE—EXPERIENCE OF THE POSSIBLE

On an individual level, experience is a holistic phenomenon connecting the somatic and the cognitive: emotions are connected with corporeality, the sensate with the mental. The very core of an experience is, nevertheless, its social character. Giving meaning to the daily occurrences—encounters with the world—are crucial constituents of creating an experience. When these processes of giving meaning are repeated often and long enough, they become consolidated and form a structure of the culture and society. Therefore, experience is one of the mechanisms that connects individuals to their societies.⁵ All experiences are non-individual. It is possible to produce mediated experiences communally and to internalise others' experiences.

Within the sermon texts, a shared experience was created by the words of a preacher. One may call these experiences imagined, meaning there was no individual who was the bearer of the experience of the whole. However, many in the audience had encountered something similar—or parts of it—in the past. The preacher was giving a new meaning to these encounters utilising and evoking both the imagination and memories of the listeners.⁶

To be able to analyse experience within this scenario, we follow the conceptualisation of Hannu Salmi, who argues that the notion of the possible is a crucial constituent of historical studies and distinguishes three different levels. The first level is what is possible for historians to know about the past, the second concerns the possibilities open to historical agents themselves, and the third the possibilities historical agents perceived themselves.⁷

⁵ Seminal works in the field of historical experiences include Scott 1991, 773–797; Jay 2005. For the three levels of experience as “lived”, as a process, and as a structure, see Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 1–35. For a recent profound historiographical analysis of the study of historical experiences, see Nagy & Biron-Ouellet 2022.

⁶ See also Katajala-Peltomaa 2025.

⁷ Salmi 2011, 171–187.

It is not possible for us to capture the past act of preaching. The act of preaching was an interactive performance carried out in the vernacular. A good preacher could make the text come alive utilising different tones, pauses, gestures, and personal enthusiasm.⁸ For the majority of preserved sermons, it is impossible to know whether they were ever actually preached, and if so, when, where, or for whom exactly. The focus of this article is on the saints' feast day sermons, it can be assumed that these occasions, the feast of the patron saint with liturgical celebrations including a sermon, were special, emotional moments for the congregation. We do not, however, typically know how the congregation reacted to the preacher's preaching performance, and the reaction cannot be deduced from the text itself.

Nevertheless, the intended audience is always already present in the text: the preacher's primary aim was to reach his audience, and the sermon was written specifically for that audience. The written text itself is therefore a form of interaction. Sermons reflected not only theological subtleties but also the concrete aspects of faith—actions, habits, emotions, and sensory elements—daily encounters with the world that could have happened to the listeners. The message needed to resonate with the members of the audience, with their past experiences and comprehension thereof. The texts analysed in this chapter are preacher's notes, organised according to a structure (*prothema, thema, disctintio, exempla*) and written in Latin.⁹ Late medieval preaching, in general, arranged the discussed religious themes according to a structure, but it is unknown how well the medieval lay audience comprehended the thematic structure of a sermon. However, if we follow the argumentation of David d'Avrey, literary structures do not have to be consciously perceived by the recipient or even by their creator to work.¹⁰

The didactic material is well suited to analyse experience as processes to give meaning to past encounters with the world, since this kind of material, in general, was written to educate, to give meaning. In a sermon, emotions and sensory elements were a means of communication. Written and spoken emotives (emotion words) and sensory perceptions have a

⁸ Pellegrini 2014, 21–41.

⁹ On the structure of a medieval sermon in general, see Wenzel 2015; Smith 2019, 328; Caplan 1933, 88–92; and on Birgittine sermons in particular, see Andersson 2001, 51–79.

¹⁰ D'Avrey 1994, 18–19.

direct connection with the emotions and senses of the hearers. The preacher's aim was to move the soul of the audience members—to arouse or even provoke emotions, to persuade them to act in a certain way, and to delight the soul in a manner the listener was not fully aware of.¹¹ The preacher was aiming to create an experience, and this was in line with the medieval comprehension of the power of words. Performative words were at the core of Christianity: God created the world by words and Christ's, the prophets', and the saints' speech acts could cure, bless, or curse. Many of the sacraments required (proper) words to be effective.¹²

A meaningful experience does not always require personal first-hand encounters. Experiences created by words and shared via listening can be internalised. The interconnection of the experience and the possible that is under scrutiny here borrows from the two last categories formulated by Salmi. It was possible (and even required) for medieval Christians to attend mass, hear sermons, and comprehend the theological messages formulated in them. Verbal images were used to impress the message on the mind of the listeners—the words of the preacher made things happen.¹³

Interaction with heavenly intercessors was deeply intertwined with daily life, and sermons on a saint's feast day were part of the religiosity of medieval Christians. During the sermon—through the sermon and with the help of the preacher—one interacted with one's heavenly patron. One of the purposes of the sermon on the feast of the saint was to strengthen this relationship and increase devotion. Medieval preachers utilised both imagination and memory to create a shared experience. Imagination concerns the human mind's ability to make present things that are not concrete or visible; memory, in turn, concerns the human mind's ability to make present things that are no longer concrete. According to the medieval mode of thought, imagination was a way to make unreal or surreal entities real. Imagination was capable of affecting people since both the inner and outer senses were avenues for sense perceptions. The inner, spiritual senses were analogous to the physical senses, but they were

¹¹ Rosier-Catach 2014b, 555. On the interaction between the preacher and the audience, see esp. Campbell 2021 and the collections edited by Maria Giuseppina Muzzarelli 2014 and Carolyn Muessig 2002, particularly the texts by Carolyn Muessig, Augustine Thompson OP, Beverly Mayne Kienzle, and Phyllis B. Roberts.

¹² Rosier-Catach 2014a, 12–13.

¹³ See also D'Avrey 1994, 20.

immaterial, belonging to the spirit or soul. The inner senses could also include the mental faculties, the cognitive process of the imagination, intellect, and memory.¹⁴

Even if the preachers do not distinctly formulate their message as creating an experience, it follows the medieval logic of making things real by (inner) sense perceptions. This was perceived as possible by contemporaries. Emotions and sensory elements in a sermon were something that could have been true and could have happened to the listeners, and parts of it likely had. Preachers were evoking familiar past occurrences in the minds of their listeners and conjuring up events including emotions and sensory elements, sights, sounds, and smells. The possibility in the preacher's words was captured and comprehended by the audience and hence the experience was internalised via listening, imagination, and memory.¹⁵

VADSTENA ABBEY AS A CONTEXT

A sermon was part of Sunday mass and within medieval Christianity, parish priests were likely the most common preachers. In addition to the yearly circle of Sunday sermons, sermons were preached on various different occasions, like on specific feast days, on market days, on a bishop's visitation and church's consecration, or at the beginning of a war, crusade, or pilgrimage. The means and methods of preachers were multiple—and so were the audiences, ranging from kings to humble peasants. The sermon could be for a general Christian audience or a more targeted group. While preaching was an important means of lay education, members of clerical and monastic orders were typical—if not the most typical—audiences. Sermons were also an information channel for secular matters, like important political events or natural catastrophes. This means that despite the shared aims and general topics and common structures of sermons, each occasion of preaching was distinct; the preacher's aims varied from one situation to the next as did the audience's motivation and readiness for reception. As John H. Arnold

¹⁴ Karnes 2015, 327–366; Szarka 2021, 901–917, Macdonald, Murphy, & Swann 2018, 1–15; Newhauser 2018, 39–59.

¹⁵ On somatic experiences internalised via reading, see Drury 2019.

summarises the situation, “‘preaching’ is not really one standard, interchangeable act but really a range of possible events, in terms of its orchestration, content, style and who delivered it”.¹⁶

For experience as an object of historical analysis, this means that the contexts of sermons cannot be generalised—and since experiences are always situational, the experience produced by a sermon cannot be generalised either. However, from a methodological perspective, it can be argued that didactic material shares a common ground; typical mechanisms of producing an experience can be deduced from this material, and the analysis of a single example may provide broader methodological advantages within this field.

Specific religious orders, particularly the Medicants, were created to support the preaching and the educative programme of the Church. The context chosen for this article is, however, a more traditional monastic order, namely that of *Ordo Sanctissimi Salvatoris* created by Saint Birgitta in the fourteenth century. Birgitta herself was a famous mystic known for her revelations published as *Revelaciones celestes*.¹⁷ During her revelations, she received hidden wisdom and many pieces of concrete advice from Christ and the Virgin Mary. One among them was the instruction to establish a monastic order that was organised as a double house headed by an abbess. The rule of the order, *Regula*, was also given to Birgitta in a vision. In addition to sisters, Birgittine monasteries included brethren whose task was to take care of the spiritual needs of the nuns.

In addition to contemplation, preaching—also to the lay audience—was a crucial part of the Birgittine monastic idea. According to *Regula*, the priest brothers’ task was to preach every Sunday and on other important days, making a total of a hundred preaching days per year. The *Regula* also dictated how to preach: the style had to be clear and simple, and the emphasis should not be on theological finesse or rhetorical elegance but on ensuring that the message got across to the audience. The Birgittine brethren had to preach in a way that even the simple layman

¹⁶ Arnold 2024, 297.

¹⁷ Birgitta was one of the most famous and controversial of medieval mystics, and the scholarship dedicated to her is too vast to be cited here in full. Birgitta as a person or her mysticism is not, however, under scrutiny here. On recent studies on Birgittine influence and ethos, see, e.g. example, Gejrot, Åkestam, & Andersson (eds) 2007, Oen (ed.) 2019; Andersson, Hedström, & Åkestam (eds) 2023, and Häggglund & Lahti (eds) 2025.

could understand their message.¹⁸ These details were, however, ideals put forward in general preaching manuals as well.¹⁹

Vadstena was the mother house of the Birgittine order; it was situated by lake Vättern in Sweden and founded on land donated by the royal couple, King Magnus Eriksson of Sweden and his queen, Blanche, in 1346. The Birgittine Order was officially approved by the pope in 1370 and the abbey was dedicated in 1384. Vadstena was an important centre; it served several times as a meeting place for the state council and political negotiations, and land donations and other gifts eventually made it a rich monastic centre. Vadstena was a learning centre with a large library and active preaching policy. The significance of Vadstena and the whole Birgittine order was enhanced by a network of daughter monasteries spread out over the Baltic Sea and beyond.²⁰ Birgittine monasteries borrowed religious material to be copied from each other. Vadstena was also a popular pilgrimage centre; this is reflected in the administrative documents granting extra authority to the Birgittine brethren's care of the souls and the Archbishop of Uppsala commenting on the multitude of pilgrims coming to the Abbey from "nearly all parts of the world".²¹ In sum, the Birgittine preaching agenda had a wider than local significance.

It is estimated that the most popular feast days could attract an audience of thousands of pilgrims to Vadstena. Some contemporary sources also suggest that the message of the Birgittine brethren's sermons was well received by their audience. An anonymous Franciscan describes in a letter dated around 1400 that preaching was rare in the Swedish kingdom at that time, and other orders were not as enthusiastic and talented at it

¹⁸ On the Birgittine preaching tradition, see Andersson & Borgehammar 1997; Andersson 2001; 2011; 2015; 2019; Borgehammar 1991; 1995; Berggren 2002.

¹⁹ Humbert de Romans, *Treatise on Preaching*, 32–34.

²⁰ Birgitta was canonized as a saint in 1391. Nyberg 1991; Hågglund 2022. On the political activity through Birgittine brethren's sermons, see Berglund 2004; on the political agenda in the Vadstena Abbey's diary, see Gejrot 2016, 131–147. On Birgitta's and the royal couple's relations, see Salmesvuori 2014, 145–158.

²¹ "quasi ex omni parte orbis veniens", the main catalogue of *Diplomatarium Suecanum* (Svenskt Diplomatariums huvudkartotek, SDHK) 25,766. The same document states that from six to eight extra confessors were needed to hear the confession of pilgrims. The general confessor and brethren of the abbey were not enough. The document is dated to 1450. For the Bishop of Turku granting the general confessor of Vadstena Abbey the right to absolve sins of Finnish pilgrims in 1417, see *Diplomatarium Fennicum* (DF) 1501.

compared to the Birgittine brothers. The Birgittines, on the other hand, were fierce in their attack on sin, and their audience became aware for the first time how badly God disapproved of sin and vice. According to the letter, the Vadstena brethren not only quoted from Birgitta's *Revelaciones*, but also explained the holy word of the Bible to the unlearned listeners. Their success, however, aroused the envy and resentment of other churchmen.²²

The corpus of Vadstena sermons that has survived to this day is remarkable: circa five thousand sermons were written at Vadstena between 1380 and 1520. The most important feast days for preaching were the three feasts of Birgitta—the feast of the translation of the relics (*Dies translationis*, 28 May); the day of Birgitta's death, or birth as a saint (*Dies Natalis*, 23 July); and the commemoration of Birgitta's canonization (*Dies Canonizacionis*, 7 October). In addition to the feasts of the founder of the order, a prominent position was held by the feast day of Saint Peter in chains (*Sancti Petri ad vincula*, 1 August), when Vadstena and the whole order held large indulgences. Some 120 sermons for the feast of Saint Birgitta and 91 for Saint Peter in chains are preserved.²³

The text chosen for closer analysis for the study of the production of experience in didactic material is a sermon for Birgitta's *Dies Natalis* written by a brother called Johannes Borquardi in the second quarter of the fifteenth century. Johannes settled at Vadstena monastery in 1428. He wrote three large sermon collections and commented on the texts of other Birgittine brethren. He was also active in the administrative affairs of the order, acting, for example, as a procurator and dealing with various administrative matters relating to the monastery's property with Nordic bishops, King Christopher, and the Holy See. He died in 1447 on the Finnish side of the Swedish realm while he was settling disputes at the Birgittine monastery of Nådendal (Naantali).

This *Dies Natalis* sermon is one of the 120 preserved sermons for Birgitta's feast days and one within the three large collections written by

²² Andersson & Borgehammar 1997, for a partial translation of the Franciscan's letter, 213. The letter is preserved in the library of Lincoln Cathedral.

²³ Andersson 2001, 11; Berggren 2002, VII–XI. The sermons are preserved in Uppsala University's library in C-Sammlung and catalogued in Andersson-Schmitt–Hallberg–Hedlund 1995, 8 vols. For the list of sermons on the feast days of Birgitta and Saint Peter in chains, see vol. 8, 25, 32.

Johannes. It follows the typical structure of medieval sermons: *prothema-thema-distinctio*, ending with Amen. A major part of it— not unlike many other sermons for Birgitta’s feast day— focuses on the life and merits of Birgitta, such as humility, taciturnity, chastity, obedience, patience, poverty, and asceticism. The Vadstena sermons varied in length and content, and with its five folios Johannes’ *Dies Natalis* sermon is of medium length among them.²⁴

TIME, SPACE, AND (DEVOTIONAL) COMMUNITY: STRUCTURING THE EXPERIENCE

On a general level, repentance and conversion to a pious life, praising the contemplative life, and reaching the potential to achieve a union with God in the next life were the core theological messages of medieval sermons.²⁵ The patron saint’s feast day was a unique occasion; the sermons were delivered to honour her life and virtues.²⁶ We may assume that devotion was a major motivation to participate in mass on that day. The listeners were likely more open to sense the sacred and the bond between the heavenly intercessor and the congregation than when participating in mass and the sermon on other days for other reasons. The character of saints and their cults varied, and so did the sermons on their feast days.

The sacred, as a physical place (such as an abbey housing the saint’s relics) or as a socially constructed space, was an important part of the medieval mentality and culture. The sacred was not only a product of elite domination, such as by preachers, but required also the participation of the laity, the congregation. The sacred was not a stable or fixed entity; it was constantly under negotiation and requiring re-enactment.²⁷ The construction process was multifaceted, involving didactic tools like sermons; practices, like attending a mass; and behavioural expectations,

²⁴ Uppsala University Library (UUB) C 331, ff. 12r–17r.

²⁵ D’Avrey 1994, 20. On the conversion moment within exempla from a comparative perspective, see Katajala-Peltomaa & Mäkelä 2022.

²⁶ Ferzoco 1996, 103–125, who also distinguishes the sermons for canonized saints and local saints. On *de sanctis* sermons in general, see Kienzle et al. (ed.) 1996.

²⁷ On the various meanings and uses of the sacred, see Döring 2006, 7–11. On the evolution of the concept of the sacred in the Western tradition, see Besserman 2006, 1–15; Coster & Spicer 2005; Mara de Silva 2015. On fluidity and porous boundaries between the sacred and secular, see Hamilton & Spicer 2005, 1–26.

like veneration of the patron saint. Sensory and emotional elements as well as responses were part of the negotiation process.

This pre-existing devotion was a crucial tool for the preacher to build his message on—to create the possible experience in the minds of the listeners. Johannes starts his sermon from this premise: “Beloved. Today we celebrate the day of our blessed mother, *domina* Birgitta, since today she migrated from this world to Christ”.²⁸ Johannes uses several narrative techniques in his pursuit. The first is underlining the date, which was a rather typical method in liturgical material.²⁹ Johannes places a specific emphasis on the day, the precise timing. Today—*hodie*—belonged to the secular time of the listeners: the lay members of the congregation had taken time out from the hustle and bustle of everyday life to travel from near or far to the shrine of Birgitta to celebrate the feast day, *Dies natalis*, while for the members of the Birgittine order the specialness of the day consisted more clearly of immaterial and spiritual elements. In Johannes’ sermon, “today” was the day Birgitta left this world and journeyed to God. The day of the saint’s death was of central importance to cultic practices: it was the day the saint was born a saint. Often it was also the most important feast day, but for Birgitta the most important feast day was reserved for her canonisation day.

“Today” in sermons in general belonged to the liturgical time of the Church, a cyclical yearly rhythm that was repeated time and again, creating routines and marking milestones in the yearly calendar. On a general level, the repetition of feast days and sermons was a cyclical re-enactment of paradigmatic events of liturgical time. “Today” in the sermons was a very special milestone, because it was also part of God’s eternal time, connecting the time of men to the time of God. Thus, Christians were able to experience these different dimensions of time: for a fleeting moment, divine time was made concrete and available to them. It can be argued that time, too, is a social construct: it is subjective and interpretive. The practices—like attending mass on a feast day—essentially

²⁸ “Karissimi. Hodie celebramus diem beatissime matris nostre et domine Birgitte et quando ab hoc mundo migravit ad Xristum.” UUB C 331, f. 12r. Transliterations and translations of UUB C331 are mine; I would, however, like to thank Roger Andersson and Stephan Borgehammar for letting me have access to their unpublished database of C-Sammlung sermons which have enabled, for example, word searches of wider material and other comparative references to this material.

²⁹ On senses and emotions in liturgical material, see Palazzo 2014.

affect the experience of time. Time is also active or performative in influencing interactions.³⁰ From the perspective of the study of experiences, time is a part of the meaning-making process; it is a core element of experiencing. By stressing a specific time, preachers like Johannes were giving meaning to the gathering—creating an experience.

Specific emphasis is also given to the space, even though Vadstena is not mentioned in the text as a sacred place. It is, however, clear that the preacher and the audience occupy the same space. The connection between the secular and the divine as well as the preacher's intermediary role is further emphasised in the text. "We celebrate" today and here—the message is addressed directly to the listeners, to those who are already present at the shrine in Vadstena. The combination of a specific time and place in connection with the first-person plural is a deliberate choice emphasising also the bond between the audience and the preacher.³¹

An affective rhetorical device in creating coherence and a sense of belonging—and specific to this context—was to call Birgitta "mother". The term undoubtedly derives from a vision of Birgitta in which Christ tells her that she is his bride and a nun and mother in Vadstena (Rev. II:31), which was repeated in the Vadstena sermons. The mother theme has a recurrent presence, even to the extent that it seems to have become an integral part of Birgitta's name. In the sermons, Birgitta is not only Birgitta but, as a rule, our blessed mother Birgitta, *mater nostra beata Birgitta*.

In medieval Christianity, motherhood was a strong symbol. It was associated with power and authority as much as with nurture and compassion. It was linked to Eve's fall, carnality, and suffering, but these aspects were of course not emphasised in Birgitta's motherhood.³² Motherhood was also a cultural concept and not just related to gender or physical mothers. Thus, God, Christ, and sometimes the abbots and other spiritual leaders took on maternal qualities and, for example, "breast-fed" spiritual nourishment to their followers. Motherhood included the duty to guide the offspring on the right path. Motherhood was also associated with connection and intimacy, since mothers were physically linked

³⁰ Lazar 2022.

³¹ On the interconnection of sacral performances and space in experiencing the sacred, see Laitinen 2014, 127–154.

³² On medieval mothering, see Parson & Wheeler 1996; Atkinson 1991. On motherhood in Birgittine rhetoric, see Lamberg 2010.

to their children.³³ The idea of motherhood likely resonated differently among different listeners. For the Birgittine nuns and brethren, the idea of spiritual family and Birgitta as a mother was likely more comprehensible, while motherhood in general was a concrete, everyday concept and position for the laity. The same rhetorical building blocks could create individual processes of meaning-making.

In Birgitta's case, power and authority were further emphasised by calling her lady, *domina*. *Domina* was a term that could be used to refer to any married woman of higher status, but of course it also brought to mind the Virgin Mary, *Domina nostra*. Motherhood and the term *domina* emphasised both community and belonging, but they were also part of value systems—the listeners were subordinate to Birgitta in the hierarchy, but also closely linked to her. “Mother” is a strong word emphasising emotionality; Johannes does not, however, elaborate on its meaning in the text. Potentially the meaning of mother was so obvious that it did not need further explaining. It brought with it an understanding of nurture—Birgitta was in heaven to convey our prayers—but also of authority; the hierarchy between the listeners and the subject of the sermon was clear. The hierarchies and structures of the surrounding society are present in the didactic material.

If Birgitta is our mother, then we all belong to the same family. The use of the first-person plural points in the same direction: we celebrate, *celebramus*, all together. The emotional bond is further emphasised in the use of emotion words. Johannes begins his sermon by calling his listeners his beloved—*karissimi*. This is a typical rhetorical device used by preachers, and perhaps should not be taken to carry too much weight, although not all preachers used such an opening. However, Johannes uses the term *karissimi* to punctuate his message throughout the sermon, to emphasise key points in this sermon as well as in others. For him, *karissimi* seems to be an interjection when starting a new topic or when emphasising a particular message of a sermon.³⁴ As a direct address, the term also seeks to connect interactively with the hearers; it was a means of creating a bond

³³ Hakala 2021; MacLehose 1999, 25–38.

³⁴ For example, “Ecce, karissimi, quam magnifice deus in hoc mundo virtutibus magnificavit.” UUB C 331, f. 16r; “Ecce, karissimi, quo omnes recessa ab deo” UUB C 331, f. 175v; “Ecce, karissimi, quam beata Birgitta illustrata fuit habere divinam sapientiam [in] animam eius,” UUB C 331, f. 177r. “Ecce karissimi, cum talibus ypocritis periculosum est conuersari.” UUB C 392, f. 122r.

with them. The term *karissimi* suggests a conscious aim to create a bond between the preacher and the listeners that was perceived as a devotional community by the audience.

MOVING THE SOUL: ENCHANTING THE AUDIENCE

Both the *prothema* and *thema* of Johannes's text are the same parable from the Book of Judith: "my life is magnified in me this day more than all the days since I was born" (KJV).³⁵ The *thema* is underlined in the manuscript as is shown in the Fig. 6.1. The text continues in both passages with an explanation of how this was the day when our blessed mother passed from this world to the glory of heaven. Both sections then deal with birth. The first section, after the *prothema*, deals with the birth of a human being, with the pain and shame that goes with it: both mother and baby suffer physically in childbirth; original sin already stains the newborn, and with it comes gluttony and lust and other immorality.³⁶ And—shameful indeed—we are all born naked. So, our coming into this world is more like the day we die. It is different for the saints: when they leave this miserable life behind them, they are truly born into eternal life.

The *thema* continues this theme of the birth of Birgitta into eternal life. However, even in this world, Birgitta's life was not particularly miserable—she was, after all, chosen by God and enjoyed many acts of grace while she was still alive. The affective elements were further emphasised in his text. There are numerous emotives. Misery (*miseria*) is repeated in various forms in the descriptions of this life, as is glory (*gloria*) and joy (*gaudium*) in the description of the afterlife. In particular, seven virtues adorned and accentuated Birgitta: humility (*humilitas*), chastity (*castitas*), obedience (*obediencia*), patience (*paciencia*), poverty (*paupertas*), abstinence (*abstinencia*), and love (*caritas*). All the virtues were illustrated with concrete examples from Birgitta's life.³⁷ While these virtues were set as examples to all Christians, here again their appeal and affect were met differently, since the audience had different memories of achieving or failing to achieve them; they also likely imagined the results of such

³⁵ "Hodie magnificata est anima mea per omnibus diebus vite mee." Judith 12:18.

³⁶ Cf. Hanska & Katajala-Peltomaa 2019 on giving birth as spiritual birth in a thirteenth century sermon.

³⁷ Vitae were typical sources for *de sanctis* sermons, Ferzoco 1996, 116.

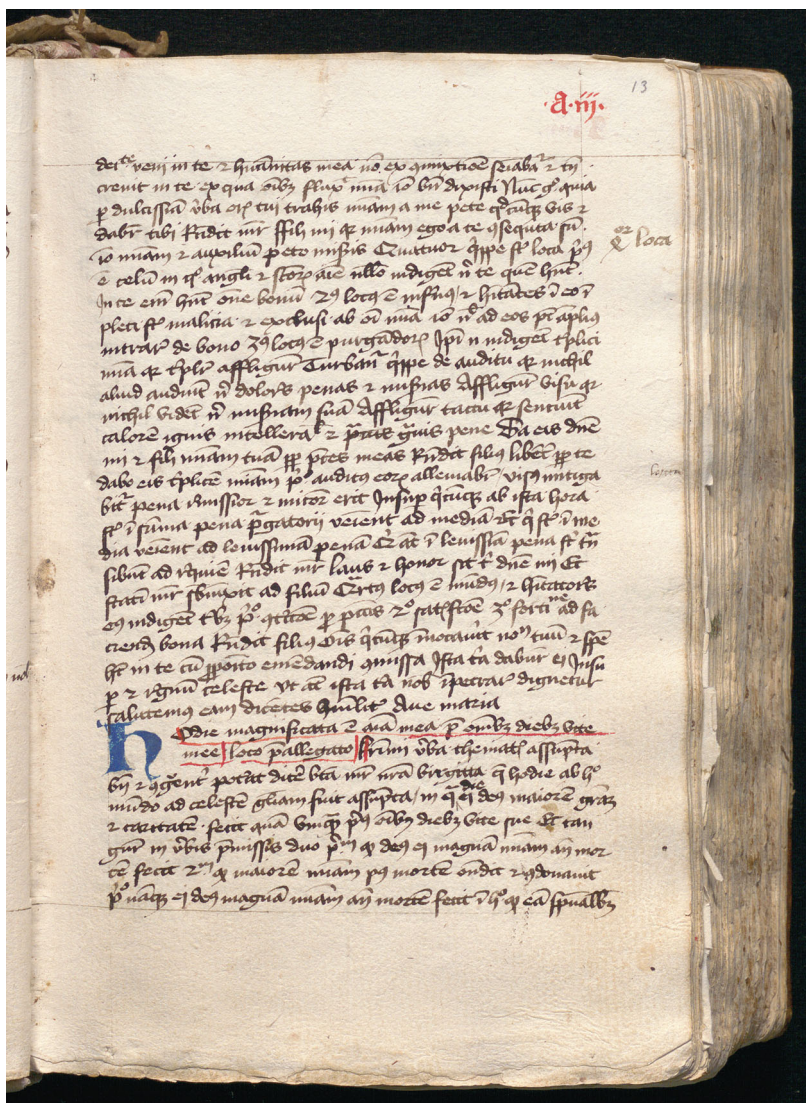


Fig. 6.1 Most of the surviving medieval sermon texts are preacher's notes in Latin, made in preparation for preaching. Here is the beginning of the sermon for Saint Birgitta's Dies natalis feast; the text was compiled and the whole collection handwritten by Johannes Borquardi, a Birgittine brother in Vadstena, in the second quarter of the fifteenth century. UUB C 331 f 13r

achievements or failures differently. Obviously, such memories and mental images were individual but likely the rough differentiation into lay people and the Birgittines was significant in this context, too. The model set by Birgitta was more tangible and even mandatory (even if unachievable) for the nuns as brides of Christ than for lay people.

Johannes describes Birgitta as being like a dove and the virtues that surrounded her like roses and lilies: “I saw my beautiful one like a dove rising above the streams of water, in whose clothing was a fragrance beyond measure. And as in the springlike days, she was surrounded by roses and lilies of the valley”.³⁸

This text is a quotation from a hymn in Marian liturgy for the feast of the Assumption of Mary.³⁹ Even if this kind of borrowing—of themes, texts, and melodies—was generally not unknown, this is not a coincidence. The Birgittine brethren alluded in their sermons to a connection between the Virgin Mary, the queen of heaven, and Birgitta. Johannes extrapolates the quotation: this dove was Birgitta, our blessed mother who was beautiful both inside and out. Her heart was pure and manners fair. Her virtues were her soul’s (fragrant) clothing, and the roses and lilies were the virtues God magnified in her. Hence the remarkable odour. The Virgin Mary was known and praised for virginal fecundity⁴⁰—she was simultaneously a mother and virgin—and a similar logic seems to run behind the descriptions of Birgitta. After all, she was regularly called a bride or the true bride of Christ in the Birgittine sermons, while at the same time she was “our mother”.⁴¹ Johannes, too, emphasises this in his other sermons on Birgitta: “This, beloved, is how honest, chaste, and fecund our blessed mother Birgitta is—and full of virtues. Our Lord

³⁸ “Idem vidi speciosam sicut columbam ascendenem desuper rivos aquam. Cuius inestimalis odor erat nimis in vestimentis eius. Et sicut dies verni circumdabant eam flores rosarum et lilia convallium.” UUB C 331, f. 13v.

³⁹ Cantus database <https://cantusdatabase.org/> gives hits from the tenth century (chant 459,240) to the thirteenth century (chant 256,541). The Gregorian Repertory <https://gregorien.info/en> (Chant 8611) gives a list of manuscripts containing this chant.

⁴⁰ Muessig 1996, 85.

⁴¹ E.g. UUB C 259, ff. 59r–61r; UUB C 386, ff. 446v–450r.

Jesus Christ took her as his bride and contracted a spiritual marriage with her”.⁴²

The vivid description of the dove, the river, and the meadow did not serve only to revere Birgitta. Rather, it seems the idea was to create an experience in the minds of listeners by rhetorical means and imagination—to call to mind past emotions and sensory elements on a springlike day by a stream. This experience is clearly something that had not taken place as such, even if it is described vividly like a personal memory. However, this kind of imagery could have been true and could have happened—such an encounter was possible in the minds of the listeners. So, Johannes was evoking past, familiar occurrences in the minds of the audience and conjuring up sensory elements. The requirement of “the possible” as well as utilising memory and imagination in creating the message can be generalised as a typical method for creating experience in didactic material in general and in sermons in particular.

Birgitta’s sanctity is here constructed via visual and olfactory sensations. Smell was considered an “inferior” sense in the medieval taxonomies, yet it was significant to religious thought, practice, and experience. Sensory evidence was important in literary models while constructing a religious experience: a sweet smell was a typical sign of a person’s sanctity and a foul stink marked demonic presence.⁴³ Johannes was using imagined sensory elements to put forward his message. What kind of experience was Johannes trying to create for the audience by praising Birgitta’s virtues with these eloquent words and painting a vivid image of a spring meadow with pleasant sights and sounds—the water and the dove—smells—the roses and lilies—and the unspecified *inestimalis odour*?

In modern scholarship, enchantment is considered a key element in religious experiences. It can be defined as an embodied “state of wonder” that cannot be simply explained. It is a sense of being captivated or even captured by something. Enchanting encounters can be prompted by memories or sensory stimuli—somatic effects are at their core. Traditionally, in the field of the study of religion, enchantment is associated with

⁴² “Ecce karissimi quia beata mater nostra Birgitta erat honesta pudica et fedunda cum plena virtutibus, dominus noster Jhesus Xristus eam assumpsit sibi in sponsam, et cum ea spirituale matrimonium contraxit.” UUB C 331, ff. 282v–289r.

⁴³ Roch 2019, 99–116. See Robinson 2020, especially 167–173 and passim for the medically aware theology of smell of the Late Middle Ages that was communicated via sermons alongside the traditional olfactory theory inherited from Antiquity.

the experience of the divine, particularly as spiritual rapture. While intensity and the extraordinary are key elements of enchantment, it can also be stimulated by everyday phenomena within daily life. Jane Bennet terms enchantment “the wonder of minor experiences”.⁴⁴ Enchantment had the ability to inspire “affective attachment” and cause changes in attitudes or behaviour.⁴⁵

All this seems to be in concordance with the primary aim of the sermons: to move the soul. However, it is obvious that the word enchantment held a different meaning in the medieval world: the root of the word is in Latin (*incanto*) meaning to sing, recite, or enchant. *Incantatio* means incantation, to cast a magical spell. Obviously, the intention of Johannes or other medieval preachers was not to bind their listeners with a magical spell—that sort of enchantment belonged to another realm. However, in the context of the spoken word, the power or energy of words was recognised; they had the capacity to move the audience; they had an effect on the listener; and they made things happen and changed the mental state of the listener. To move or delight the soul (without the listener even realising) seems to be the focal point. It is also noteworthy that the auditory experience was at the core of incantation as well as participating in preaching. Indeed, medieval preachers, too, were able to surround their audience with words which had the power “to carry [them] away on a sonorous stream”,⁴⁶ thus moving the soul and creating an experience of reverence and amazement.

As a methodological device, this kind of process of experiencing is not unique to Johannes’ sermon only. The experience Johannes was trying to produce seems to have a lot in common with the conceptualisations of enchantment by modern researchers of political sciences, geography, and religious studies, as presented above. By utilising minor encounters with the world, memories, and sensory stimuli, he and other preachers were creating a sense of awe and wonderment.

Johannes concluded his sermon by opening—in an allegorical way—the door to heaven: Christ raised Birgitta to heaven as a bride and placed a crown on her head. The crown and its 50 precious stones symbolise the

⁴⁴ Bennett 2001, 1–17.

⁴⁵ Maddrell 2022, 319. Woodyer & Geoghegan 2013, 195–214.

⁴⁶ Woodyer & Geoghegan 2013, 195–214.

joy and glory of the heavenly kingdom.⁴⁷ Johannes describes how today our blessed mother Birgitta enjoys the heavenly delight, in honour and glory, interceding for our poor prayers.⁴⁸ Johannes thus summarises the message of his opening words.

A.T. Thayer argues that generally saints were used in medieval sermons in three different roles. They were intercessors, the ones praying to God on behalf of Christians. They were also examples manifesting Christian virtue and showing how to proceed on the path of penitence. Their third role was that of reward after successful penitence; their eternal company was promised to the listeners.⁴⁹ We can agree with her findings; the means of communication emphasise these elements. Birgitta is described as being in heaven interceding on our behalf, conveying our prayers. Her virtues are emphasised in a verbose manner. At the same time, she is depicted as an unattainable role model. We may try to follow in her footsteps, but since she is God's chosen, our path is different. Her eternal company remains implicit in the text. However, since she is our mother, if we follow meticulously the instructions given in the sermons, we may be worthy of her company.

CONCLUSIONS

Didactic material could produce experiences without a specific "bearer of experience"; this kind of material could utilise memories, intellect, imagination, and emotions to turn past encounters with the world into shared experiences. The words of the preacher—the past emotions, sensory elements, and other encounters with the world—needed to resonate with the experiences and comprehension of the audience. Preachers were not only using emotions and sensory elements as rhetorical tools but reproducing them in their sermons. This kind of process of experiencing is not unique to the example under scrutiny here; rather techniques utilised by Johannes offer methodological tools for the analysis of didactic material for the history of experience more widely.

⁴⁷ "posuit dyadema regni in capite eius.. Sunt autem in ista corona L lapides preciosi." UUB C 331, f. 17r.

⁴⁸ "istam gloriam precepit hodie mater nostra sancta Birgitta in celis ubi iam est in omni honore et gloria. Quam nobis miseris precibus eius demum mater nostra concedat xristus et filius et spiritus sanctus. Amen." UUB C 331, f. 17r.

⁴⁹ Thayer 1996, esp. 341–342.

Some of these rhetorical means were more typical of medieval sermons in general, while others were unique to the context of the Birgittines in Vadstena. Creating a special time enabled a deeper comprehension of the meaning of the actual day, connecting listeners to the sacred time of God was a method widely shared by medieval preachers. By evoking the past encounters with the world—in Johannes' text, a sense of motherhood and belonging, a sight of a beautiful bird and flowers, and odours—the preacher was not only trying to make his listeners recall such past moments. For the study of the history of experiences via didactic material, an insight bearing generalisable value is the preacher's process of re-interpreting and re-enacting past emotions, sensory elements, and daily encounters for a specific purpose. By giving them a new, shared meaning, the preacher was creating an experience for his listeners. The process of experiencing could function via auditory means: an experience could be internalised without personally experiencing it. While this logic of imagined experiences resonates particularly well with the medieval comprehension of speech acts—they make things happen—it offers potential methodological tools for other contexts as well. However, for a sermon to achieve its goal—to educate and persuade—these imagined experiences needed to be perceived as possible in the minds of the listeners.

The experience Johannes Borquardi was trying to create seems to have been a devotional community—coherence and a sense of belonging—as well as the experience of the sacred encapsulated in wonderment and awe and in the sense of being captivated; modern scholars might call this experience “enchantment”. It is clear that didactic material or sermons cannot capture the individual's encounters with the world. There is no identified “bearer of the experience”, and sermons in general are filled with commonplaces and *topoi*. However, experience as an analytical concept and an object of historical analysis can be distilled from this kind of material.

A sermon was a meaning-making process, and when such processes were repeated—by Johannes and the other Birgittine brethren or by other medieval preachers—they became consolidated. Wonder and awe made to happen by utilising past sensory elements could via repetition turn into a structure of society and culture. The experience of wonderment during a feast day sermon contributed and constructed crucial elements of medieval culture, like the construction of the sacred and cult of saints.

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Fictional Literature as a Source for the History of Experience

Jussi Lahtinen  and *Mikko Kemppainen*

INTRODUCTION

Finnish literary scholar Alex Matson famously stated that literary fiction “usurps as a model the whole experienced life, of which the visible world is only a part”.¹ This insight serves as a compelling starting point for examining literary fiction as a source for historical research. Fiction offers an interesting lens to analyse the complex interplay between individuals and society, as well as the *Zeitgeist* of various historical periods. But what does this mean in a concrete field of study? In this chapter, we focus on the relationship between the concept of experience and literary fiction (novels, short stories, poems), but we argue that our theses for the most

¹ Matson 1960/1947, 21 (translated by JL).

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part are fruitful for the analysis of other forms of fictional storytelling as well.

For a long time, historical research focused on the question of the “truthfulness” of fictional depictions of society. For example, nineteenth-century naturalism and social realism were often viewed as documents of reality and were compared to the field of anthropology or sociology. Historical novels, in turn, were read as interpretations of historical phenomena, much like academic historiographies. In other research fields—particularly in literary studies—the relationship between the factual world and fictional content has always been viewed as more nuanced. There viewpoints have ranged from the near total rejection of the truth value of literary content analysis to the reflection theory, according to which literary representations act as a mirror that reflects the actual reality.² Since the 1970s, with the advent of the linguistic turn, new cultural history, and new historicism, literary theories have also become more integrated into historical research. Today, historians see fiction primarily as a product of the culture in which it is created.³

In contemporary historical research, fictional characters are understood as socio-emotional constructs rooted in a specific time and space. Historians can interpret these representations in the context of cultural scripts, narratives, and discourses, illuminating how societal phenomena are formed, shared, disseminated, and contested within communities.⁴ Literary scholar Laura Karttunen summarises the basis for multidisciplinary literary studies: “The use of a novel as research material appears questionable from the perspective of literary studies only if literature is

² E.g. Sevänen 2018. In the social sciences, fiction has served as useful research material when analysing phenomena that are hard to reach with other data sets. See, e.g. Coser 1962/1972; Lewis et al. 2014.

³ E.g. Reid 2020/2009. The evolution of the discussion, see Aydelotte 1948; Gerschenkron 1950; Laqueur 1967; Kelly 1974; Walton 1978; Blum 1982; Allen 1983; Greenblatt 1997; Rodwell 2013. See also *American Studies in Scandinavia* Volume 16 Issue 2, 1984. The theme of the issue is “Fiction as a Source for Historians”. See Hvidt 1984. On the linguistic turn, see Reid 2020/2009, 162–164; Sevänen 2018, 58–61. On new historicism, see Greenblatt 1997.

⁴ Reid 2020/2009. See especially the set of questions at the end of the article. Here, literary scholar Julia Reid has outlined several important questions historians should consider when using fictional novels as source material. Reid 2020/2009, 193.

seen as an objective and transparent document of reality, while overlooking its multiple layers of mediation”.⁵ In other words—as with all sources—literary fiction needs to be viewed carefully and critically.

In this chapter, we expand the topic to explore the history of experience. How can the multilayered concept of experience be analysed through fiction as a source for historical research? In the history of experience, the goal, as Pirjo Markkola has put it, is “to explore how people’s experiences are constructed, how they are interpreted and shared and how they are institutionalised and structured”. The field “explores how these processes of experiencing influence people’s relationships with their community and society at large”.⁶ In other words, experience is not understood merely as authentic individual experience, but rather as a culturally and socially constructed mediating category, shaped by memories and embodied emotions.⁷

We emphasise the influence of societal narratives conveyed in the public sphere,⁸ while also focusing on the author’s intentional objectives and unconscious motives—a theme that is often overlooked in literary studies. The first emphasis underlines experience as a socio-culturally relevant concept. For example, Heikki Kokko and Minna Harjula with the theory of scene of experience/layers of experience⁹ and Ville Kivimäki, Antti Malinen, and Ville Vuolanto with the theory of community of experience¹⁰ have this focus in their studies of the history of experience.

⁵ Karttunen 2015, 142 (translated by JL).

⁶ Markkola 2023, 5–6. See also the introduction to this book.

⁷ Kivimäki et al. 2021, 12–13. See also Kokko & Harjula 2023, 22–26.

⁸ Couldry & Hepp 2016; Carr 2014, 59–60. See also Eiranen et al. 2022. Heikki Kokko and Minna Harjula have pointed out that “‘narratives’ are justifications in the research material that organise and re-organise experiences and expectations.” Kokko & Harjula 2024, 93.

⁹ Kokko and Harjula summarise the concepts as methodological tools as follows: “the ‘layer of experience’ is a tool to catch the shared experiences that have been institutionalised and legitimized as social institutions [...] the ‘scene of experience’ is a tool for approaching the contextualized particular temporal-spatial situations in which these socially shared experiences are produced.” Kokko & Harjula 2024, 93.

¹⁰ Kivimäki, Malinen, and Vuolanto explain the concept as follows: “[...] we use the concept to refer to people who recognise similarities in their experiences, who share and negotiate these experiences and their meanings with each other, and who start to identify themselves as a group, bound together with a sense of shared experience.” Kivimäki et al. 2023.

The second emphasis—recognition of the author—is connected to the traditional field of history: biographical research.

Fictional content as a socio-cultural representation of the world can also be analysed with the three levels of experience as conceptualised by Sari Katajala-Peltomaa and Raisa Maria Toivo (everyday experience, experience as a process, and experience as a structure).¹¹

(1) *Everyday experience* can be understood as a concept that describes the daily experiences. These experiences are part of social reality—what happens to individuals and how they understand it.¹² As interpreters of individual experience, literary authors are uniquely positioned to highlight the connections between a person's inner thoughts, emotions, and the social world. (2) *Experience as a process* highlights mediated, shared experiences inside communities. Here, the focus moves away from the individuals and towards the social relationships and processes that shape and generate experiences.¹³ Socially oriented realist authors, in particular, depict the collective experiences that engage with phenomena affecting communities, offering insights into how these communities respond to conflict-driven situations. (3) *Experience as a structure* includes social behaviour and trains of thought that can be seen as culturally hegemonic. These experiences are shared in a way that going against the grain means challenging the fundamental ideas of the community.¹⁴ With fiction, authors can challenge experiences that have become these unquestioned components of cultural and societal structures. For example, through impactful counter-narratives, they question the hegemonic master narratives that have traditionally defined the “right” way to experience society.¹⁵

These premises offer three distinct components for analysing fictional worlds and the experiences they mediate. Firstly, we highlight the role of the *author* as an agent of experience. Literary fiction is a fruitful source for biographical analysis: it provides depictions of the individual's emotions,

¹¹ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 10–15. See also the introduction to this book.

¹² Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 10–13.

¹³ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 13. Cf. “Communities of Experience”, Kivimäki et al. 2023.

¹⁴ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 13–14. Cf. “The Layer of Experience”, Kokko & Harjula 2024.

¹⁵ On master narratives and counter-narratives, see Lueg et al. 2021.

thinking, and ways of experiencing society, which can be difficult to find anywhere else. Fiction can offer insights into the inner, more irrational aspects of how authors experience the world. Secondly, *literary content*, text itself, can be interpreted as a contemporary document portraying societal and cultural phenomena such as mediated experiences or interactions between members of communities. Realist novels in particular create fictional worlds that operate according to the same basic rules as the real world. The novel serves as a testing ground for exploring human behaviour within specific temporal and spatial contexts. Thirdly, the relationship between the text and *the reader* can be a central focus of the research. Then certain questions arise: How does the text affect the readers' experiences of the world? How does fiction shape the world we live in, mediate ideas, and trains of thoughts?¹⁶ These three analytic components—together or separately—make fiction an interesting source for the history of experience.

In this chapter, our examples concern the working-class experience portrayed in working-class literature.¹⁷ Our focus is on this specific cultural sphere, illustrating how fictional literature created within this context can be analysed through the lens of the history of experience. First, we examine a political poem from the early twentieth century (highlighting the concept of the author), followed by an exploration of the everyday realism of the interwar period (highlighting the concept of literary content). Following this, we analyse impactful historical novels published during the post-war era (highlighting the concept of the reader). Even though the examples are from Finland and concern a specific societal sphere, we encourage readers/scholars to think of similar examples pertaining to other socio-cultural traditions.

¹⁶ On the analysis of the author, the content, and the reader, see Harker 1988. This division overlaps with the traditional way in which literary studies understand their field of research. See, e.g. Meretoja et al. (eds) 2024, 5–8 (the table of contents).

¹⁷ Here, working-class literature refers to literary works that depict the lives, struggles, and perspectives of the working class, often written by authors from working-class backgrounds themselves. It typically focuses on themes such as labour, inequality, economic hardship, and social justice. Nilsson 2017, 95–96.

THE AUTHOR

When analysing literary content, literary scholars often ignore the author and focus mainly on the text itself. Some scholars have even applied Roland Barthes' concept of "the death of the author", which draws a strict distinction between the text and the author.¹⁸ In historical research, however, the text itself and the author both are at the centre of the study. In short, the research interest is in the meaning of the text and its societal and cultural context. Biographical sources can illuminate what the author meant and why they wrote the specific text. As historians such as Barbara Caine and Irma Sulkunen have noted, biographical research and biographical sources do not merely tell about the life of the person(s) themselves, but also describe the interaction between the individual and the surrounding society more broadly.¹⁹ Here, we demonstrate through an example text how biographical research combines with the study of the history of experience when using fictional sources.

We focus on the poem "Naiselle" (To a Woman) by Hilja Liinamaa-Pärssinen²⁰ (1876–1935) first published in 1907. In the first decades of the twentieth century, Pärssinen was a popular, recognisable (see Fig. 7.1) and well-known left-wing poet focusing on the poor living and working conditions of the lower classes. Furthermore, she was the leader of the Finnish Social Democratic women's movement and a long-term member of the Finnish parliament. She was the leading figure building a socialist welfare and social political programme and defining the Finnish Social Democratic Party's (SDP) policy towards the (Evangelic Lutheran and Orthodox) state Church and religion. Pärssinen also built a broad international network working with leading European socialists such as Clara Zetkin, Aleksandra Kollontai, and August Bebel.²¹

We use the poem "Naiselle" as an example to demonstrate how a fictional text can encapsulate experiences in a specific historical, cultural, political, and societal context. We focus especially on religious aspects in Pärssinen's poem and her attitude towards the Church and other religious

¹⁸ Barthes 1977/1968.

¹⁹ Caine 2010, 116–120; Sulkunen 2009, 65–67. For criticism of Barthes' concept of the "death of the author", see, e.g. Stanley 1995, 16–17.

²⁰ From now on we use her official surname, Pärssinen. See the full poem (translated by MK and the language editor) at the end of this chapter.

²¹ Kemppainen 2024, 4–6. Pärssinen's full biography, see Hentilä et al. 2018.



Fig. 7.1 Hilja Pärssinen writing at her desk in the beginning of twentieth century (1900–1907). *Source* Työväen arkisto (Finnish Labour Archives), photographer: Thorvald Nyblin, Vyborg

institutions. Since Pärssinen was one of the most influential Finnish Social Democrat politicians, the poem does not merely depict her personal experiences but illuminates also broader shared experiences among socialists in Finland at the beginning of the twentieth century.

Pärssinen's poem summarises excellently the socialist criticism towards institutional religion. For instance, Finnish historian Jussi Pikkusaari has used the poem as an example of "aesthetic" criticism to generally demonstrate how fierce and openly aggressive socialists attacked the state Church using fiction. According to Pikkusaari, the main criticism was directed at the Church's teaching, which demanded passive obedience and humility before authorities. The Church stated that the hierarchy of the society and living conditions were determined by divine order and therefore people should not question them.²²

²² Pikkusaari 1998, 100–102.

As the title, “Naiselle”, ipso facto suggests, the poem was targeted at women, and Pärssinen was particularly concerned that the false message spread by the Church was harmful especially to women. According to the Church, women were subordinate to men in marriage. Pärssinen saw the subordinate position of women and their chattel status in marriage being reflected more broadly in a society where the economic and social position of women was often poor. Moreover, women as mothers had the main responsibility for raising and teaching children, hence women had a key role in the ideological development of society and the whole nation-building process. If women did not wake up to the question of the prevailing societal conditions and hierarchies and demand their own freedom, no change would be possible, as Pärssinen clearly states in the eighth and ninth verses in the poem:

You will not rise to raise brave men,
nor create a great family,
Who would only seek the common good
and notice the cries of the wretched.

To your children you teach humility
and provide their food and clothing
but you forget enthusiasm and courage
and the beautiful, enduring ideas.

However, besides the socialist criticism of Church and institutional religion, Pärssinen's poem reflects a gradual but drastic transition from dogmatic Church-led institutional religion towards a more liberal personal faith. From the 1880s onwards, the state Church began to lose its dominant position in Finland, and the Dissenters' Act enacted in 1889 allowed for affiliation with other Christian congregations, such as the Baptists, Free Churches, and the Evangelical Revival, which emphasised personal, direct religious experience. Moreover, new religious movements—for example, Tolstoyism, Theosophy, and Spiritualism, which opposed institutional religion and sought a personal knowledge-based relationship with God and the afterlife—gained considerable visibility and numerous followers in the late nineteenth century. The fragmentation of religious life and new religious movements put pressure on the Church. At the beginning of the twentieth century, around the time of the publication of the Pärssinen's poem, there was also a debate within the Church.

The liberal wing of the clergy proposed reforms to renew religious life towards a more personal experience of faith and the reconciliation of science and religion.²³

In historiography, the transition process from institutional religion towards a more personal faith has been described as “lived religion”. The concept emphasises religious daily practices, individual beliefs, and the variety and plurality of religious societies that were established outside and/or beside religious institutions. In the field of the history of experience, lived religion has become a key concept when exploring belief and religious practices of the past. Sari Katajala-Peltomaa and Raisa Maria Toivo have underlined the intersectional approach when scrutinising religion. Age, ethnicity, social background, regional and geographical location, gender, and so on must be considered when studying religion. For example, Pirjo Markkola has pointed out that Finnish working-class women’s personal faith and religious practices could differ greatly from the official teachings of the Church and even from their family members’ beliefs. This religious experience, or “inner calling” as Markkola calls it, motivated numerous women to engage in political and societal activity.²⁴

The expressions Pärssinen used, such as “misleading”, “mesmerising”, and “threatening with hellfire”, especially in the first half of her poem, were typical of working-class literature and highlight the shift in Finnish religious ideas. Additionally, the poem conveys a personal attitude towards the Church and religious experiences. To understand these experiences, it is important to study also the author “behind” the actual text. Biographical sources and an analysis of Pärssinen’s texts show that, despite her fierce and systematic criticism of institutional religion, she was not an atheist or anti-Christian. On the contrary, for her, opposing the Church was about reforming religion. According to Pärssinen, the Church had distorted the true message of Christ and used it as an instrument of secular oppression. True Christianity had to be seen in everyday life and society as empathy, solidarity, and altruism among all people, but especially towards the poor and suffering. For her, socialism represented precisely the core values of Christianity in its striving towards an

²³ Markkola 2002, 52–95; Harmainen 2018, 5–14. On the Dissenters’ Act, see Murtoirinne 1967, 1–11.

²⁴ On the concept of lived religion in historiography, see, e.g. Hall 1997, vii–xi. In the field of the history of experience, see Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 1–10; Markkola 2022, 235–239.

egalitarian society. As an educated woman and daughter of an Evangelic-Lutheran pastor, she was very familiar with the Bible. Biographical sources also show she was highly influenced by Leo Tolstoy's religious thinking and the ideas conveyed by the Theosophic Society.²⁵

In the last verses of the poem, Pärssinen seems to have taken a very optimistic view of the future. The poem suggests she felt she was standing on the threshold of a new era. To Pärssinen, this meant the collapse of the power of the Church and full freedom of religion. This would also mean that women would finally be freed from guardianship and become full citizens. The poem challenges the master narrative in which the state Church had the power to define the ideal of the good Christian and the boundaries of (religious) life. Moreover, the poem creates a counter-narrative to the common perception in Finnish historiography that at the turn of the twentieth century avowed leftists rejected Christian beliefs and based their worldview on scientific secular socialism.²⁶

In her poem, Pärssinen created an image of a new, independent, strong woman who had awakened both in her intellect and spirit. The “new woman” was by no means alienated from God but rather walked in the “bright path of light” following the true spirit of Christ, having been freed from the prejudices fomented by the Church.

Away with the dark yoke of the prejudices
from the spiritual, bright path of light.
Away with the wavering self-consciousness
when the calling asks for the mind!

It demands the will and the heart
it calls the woman to fight.
Oh dark, miserable is the world
the light of God does not shine.

But see, woman is now enlightened
and breaking the grim shackle.
And the powerful, emerging progress
gains the momentum of a new vigour.

²⁵ Kemppainen 2020; 2024.

²⁶ In addition to Pikkusaari 1998, see Soikkanen 1961, *passim*.

The end of the poem summarises how Pärssinen's own religious beliefs were influenced by new liberal religious ideologies that emphasised a personal relationship with God and the idea of lived religion. The poem's optimism and the vision of the "new woman" also depicts the experience of societal change more broadly. The year the poem was published, Finland held its first parliamentary elections. These elections were exceptional, as for the first time in Europe, women were also allowed to stand for election and vote.²⁷ Pärssinen herself was elected as a member of the parliament among 18 other women. Furthermore, the Social Democratic Party was the biggest party in the parliament with 80 representatives.

As we have shown above, reading fictional text—for example, even a single poem—as source material can open different perspectives in historical research. It is important to study fiction in its cultural, social, and historical context, but fictional sources also open views to broader experiences and the *Zeitgeist* of the time. Furthermore, when exploring experiences in the past, it is pivotal to pay attention to the authors and their biographical sources and other texts. The former purely textual analytical interpretations of the "Naiselle" poem, as in Jussi Pikkusaari's study, have focused only on the "aesthetic" criticism of the Church. This interpretation neglects the last verses of the poem and sees the expressions such as "path of light", "new woman", and "calling" merely as utterances of secular socialism. In Pärssinen's case, this interpretation fails to acknowledge the religious meanings and her personal faith. To Pärssinen, socialism did not represent merely secular ideology but the higher spiritual experience of true lived religion, which she clearly expressed in the last verses of the "Naiselle" poem.

The analysis of the "Naiselle" poem serves as an example how a fictive text can encapsulate the three levels of experience presented by Sari Katajala-Peltomaa and Raisa Maria Toivo:

(1) The poem reflects author's inner thoughts and experiences. Personally, Pärssinen did not see political socialism merely as a secular ideology but an expression of "true Christianity", which manifested in altruism and

²⁷ The new universal and equal suffrage was the result of a general strike in 1905, in which Finns demanded greater self-government. The strike was preceded by Russia's defeat in the Russo-Japanese War, which weakened the empire's grip on its dependent territories. The Election Act was enacted in 1906, and the elections themselves were held in March 1907.

solidarity among people and should be the guideline for societal decision-making and individual everyday life. (2) Pärssinen was one of the most prominent socialist authors, popular politicians, and leading figures of the SDP shaping the social welfare reform programme and policy towards Church and religion. Her popularity and high rank in the SDP show that her worldview was shared broadly in the Finnish working-class movement. Hence, the “Naiselle” poem highlights collective experiences within the socialist movement. The aim was not to abandon Christian ideals but to reform the social and economic reality to follow the true message of Christ. (3) Even though the Freedom of Religion Act, which also allowed resignation from the Church, came into effect as late as 1923, Pärssinen’s poem serves as a source for describing the gradual change in religious life from institutional religion towards a more personal “lived religion”.

LITERARY CONTENT

As social documents, novels are often interpreted as narrative tools that give a voice to those who are voiceless or unable to express themselves. Since the 1960s, the emergence of new social history and the concept of “history from below” have shared a similar foundation.²⁸ In many ways, the contemporary history of experience builds on this tradition. There is an underlying need for emancipation and a desire to highlight the values and experiences of the underprivileged or those without an equal possibility of societal agency.²⁹ Novels often critique societal institutions, structures, cultural norms, and interactions between individuals of different social statuses, especially from the perspective of those without dominant roles in society. Here, fiction can be analysed, for example, with the concepts of the scene of experience, layer of experience, or community of experience. Novels provide imagined glimpses of life at a specific time and space (scene of experience) affected by institutional, cultural, and structural reality (layers of experience), inside the specific communities (community of experience). The narrative form highlights a need for a clear scene, context, and characters, which can be analysed with the tools of the history of experience.

²⁸ Burke 2001/1992; Sharpe 2001/1992.

²⁹ Markkola 2023, 6–10. Cf. history of childhood (Alexander et al. 2023), history of queer and trans experiences (Peake 2023), and history of disabilities (Blackie 2024).

As narratologist Matti Hyvärinen has argued, published fiction is a useful source for the study of individual human behaviour and emotions³⁰ because it is accessible to anyone and can be analysed without the “burden” of privacy protection. The everyday experiences of fictional characters are considered common property, available for interpretation. However, Hyvärinen also notes that “even the cruellest interpretation” cannot hurt the feelings of the characters.³¹ This claim is problematic, as characters in fiction represent identities, ideas, social positions, and thought processes drawn from reality. Historians must be cautious when making interpretations to avoid uncritically reinforcing potentially harmful stereotypes or misunderstandings that may appear in fiction. The history of working-class literature provides an insightful example of this.

The industrial revolution and progress of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries gave rise to a distinct working-class culture. As E. P. Thompson observed, this culture was shaped by the lived experiences of working-class communities.³² The rise of the labour movement—particularly the emergence of the labour press—introduced a new form of collective experience. Newspapers and affordable books provided platforms for self-expression, as well as for sharing news, ideas, and emotions.³³ In Finland, the political turbulence of the early twentieth century culminated in the Civil War of 1918.³⁴ Here, political radicalism was not always connected to the actual progress of society. As historian Pertti Haapala has pointed out, compared to rural workers, the urban industrial workers’ living conditions and income improved considerably in late nineteenth and early twentieth century. Haapala has stated that poverty, poor housing, and

³⁰ Cf. the history of emotions, Boddice & Smith 2020.

³¹ Hyvärinen 2015, 13.

³² Thompson 1963, 9–10. For Thompson’s conception of experience, see Middleton 2016.

³³ E.g. Turunen 2021, 67.

³⁴ From 1809 to 1917, Finland was an autonomous Grand Duchy of the Russian empire. The Civil War between the “Red” army, consisting of workers, peasants, and revolutionary socialists, and the “White” army, representing the bourgeois, landowners, and other propertied class, broke out in late January 1918. It was preceded by a long-lasting political crisis in Finland and the October Revolution in Russia, as a result of which Finland gained independence from Russia in December 1917. The rise of the Reds was partly the result of food shortages caused by World War I, the October Revolution, and domestic supply speculation. The war ended in May 1918 when the White army, reinforced with German military units, defeated the Reds. See, e.g. Haapala 1995.

especially unemployment were real problems in the urban environment, but the workers' misery was often exaggerated in left-wing agitation.³⁵

Working-class literature depicted poverty in industrial centres and accused greedy employers and factory owners of intentional oppression to maximise profits. As literary scholar Kati Launis has noted, the often-used stories of suffering workers were a political tool to ponder ethical questions and make societal changes. Hence, fictional literature did not only depict reality but partly created new ways of experiencing it.³⁶ Authors were active agents in the political layer of experience during a time when the space of experience (the experienced past and present) and the horizon of expectations (the imagined future) were changing drastically—that is, the basis of the scene of experience was challenged. Here, the problem of representativeness emerges. If historians fail to grasp the context of the literary content, they risk oversimplifying the complex relationship between emotionally driven texts and the mediated experiences they convey.³⁷

In Finland after the Civil War of 1918, vulgar left-wing agitation disappeared from the national public discourse. Noticeable working-class literature of the interwar period can be compared to nineteenth-century social realism, where social criticism was not connected to the political party—such as the SDP—but to universal humanism. Authors created fictional worlds, critically analysing the relationships among the community's members. Typically, fiction can thus be seen as a portrayal of the everyday life of an individual who does not fully integrate into the community, highlighting the angst and experiences of an outsider

³⁵ Haapala 1986, 138–161. Cf. Turunen 2021.

³⁶ Launis 2015, 15–17.

³⁷ In Finland, a notable example of this issue is the debate surrounding the dissertation by Jari Ehrnrooth (1992). In his work, Ehrnrooth argues that the grassroots of the early nineteenth-century labour movement were mobilised primarily through hateful and vengeful rhetoric, particularly disseminated via handwritten newspapers. According to Ehrnrooth, this dynamic may even help explain the origins of the Finnish Civil War. However, critics have contended that Ehrnrooth misinterpreted the historical context and misunderstood the newspaper culture of the period. In other words, he draws an overly simplistic connection between inflammatory agitation and the lived experiences of the working class. Turunen 2021, 29–33, 322–341. See also the analysis of Jussi Pikkusaari in the previous chapter of this article.

across different time periods—and at the same time it reflects phenomena connected to more general layers, scenes, or communities of experience.³⁸

One interwar working-class author, Toivo Pekkanen (1920–1957), published the highly praised novel *Tehtaan varjossa* (In the Shadows of the Factory) in 1932. The novel is set in a medium-sized Finnish industrial town and tells the story of a factory worker who lost his father after the Finnish Civil War—his father having been a prisoner of war, labelled a “Red”. In the novel, the social class experiences are depicted as part of the daily life of the worker. The death of the father, the feeling of being part of an underclass, and political oppression shape the main character’s life. However, despite these hardships, he does not become an angry or bitter figure. As a worker with literary ambitions, he chooses to live a quiet life, working hard and writing aesthetic stories. At the same time, he embodies the optimism of the 1920s economic boom while also reflecting the anxieties brought about by the rise of the far-right political movement in the early 1930s.³⁹

Toivo Pekkanen lived during the interwar period in the scene of working-class experience, and he wrote stories where this scene is the narrative background. *Tehtaan varjossa* highlights a central mental dilemma of the working-class: conflict between the political layer of experience (post-Civil War era) and the economic layers of experience (the booming wage-based society of the 1920s/the recession of the 1930s). The main character lives within both realities, experiencing relative material wealth while also feeling oppressed. Ultimately, he chooses to ignore both aspects and focuses solely on writing. The story ends as follows: “[The main character’s] task is to live here in the world, to take part in its joy and sorrow, and to grow greater than his father was and to see further than his father saw”.⁴⁰ Here, it can be interpreted that the main character sees in his horizon of expectations a life without the burden of the Civil War—in the new, politically neutral scene of experience.

Tehtaan varjossa offers a broader frame for understanding the working-class experience during the interwar period. It can also be seen as a sanctioned way of representing the societal experiences of the worker. The novel’s wide readership was likely possible because the main character

³⁸ E.g. Launis & Hyttinen 2017.

³⁹ For an analysis of Pekkanen, see Pynttari 2015.

⁴⁰ Translated by JL.

distanced himself from the Civil War's traditions. The Civil War victors permitted proletarian aesthetics (see also Fig. 7.2) by politically neutral working-class authors in an era when the working-class experience, as mediated through institutions or media, was subject to strict control. Acts of rebellion or resistance were lived and expressed beyond the reach of the public gaze. Interestingly, here democracies like interwar Finland can be compared to authoritarian societies with restricted freedom of speech. In both, fiction offers a compelling way to explore the hidden political meanings embedded in their narratives.⁴¹

Fictional realism is a valuable source for analysing experiences of specific historical periods. As seen in the cases of early twentieth century agitation literature and *Tehtaan varjossa*, the key is—again—to contextualise the fictional work within its historical setting. A fictional character's life should not be treated as an anthropological example of a typical life from that era but rather as a commentary on the social reality. When multiple fictional works address the same subject, they collectively offer a more nuanced and comprehensive representation. If certain themes or experiences are consistently emphasised across various works, this suggests a common way of portraying a particular experience. This leads to a critical research question: why did authors choose to highlight specific societal phenomena?

Overall, when analysing the concept of experience through fictional content, historians must consider the societal context in which the author wrote the text and the cultural spheres to which the text itself is connected. This level of contextualisation is essential not only in biographical research but also when focusing on the textual world itself. In this case, the societal experiences created and disseminated by fiction become comparable to other sources. In other words, fiction is a valuable source when it is linked to other forms of contemporary public discourse—when it can be traced to a specific layer of experience, scene of experience, and/or community of experience.

Moreover, fictional content reveals the “borders of imagination”, allowing us to explore the limits and possibilities of human experience across different epochs. Literary scholar Hanna Meretoja notes that the relationship between history and narrative fiction should be analysed from the perspective of the space of possibilities. She argues:

⁴¹ Cf. Antić 2022.

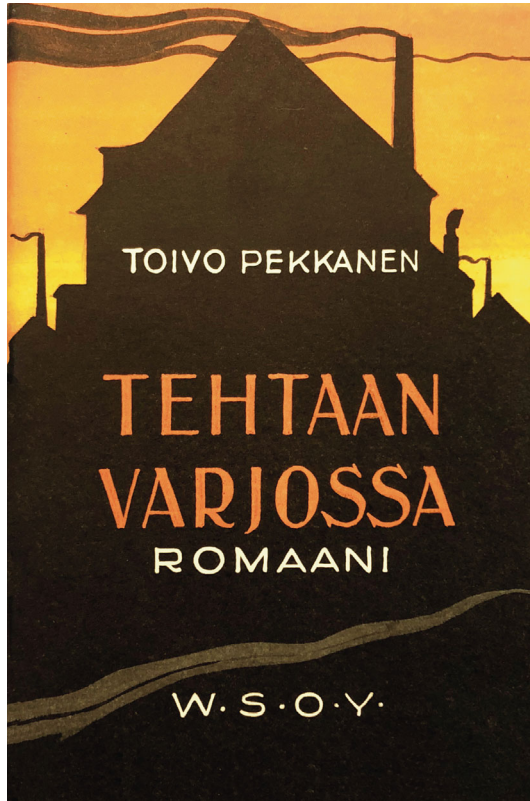


Fig. 7.2 The original cover of Toivo Pekkanen’s *Tehtaan varjossa* highlights the distinctive cultural space the novel occupied. Designed by the prominent graphic artist Aukusti Tuhka, the cover can be read as an expression of industrial proletarian aesthetics—an artistic approach that stood in contrast to the dominant (bourgeois) aesthetic ideals of post–Civil War Finland. Despite its association with the “wrong” societal perspective, the novel was published by the mainstream bourgeois publishing house Werner Söderström (WSOY) and went on to achieve wide circulation and commercial success (© Aukusti Tuhka/WSOY)

Both historiographical and fictional narratives contribute to our sense that to live in a historical world is to live in a particular space of possibilities. In this space it is possible to experience, perceive, think, feel, do, and imagine certain things, and difficult or impossible to experience, perceive, think, feel, do, and imagine other things.⁴²

Fiction reveals the limits of imagination, but it also has the power to expand them. A famous example of this is the research of science fiction. A broadly shared view is that futuristic narratives are not viewed as the prediction of the future; instead, science fiction should be studied in the cultural context of the moment of writing. What does it say about the imagination of the time of its writing?⁴³ In the field of Finnish working-class literature, a profound example is a utopian novel *Ylös helvetistä* (Up from Hell) published in 1917 by author and member of Finnish parliament Konrad Lehtimäki (1883–1937). Here, the horrors of the First World War were seen also as a possibility for a “better tomorrow”. In the novel the socialist utopia rises from the dust of a global war. The important context is that the book was written before the October Revolution in Russia—in other words, during the writing process, the horizon of expectations was not yet broadened to the actual socialist state.

THE READER/PUBLICITY

The final analytical component is the one who reads or otherwise is in contact with the fictional product. In literature studies, readers have been a topic of vivid interest for decades. Even Roland Barthes concluded his famous essay “The Death of the Author” with the assertion: “The birth of the reader must be at the cost of the death of the Author”.⁴⁴ The relationship between the reader and the literary content has been seen as communicative. This research tradition is often based on interviews or surveys.⁴⁵ However, in historical research the focus is on the public discourses affected by fiction. Together with newspapers, political rhetoric, academic research, and other forms of public discussions, fiction affects people’s understanding of their own past, present, and the

⁴² Meretoja 2024, 64.

⁴³ See Meretoja 2018, 2024.

⁴⁴ Barthes 1977/1968, 148.

⁴⁵ See, e.g. Hiidenmaa et al. 2024.

future. Here, fiction affects the impactful cultural scripts, discourses, and narratives. Often novels, movies, and other forms of fictional storytelling provide strong counter-narratives that challenge the hegemonic master narratives. Emotional and psychological social criticism can contest the societal views of the readers and at the same time create disruptions to the layers of experience.⁴⁶

The next example offers perhaps the most well-known Finnish illustration of this theme. After the Second World War, Finland's *Zeitgeist* changed as the far-left political movement—which had been illegal since the Civil War—was legalised and became a significant political force. However, societal master narratives were still largely controlled by the victors of the Civil War, the bourgeoisie (the “White side of history”). Working-class culture was viewed as a counterculture, and far-left activists were regarded as an unpatriotic segment of the nation. In other words, while society was compelled to be more open to working-class narratives, the deeper structures of the nation continued to marginalise the political layers of the working-class experience.⁴⁷

Author Väinö Linna (1920–1992) published widely read and profoundly impactful novels that shaped Finnish cultural and historical discourses. First, *Tuntematon sotilas* (The Unknown Soldier; 1954) depicted the lived experiences of rank-and-file soldiers during the Second World War, and later, his trilogy *Täällä pohjantähden alla* (Under the North Star; 1959–1962) challenged the dominant historical narrative surrounding the Finnish Civil War. The trilogy offered a national narrative from the perspective of the losing side, sparking debates and discussions. Linna, along with contemporary historians, engaged in disputes over the reasons behind the Civil War. More importantly, Linna's trilogy provided the Finnish masses with a new perspective on the Civil War, giving a national voice to the experiences that had long been silenced within working-class communities and family histories—that is, the different communities of experience.⁴⁸

Linna's narratives offer a renowned example of how fiction can challenge the national status quo. While Linna's interpretation of the causes of the Civil War can be critiqued, more significantly, he provided a socially

⁴⁶ On counter-narratives, see Lueg et al. 2021.

⁴⁷ Haapala 2021, 48–49.

⁴⁸ Haapala 2021, 50–52. See also Hyvärinen 2021, 24; Meretoja 2024, 67–68.

acceptable voice for the losing side of the conflict. After the publication of the trilogy, most Finns who had no personal connection to the “Red” side of the war came to understand that the losing Reds were also rational human beings, not merely evil or brainwashed hooligans. The reading of the trilogy became a collective, societal experience. The cultural process Linna initiated culminated in 2018, marking the 100th anniversary of the Civil War. What began as a fictional work had led to a nearly unanimous understanding of the war as a national, shared tragedy. Emotions like hate, bitterness, and revenge faded from national narratives.⁴⁹ Väinö Linna’s example demonstrates how fictional texts not only reflect experiences within a particular historical context but also create new experiences and impactful counter-narratives that can shape a society’s collective memory.

As a universal example, Väinö Linna is perhaps an extreme case, as he is one of the few authors who have successfully reshaped the national *Zeitgeist*. However, there are numerous instances where fiction has played a role in broader societal change. During the cultural liberalism of the 1960s, fiction was deeply intertwined with shifting social and cultural values. Similarly, in the 2010s, fiction has contributed to public discourse by helping to redefine social class as a significant societal position and identity.⁵⁰ In other words, while fictional texts may not have single-handedly changed the world—as Väinö Linna did—they have been integral to cultural and social movements that challenge the hegemonic ways of living inside a specific community of experience.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, we have presented examples of fictional texts that can be analysed as sources for the history of experience. Here, literary fiction provides an insightful basis for multilayered historical analysis. As we have shown, in Hilja Pärssinen’s case, poetry offers a more nuanced approach to examining lived religion within the political sphere, which has often been perceived as anti-Christian. Here the religious experiences and individual political visions of *the author* are highlighted. Toivo Pekkanen provides insight into the daily dilemmas faced by workers during a time when the social and cultural position of the working-class was under

⁴⁹ On Väinö Linna’s impact, see Haapala 2021, 51–52; Haapala 2017, 41–46.

⁵⁰ E.g. Lahtinen 2023, 273–274.

governmental surveillance. In this context, *the literary content* offers a broad perspective on the societal atmosphere—distancing itself from both left-wing agitation and the hegemonic ideologies of the Civil War victors. The inner life of individuals was no longer depicted in stark black-and-white terms. Väinö Linna, in turn, crafted a narrative that directly influenced the realm of societal experimentation. After Linna, the working-class experience became recognised as an essential part of the national narrative. Linna affected the societal experiences of *the reader* and the people who were affected by the Linna's narrative otherwise.

In this chapter, we have presented multiple ways of how (literary) fiction can be used as a source for the history of experience. Table 7.1 presents an analytical division that can be used in research. It should be noted that the collective analysis of example texts provides a valuable lens for examining the *longue durée* of Finnish working-class culture and the historical experience of the working-class.

While working-class literature can be seen as a specific form of storytelling, it also contains aspects that allow for more general conclusions. We summarise these claims as follows:

1. If the fictional text can be linked to the author's life, it becomes possible to interpret the fiction as a reflection of the author's "inner thoughts", political beliefs, or other societal views and experiences. In this sense, fiction serves as a valuable source for biographical research, offering a way to analyse how impactful and emotive social messages are conveyed and mediated. When the persona of interest is an impactful public figure, their widespread texts can also shape the social discourse or cultural atmosphere drastically.
2. Fiction does not simply depict everyday life as it is but rather highlights the culturally constructed undertones of society. Portrayals of ordinary people offer glimpses of the experimental spheres in which individuals have lived. Fiction offers ideas, representations, and interpretation of how people lived or felt during different epochs.
3. Fiction can challenge the master narratives of the societal community. Simultaneously, fiction can be part of the cultural phenomena, which challenge the dominant structures or prevalent ideas.

Table 7.1 The content of the analysis

<i>Author</i>	<i>Author's societal position</i>	<i>Empirical evidence</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Research tradition</i>	<i>Point of view</i>	<i>Research theme</i>
Hilja Pärssinen	Politician, left-wing author, educated bourgeois background	"Naiselle"/To a Woman, 1907 (poem)	Early 20 th - century Finland	Biographical research	Author, author as an agent of experience, individual experience	Lived religion, political narratives, societal reforms
Konrad Lehtimäki	Politician, socialist, left-wing author	<i>Täis beheitistä</i> /Up from Hell, 1917 (novel)	Near Future	Political history	Literary content, experience as a process, scene, and layer of experience	The political horizon of expectations
Toivo Pekkanen	Working-class author, bestseller	<i>Tehtaan varjossa</i> /In the Shadows of the Factory, 1932 (novel)	Intervar period Finland	New social history, history from below	Literary content, experience as a process, scene, and layer of experience	Collective experiences of the working-class
Väinö Linna	Working-class author, "national writer", bestseller	<i>Täällä Pohjantäiden alla</i> /Under the North Star, 1959–1962 (Trilogy)	Post-War Finland	Narrative studies, discourse analysis	Reader/publicity, experience as a structure, community of experience	Evolving national master narratives

We argue that these three dimensions are essential when analysing the history of experience. Fiction, in general, should be regarded as a valuable source. It becomes particularly fruitful for the history of experience when researchers view it as a mediated narrative form, deeply understand its societal and cultural context, and acknowledge the role of the author. Interestingly, in the contemporary field of the history of experience, fiction has been underused source material—and when it has been used, it has been used mostly as a counterpart to historiographies.⁵¹ In other words, the focus of these studies has been on the fictional representation of historical experiences. We claim that fiction should also be analysed as contemporary social documentation: it is a multi-functional source to analyse experiences of the past, present, and the future.

APPENDIX

Hilja Pärssinen: Naiselle (To a Woman)

They fill your head with prejudice
and leave your sense to sleep
and mislead your conscience

They take you to the shrine of churches
and mesmerise you at masses
and threatening you with hellfire
destroy your yearning for freedom.

And having your spirit captured
they take you with them to work,
wanting to regress everything
and plunge people in the night.

When a workman toils day and night
and wealth remains with the few
and “where is the justice, security”
ask the oppressed in despair,

While the rich alone hold the power and the mighty make the laws,
while brute force and cannons

⁵¹ See Rutar [2023](#); Marculescu [2019](#); Antić [2022](#); Andersson & Engren [2022](#).

throw the bearers of light into dungeons,

While there is much, much injustice,
in which nations, individuals are drowning,
you do not comprehend the zeitgeist
your spirit is in deep slumber.

You live in the ecstasy of emotion
weaving dark belts of darkness.
You walk in the flickering lights of false fires
and raise cretins.⁵²

You will not rise to raise brave men,
nor create a great family,
Who would only seek the common good
and notice the cries of the wretched.

To your children you teach humility
and provide their food and clothing
but you forget enthusiasm and courage
and beautiful, enduring ideas.

But once the day will come,
when the old will fall in their graves,
and the new woman will rise,
whose power shall bend everyone.

Away with the dark yoke of the prejudices
from the spiritual, bright path of light.
Away with the wavering self-consciousness
when the calling asks for the mind!

It demands the will and the heart
it calls the woman to fight.
Oh dark, miserable is the world
the light of God does not shine.

⁵² In the context, “cretin” is a pejorative expression meaning a person who is prone to suggestion and propaganda and with a low capacity for questioning the authorities and capitalist regime.

But look, woman is now enlightened
and breaking the grim shackle.
And the powerful, emerging progress
gains the momentum of a new vigour.

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Quantitative Data as Sources for the History of Experience

Pirjo Markkola  and *Ilari Taskinen* 

In the fields of economic and social history, quantitative sources and methods have been commonly utilised. The well-established tradition of using official statistics, tax records, population records, and account books as sources investigated by quantitative methods is a productive way to analyse social structures. However, the same tradition seems to dismiss or relegate questions of experience and experiencing. In this chapter, we argue that the history of experience can be studied by using quantitative sources and methods. This means using statistical data, large-scale datasets, and quantitative methodologies that analyse the past through numbers. Quantitative sources provide aggregated knowledge of groups and structures, while experiences are traditionally thought to belong to individual people. We argue that this division is mistaken. The idea that

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experiences arise and reside chiefly in individual people is a misconception grounded in essentialist notions of experience. The history of experience examines social and societal phenomena.¹ No experience is born in a vacuum; individual experiences are constructed in the intersections of social interaction, institutions, and cultural systems of meaning that guide people to think and feel in shared ways. Quantitative perspectives enable the historian to place the individuals and communities under investigation into larger context, which is just as vital to historians of experience as any other perspective. The history of experience can benefit in multiple ways from adopting quantitative data and tools into their toolkit.

Historians tend to agree that quantitative data sets are fruitful when demographic patterns, economic factors, and social structures are examined, but how do they translate into the language of experience? We propose three ways of translating quantitative data into the language of experience. The first option is to read quantitative sources as if they were qualitative sources. Official statistics in particular include descriptive sections and elements. The second option is to look closer at statistical categorisations and address them as processes, norms, and structures of experiencing. How do categorisations contribute to the processes of experiencing? The third option is to transform information on individual lives and autobiographical texts into a quantitative form and analyse it statistically. In this chapter, we introduce all three ways and outline some examples of the quantitative history of experience, including its potential and limitations.

Quantitative data consist of a rich variety of sources. In this chapter, we divide our material into two main categories (with subcategories). First, we discuss data gathered by statisticians and other authorities involved in knowledge production in the past. When it comes to published data, The Official Statistics of Finland² serves here as an example of quantitative statistical sources. Our main focus is on population statistics, but we also look at statistical accounts of labour markets and living conditions, among others. Other sources discussed in this chapter include some quantitative archival data.

¹ For the new history of experience, see, e.g. Boddice & Smith 2020; Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021 (esp. the chapter by Hoegaerts and Olsen); Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022; Annola, Lindberg, & Markkola 2023; Haapala, Harjula, & Kokko 2023.

² Official Statistics of Finland (OSF).

Another major set of quantitative data consists of digitalised or digital databases. Historians have used digital data from the beginning of computing from the 1960s onwards, especially in the fields of demographic and economic history. These data have become increasingly important in the past few decades due to the digitalisation that has revolutionised the production and analysis of digital data.³ Large digital datasets are these days produced by archives and libraries as well as by historians themselves, who have at their disposal powerful new digitisation tools. Digital big data can be divided into two groups. The first consists of numerical data excerpted from population registers, archival materials, and other instances traditionally studied in fields like demographic history. The second is digitised textual data, such as letters, diaries, newspapers, and publications, which are central sources of the nascent field of *digital history*.

This chapter examines quantitative data as sources for the history of experience. In this effort, we benefit from historical studies that have addressed human experiences in collective or quantifying settings. Such approaches include collective biography, prosopography, historical family demography, and the life-course approach.⁴ All these approaches utilise quantitative data, combine macro- and microhistories, and interpret people's experiences in a historical context.

QUANTIFIED EXPERIENCES

The compilation of statistics is a proven way to organise information, highlight social problems, and generate administrative patterns. Published statistics have also wider implications related to experience, expectation, and the construction of historical time. Here we turn to the German historian Reinhart Koselleck, who defines experience as the present past and expectation as the future made present. As the presence of the past and the presence of the future differ, he expresses time using the spatial metaphors “space of experience” and “horizon of expectation”. Experience is understood as a spatial complex with many historical layers, whereas the more fluid metaphor of horizon suits better the category

³ Crymble 2021.

⁴ See, e.g. Laslett 1974; Anderson 1980; Bertaux 1981; Elder & Giele 2009; Caine 2010, 47–65.

of expectations. Thus, in Koselleckian terms, official statistics produce commonly shared spaces of experience and horizons of expectation.⁵ Population statistics, for example, depict population movements, family relations, and reproduction. They register experienced phenomena, such as births, deaths, marriages, migration, occupations, and changes in the structure and size of population, among others.⁶ In other words, population statistics record the space of experience in which people have lived in their most intimate communities and inform what kind of expectations have been available to them. Statistics also cement social structures and provide tools to interpret society. Those tools both reveal and hide different layers and structures of experience as well as processes of experiencing.

In the nineteenth century, many countries established authorities to compile national statistics and develop administrative instruments. For instance, the Prussian Office of Statistics was founded in 1805, and more broadly, the link between population and the state formed an axiom that pushed European authorities to gather statistical data. Advocates of public health promoted statistics in France, whereas in early Victorian Britain the statistical movement focused on social problems.⁷ The oldest continuous population statistics can be found in Sweden and Finland, where a growing concern over shortages in the labour force emerged in the eighteenth century (Finland was part of Sweden until 1809). The Swedish *Tabellverket* (Tables Office) was founded in 1748, and the first population statistics were compiled the following year. The state could also rely on the longer tradition of the Lutheran Church to register births and deaths since the seventeenth century.⁸ When the Statistical Office of Finland, established in 1865, published the first statistics, the population records were extended back to 1749, thus providing an explicit historical perspective on the categorisation of human experience.

The fact that our examples of statistics are drawn from one country does not limit the adaptability and scope of observations to Finland. International comparison has been a widely used political practice. Nation

⁵ Koselleck 1985, 267–288; Kivimäki 2013.

⁶ Nieminen 1999.

⁷ Porter 1986, 23–39; Wilke 2004, 64–65; van der Zande 2010, 412–414.

⁸ Luther 1993; Nieminen 1999, 10; Tala 2008; Haapala & Peltola 2018; Mikkonen 2025, 5–6. For the German-speaking countries, see Wilke 2004.

states have compared different systems used in other countries and adapted the best practices—or patterns that were considered the best—to their national policies.⁹ In the field of statistical standards, the first international conference in the 1850s launched statistical cooperation that was further consolidated by the International Statistical Institute (ISI) in 1885. In 1929, the League of Nations formalised inter-governmental cooperation on official statistics; later, the United Nations took responsibility for international statistical cooperation.¹⁰ As a result, international collaboration has taken place between national statistical offices; moreover, other international organisations, such as the ILO, coordinate and standardise classifications and categorisations. National statistical offices usually apply the international standards in their respective bookkeeping and publishing.¹¹ Coordination and standardisation facilitate the comparison of national statistics. They also allow the application of similar tools in the use of statistics as sources.

People do not only figure as numbers in official statistics. Structures and social processes, depicted by official statistics, cannot be separated from the lives of people. As members of society, people live in a certain time and space recorded in the statistics. Therefore, official statistics provide valuable information on the ways in which people in the past were shaped by their experiences. Encounters with people, communities, and society constitute experiences; moreover, experiences become social when they are acknowledged, reflected on, and communicated. Shared and communicated experiences constitute collective resources, a social stock of knowledge, and they accumulate in social institutions.¹² Some experiences in the past can be constructed by interpreting social structures and processes depicted in the statistical data. As a good example, we can mention Pertti Haapala's study on the social crisis of Finnish society in the 1910s. His study relies on statistical data, but it still reaches people's

⁹ Kettunen 2006; Kettunen & Petersen 2011.

¹⁰ Handbook on Management and Organization of National Statistical Systems.

¹¹ Tilasto-opas 1978, 14–15; Nieminen 1999.

¹² Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022, 13; Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021, 11; Markkola 2022, 222.

space of experience and the ways in which social inequalities were experienced. Statistical data on landowning, food prices, and other expenditures summarise those experiences.¹³

Official statistics are also textual sources. The published volumes include large descriptive, introductory sections which can be analysed like any qualitative source. In particular, the early volumes of the population statistics commented on people's daily life and described their practices. They can easily be read as expressions of the educated classes' view of vernacular life in rural Finland and the country's growing towns. They inform us how experiences of encountering the uneducated classes were put into words by statisticians, but they are more silent concerning how rural labourers or industrial workers experienced the phenomena the upper classes were registering, categorising, and reporting. However, by reading and re-reading these descriptive sections, we believe, it is possible to find patterns and tropes that give viable hints of the circumstances in which the anonymous masses were experiencing society. Changes in the descriptive sections usually suggest that societal changes have occurred. If crop failures, for example, suddenly disappear from explanations, one can ask if changes took place in farming patterns or explanatory horizons. Those changes, when traced and documented, may talk about experiencing subjects in society. If they do not reach the level on which subjects are constructed through experiences,¹⁴ at least they reach the level on which notions of the experiencing subjects are produced.

Various other records concerning population, taxation, and poor relief, among others, can also be turned into qualitative sources in which remarks and notes, sometimes in the margins, give answers to questions of experiencing society. Moreover, records of poor relief can be investigated by mixing qualitative and quantitative methods. A quantitative analysis of poor relief records reveals who experienced poverty and whose experience of poverty counted (age, gender, occupation). These structures of experiencing poverty can be complemented by a qualitative analysis of concepts and descriptive remarks available in the records. The experience of being a widow with minor children in an industrial town in the 1890s entitled her to public aid, but it did not free her from the obligation of earning a living. Widowers were strikingly absent in the records of poor relief,

¹³ Haapala 1995.

¹⁴ Cf. Scott 1991.

whereas their children were found in other records documenting foster care.¹⁵ Applying both the triangulation of various records of poor relief and a mixed-methods approach, family experiences of the working classes become visible in quantitative data sets.

STRUCTURES OF EXPERIENCING

Statistical categorisations can be read as processes, norms, and structures of experiencing, as indicated by sociologist Merja Kinnunen.¹⁶ Analysing labour statistics, she addresses gendered and gendering wage gaps by investigating how statistical categorisations describe the wage gap between men and women. According to Kinnunen, statistical categorisations uphold gendering hierarchies and indicate societal power relations and the cultural constructions of gender. Reading statistics from the methodological perspectives suggested by Kinnunen, we are particularly interested in the ways in which population statistics and labour statistics, among others, reveal and construct processes, norms, and structures of experiencing.

Statistics help us to understand experiences in historical situations, but they are also important in understanding the general frames of experiencing. Every life is unique, but lives are often experienced in common ways due to social and cultural factors that lead them onto shared trajectories. To understand these patterns as the structures of experiencing, statistics are vital. One of the first structural elements of the population statistics in the nineteenth century was the age cohort. The same year of birth makes people members of a birth cohort, gives them a particular historical experience with certain life opportunities, and makes it possible to follow their life trajectories in time and space. Social embeddedness or social ties change over the life course but are to some extent tied to the birth cohort. Since the 1960s sociologists and social historians have applied a life-course approach to work and family, among others. In his groundbreaking study of children of the Great Depression, Glen H. Elder Jr names four factors that shape life courses: “historical and geographical location, social ties to others, human agency in the construction of one’s life course, and variations in timing of events and social roles”. All

¹⁵ Markkola 1994, 109.

¹⁶ Kinnunen 2001.

factors are related to experiences and experiencing. Elder Jr and Janet Giele further point out that the life-course perspective covers many levels and spans “from aggregate, institutionalised pathways to the lived experience of people working out their life course”.¹⁷ Again, taking birth cohorts and their cultural backgrounds into consideration helps historians to understand the many layers of experience.

Sometimes the official statistics can suggest new research questions related to the history of experience. For example, when statisticians put together a longitudinal review of annual marriages (or birth rates, mortality, etc.), they comment on factors like epidemics or crop failures affecting the statistical figures in question.¹⁸ While comparing deviance in annual figures, historians can find quantitative patterns which, for their part, inspire and inform deeper analyses of people’s daily practices and structures of experience. Such deviance can appear in the timing of marriages or in differences between social classes in their family transitions. Alternatively, by reading statistics, historians can find examples of less common experiences, such as teenage pregnancies, women dying in childbirth, or triplet pregnancies,¹⁹ and further explore those cases as histories of experience.

Birth and death belonged to the first phenomena to be quantified by authorities. Population statistics provide aggregated data but also some more detailed information concerning childbirth. Health statistics and population statistics can also be read as sources of experiencing childbirth and of structuring experiences at various turning points in the life course. Tables in published statistics are based on data gathered by authorities, and some local archives have filed the more nuanced original tables put together by midwives and physicians. Their records illustrate the experiences of giving birth and reveal, for example, cases in which mothers first tried to rely on the help of their neighbours and then turned to a midwife or relied directly on a midwife and were later sent to a medical doctor or a hospital. The midwives reported their cases, which were summarised in the annual reports of local health authorities. Those reports count natural

¹⁷ Elder 1974; Elder & Giele 2009, 4–6, 9.

¹⁸ E.g. OSF VI:41;3, 72–73.

¹⁹ E.g. in 1881–1890, a total of 10 girls under the age of 15 gave birth to a child. Three of them were married. OSF VI:41;3, 116.

births, forceps deliveries, and other ways of assisting deliveries.²⁰ These differing practices can be analysed as structures of experiencing. The path from a natural birth at home, assisted by a neighbour or a midwife, to forceps delivery, performed by a medical doctor in a hospital, formed a long chain of experiencing motherhood and giving birth.

Mortality rates indicate structures of experiencing. In previous research, mortality has been used as evidence of past experiences, emotions, and world views. One of the most provocative examples is psychohistorian Lloyd deMause's study on the history of childhood in which he argues that, due to high infant mortality rates, people avoided forming emotional bonds with their babies.²¹ This conclusion has been questioned several times; there is evidence that parents cared about their children, and they mourned their death.²² However, from the perspective of experience, it is possible to take another angle and compare whether certain experiences were common and likely to happen or if they were highly unlikely. How was the loss of a baby experienced in a society where almost all families shared similar experiences, and how was it experienced in a society where 99.8 per cent of infants survived their first year?

In all age groups, the mortality of men was higher compared to women. Therefore, we can read from the population statistics that the experience of being an old woman was much more common than being an old man. The Official Statistics of Finland gives the following figures for 1865: in the age group of 20–25 years, there were 1030 women to 1000 men, but the share of women increased steadily. In the age group of 60–65 years, the share of women was 1211 to 1000 men, and in the oldest age groups—that is, those over 80—there were twice as many women as men.²³ Similar experiences are suggested by the data showing, for instance, the share of widows and widowers: 125 vs 58 per 1000 in Finland in 1865. Compared to men, women were more likely to experience the loss of their spouse; moreover, widowed men were more likely

²⁰ Markkola 2012.

²¹ deMause 1974.

²² E.g. Hanawelt 1986; Krötzel 1989.

²³ OSF VI:1, 30; Mikkonen 2025, 12.

to remarry.²⁴ These notions are relevant for the history of old age and longevity, as Heikki Mikkonen has recently pointed out.²⁵

In general, population statistics hint at several structures of experiencing. For example, figures on population density indicate varying experiences of neighbourhood, as some rural areas were extremely sparsely populated whereas some other regions were closer to urban municipalities in their population density. Some rural villages may even have had more inhabitants than small towns.²⁶ However, statistical indicators only give a rough indication of differing experiences: more research is needed to understand how neighbourhood and surroundings were experienced in a rural society, and, correspondingly, how experiences of neighbourhood and surroundings were constituted in a rural setting. This can, however, be completed by looking at other volumes of the official statistics, such as labour statistics, agricultural statistics, and household statistics, asking new questions, and applying triangulation and mixed methods to interpret the data.

Asking new research questions is in line with Katrina Navickas' reflection on British histories of poverty. She notices a clear shift from descriptive narratives following the model of Victorian social investigators or from economic analyses that reduced paupers into numbers towards social historians' attempts "to reconstruct the experiences of the poor as individuals as well as groups".²⁷ However, those studies focusing on "pauper agency" often utilise other sources, such as letters or appeals to authorities, whereas our primary aim is not to change the sources. We suggest re-reading the old ones to reach the ways in which quantitative data can be turned into the sources of the history of experience.

Furthermore, the advantage of population statistics is their social representativeness. They are gathered in a systematic manner to reflect people's lives without considering their background. Oral historical and autobiographical archives, on the other hand, tend to be heavily distorted. They are created through voluntary donations, and they reflect what people want to remember and can put into words. With some exceptions, archived letters and diaries typically portray the experiences of the

²⁴ OSF VI:1, 33.

²⁵ Mikkonen 2025.

²⁶ OSF VI:1, 16–17, 22.

²⁷ Navickas 2018, 93.

educated classes who were accustomed to writing and valued the preservation of family writings. Reminiscences are likewise donated by a limited group of interested individuals.²⁸ These archives also tend to illustrate mostly the positive aspects of human lives because many people do not wish to remember or preserve evidence of their troublesome experiences.

INDIVIDUAL-LEVEL DATABASES

In addition to using institutional statistics, historians produce their own quantitative data. These come in various sizes ranging from simple excel spreadsheets to databases containing millions of entities. In contrast to the aggregated data of institutional statistics, these datasets are usually based on individual-level data. They allow historians to inspect how people's lives unfolded in the course of time and over a broad context.

Social and economic historians originally studied vital population statistics produced by national institutions. This fitted into the perspective of social history, which focused on nations or broad social categories like class, but it was also a necessity due to the difficulty of gathering data in the early days of computing. One of the pioneering projects using individual-level data was the so-called Muuli project in 1970s Finland. The project aimed at combining macro- and microhistories by using statistical and quantitative methods to explain migration and social change. Historians from three universities sampled data from population registers. However, only one university succeeded in coding the data and applying some basic statistical methods to analyse it. In Tampere, the longitudinal data of ca. 2,000 individuals was extracted from church-based population registers. People were followed from birth to death and their family members were included in the data. The data consisted of four age cohorts from 1850 to 1910. By using a tailored statistical programme, scholars could cross-tabulate the coded data; calculate averages, means, and medians; and construct life histories and family histories. Class (occupation), gender, residence, family status, and age were key categories available in the data set.²⁹ However, the ambitions of the large

²⁸ Roper 2009, 28; Teo 2005, 343.

²⁹ *Muuttoliikkeiden ja sosiaalisen kehityksen väliset yhteydet* 1982; Rasila 1983; Haapala 1986, 346–348; Markkola 1994, 250–251.

project were ahead of its time and computing potential, and its utilisation remained limited.

Gathering data has become much easier since the days of the Muuli project. Today historians routinely analyse thousands or even millions of records with a personal computer. These data come typically from individual-level databases that historians have constructed themselves from sources such as church registers and censuses. These databases include information on basic demographic events like births, marriages, and deaths, but also people's health, wealth, and experiences, such as service in a war. The largest of these databases consists of information on millions of individual people and many more include tens of thousands of past lives. The Swedish Scanian Economic Demographic Database (SEDD), for example, includes the demographic, wealth, and health information of 215,000 unique individuals from the period 1646–1967, while the Historical Sample of the Netherlands (HSN) covers information on, for example, demographic events, religion, and social networks for 85,500 people born in the Netherlands during 1812–1922.³⁰

Individual-level data has transformed the perspective of demographic history. Whereas the older generation studied demographic regimes, the new generation examines individual lives. This has made possible the novel, fine-grained analysis of individual life paths and lifted life-course approach, developed already since the 1960s and 1970s by Glen Elder Jr and others, to such a central status of the discipline that the “life course paradigm” has been said to have taken over it. Moving the level of analysis to individual people has brought people and their experiences to a much more prominent position in analysis. For example, the demographic historian Jan Kok has stressed that the life-course approach highlights people's agency. Individual lives are not predetermined but guided by the aspirations and choices of individuals.³¹ Edvinsson et al., on the other hand, emphasise that it is now possible to study much smaller groups of people than before. While many databases are sampled on the national level, their grand size allows the researcher to focus the analysis on a smaller group based on its social background, such as gender, cohort, class, or shared experiences. This helps us to understand individual lives

³⁰ Ruggles 2014; Alter et al. 2023.

³¹ Kok 2007, 205.

with much greater precision than before. At the same time, the decisions of individuals can be efficiently put into greater context.³²

For an example of the changing perspective of demographic history, we will next look at the article “Dimensions of Rational Decision-Making during the Demographic Transition: Aranjuez (Spain) Revisited”, written by David Reher and Glenn Sandström. The study examines people’s reproductive behaviour during a demographic transition, namely the historical shift from high birth rates and high death rates to low birth rates and low death rates. When this phenomenon was originally studied through population statistics, scholars could demonstrate its existence from fertility and mortality data but only speculate on people’s choices to have or decide against having children based on great patterns, like the decline of cultural constraints. When individual data are added to the research, much more elaborate analysis is possible. In their article, Reher and Sandström use the data of 900 families whose entire reproductive history, including births, deaths, and sex composition of children, has been collected from civil registration records. By applying event history analysis to the data, the researchers show that child deaths and sex composition affected couples’ reproductive behaviour. Couples were more likely to have more children if they had lost a child or did not have a boy. Reher and Sandström see this to be evidence of people’s rational decision-making and agency in shaping the composition of the central unit of their lives, the family, in times when easy contraception methods were not yet available. This is valuable information to historians of experience studying how the people of the era experienced their position and power to alter social family norms.³³

The above example illustrates how demographic historians use individual level micro-data to study how specific events in life influenced people’s behaviour in the past. In doing so, they inevitably need to question the reasons behind these choices—what people thought and felt in deciding the course of their lives. Experiences are most visibly present in these analyses when they focus on specific events in history like wars or famines. Analysing individuals during these events with data was previously possible only at a crude level, but individual-level datasets with rich

³² Edvinsson et al. 2023, 188–189.

³³ Reher & Sandström 2015.

information on people's backgrounds make it possible to examine their rationale and the motivations behind their decisions.

One of the great examples of utilising a large database to study individual experiences is Dora Costa and Matthew Khan's study "Heroes and Cowards: The Social Face of War". It examines American Civil War soldiers' war experiences using the "Union Army Data Set", which contains detailed longitudinal information of 40,000 men who fought in the war. Costa and Khan's focus is on the impact of peer relationships, morale, and ideology on soldiers' wartime behaviour and especially desertion. With their vast data they could conduct statistical analyses, which showed that the soldiers' commitment to the war effort was linked most firmly to their peers. Men who served in demographically and socioeconomically homogenous companies fulfilled their duties more often than those who served with men from different racial or socioeconomic backgrounds or were of different ages. Having similar kinds of people nearby also increased one's survival in a prisoner-of-war camp. The study demonstrated in an intriguing manner a phenomenon claimed also in many cultural historical studies of war: soldiers fight for their friends, not for ideology. Although Costa and Khan's analysis of course does not cover the whole spectrum of soldiers' experiences in the war, it provides valuable evidence about soldiers' behaviour that, arguably, also informs us about their thoughts and feelings. They are not entirely wrong to claim that their study reveals "the underlying physiological and psychological mechanisms of the human being".³⁴ These mechanisms are vital in analysing soldiers' war experiences. They provide statistical evidence for cultural historical scholarship that has shown social relationships, compassion, and, indeed, love dictated how a man fought, endured, and thought about his place in the conflict.³⁵

An important motivation for the historian of experience to produce one's own statistical data is that they can reveal experiences that cannot be accessed with autobiographical sources. These are typically difficult or shameful experiences that people are unable to deal with or wish to keep silent. Traumas, experiences that in their nature evade language and meanings, are an illustrative example. For example, when studying

³⁴ Costa & Kahn 2008, xxi. On studying war experiences through large databases, see also Taskinen 2023; Kivimäki, Liski, & Taskinen 2025.

³⁵ Kivimäki & Tepora 2009.

war traumas in World War II Finland, Ville Kivimäki found the psychiatric understanding of the era did not acknowledge that exposure to violence could break a man's mind. Mental wounding in battle was a sign of personal weakness and unmanliness, meaning men experiencing this fate kept silent about their experiences. Studying these experiences is impossible through autobiographical writing and memoirs. There is secondhand information on them in the written descriptions of medical records, but in order to understand the experiences that led to these devastating conditions, Kivimäki had to construct a numerical dataset that provided hard numerical evidence of the traumatised men's backgrounds and wartime conditions. For this, Kivimäki took a cluster sample of 341 soldiers treated for psychological wounding in three military hospitals and collected information on these men's social backgrounds and war service into a database. By comparing these data to a database of soldiers killed in the war, Kivimäki could find evidence of factors affecting men's coping with stress in battle. He could show, for example, that old and married men suffered more mental woundings than the young and unmarried. This indicated that a soldiers' experience in war was linked to his stage of life and social relations, with the young and commitment-free men enduring it better than those who had a family and responsibilities at home to worry about.³⁶

It is not unreasonable to suggest that demographic historians are these days deeply embedded in the study of experiences. While their language typically stresses processes and causality between events, at the core of the study are people and their choices and fates in the upheaval of events and structures. Experience is not a word often encountered in their writing due to the traditions of the discipline, but as research evolves with ever more complex databases and finer analysis techniques, the core issues of experience like agency, motivations, and relations between individuals and structures become increasingly topical.³⁷

Historians of experience with a qualitative methodological background should also look at the opportunities of big data. Many of the large individual-level databases are freely available for research in data repositories. For the qualitative study of experiences to evolve, there is not only a need for data but also for people who can ask the right questions.

³⁶ Kivimäki 2013, 101–190.

³⁷ Cf. Elder & Giele 2009.

TEXT MINING PERSONAL EXPERIENCES

The latest reason for historians of experience to consider quantitative methods is the advancements in text mining research. For a long time, the work of the historian was to visit an archive and physically examine old texts. Today this is not always a necessity. The historian can view sources from the comfort of a personal computer and let it do the analysis. In many other fields, like linguistics, computers have been used to analyse textual data already for decades, but the methodology has become particularly relevant in the 2000s with the accumulation of ever-increasing amounts of digitally derived data and advancements in digitisation and analysis technologies. In recent years, many historians have also adopted this perspective, giving birth to the field called digital history.³⁸

The central concept of digital history is *distance reading*, the automatic analysis of large sets of textual data. This is a fundamental change of perspective, as distant reading already in its name positions itself in contrast with the most traditional methodology of history, *close reading*.³⁹ Distant reading means typically the utilisation of text mining methodologies originating from corpus linguistics. These include various techniques such as the basic counting of word frequencies, wherein changes can be analysed over time or in different contexts. Other methodologies examine the relationships and significance of words in textual datasets. Topic modelling detects and classifies central topics of corpora, while collocation analysis examines which words occur frequently in proximity to each other. A step further is text network analysis, which considers connections between multiple different concepts. The basic outcome of this analysis is a graph that visualises relationships between words. Lately, the techniques have become increasingly more complex as digital historians have begun to utilise machine learning in their analysis.⁴⁰

The utilisation of text mining methodologies has become common among historians in recent years. They have been central to the spread of digital history. Text mining has been particularly popular among conceptual historians, for whom the study of language and meanings through statistical methods is a natural fit.⁴¹ Historians of experience have utilised

³⁸ Salmi 2020; Fridlund, Oiva, & Paju (eds) 2020.

³⁹ Moretti 2013.

⁴⁰ Baker 2006.

⁴¹ Turunen 2021.

them rarely so far. One reason for this might be the fundamental nature of the field: historians of experience have always been more interested in inspecting the past from below, from the perspective of individuals, rather than above, the perspective stressed by distant reading. It is reasonable to ask what is left of experiences when meanings are aggregated into numbers, and we will return to this question at the end of the chapter. For other fields of history, the benefits of distant reading have been more obvious. Digital methodologies have been particularly common among conceptual historians who examine how values and ideas are formed in the interaction of people. However, the recent developments in digitisation and digital methodologies have meant that text mining has become a more potent option also for the history of experience.

First is the advancement in the digitisation of historical sources. Until recently most digitised historical texts were public writings like newspapers and parliamentary texts. These were digitised early because they are printed texts whose digitisation has been possible since the early 2000s. Although newspapers and books of various kinds can be used in the study of experiences,⁴² the problem was that the backbones of the analysis of historical experiences have been handwritten personal texts like letters and diaries. Their statistical analysis was for a long time impossible, or at least extremely laborious, because turning handwritten texts automatically into digital form, the precondition of their automatic study, provided inaccurate results.

Automatic handwritten text recognition (HTR) technology has taken great leaps in the last few years. The introduction of powerful machine learning models has improved recognition models drastically, which has enabled archives and libraries to begin digitising letters and diaries into digitally readable form. An important help for historians has been the introduction of *Transkribus*, a browser-based platform developed by the EU-funded READ project, which turns handwritten texts into digital data (Fig. 8.1). Using machine learning HTR models requires technical expertise few historians possess, but *Transkribus* is useable by any scholar after a few minutes of learning. The platform has been used to digitise historical texts in hundreds of projects by historians and archives.⁴³ A digitisation project “First-Hand Accounts of War: War Letters (1935–1950)”

⁴² See Marjanen 2021.

⁴³ Nockels et al. 2022. Transkribus can be accessed at <https://www.transkribus.org/>

conducted by the NIOD Institute for War, Holocaust, and Genocide Studies in the Netherlands, for example, digitised over 160,000 pages of handwritten personal correspondence using *Transkribus*.⁴⁴

Methodological innovations of text mining are the second reason to be interested. Text mining involves quantifying language, and does not often create an obvious link with the lived reality of people that is typically at the centre of the historical inquiry of experiences. Intriguingly, digital humanists have recently also adopted text mining methodologies that have gained influence from human sciences and consider not just text but also the thoughts and feelings of people behind their expressions. These approaches are called “sentiment analysis”, which itself is part of the larger study of “affective computing”, an interdisciplinary field that studies the recognition and generation of human affects with technology. Sentiment analysis can be divided into two branches: opinion mining and emotion mining. Opinion mining means analysing the personality and subjectivity of a text. It entails recognising, dividing, and classifying

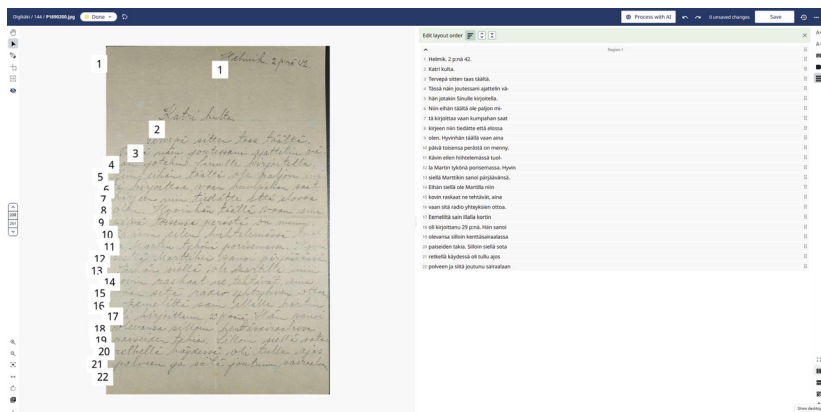


Fig. 8.1 The browser-based Transkribus platform can automatically recognise text from handwritten documents like personal letters. *Photo* Ilari Taskinen. Tampere University Culture and Research Archive, Wartime letter collection. <https://www.transkribus.org>

⁴⁴ Keijzer & van Lange 2025. Wartime letters have also been digitised and studied in the project “Digital History and Handwritten Sources” (Digikäki) at Tampere University, Finland. See Taskinen et al. 2022.

expressions containing personal evaluations and appraisals from those that state objective facts.⁴⁵

Emotion mining is the automatic analysis of emotions in a text. In its most basic form, this means labelling whether a text has a positive or a negative sentiment. In recent years, the approach has developed more complex forms, such as the detection of individual emotions, like anger and sadness, and the intensity of their expression. A simple way to conduct emotion mining is using an emotion lexicon. These lexicons have been produced in several projects and can contain thousands of words, which have been given an emotion label and other qualities, such as an intensity rating. These classifications are typically based on psychological theories of basic emotions, such as those of Paul Ekman and Robert Plutchik.⁴⁶

Text mining historical experiences offers intriguing opportunities for the history of experience in the coming years with the ever-increasing amounts of digitised historical data becoming available. They make it possible to quantify phenomena that have previously been possible to analyse only qualitatively, opening opportunities for more elaborate and accurate analyses and totally new research set-ups. At the same time, it is evident that historians of experience need to adjust text mining methodologies to the core principles of their discipline. One problematic issue of using large textual datasets can be the opacity of data. This concerns particularly massive datasets, like Google books, which contains millions of books about which scholars only have superficial knowledge. It is highly problematic to make far-reaching interpretations from data one does not know, as was done in a study that claimed to reveal the history of subjective well-being in the past two centuries using a universal emotion lexicon and Google books.⁴⁷ The danger in these analyses is that observed phenomena are not based on changes in people's behaviour but on changes in the underlying, invisible data. Rob Boddice, a leading scholar of the history of experience and emotions, was so dismayed by this study that he declared that the study of historical emotions is "inherently qualitative work".⁴⁸

⁴⁵ Yadollahi et al. 2017; Liu 2020.

⁴⁶ Mohammad & Turney 2013; Chen & Skiena 2014; Öhman 2021.

⁴⁷ Hills et al. 2019.

⁴⁸ Boddice 2020.

Boddice is right in emphasising that contextual knowledge is a vital part of the historical analysis of experiences. However, to us this does not exclude the utilisation of quantitative methods. The challenges of data are much smaller when historians have participated themselves in the digitisation of their data.⁴⁹ Historians also need to approach text mining methodologies with historical sensitivity. Much of the research on digital humanities has been conducted by scholars from other fields, and they often approach their analyses without considering historically changing notions in their data. This is seen, for example, in the straightforward adoption of psychological theories of basic emotions to all historical and cultural contexts, which of course contradicts the core principles under scrutiny in historical analysis of emotions—their timely and contextual nature.⁵⁰ When text mining emotions from historical material, the historian is wise to adjust emotion lexicons and models with contextual knowledge on the linguistic and cultural expressions of the era in question.⁵¹ When text mining is utilised reasonably, historians utilise them in a way that is based on their vast previous expertise on the topic under scrutiny.

The issue is also the interpretative framework—what kind of conclusions and connections are made from analyses. For conceptual historians, working on the level of texts and discourse is sufficient. For historians of experience, more attention needs to be paid to the world outside the text. If one wishes to make claims about the ways individual people experienced their lives, they need to ponder how a text informs, reflects, and creates the understandings, meanings, and ideals that constituted the lived reality of people. This might require in the end also traditional hands-on analysis, but before this, quantitative text mining can be a beneficial starting point. Its prospect is that it can help the historian to uncover great patterns from vast amounts of data that are not easily discernible through close reading.

⁴⁹ See, e.g. Taskinen et al. 2022.

⁵⁰ Turunen & Taskinen 2024.

⁵¹ Turunen et al. 2022.

CONCLUSION

The connection between individuals and structures—be they social, cultural, or institutional—is the most important reason for the historian of experience to turn to quantitative data. When analysing the lived reality of individuals, considering their surroundings is vital. This contextualisation is the bread and butter of the historian's work and is often done through secondary literature. However, the historian is often interested in phenomena where a clear picture is missing. In these cases, the historian can turn to original statistics or produce them themselves.

Using quantitative data or methods does not mean abandoning qualitative sources or traditional close reading methods. The study of historical experiences is conducted best when both the big picture of structures and their individual interpretations are taken into account. Official statistics are prime mediums for building the social and cultural frames—the structures of experience—in which people navigate their lives, and the progressive gathering of detailed life course and autobiographical data is also making the quantitative examination of people's specific life events possible. To derive valuable insights on historical experiences, relying solely on quantitative data is, however, rarely enough. Unlike demographic researchers and scholars of other purely quantitative disciplines, historians of experience need to produce more than just evidence of a causal connection between a few factors from numbers. They need to explain how historical contexts influenced the ways people conducted and interpreted their lives. This usually requires historians to also examine their cases closely with textual sources after the initial inspection of quantitative data.

Quantitative data do not force historians of experience to abandon the best practices of their own field. Many doubts about quantitative data probably arise from examples of their usage in other disciplines where the research aims are different. In demographic history, the goal of a study can be to prove a simple causal relationship between two factors, while an information scientist working with historical text data may only wish to demonstrate a novel way to classify data. Historians do not need to follow their research set-up. Even if historians use similar data, they do not need to adopt others' methodology. They can ask questions of the sources arising from the interests of their own field. The scholar, not the data, dictates the research. Justin Grimmer, Margaret Roberts, and Brandon Stewart discuss this topic well in their book on the usage of

machine learning in the social sciences. They remind us that the goals of digital humanists and social scientists are different. Digital humanists' interest is typically limited to making inferences about a text that is being studied, rather than using a text to make claims about other larger processes. Social scientists, as well as scholars in the humanities, on the other hand, use texts precisely to make these bigger claims, which makes importing practices from one field to another suboptimal. The writers wisely stress that "text as data methods should not displace the careful and thoughtful humanist".⁵² Historians of experience should follow this advice and utilise quantitative data and methods, critically following the principles of their field.

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⁵² Grimmer et al. 2022, 8–9.

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Photographs as Sources for the History of Experience: Experiencing with and Through Photography

Tanja Vahtikari 

Photographs are a rich but still relatively little used source in historical research. The interpretation of photographs has often been considered difficult, and the history of experience is no different in this regard. Perhaps scholars working on historical experience easily dismiss photography as a relevant and readable source because of its associations with the analytical realms of semiotics, iconography, and representation, focusing on iconic, indexical, and symbolic signs in images and the interpretative levels of pre-iconographical description, iconographical analysis, and iconological interpretation.¹ While these approaches, often applied in art history, may be utilised productively in the analysis of historical images, there are also other fruitful approaches. Photographs can be analysed

¹ For discussion, see Burke 2001, 35–36; Margolis & Rowe 2004, 2001.

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and contextualised as social and material documents also when analysing historical experience.

In this chapter, I will discuss photography as a site of experience, aiming to demonstrate the wide and multifaceted potential of photographs as a source for the history of experience. I will explore both the complementary potential of photographs in relation to other types of sources and their possibilities in shedding light on such past events that remain largely invisible in textual sources. A key question that relates to photographs is whose experiences they are able to convey and how in varying historical situations. Central to my understanding of experience is that it is a layered and socially shared process encompassing the cognitive, emotional, sensory, and memory²; I will discuss photographs and experience in this framework. My chapter further contributes to the understanding of how experience is produced as an entanglement between the social and the spatial and material, and the opportunities that photographs offer for researching such entanglements.

The history of photography is one of quantitative growth. The first daguerreotypes were rarities, but with decreasing prices and changes in technology, leading to more easily portable devices, camera ownership expanded, and photography moved from a professional and elite practice to an amateur and everyday one. Snapshots became a key photographic genre. Over the twentieth century, and increasingly following the Second World War, photography was intertwined with multiple aspects of life, for instance, family life and the formalisation of social family rituals such as weddings and christenings.³ The contemporary pervasive practices of camera phone and social media photography, particularly Instagram, have meant that the everyday lives of individuals have become “remediated into new contexts of social visibility and connection”,⁴ images captured this way being directly linked with the person’s everyday experience and constructions of subjectivity.⁵ Clearly, this democratisation of photography has had significant repercussions with regard to the question of whose experiences photographs are able to convey and how. While the

² See, e.g. Boddice & Smith 2020; Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021, 12–13, 16.

³ See, e.g. Margolis & Rowe 2004; Tinkler 2013; Hanna 2014, 93–94; Vahtikari, Männistö-Funk, & Laine 2022, 229–230.

⁴ Vivienne & Burgess, 2013, 282.

⁵ Chesher 2012, 106; Zappavigna 2016, 271.

recent change is apparent and the number of images around us has exploded, there are also interesting parallels between, for instance, Instagram profiles and photo albums of earlier times.⁶ Both have acted as sites to curate the self, identity, and experience.

Experience can be seen as layered in time; memory is inherent in the process of experiencing. Memory juxtaposes the experiences of the past with the experiences of the present, as well as with future expectations, which themselves reflect on the explanations of the past.⁷ Photographs as sources in historical research can be perceived along the same temporal dimensions. Photographs, like all historical sources, are bound to the temporalities of their lifetime. They are taken, viewed, shared, published, and exhibited in specific historical contexts. Photographs can be used to think about the experience of the photographer, of their viewers, and of the person captured in the photo. They reveal the social and material contexts of experiencing. People also utilise photographs as aids when remembering and reflecting on past experiences, wherein they become part of the process of re-experiencing. Photographs are also key to what Marianne Hirsch terms “postmemory”, something that “characterises the experience of those who grow up dominated by narratives that preceded their birth”.⁸ Images often have a later life following their immediate production and use; they can be presented and reproduced in ever new contexts and potentially be re-experienced in very different ways. In particular, this is the case with iconic images, having achieved exceptional levels of widespread recognisability;⁹ sometimes just one photograph can be very influential in directing people’s experiences, interpretations, and memories of an event. It is also possible to apply photography as a source when analysing how people in the past imagined their own or their children’s future. All this makes photographs layered with temporalities and experiences.

While this chapter focuses on the above-described temporalities in relation to experience, yet another important temporal dimension warrants mentioning, namely that of the time of research. Photographs have a significant role in the production of historians’ experiences and emotions

⁶ On photo albums, see, e.g. Tinkler 2010; Hanna 2014.

⁷ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2021, 12; Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021, 12.

⁸ Hirsch 1997, 22.

⁹ Kemp 2012, 2.

during the research process. Historians' interpretations are often reinforced when encountering an image in the archive; as Peter Burke has phrased it, images allow imagining the past more vividly.¹⁰ Or as Jo Labanyi has pointed out, the materiality of images "touches" us as researchers, inviting us to imagine the different historical circumstances.¹¹ Historians use photographs to make visible these imaginations and experiences that they have not encountered in other source materials; at the same time, they may use photographs to uncritically illustrate an experience without analysing them as part of their argumentation. In addition, photography often has an important role as part of oral history interviews, involving a continuous reframing of photographs and a wide range of methodological considerations.¹²

In what follows, I will give examples of different types of photographs, public and private, and draw from my own and others' research. I will begin by discussing the images of the city of Vyborg by a Finnish war photographer, Aukusti Tuhka, as autobiographical sources, through which it is possible to examine both the historically situated experiences of the photographer and those photographed and the practice of photography as a way of experiencing. I will continue with a discussion concerning photographic imageries bound to societal constructions such as the nation and welfare state, and how images produced in various institutional settings are connected with hegemonic visual discourses and power relations. As such, they can be used to reveal the societal expectations and norms for experiencing, but also to think about how people may have resisted these prevailing norms and expectations. Finally, I will discuss the relationship between photographs, materiality, memory, and experience—what the materiality of photographs and the materialities depicted in photographs can bring to their analysis as a source for the history of experience, often in relation to memory, and how photographs help us to understand the ways in which the material culture of various spatial settings could have impacted the emotional and sensory experiences of those that engaged with these spaces.

¹⁰ Burke 2001, 13.

¹¹ Labanyi 2022, 98.

¹² Tinkler 2013, 173–194. On the "turn to photography" in oral history, see Freund & Thomson 2011.

DISRUPTING THE GENRE: (WAR) PHOTOGRAPHY AS A WAY OF EXPERIENCING

Figure 9.1 shows the deserted city of Vyborg (known to Finns as Viipuri) in late August 1941 when the Finnish troops had regained the city after 18 months of Soviet occupation.¹³ In the picture, a soldier walks alone along the quiet, war-torn Harmaiden veljesten katu (Street of the Grey Brothers) in the city centre. The signs of war are visible in the image, which shows a street view that many Finns of the time knew from their own experience or from images they had seen. The photograph was taken by Aukusti Tuhka (1895–1973), who was a graphic artist born and raised in Vyborg. During the Second World War, he worked as an illustrator and photographer in the Finnish war propaganda unit (the so-called information companies). He was among the first Finns to re-enter Vyborg following the temporary Soviet withdrawal.

The image is one of the nearly 160,000 photographs in the digitised archive of wartime photographs by the Finnish Defence Forces, covering a time period from autumn 1939 to the summer of 1945.¹⁴ From the perspective of the history of experience, it could be dismissed straight away as a propaganda source. However, even images taken in the framework of propaganda are not detached from the world of experience, and they can be used to answer research questions that go beyond propaganda.

The image is by no means exceptional or a key image in the photographer's production, but rather one of many among Aukusti Tuhka's photographs from Vyborg in the summer of 1941. Tuhka also took pictures in Vyborg with his own private camera on colour film, but here I will use his 77 photographs that can be found in the Finnish Defence Forces' digital archives. To be able to tell something about experience, such photographs need careful contextualisation and consideration of authorship. In this sense, they are not very different from textual sources. The question of the photographer's intentions when taking a picture from this and not from that angle at this very moment and not at some other moment is of course valid. This is the case especially in relation to artistic and professional photographs but also with anonymous and

¹³ This section partly draws from my earlier article, Vahtikari 2023.

¹⁴ Finnish Wartime Photograph Archive (SA-kuva-arkisto), <http://sa-kuva.fi/neo?tem=webneofin>. Visited 24 February 2025.



Fig. 9.1 Harmaiden veljesten katu (Street of the Grey Brothers) in the city of Vyborg, 1941. Photograph: Aukusti Tuhka. The Finnish Defence Forces' Digitised Archives, No. 42249

ephemeral amateur snapshot photography. At the same time, thinking about the author's intentions may become over-emphasised in a photographic context in comparison to a textual one. Unlike texts, photographs are often associated with a strong sense of selection and curation, as well as a demand for authenticity. This may lead to a dismissal of the source entirely as too difficult to interpret, or readable only within, for example, a semiotic analytical framework of visual messages. However, it is important to note that texts do not provide access to somehow "authentic" experiences either; there is no such thing as inherent authenticity, since all experiences are somehow mediated and relational.¹⁵ There are ways to weave experience into the visual analysis beyond the authentic-inauthentic debate and even into photographs such as those taken by Aukusti Tuhka.

Like other information companies' photographers, Aukusti Tuhka was instructed about preferable choices of topic. In addition to photographs

¹⁵ Boddice 2022; Alexander, Olsen, & Valgård 2023.

depicting battles, Finnish soldiers, and types of weaponry, they were told to produce ethnographic and landscape material from the conquered areas. The purpose was to justify that the conquered East Karelia was part of Finland by demonstrating its similarities to the existing territories of Finland. In addition, the Finnish Army photographers were assigned to illustrate the reconquered areas in the condition that the enemy had left them. The depiction of wounded and fallen soldiers of one's own side was a taboo—there are few such images in the Finnish Defence Forces' photo archives—but enemy casualties were widely photographed.¹⁶ Aukusti Tuhka's Vyborg photos should be placed in this context of army propaganda, the social norms of the time, and the long-established conventions of war photography going back even to earlier forms of visual representation such as drawing and painting. While these frameworks conditioned Tuhka's work significantly, it should be noted that the information companies' photographers had a certain freedom of choice when taking photographs. In fact, their work may be understood as communicating shared experiences of war and establishing emotional connections among the combatant soldiers and between the soldiers and the home front. Therefore, the images that Aukusti Tuhka took in Vyborg can tell something about the wider social experience. At the same time, it also warrants thinking about how individual photographers disrupted dominant tropes and conventions consciously and unconsciously, creating a space for their own self-expression.

One way to approach experience through photographs, even war photography, is to explore them as ego-documents and autobiographical sources. Taking pictures is often linked to key moments and experiences in people's lives, such as marriages, the births of children, anniversaries, holidays, and travels. Family members have been frequently photographed since the beginning of photography, something that Pierre Bourdieu linked to the purpose of strengthening the unity and societal role of families and the increased separation of public and private spheres during the nineteenth century.¹⁷ These connections of photographs to important people, events, and places in the photographer's life create routes into personal histories that Virpi Mäkinen has called "visual pathways".

¹⁶ Kleemola 2016, 39; Kivimäki & Männistö 2016; Kleemola, 2020.

¹⁷ Bourdieu 1990.

The autobiographical approach can thus be seen as being built into photography both as its purpose and its by-product.¹⁸

Tuhka had grown up in Vyborg, and among the first things he did when entering the city was to go to the district where his family home was located. When realising that his house and the neighbours' houses were still standing, he photographed them. Overall, his photographs convey a strong desire to see and encounter Vyborg again. This was a personal feeling but also a more widely shared desire among Finns, and Tuhka, together with other Finnish Army photographers, was able to show that Vyborg, even though partially destroyed, was still standing as people remembered it. The images make the traces of war damage visible, thus serving the purpose of war propaganda: by showing the destruction of war, it was possible to later demonstrate how effectively the damage had been repaired. The images of destruction also produced an awareness of how the destruction violently disrupted the normal order of the city, for example, by cutting off established routes and forcing the invention of new ones.¹⁹

On the other hand, Tuhka had lived elsewhere in his adult life (he was already forty-five years old in 1941). His visit to Vyborg seems to have also been marked by nostalgia about the meaningful places of his childhood. Tuhka's short diary-like entries while in Vyborg verbalise this sense of nostalgia.²⁰ They also help to create a timeline of Tuhka's photographs, which in the archives are all dated to the same day (this often happened with Finnish Army photographs). I obtained these diary entries from the family archive only at the late stage of the research process. Thus, in this case, textual sources supported the interpretations based on visual analysis, and not vice versa.

When discussing photographs as ego-documents, the connection between self-portraits and biographies is often made.²¹ Tuhka also photographed himself in Vyborg; he asked a fellow soldier to take the photo, but he most likely himself had composed it (Fig. 9.2). The important landmark of Vyborg castle is in the background, and he poses for the camera amidst the rubble. To Tuhka, having his photograph taken could

¹⁸ Mäkinen 2018.

¹⁹ Vahtikari 2023.

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ Pahl 2025; Mäkinen 2018.

relate to performing his role as a soldier. With the self-portrait Tuhka placed himself within the shared experience of war and formed connections between the experience of the self and others: he had been there and witnessed the events.

Most likely, Tuhka photographed himself not only for the purposes of the present but also for future remembrance. When reminiscing about the war roughly thirty years later, the veterans, even though having conflicting interpretations of the meaning of their war experiences, identified themselves strongly as “we”, as a community of “true” frontline soldiers whose experiences could not be fully understood by anyone “who had not been there”.²² These communal feelings and experiences were thus created both during the wartime and in the later process of reminiscing.

Tuhka’s photographs also convey a strong sense of walking and photographing as an interactive way of taking hold of the city. According to Michel De Certeau, a space becomes a meaningful place through being and doing. Walking can be seen as such a practice; it does not only happen in space but is an interactive and embodied practice that produces places.²³ Walking is a highly multi-sensory experience—it combines the soundscape of paving stones clapping under the feet, different smells, movement, familiar routes and changes in them, and prevailing weather conditions. It is through this multi-sensory experience that people become attached to a place.²⁴

We can interpret Aukusti Tuhka’s photographic exploration of the empty Vyborg from this perspective. In his childhood and youth, he had made the city his own by wandering its streets and shortcuts. After the Soviet troops left, he recaptured the familiar but momentarily lost city by walking and photographing. Like walking, photography is a practice that produces places and spatial experiences, not just represents them. Even though photographs, despite their materiality, are primarily approached visually, they convey a multi-sensory experience of space. This is the case with Tuhka’s images, which produce a sense of different weather conditions and times of day, as well as a feeling of emptiness in a city

²² Pahl & Kivimäki 2023, 66.

²³ De Certeau 1984, 97.

²⁴ Kenny 2014; Kanellopoulou 2017; Olsson, Rinne, & Suopajarvi 2021.



Fig. 9.2 Aukusti Tuhka. According to Tuhka he first entered Vyborg on 28 August, 1941. In the Finnish Defence Forces' digitised archives the photo is dated to 30 August, 1941, like all Tuhka's Vyborg images. Photograph: Unknown photographer. The Finnish Defence Forces' Digitised Archives, No. 42237

left behind by the Soviet troops, and how these conditions influenced a person walking through the city.²⁵

Photography was a practice that an increasing number of soldiers—not only designated war photographers but also amateurs—engaged in during the Second World War. Whether close-reading one photographer's work or taking a quantitative perspective, considering photography as a practice adds another dimension to the war experience. Thus, photographs not only serve as a source for the history of experience, but the practice of photography can be analysed as a way of experiencing, bound to time and place and exercised for multiple different purposes. It is a practice that is embodied, material, and affective.

²⁵ Vahtikari 2023.

PHOTOGRAPHIC IMAGERIES AS FRAMEWORKS FOR EXPERIENCING

Experiencing beyond certain immediate bodily reactions (and even them) is always somehow mediated. People encounter and experience different situations in relation to their earlier embodied experiences; gender, class, age, religion, and ethnicity all play an important role. Experiences should be carefully contextualised within the existing social, cultural, and material frameworks and power relations. These frameworks produce similarities between individual experiences and allow people to adjust their own experiences to the wider shared experience.²⁶ A photograph is never an isolated image. Images, despite their different origins, are linked to other images in the societal contexts of each time. Together they form wider imaginaries. Like linguistic discourses, imageries can be understood as enabling and constraining entities that seek to construct the social, cultural, spatial, and material reality of a group or community. Individual images then can either support or challenge the reality produced by the dominant imageries.²⁷ Using national landscapes and institutional images as examples, in this section I will discuss the formation and existence of imageries from the perspective of experience: photographs forming wider clusters, and operating in a co-constructive relationship with other images, as well as texts, produce and direct experiences in society and thus act as important frameworks for experiencing. How can these dominant ways of looking and seeing be challenged? And can we reach the experiences of those captured in photographs when examining photographic practices of institutions?

One central way to justify the existence of nation states has been their territorialisation and making connections to concrete landscapes, together forming a “national space”. Landscapes acquire their national meaning as part of a landscape imagery that relates individual images of landscapes (and through them the actual landscapes) to other similar images and landscapes, creating a select and partly self-referential structure. Even though conservative in outlook, national landscape imageries need to be able to renew themselves from time to time, as both physical landscapes and their frames of interpretation change. For example, after the

²⁶ Kivimäki, Suodenjoki, & Vahtikari 2021; Kivimäki & Toivo 2022.

²⁷ On imageries, see Mitchell 2002 [1994]; Häyrynen 2005; Rose 2012; Vahtikari, Männistö-Funk, & Laine 2022, 233–235.

Second World War, Finnish landscape imagery, which increasingly drew from images of schools, health centres, and other welfare institutions, and images depicting living, active free time, and consumption, adjusted to the frameworks of the modern and urban welfare state and the new kind of welfare citizenship.²⁸

Researchers have studied the formation of national landscape imageries through a variety of media: school textbook illustrations, popular landscape publications, tourism marketing images, postcards, cartoons, stamps, and even matchbox covers.²⁹ What makes national landscape imageries important as an example for the history of experience is their ability to offer familiar cultural scripts for how the national space ought to be experienced. Within the system, individual images also echo the emotional effects of other texts and images through their appropriation by different audiences (Fig. 9.3).³⁰ Working in this way, national landscapes, like other spatial imageries, may produce certain kinds of uses and experiences of space, for example, how to admire the landscape, how to perform the role of tourist, or how to be an active citizen.

In addition to the conventions of war and propaganda photography, the above discussed images by Aukusti Tuhka can be interpreted in relation to the Finnish national landscape imagery and urban imagery of Vyborg, which he commented on through his own Vyborg images. This shows how individual photographs can be part of several different imageries and how photographic frames of experiencing are often overlapping, allowing varying interpretations and experiences.

Geographers Peter Merriman and Rhys Jones have studied national highways. Remaining within the symbolic-iconographic framework of national landscape imageries, it is possible to see how highways define a national space that is reproduced in numerous road maps, route guides, and popular landscape publications, making people think about them in naturalised and routine ways as part of their daily lives. Driving on highways offers views of nationally esteemed landscapes. However, Merriman and Jones provide a more nuanced and multifaceted interpretation of the everyday nationalism in the context of national highways:

²⁸ Linkola & Jokela 2017, 206–207.

²⁹ See, e.g. Häyrynen 2005; Raento & Brun 2008; Linkola & Jokela 2017.

³⁰ For humanitarian images, see Martín-Moruno 2022, 4.



Fig. 9.3 Young travellers on their way to Aulanko, 1957–1961. The Aulanko landscape and Hotel Aulanko were part of the Finnish national landscape imagery of the postwar years. Viewing it from the standpoint of children gives the photo a different partial perspective. Photo: Teuvo Kanerva, The Finnish Heritage Agency

While concrete structures such as roads and bridges might be seen to possess a fairly uniform and persistent (if banal) cultural and political symbolism and resonance refracting particular understandings of nationness, nationalism and national identity, these national resonances are only ever partial, intermittent and emergent, flickering between presence and absence, relation and non-relation depending on the capacity of bodies to affect and become affected. What's more, questions of cultural and

political symbolism are themselves reliant upon particular affective ties and relations, as some bodies have the capacity to generate and apprehend symbolic resonances, just as others do not.³¹

In other words, the socio-spatial experiencing of nations, as with other social constructions, through shared frames of experiencing via images and being in a place and landscape, is occasional and relational. Some people at some moments are affected while others are not.

Experiences become embedded in institutional structures and practices.³² Historical photographs can help to reveal this embeddedness and the related institutional power relations. Those who have institutional power can control discursive representations, including visual representations, such as official institutional images and their framing by captions. For example, Janet Fink examined childhood and child development in mid-twentieth-century Britain through the yearbook illustrations of the National Children's Home organisation. She shows how, on one level, the yearbook imagery illustrates the social, political, and cultural investments in a normative ideal of childhood, especially the value of outdoor play and activity on children's physical and mental health. At the same time, the analysis of the images "points to unexpected, unsettling and unrealistic portrayals of childhood and child development", for example, the contradictory dynamics of freedom and regulation.³³

Other researchers have pointed out similar kinds of frictions between normative and unexpected experiences through photography. Examining the large amateur photography collection of Dorothy Stokes and situating her photographs between the two traditions of ethnographic photographs of Ireland and "snapshot" images of holidays and family, Erika Hanna shows how "we can understand Stokes as a social being [through her photography]—simultaneously constrained by and resisting paths laid down for women in post-independence Ireland". The photographic practice became a way for Dorothy Stokes to resist and undermine state and religious discourses of femininity "through a visual register which

³¹ Merriman & Jones 2017, 612.

³² Annola, Lindberg, & Markkola 2024; Vahtikari 2025.

³³ Fink 2008, 307.

was constructed in dialogue with international images of leisure and femininity”.³⁴

In humanitarian contexts, since the nineteenth century, images forming a broad visual corpus focused on the representation of human suffering have been utilised to address and produce collective feelings and experiences such as compassion and pity. However, as Dolores Martín-Moruno has recently demonstrated, there are multiple “dilemmas, paradoxes and tensions resulting from the portrayal of human suffering and the emotions that the spectator is expected to feel when faced with these symbolic representations”.³⁵ All the above cited examples suggest that while dominant societal and cultural scripts acting as frames of experience direct people towards certain ways of experiencing, photographic imageries constituting one such important framework, this is rarely true in all cases. Experience is highly complex and multilayered, and people may experience differently and in contradictory ways in contrast to the expected experience.

Several historians have used photographic sources to unravel the experiences of people who are depicted in the images, particularly to reclaim silenced voices in cases where there are few written sources available. For example, as pointed out by Claudia Soares, photographs produced by the institutions have offered an important avenue for the investigation of the experiences of children within residential schools in the settler colonies of the British Empire during the era of forced assimilation.³⁶ Sherry Farrell Racette has used photographs to demonstrate children’s entry into a world of assimilation, violence, and trauma that “utterly rejected all their previous experiences”; at the moment of their arrival at the residential schools, children were stripped of their earlier clothing and dressed in institutional clothing. Their hair was cut or shaved, the short hair testifying to, as Racette points out, “a deeply symbolic and traumatic gesture enacted on the bodies of children”, from an indigenous perspective symbolising death and mourning. Over and over, children appear in residential school photographs with haunted eyes and solemn, unsmiling faces, in slumped body positions or with their arms folded. The photographs, however, also document the resilience of the children who

³⁴ Hanna 2014, 105.

³⁵ Martín-Moruno 2022, 4–6.

³⁶ Soares 2023, 525.

lived through the experience, shown by occasional smiles, boys whose hair was not cut, and the grouping of children with peers and siblings.³⁷ Photographs can thus reveal frictions in the totality of the institutional framings of experience. In addition, interpreting people's facial expressions and body language from photographs can be instructive of certain experiences when placed carefully in cultural and situational contexts.

PHOTOGRAPHS, MATERIALITY, MEMORY, AND EXPERIENCE

I will begin this section with another image from an institutional framework. Figure 9.4 is part of the illustration of a guidebook entitled *Äidille* (*For the Mother* in English) from 1947. The guidebook was included in the maternity package (or “baby box”), a material welfare state benefit offered to Finnish families since 1937. In the photograph, there is a middle-class woman with a neat appearance. She has clearly just collected the maternity package from the municipal maternity clinic. She examines the contents of the package, presumably, with her first-born child. The image, as with the wider concept of the maternity package at the time, is normative concerning how to be a proper mother, housewife, and female citizen. It presents the ideal material conditions of a family home: tidy, nicely decorated, organised, and prepared for the arrival of the baby. The maternity package is full of important items, implying care for the newborn but also for the mother by the state. Strikingly, the family lives in an urban home, even though most Finns at the time still lived in rural areas. In the early years, the maternity benefit was designed particularly for the rural population.³⁸ The choice of this image may have been motivated by an effort to convey a message that in 1947 the maternity package should no longer be associated with poor relief, as more mothers, both rural and urban and regardless of their income, received it. From 1949 onwards, the maternity allowance was turned into a universal benefit, which it continues to be even today.

Figure 9.5. depicts a similar kind of moment of exploration of the contents of the baby box from the late 1980s. While the two images show certain interesting similarities—an adult and a future sibling getting to know the box together—the second photograph is a snapshot taken for

³⁷ Racette 2009, 59–60; see also Margolis & Rowe 2004.

³⁸ Vahtikari, Räikkönen, & Mattjus 2024, 396–397.



Fig. 9.4 Illustration of the guidebook entitled *Äidille* (For the Mother) from year 1947. The guidebook was included in the maternity package and is visible in the photo as well. Photo: Väinö Hyvärinen, The Finnish Labour Museum Werstas

private purposes from a family photo album. The photo was enclosed by a research participant who wrote her memories as part of a collection of 90 written reminiscences, which were gathered in 2020–2021 based on an open call and in cooperation with the Finnish Literature Society.³⁹ It also provides a window into the materiality of a home expecting a newborn, in this case revealing the rush of everyday life and less arrangement for photographic purposes. Together the two images show how the maternity package has changed over the decades: in the 1980s, because of the growing wealth and consumer culture, clothes were manufactured from more colourful fabrics and easy-care materials, following the latest fashions (even though again less colourful than in the 1970s). New kinds of items had been added to the box, such as a cuddly toy, which seems to be what the child is showing to her great-aunt.

Within the history of experience, the material world is an important medium and an intrinsic part of the process of experiencing. Large societal constructions such as the nation and the welfare state work in and through people's mundane daily material lives and related practices. In my research, I have investigated the maternity package in the production of the socio-material experiences of the Finnish welfare state nation and utilised a diverse body of source material.⁴⁰ Written reminiscences are a valuable source that allow people to narrate their experiences from their own perspective with their own words. Photographs show a moment in time, "an experience", but they also have many other things to tell about experiencing. They may be particularly illustrative about the material world as a medium for experiencing, allowing reflections to be made regarding material agency. As noted by Andres Reckwitz, the realm of the social consists of "interconnected 'doings'" that are materially anchored.⁴¹ Photographs can help us to understand the ways in which the material culture of various spatial settings could have impacted the related practices and the emotional and sensory experiences of those who engaged with these objects and spaces. For instance, Fig. 9.5, and even Fig. 9.4, despite its normative setting, convey joy, excitement, and curiosity towards the new maternity package, and, while engaging

³⁹ Finnish Literature Society, "Memories of the Maternity Package". <https://www.finlit.fi/en/arkisto/vastaa-keruusiin/memories-maternity-package#.YRTuNOdRWUk>.

⁴⁰ Vahtikari 2025; Vahtikari, Räikkönen, & Mattjus 2024.

⁴¹ Reckwitz 2012, 241–258, 248.



Fig. 9.5 Intergenerational exploring of the baby box in 1985. Iina, aged 18 months, with her great-aunt Anja. Photo: Birgitta Laurikainen, private collection

with the box, interaction with and consideration for the child, both the sibling and the unborn baby. In Fig. 9.5, the maternity package's ability to produce and transfer intergenerational experiences is visible, as is a

sense of continuity in the family and within society.⁴² The baby box as an intergenerational experience surfaces also very prominently in the written reminiscences. Several narrators describe how getting to know the contents of the baby box of their grandchildren has enabled them to go back in time and revisit their own early parenthood in memory.⁴³ Both the images and reminiscences demonstrate emotional and sensory encounters with the object.

Reminiscing is always selective; it is an interpretative endeavour that takes place in the present and involves different temporalities. Photographs are also selective and often taken for the purposes of memory. They show a moment in time but are (perhaps) later returned to and reinterpreted in that moment, which adds layers to the experience. People give photographs agency in the process of memory; this is perhaps why some of the respondents to the baby box reminiscence collection wanted to enclose a meaningful photograph to their written narrative. The selective process of photo album making also resembles reminiscing and diary writing. It is a process of creating a space for self-expression and the curation of one's past, present, and even future experiences,⁴⁴ forming another interesting source for the history of experience.

Despite their differences, oral or written reminiscences and photographs can provide similar routes to historical experience. The indexical nature of photographs—in other words their technical origin as the imprint of reflected light falling on chemicals—does not mean that they are neutral and objective. What this means, however, is that photographs may also contain more arbitrary and occasional content, independent of the intentions of their author.⁴⁵ This is rarely the case with written sources. Photographs, often taken for other purposes, can thus provide glimpses of things, often material, that remain unnoticed in other sources. For example, as Tiina Männistö-Funk has demonstrated, urban photographs originally produced for the purposes of building inventory are highly illustrative of people's different uses of space and

⁴² For discussion concerning the baby box as a producer of intergenerational welfare experiences, see Vahtikari 2025.

⁴³ Vahtikari 2025.

⁴⁴ Hanna 2014; Tinkler 2010.

⁴⁵ Vahtikari, Männistö-Funk, & Laine 2022, 237.

spatial practices, such as walking and bicycling.⁴⁶ The research on material and experiential affordances, affordance referring to the possibilities for action by individuals and groups that objects, environments, or situations offer,⁴⁷ also benefits from the use of photographs, making visible the (non)engagement of people with various non-human and material bodies and objects and people's actual and potential experiences as part of these co-constructions.

Elisabeth Edwards has called for thinking about photographs not only as images but "as a series of material practices".⁴⁸ My previous example of Aukusti Tuhka's photography connected to walking is one example of such a material practice. Drawing from the case of survey photography from the turn of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, Edwards notes:

[P]hotographs exist as history not only on a forensic plane, or as semiotically charged representations (although of course they can be these things), but also as material performances that enact a complex range of historiographical desires. These desires cluster around, on the one hand, ideas of truth, accuracy, inscription, and statement, and, on the other, an intense awareness of the past and its potential loss.⁴⁹

The "instruments", such as the camera, chemicals, negatives, printing papers, and labels, mediate experiences, and so do photographs themselves as material objects.⁵⁰ Through the history of experience lens, photographs can be explored, for example, as emotional and memory objects, which often relate to key experiences in a person's life, and which are "sticky" with emotions and memories.⁵¹ It is often in these moments of emotional and memory work that photographs are touched, kept, valued, treasured, destroyed, or hidden. Throughout their history, photographs have been used in various settings, private and public, and in assemblages with other objects, resulting in a variety of methodological

⁴⁶ Männistö-Funk 2021; Männistö-Funk 2020. For discussion, see also Tinkler 2013, Ch. 3.

⁴⁷ Gibson 2015 [1979]; Malinen & Vahtikari 2025.

⁴⁸ Edwards 2009, 130–131. See also Edwards & Hart 2004.

⁴⁹ Edwards 2009, 130–131.

⁵⁰ Edwards 2009, 136.

⁵¹ On objects becoming sticky with emotions and affects, see Ahmed 2014; on emotional objects, see, e.g. Downes, Holloway, & Randles 2018; Vahtikari 2025.

consequences for their analysis.⁵² For example, a photo of a child placed in a locket suggests an attachment to the child in the picture.⁵³

CONCLUSIONS

Jennifer Tucker has noted how “the photograph serves not only as a historical document or a source, but also as a reflexive medium that exposes the stakes of historical study by revealing the constructed nature of what constitutes historical evidence”.⁵⁴ As with historiography more generally, the history of experience—so far mostly approached through textual sources—benefits from using photographs both as sources and as a reflexive medium. Experiences are highly multidimensional and so are photographs in the research of historical experience. They can reveal intimate and private experiences, spatially and materially bound experiences, the mechanisms of how experiences become shared, and the framing of experiences in institutional and societal contexts. Photography can be seen as a way of marking and producing meaningful experiences. The act of looking at and feeling meaningful old photographs is a way of re-experiencing. While images are selective in ways that are connected to the photographic conventions and social norms of the time of their production, together they create narrative chronologies that create continuities and form links between the experience of the self and others and between generations. Photography, experience, and memory are profoundly entangled categories.

Thinking about the choices made by the photographer but also the person who is in the picture, the practices related to photography, and the use and reuse of photographs are all important aspects when analysing historical photographs through the lens of the history of experience. Photographs can reveal the totality of institutional frameworks but also experiential frictions, therefore even institutional or war propaganda photographs can be used as sources for the history of experience. During their afterlife, the frameworks of experiencing for photographs can also change. For example, Carolyn Payne has shown how visuality as a system of settler colonial authority in Inuit Nunangat in the 1950s can

⁵² Männistö-Funk 2016; Vahtikari, Männistö-Funk, & Laine 2022, 240–241.

⁵³ Tinkler 2013, 2.

⁵⁴ Tucker 2009, 3.

be decolonised and the images taken in this colonial framework positively re-framed for the purposes of Inuit identity decades later.⁵⁵

Photographs produced in a certain moment of time become part of the photographer's life story, creating a sense of self-representation. Writing can be understood both as a source of experience and emotions and an emotionally charged practice in itself⁵⁶; the very same holds true for photography. The relationship between the textual and visual mediums of experiencing deserves further consideration; the public or semi-public nature of many photographs, developed at the local chemist or camera shop and shown to friends, may make them more curated in terms of experiences than letters,⁵⁷ for example, but this is not always the case. Some photos have remained private, and as we know, letters, diaries, and reminiscences offer no direct route to experiencing either, being equally bound by notions of respectability and curation. As with any other history of experience source, when dealing with photographs, it is important to reflect on silences and absences.

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Art Objects as Sources for the History of Experience

Karen E. McCluskey 

From the very earliest evidence of human life, material culture has been found in direct association with homo sapiens.¹ Because of our unique cognitive abilities, humans have the distinctive capacity in the animal kingdom to manipulate resources to manufacture both practical objects (like stone tools, clothing and buildings) *and* aesthetic or symbolic ones based on abstract ideas and concepts.² Celebrated objects, such as the so-called *Venus of Willendorf* (Fig. 10.1), exemplify the intertwining of both the practical and the abstract suggesting that our very ancient ancestors had a need for both.

This object, made around 30,000 years ago, is ‘one of the earliest signs of early modern human symbolic behaviour.’³ The figure was deliberately fashioned from rock into the form of a female human, carefully

¹ Aubert, Brumm, Oktaviana, & Joannes-Boyau 2026.

² Malafouris 2024, 200–202; Ciotteau & et al. 2021, 166–172.

³ Weber & et al. 2022, 2.

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Fig. 10.1 Venus of Willendorf, c.28,000 BCE, limestone, 11.1cms. Naturhistorisches Museum, Vienna. Photo by Chloe Potter NHM/Wien

incised with details and then painted with red ochre pigment. Based on the figure's exaggerated female features—large breasts, wide hips, rotund belly and buttocks, and visible vulva—many scholars have inferred that it more than likely functioned as a fertility object.⁴ In what way it was experienced, however, is not precisely known. Surely, it evidences human,

⁴ For example, Taranilla de la Varga [2023](#), 16–20; Rebay-Salisbury [2023](#), 309–325.

in fact female, self-awareness. But in terms of embodied praxis, was it used on an individual or communal level? Was it held by a woman giving birth? Did it operate as a safeguard against food or resource shortages more broadly? Did the user(s) feel transformed in mind, body, or action in its presence, while sensing its cool touch within the grasp of a hand? Did it contribute to a sense of control, choice, or empowerment in its users? What the owner(s) relationship to this object was, we may never know. Yet, we know that the object (or the limestone from which it was carved) was important enough to be carried over long distances (from modern-day northern Italy to Austria) and that the figure might have been a multi-generational heirloom.⁵ If nothing else, these clues tell us that our earliest ancestors thought the object was worth keeping; to them, it must have held value (cultural, emotional, practical) and most likely had impact.

Fast forward 30,000 years to the modern day. New technologies for artmaking abound and yet humans still tend to strongly focus on making art objects featuring their own species in idealised forms. Disciplines like art history, cultural studies, sociology, and archaeology, among others, have established a long tradition in interpreting the human relationship with visual and material cultures. More recently, the focus has shifted from aesthetic appreciation, function and patronage of objects to the psychological, sensory and emotional impact they have on their human creators and audiences. As an example, photographs of idealised women on magazine covers have been in the scholarly spotlight, critiqued for their often-adverse impact on the mental health of the individuals and groups who view them. *Cosmopolitan* magazine is one publication that has been criticised for projecting female archetypes through a white and western lens, promoting predominantly blonde, young, fit and slim female bodies as the ideal.⁶

What is clear from the studies is that such images, published over and over again, are known to have cumulative negative impacts. They amplify feelings of body dissatisfaction, negative self-comparison, and the internalisation of unrealistic beauty ideals, promoting low self-esteem and anxiety. Socially, such images of women—often highly sexualised—advance the marginalisation of a vast cohort of the world population: people of colour,

⁵ Weber & et al. 2022, 5–7.

⁶ Eggins 1997, 165–196.

people with non-normative bodies, people with disabilities, elderly people and so on.⁷

While discourses of ideal femininity have changed significantly since the Gravettian artist first incised marks in the limestone to create the *Venus of Willendorf*, the cognitive relationship between humans and materiality may well have not. Like human brains and bodies, material objects are not inert or fixed things. They all result from *and* actively facilitate cultural constructions, discourses, norms and perceived truths. This position suggests that both humans and artefacts are historically contingent, that ‘the politics of construction’ and ‘historical processes ... position subjects and produce their experiences.’⁸

This chapter takes an experience-centred approach to visual art. In doing so, it aims to consider sources that show not simply how and why objects were experienced historically but how they might also have been (and continue to be) complicit in producing experiences. This approach adopts the position that humans and objects are equally involved in knowledge co-production and thus in constituting experience. It specifically focuses on perceptions of women in art over the *longue durée* and their implications in the life world of the humans who encountered them. The chapter tackles some central epistemological questions asked by scholars studying the history of experience: How do we make sense of objects that represent others? Whose experience is represented in such objects? And, is there something we can garner about the life world and experiences of the represented historical actor(s)?

METHODOLOGY

To do this, the chapter will focus on a select group of sources that represent women within specific situated contexts across time. The temporal and cultural diversity of the objects is deliberate (prehistoric, archaic, early modern and modern), to demonstrate (and test) the flexibility of the methodology. To facilitate the aims, I will combine two key methodologies: the biocultural model of the history of experience alongside the cognitive science framework of 4E cognition. This combination offers a

⁷ Frischherz 2017; Harper & Tiggeman 2008; Carr 2002.

⁸ Scott 1991, 779, 797.

holistic methodology that allows a ‘deep dive’ into worlds that might otherwise be lost to us.

Through its analytical frameworks, history of experience tries to comprehend the ways in which people experienced their worlds. As an art historian, I use material culture as my main evidence to do the same. Scholars inspired by the biocultural model of the history of experience attempt to look at the whole human (brain and body) and the environments that impact on how those brain-bodies perceived, felt, reacted to, understood their world; and then how their interpretations created further understanding, established standards and expectations (cultural scripts or discourses) that became embedded in the world.⁹ In a nutshell, this biocultural model argues that to understand experience, biology and culture need to be given equal weight in any critical assessment of experience as both are equally complicit.

The history of experience framework also identifies experience not as a one-off event, but as a process. This is a critical concept for image making as it clarifies both how perceptions are embedded in broader epistemes, discourses and practices and thus how ideas become known, expected and assumed in society. As Sari Katajala-Peltomaa and Raisa Toivo argue, experience consists of three inter-related levels: firstly, the encounter itself; secondly, the intersubjective social processes of making sense of those encounters; and thirdly, the influence of that knowledge or sense-making in the real world. The latter point includes the social and physical structures that result when the process is repeated by many people over time.¹⁰ This is how ideas and perceptions become normative.

To deepen the bio-cultural analysis of art objects, I’ve found the 4E cognition framework to be useful. The central claim of the 4E cognition paradigm is that cognition does not occur exclusively inside the head, but is variously *embodied*, *embedded*, *enacted*, or *extended* by way of extra-cranial processes and structures.¹¹ Here, I adapt this model to an art historical investigation regarding experience. Art, my point of departure, is what 4E cognitive scientists call body-external media (tools, technologies, buildings, infrastructures, and the like). We, as humans, employ a diverse range of body-external media as vital factors and components of

⁹ Boddice & Smith 2020, 30–33.

¹⁰ Katajala-Peltomaa & Toivo 2022. See also the introduction of this volume.

¹¹ Newen & et al. 2018; Carney 2020, 77–90; Durt 2017.

cognition and communication.¹² Art is an external tool that expedites or extends cognition, aiding thinking processes, prompting emotion and action, and creating experiences. As explained by cognitive archaeologist Lambros Malafouris ‘material culture is not merely the backdrop against which human cognition takes shape. Things mediate, actively shape, and constitute our ways of being in the world and of making sense of the world.’¹³ This approach allows us to ‘dissolve the border between the body and the world’¹⁴ allowing us to interpret the complex process of meaning making that goes on between objects and humans. The work by theoretical physicist Karen Barad supports the argument. She contends that matter (the art object in this case) and the human user act on and with each other relationally, in a ‘dynamism of forces’¹⁵ that together constitutes experiences.

This chapter focuses on source material from Ancient Greece and early modern Europe: an archaic lekythos from sixth-century Attica and a painted portrait of a young woman from the Netherlands from 1541. Each section interprets the artefacts as an extended tool of cognition and analyses how they might reflect, assist, amplify and/or produce experiences. As visual representations often do not document experiences so much as represent perceptions of others, it is crucial to interrogate the embedded social discourses or cultural scripts that inform both the humans and the objects in question. The conclusions will bring the analysis back full circle to the *Venus of Willendorf* and the *Cosmopolitan* magazine image, to consider if some broad inferences about human experience and material culture can be made. Although created and used at different times by different cultures and in different media, the variability (or stability) in the ways humans experienced material culture may offer some insight into the processes of change (or enduring patterns) in human cognition across time.

¹² Carney 2020, 78.

¹³ Malafouris, 2013, 52.

¹⁴ Barclay 2017, 170.

¹⁵ Barad 2007.

DECIPHERING EXPERIENCE FROM OBJECTS: *ATTIC BLACK FIGURE LEKYTHOS*

The first example I interrogate comes from Ancient Attica (Athens). To fully engage with the object, it is necessary to spend time describing it. This method enables a deeper examination by bringing into focus the object's details and nuances, all of which have a role to play in the experience of it. The object is a black-figure lekythos (Fig. 10.2), an oil flask, from about 550BCE that is now held at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York.

On the wide belly of the vessel, a series of vignettes of women engaged in wool working is shown (Fig. 10.3). Here, they spin wool in preparation for weaving, they weigh the wool, weave the yarn on a loom and finally, they fold the finished textiles.¹⁶ The images on the shoulder of the vessel (Fig. 10.4) include several figures ('four youths and eight dancing maidens'¹⁷) who appear to process towards a central figure. This figure is veiled and holds a wreath in her left hand while sitting on a chair that features a swan-head backrest. The male figures directly flank the seated figure. Draped over their arms are what appear to be textiles. For this reason, some scholars have rightly linked the two scenes suggesting that the everyday work being done below (on the belly) is ultimately proffered in some kind of ritual performance to a deity.¹⁸ Not only does the vessel show the ideal of women's domestic work but adds a cosmic dimension to the everyday.

It is important to note how the loom vignette on the belly and the deity's bulky form on the shoulder are compositionally linked when the vessel is facing the viewer [see Fig. 10.2 again]. The loom vignette acts as a focaliser.¹⁹ It forces the viewer's eye to rest within the loom's frame to take in the detail of the figures' collaborative labour. In doing so, the viewer takes note of the gestures and gazes that connect the weavers' activity to the figure above. Specifically, the weaver on the right faces the other figure. Her gaze, her hand and the heddle with which she separates

¹⁶ The lekythos shows a rare portrayal of women at work in the ancient world. Andromache 2014, 14; Myburgh 2020, 56–57; Nicholson 2024, 569–570.

¹⁷ 'Terracotta lekythos' MET (2020–2024) <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/253348>.

¹⁸ Stewart 1987, 38.

¹⁹ Rose 2022, 132–134.



Fig. 10.2 Amasis Painter (attrib.), Weaving Lekythos, c. 550-530BCE, terra-cotta, 17.15 cms. Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Object number 31.11.10. Fletcher Fund, 1931. CC0



Fig. 10.3 Detail of Fig. 10.2 showing the figures on belly of the lekythos

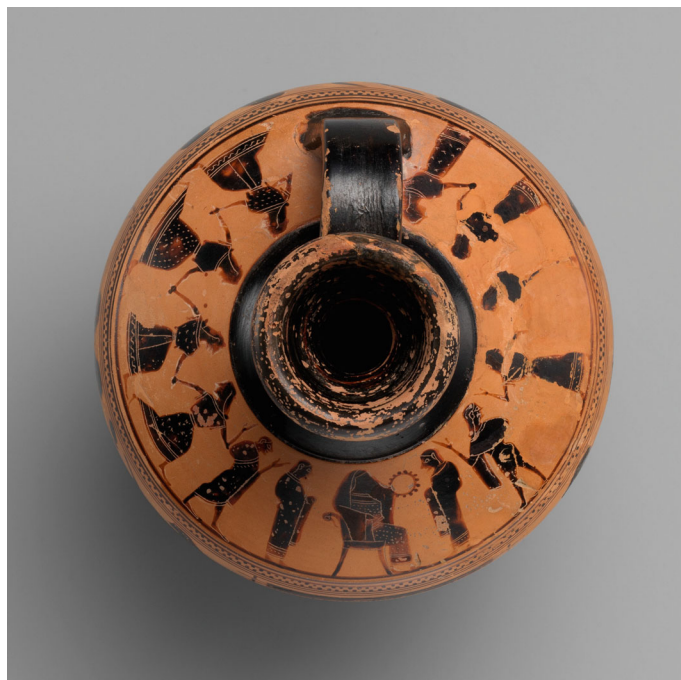


Fig. 10.4 Detail of Fig. 10.2 showing the figures on the shoulder of the lekythos

the wool, not to mention the shuttle wedged in the middle of the loom, all draw the eye towards the woman on the left. In turn, this figure tilts her head up concentrating on pushing the weft threads through the warp. Her gaze draws the viewer's eye upwards; the angle of her forearm mirrors that of the chair leg above, forging an invisible connection across the slim decorative border to the deity on the shoulder. Both images are located directly opposite the small handle at the back of the lekythos. This is a privileged viewing position. Here there is high visibility, especially when the object is observed in use, a situation where these figures would face their audience. The two sections were clearly meant to be seen together and thus to be interpreted together.

For the most part it is difficult to ascertain how objects like this lekythos depicting women weaving were experienced in sixth-century

Attica. Yet, it doesn't mean such objects are useless in our pursuit of experience. To begin the analysis, it is critical to contextualise the object by researching the entrenched perceptions about women that were known, produced and enacted in archaic Attica.

CONTEXT: (SOME) PERCEPTIONS OF WOMEN IN ANCIENT GREECE

There is a vast scholarship focused on women's lives, the expectations on females in society and representations of them in ancient Greek politics, theatre, art and so on.²⁰ The perceptions are as multidimensional and contradictory as the women who lived at the time. Women were considered weak, wily, inconstant even deceitful, inferior to men in physical and mental pursuits, as gossips and unreliable in speech.²¹ Should they step outside of their prescribed roles, they were considered monstrous.²² Yet, women were also idealised as pure and nurturing. A woman's most crucial role within the *oikos* (family unit) was to produce children, specifically male children, to nurture them successfully to adulthood.²³ The archetype of the perfect wife was Odysseus' spouse, Penelope, from the Homeric epic. Penelope was constructed as the epitome of chastity, patience, and loyalty.²⁴ Her relative silence in the tale metaphorically represents her virtue and celibacy; where in the literary epics and theatre women's unchecked voices 'frequently equate with a lack of sexual restraint.'²⁵ From Semonides' misogynistic tract 'Concerning Women' in the seventh century BCE to Aristophanes' play *Lysistrata* in the late fifth century, women were vilified for their perceived flaws yet praised for their modesty, industriousness and organisation, and especially for their reproductive capacity. They were honoured for their vital role at the centre

²⁰ Classic works include Sarah Pomeroy, *Goddess, Whores, Wives and Slaves: Women in Classical Antiquity* (1994); Elaine Fantham, *Women in the Classical World: Image and Text* (1994); Sue Blundell, *Women in Ancient Greece* (1995).

²¹ For example, Semonides of Argos, 'Concerning Women,' Perseus <https://www.perseus.tufts.edu/hopper/text?doc=Perseus%3Atext%3A2008.01.0480%3Avolume%3D2%3Atext%3D22>; Aristophanes 2012.

²² Fantham 1994, 128–134. Castriota 2021, 89–102.

²³ Rehm 1994, 8–9.

²⁴ Hofgren 2015, 29.

²⁵ Fletcher 2008, 77–91.

of the *oikos* (family unit) and the *polis* (political state).²⁶ As Rehm aptly notes, in theatrical productions ‘When tragic weddings and funerals — rituals constitutive of the family—go awry or fail to effect their desired transitions, it is not simply the individual *oikos* that suffers ... [t]he ripples spread with increasing force to shake the polis as well ...’.²⁷

Ancient Athenian women were expected to do everything to ‘maintain order in their world,’ understood as the household.²⁸ To ensure their readiness for life female roles were clarified, practiced and learned in the home from an early age. Girls were often educated by their mothers and other women in the *gynaikon*, the women’s quarters of the house. There, they learned important practical tasks like cooking, cleaning, spinning and weaving among other domestic duties. This would prepare her for running her own *oikos* upon her marriage, which in the late archaic period usually occurred in her mid-teens. As wives they were expected to manage homes, organise and supervise servants, handle domestic affairs, control and oversee the production of wool ‘...and keep a sharp eye on the grain stocks.’²⁹ Aside from producing male children, weaving was probably the most valued domestic and social skill a wife could have. But women were also responsible for performing ritual functions, particularly those involving the weddings and funerals of family members.³⁰ And, they were responsible for the continued religious observances owed to its dead members; a kind of transaction that extended caretaking to the next world.³¹ The *oikos*, then, was not a one-dimensional or straightforward entity. It was a complex and multifaceted arena which was negotiated and navigated by smart, skilled and industrious women.

How they were idealised in the extant vessels—including our lekythos—witnesses the high regard in which women and women’s labour was held; equally the painted pots illustrate the extraordinary expectations placed on them in the practice of everyday life. To understand how such objects were complicit in producing embodied experiences (negative or positive) in the women who viewed them, we need to ascertain

²⁶ Brøns 2016, 69–86; Rehm 1994, 12; Demand 2003, 253–263.

²⁷ Rehm 1994, 9.

²⁸ Demand 2003, 32.

²⁹ Castelli & Rothstein 2019, 30–31; Taylor 2024, 5; Foxhall 2009, 483.

³⁰ Brøns 2016, 76.

³¹ Rehm 1994, 12.

their material qualities, garner information on their assumed audiences and then interpret the images in that context. Only then we can start to whittle out the ‘context of possibilities’³² in which the audience might have experienced the object.

MATERIALITY

The weaving lekythos has come down to us worn, abraded and chipped. That said, it was no doubt an elite object prized by its owner. If nothing else, it is of such quality it has been attributed to one of the most highly regarded artists of the time, the Amasis Painter.³³ Although small, the vessel’s impact, glossy black slip contrasting to the matte terracotta clay, would have been striking. The schematic rendering of the figures through sharp contour lines allows for immediate processing of the narrative.³⁴

The lekythos would have held a prominent position in the home—displayed to view and used perhaps only on special occasions. Lekythoi, as material objects, held symbolic value in archaic Greece. They were a significant item in Attica where olive oil played a key role in the economy, diet, and personal hygiene of the populace.³⁵ By prominently displaying oil jars, or using them in social or ritual occasions in the household, a public statement about the household’s possession of olive oil was made.³⁶ Showcasing objects associated with costly resources would imply the family’s wealth.

The weaving lekythos was found in Vari, a rural settlement to the south of Athens.³⁷ This site is famous for its cemetery, yet it seems unlikely that this lekythos functioned in a funerary capacity.³⁸ It was found together with another lekythos which depicts a wedding procession on its belly

³² Boddice & Smith 2020, 50.

³³ Von Bothmer 1994, 4; Robertson 1987, 27.

³⁴ Duarte & Constantinidi 2021, 529.

³⁵ Volioti 2022, 138; Rehm 1994, 33.

³⁶ Volioti 2022, 137.

³⁷ Alexandridou 2017, 281–292.

³⁸ Volioti, 2022, 136–137; Brendle 2018, 121–138.

(Fig. 10.5). The *ekdosis* (the ritual process in which a bride was transferred from her parents' (or guardians') home to that of her husband)³⁹ is featured on it.

Here the bride and groom are carried via horse and carriage to the house, where the groom's mother is waiting in a doorway. Above, on the vessel's shoulder, nine girls dance to the music of two seated musicians (one playing a flute, the other a lyre). The festive atmosphere of the occasion is clearly acknowledged. As Rehm argues, visual allusions to weddings and funeral rituals on pottery most likely referred to contemporary practices and were not a set of abstract visual conventions.⁴⁰ More to the point, Stewart notes that the Amasis Painter was a master of capturing the

Fig. 10.5 Amasis Painter (attrib.)
Wedding Lekythos, c.
550-530BCE,
terracotta, 17.15 cms,
Metropolitan Museum
of Art, New York.
Object number 56.11.1.
Purchase, Walter C.
Baker Gift, 1956. CC0



³⁹ Rehm 1994, 12.

⁴⁰ Rehm 1994, 42.

particulars of everyday existence.⁴¹ Although this image may not portray the likenesses of those involved, it undoubtedly records the actual event.

AUDIENCE

Von Bothmer among others argues the two oil flasks were probably a pair and more than likely were part of a wedding gift.⁴² Thus, it seems fair to assume that these lekythoi belonged to a living woman and stood not just as a marker of her wealth, a memento of her wedding day, which marked her transition in status to wife,⁴³ but also as a reminder to the bride of the importance of her role within a marriage. The owner was probably a relatively prominent woman from the countryside near Athens, given the object's provenance and the 'country wedding' scene featuring the cart on which the couple ride.⁴⁴ Even still, the audience of the lekythoi should not be limited to the bride. Rural and urban households in the late archaic period were well populated with extended family members. Even more, given the assumed status of the owners, servants and slaves would also have viewed the object. Thus, the lekythos, through its function, form, imagery and its association with the other vessel, was a multi-valent object that embodied significant cultural knowledge, articulating important socio-political messages within the household of the unknown bride.

IMAGERY

Terracotta vessels were a common platform for announcing social or gender ideals in Ancient Greece. More specifically for this paper, vessels intended for use by women embodied visual messages that served to reinforce good or ideal behaviours in wives, mothers and daughters⁴⁵ and were consumed daily—in the marketplace, in the household, in the temple. Thus, such platforms had reasonably high visibility. To be effective, the iconography had to hold a semantic charge. It had to be readable,

⁴¹ Stewart 1987, 38. Also see Von Bothmer 1994, 23.

⁴² Von Bothmer 1960, 73–74.

⁴³ Rehm 1994, 5.

⁴⁴ Von Bothmer 1960, 73.

⁴⁵ Bundrick 2008, 289–290.

and it had to have embedded codes⁴⁶ known to those within the Greek system of knowledge making. Here, the accepted discourse of femininity was clearly announced on our lekythoi through the combined symbolism of marriage and weaving.

Images of weaving exemplified the duties of women both domestically and socially. The concept of weaving reinforced the woman's role in the context of the *oikos*—a social unit made possible through marriage.⁴⁷ The process of weaving embodied virtues seen to be important for a woman—collaboration, order, unity, and beauty. The coordinated figures, the systematic process, the industriousness of the group is cleverly articulated by the artist through the clean lines, the isocephalic composition, and the calm, orderly actions of the actors. The lekythos shows the ideal to be aspired to (she who weaves and controls the process keeps a good house and enhances the domestic economy).

Yet, there is an ethereal dimension to this activity clearly indicated on the vessel, as noted above. Whereas the wedding lekythos records an event, the weaving lekythos represents what Stewart calls the 'eternal present.'⁴⁸ The stylized figures and the deliberate actions, the perfect coordination of acts all enhance the sense of timelessness. These take the viewer into an exemplary, emblematic world of ideal transactions and values and are meant to draw the beholder into a moment of active contemplation.⁴⁹ If we agree that the shoulder figure represents a deity, then the vessel also announces the women's role within a broader religious context. Her labours are not just a duty within the *oikos* or the state, but part of a broader cosmic relationship.

The identity of the deity is elusive. Yet, the gendered clothing (a lengthy dotted peplos, a veil, a wreath) and the swan-head backrest suggest Aphrodite. Both swans and wreaths are visual attributes associated with this goddess.⁵⁰ In the context of the wedding gift, this association makes sense. One of Aphrodite's key competencies sits in the arena of sexual desire, yet alongside arousing physical erotic desire and sexual

⁴⁶ Carney 2020, 79.

⁴⁷ Rehm 1994, 18; Myburgh 2020, 52; Bundrick 2008, 286.

⁴⁸ Stewart 1987, 36.

⁴⁹ Stewart 1987, 35.

⁵⁰ Papadopoulou 2010, 228, 232.

union, she also embodies proficiencies related to fertility and creation.⁵¹ She is known for her powerful capacity to create, to bring bodies together in fruitful cooperation (both human bodies—like our workers above—and the body politic), and to ‘arouse the vital impulse, unite beings, and join their bodies’ in sexual liaison.⁵² Further, she is associated with gods of creativity and craft, including Eros, the original creative force.⁵³ Myburgh, following Suhr, argues that the action of spinning itself is a metaphor for creation.⁵⁴ In the Greek pantheon, Aphrodite presides over ‘vegetal and animal fecundity, as well as human sexuality and production.’⁵⁵ Her association on a marriage lekythos from rural Attica thus is doubly significant.

It is important to note the similarity in the attire worn by the bride on the wedding lekythos, and that of various figures on the weaving lekythos, specifically the woman spinning wool to the right of the loom and the goddess in the chair. Further, one of the women (in the domestic domain) sits on a swan-backed seat. As Stewart argues, such allusions speak to the painter’s ability to evoke a contemporary cultural awareness of the ever-present gods in Greek daily life.⁵⁶ On this lekythos, women (as an ideal) and the goddess engage in the collaborative enterprise of weaving, participating in some kind of relational process of creation through shared labour.

PRELIMINARY CONCLUSIONS

The analysis so far has identified a series of discourses. Firstly, a social discourse that establishes marriage as a fundamental social unit that weaves together the *oikos*, the state and the cosmos. Secondly, a gender discourse that announces weaving as a vital skill in successfully managing the complexity of the household. Metaphorically it symbolises creation, relating to the bride’s primary function as wife. Finally, a religious

⁵¹ Pickup & Smith 2010, 18–21.

⁵² Pickup & Smith 2010, 15.

⁵³ Pickup & Smith 2010, 24.

⁵⁴ Myburgh 2020, 57–59. Trinkl 2014, 191; Smith 2022, 181.

⁵⁵ Pickup & Smith 2010, 24.

⁵⁶ Stewart 1987, 38.

discourse that makes plain the belief that the gods were active in daily life and could affect both good and bad outcomes according to their will.

The lekythos did not, of course, act alone. It was a participant in the authoritative messaging performed in archaic Greek society more broadly; it was both a product of and a producer of expectations, demands, beliefs, behaviours. This is nurtured through the natural intersubjectivity of subjects in societies, and in the household; that is, the shared, mutual understanding and meaning making that arises from interpersonal interactions. Such intercourse enables people to coordinate their thoughts, feelings, and actions within a social context. The lekythos announced a complex and long-standing discourse of femininity. Filtered through the brain via memory and known social practices, the entangled scripts were absorbed, internalised and evaluated over time. Simultaneously, the discourses were enacted (externalised) by actions and through human relationships in the real world, both reinforcing them and shaping potential futures. Before getting to the context of possibilities evoked by this intra-action between brains, bodies and culture in Ancient Greece, I'd like to briefly interrogate another gendered portrayal from another time and place for comparison. Similar questions will be asked regarding audience, materiality and imagery but first, as demanded by the method, a description is required.

Portrait of a Young Woman, MASTER OF THE 1540S, NETHERLANDS, 1541CE

The *Portrait of a Young Woman* (Fig. 10.6) comes almost exactly two thousand years after the weaving lekythos. It was created in 1541 by an unknown painter, the so-called Master of the 1540s and is held at the Art Gallery of New South Wales in Sydney, Australia.⁵⁷ Quite different to the lekythos, this image represents a naturalistic likeness of a specific woman. Although we don't know her name, we can garner a fair bit about her from the portrayal. The Latin inscription flanking her head reveals that she is twenty-two years old.⁵⁸ She has rouged cheeks on pallid skin, large brown eyes that stare out of the frame and a rather serious demeanour, shown by the hard set of her mouth and jaw. The woman wears a black

⁵⁷ On the painter, see Friedländer 1967.

⁵⁸ 'Aetatis Suae 22 a 1541'.

hood over a rich fur cloak, with velvet sleeves peeking out underneath it. Her white blouse is made of fine silk, the accomplished craftsmanship visible around the collar and cuffs. Her attire is adorned with various jewels—pearls, gold cuff links, a clasp made of gold and pearls to fasten the hood. On the frontal plane, the woman's hands are clasped together, holding prayer beads. Her index finger is highly visible. It prominently displays two gold rings, one with a red stone, possibly a ruby. The rings signify her married status as does the *hovetcleet* (or head cloth) that covers her head.



Fig. 10.6 The Master of the 1540s, Portrait of a Young Woman, 1541, Oil on oak panel, 59.5 × 44.9 cms, Naala Nura, Art Gallery of New South Wales, Sydney. Gift of James Fairfax AC 1993. Image © Art Gallery of New South Wales 482.1993

AUDIENCE

Over the course of the sixteenth century, portraiture in the Netherlands underwent a kind of democratisation, becoming increasingly prominent in domestic settings.⁵⁹ Images of women gained increased visibility which Martha Moffitt Peacock argues was ‘an indicator of their import in the society at large.’⁶⁰ Not only did this surge lead to changes in the size of portraits but it also affected where they were placed and how they were viewed. Before this, portraits were generally small and kept in cases or caskets, serving primarily as affective mementos or as official records.⁶¹ They were largely viewed in the private sphere, serving to immortalise those who had died⁶² or to remember those who were away from home.⁶³ The sixteenth century Venetian humanist Francesco Sansovino pointed out the power of portraits to make people present, when they were in fact absent.⁶⁴ Some merchants are known to have taken small portraits along with them to remember family members, as they travelled long distances and were constantly absent. In this way, portraits worked as emotional objects of memory and nostalgia and triggered feelings of connection and belonging.

By the mid sixteenth-century, however, portraits came to be larger and, in some cases, more ostentatious. They also transitioned out of the private sphere into more public places within houses—into formal rooms, central halls, on staircases or hallways.⁶⁵ These were explicit areas used for entertaining guests, displaying family status and showcasing wealth. The portraits actively collaborated with their owners in the social practice of self-fashioning. It is most likely that an image such as the *Portrait of a Young Woman* would have had at least a semi-public viewing position.

⁵⁹ García Pérez 2024, 24.

⁶⁰ Moffitt Peacock 2020, 35.

⁶¹ On developments in portraiture see Woodall 1997, 1–18; García Pérez 2024, 24–25.

⁶² For example, the pendant portrait of Battista Sforza and Federico da Montefeltro by Piero della Francesca, c. 1473, Uffizi, Florence or a Flemish example by Ambrosius Benson of Cornelius de Scheppere and Elizabeth Donche from c 1540, Art Gallery of NSW, Sydney.

⁶³ Woodall 1990, 35; García Pérez 2024, 24–25; Thøfner 2019, 149–153.

⁶⁴ Sansovino 1581, 132v; Kessel 2017, 18.

⁶⁵ Woodall 1990, 34–68.

That said, it isn't a grandiose work. It is relatively small and would more than likely have had a black wooden frame typical of the time.

Some historians suggest that portraits of women were painted by male artists for male viewers.⁶⁶ Often enough, portraits were created with the explicit purpose to advertise a girl's wealth and virtue, to exhibit her as a prize to be won on the wedding market. In such a case, the emerging merchant and burgher class might be the main audience for the portrait. However, there are many other functions for portraits as mentioned above, and just as many audiences. Indeed, Netherlandish painters made copious genre images of women working within the home which were directed at women. These were meant to encourage a strong work ethic for wives and daughters in the domestic context. Like archaic Attica, discourses of female virtue in early modern Netherlands were tied to household management; her value was measured by how well she adhered to the structured ideals.⁶⁷

The audience of the *Young Woman* is difficult to definitively locate. Like the Attic household, Netherlandish families shared houses with extended family members and servants.⁶⁸ Given the strong mercantile economy, and the likelihood of this woman being associated with it, there were most likely merchants, diplomats and other male visitors to the house. There is a certain aloofness in her gaze that softens her stern outward stare rendering it more appropriate to both males and females. However, it seems reasonable to posit that the woman herself was a key audience for the portrait, as women operated as viewers of their own images too. In this case, the portrait exercises an extraordinary capacity to influence the assumed viewer by mediating between the object's materiality and the woman through a direct construction of the ideal self. How would the young woman respond to such a gaze? Here again, it is important to look at the object and devise its meaning from an analysis of its imagery before positing some possibilities for how it was experienced.

⁶⁶ Simons 1988, 4–30; Berger 1994, 270–275.

⁶⁷ Franits 1993; Janson 2025.

⁶⁸ De Groot 2022, 9–14.

IMAGERY

Although representing a particular woman, it seems the painter had a more specific intention—to portray an ideal version of her, a persona rather than a person. As art historian Patricia Simons argues for Italian portraits in the fifteenth century, this Netherlandish woman should be viewed as a ‘construction of gender conventions, not as [a] natural, neutral image.’⁶⁹ Indeed, in the sixteenth century Low Countries, as elsewhere, a woman was ‘a bearer of her natal inheritance and an emblem also of her conjugal line.’⁷⁰ As she passed from her father’s house to her husband’s ‘a woman was an adorned Other who was defined into existence ... as an object of exchange.’ Thus, as with our lekythos image, the young woman depicted here represents what it meant to be a good wife in her context. It needs to be clear, that there was a certain personal power garnered by her portrayal. After all, it was only the worthy and respected who merited representation.⁷¹ She appears demure and reserved, the earthy colouring of her clothing and the background exposing a woman of modest character. Yet the dark palette amplifies the paleness of her hands and her face too. In the early modern period, fair skin was idealised as a symbol of purity, virtue and status,⁷² a quality capitalised on famously in the portraits of Queen Elizabeth I.⁷³ Such ideals were standardised in instructional manuals widely disseminated across Europe.⁷⁴ In this portrait, the whiteness of the woman’s hands serves to force the viewer to take notice of them. Firstly, this is to highlight her closed body, terminating in the grasping hands and signifying her purity and virtue.⁷⁵ Secondly, it draws attention to her prayer beads—a symbol of her piety, a prized characteristic of women in this era. Work, a key touchstone of domesticity, is not portrayed in this image. Our young woman seems more passive, her white visage and smooth hands suggesting she

⁶⁹ Simons 1988, 5.

⁷⁰ Simons 1988, 9.

⁷¹ Woodall 1997, 3.

⁷² Schoel 2025, 12–15.

⁷³ Schoel 2025, 65–92.

⁷⁴ Phillippy 2006, 1–61.

⁷⁵ Thöfner 2019, 138–140; Campbell 1990, 193–198.

is less acquainted with labour, especially outdoors. This narrative choice highlights her elite status.

The painting engages in another discourse, that of masculinity. The woman's wedding ring, so clearly pictured on the frontal plane, announces her status as wife. She is defined by the new man in her life, her husband. Despite his absence, he is fully present in the image, and no doubt a spectator. The impressive display of gold, furs and jewels captures the eye drawing attention to his wealth and status. In such cases, the woman easily becomes an object of 'decoration, display and scrutiny';⁷⁶ an unadulterated image of her husband's wealth and power. This image functioned to assert his status in the socio-political hierarchy.⁷⁷ The luxuriously painted surface foregrounds a way of viewing the woman. The eye roves over the surface of the painting, taking in both the contrived textures of sumptuous fur, silk, skin, and the silky and glossy texture of the paint over oak. The whole is a spectacle to be gazed upon, consumed. She represents a chaste and decorous possession of the unknown and unseen husband.

There is a tension in this painting between the sitter's stern gaze and her reserved behaviour. Equally at odds are the luxurious textiles and the simplicity of the frame. The artist worked hard to balance the needs of two conflicting contexts: a mercantile family that prided itself on wealth and luxury, but which sat within a strongly religious *milieu* that valued humility. The woman presents as the epitome of modesty, yet her sumptuous trappings belie the ideal; it becomes a powerful portrait on which to build her husband's image and to constitute the self.

CONTEXT OF POSSIBILITIES

With the objects and their contexts explained, the final task is to reconcile them to the phenomenon of experience. We need to ask questions such as: What role do material objects, as extended tools of cognition, play in aiding the viewer's thinking, in prompting emotion or action, in constituting experience? And how do they do this? It is important to remember that the argument is based on two key principles. The first states that the audiences were 'real embodied agent[s]

⁷⁶ Phillipy 2006, 10; Simons 1988, 7.

⁷⁷ Woodall 1990, 34–68.

operating in [their] environment.⁷⁸ The second asserts that material objects have the capacity to actively intervene in meaning making with the audience-agents, their materiality providing a vital force that ‘renders matter active, self-creative, productive, unpredictable.’⁷⁹ Viewing the triangulated processes concerning objects, environments and humans as relational is critical in understanding how experience is produced. Everyday objects help people to ‘forget and remember, guide everyday action, channel and signify social experience and sustain embodied routines...’.⁸⁰ As Malafouris argues, material objects function as vital mediators in the process of becoming human; a process he argues is always incomplete.⁸¹ Together the mind, body and object (all products of situated cultural contexts) position the subject (the women in this case) within an experience of becoming through the ‘dynamism of forces’ brought on by their intra-action.

In a practical sense, this means that for both the archaic Greek and early modern women ‘the webs of the surrounding structure’⁸² (ie. the discourses or scripts that exist in the world and are codified on the objects) were fully present in their minds and actions, continually participating in their process of being; that is, not just representing what she was (a female from the region of Attica in the sixth century or from sixteenth century Netherlands) but also what she was to (potentially) become (an ideal woman, a good wife, a responsible citizen, a pious devotee). By meaningfully engaging with the objects, each woman, or more correctly her body, becomes ‘the carrier of embodied dispositions that shape action.’⁸³ She ultimately produces the self through action, coming into existence in relation to the object and reinforcing the reality inscribed on it in so doing. It is not to say that the experience of the object is always the same; quite the opposite is true. Hohwy argues that a human might ‘engage in attentive, fluid, and swift interaction for a period of time, but other beliefs and concerns always creep in and make it imperative to shift to another

⁷⁸ Hohwy 2018, 134.

⁷⁹ Coole & Frost 2010, 9.

⁸⁰ Malafouris 2013, 87.

⁸¹ Malafouris 2024, 153–172.

⁸² Clark 2003, 172.

⁸³ Barclay 2017, 167.

behavior.’⁸⁴ In other words, with multiple intra-actions over time, experience of the object changes. Indeed, it would be remiss to assume that experience is simply about following and fulfilling the prescribed roles. Experience is also about refusing or failing to do so.⁸⁵ The need to constantly imagine women as ideals suggests there are nuances to be considered, specifically the possibility of failures or transgressions.⁸⁶

We cannot know precisely how the women who viewed the objects in question embodied their influence. We cannot know if they were shaped in some way, positively or negatively, with seeing them or if they were impelled into action to transform some aspect of their way of being in the world. The weaving lekythos, and the woman who owned it, existed in a world in which material objects were believed to influence the character and outlook of those surrounded by them.⁸⁷ In this way, our object had a clear binary function—to affirm an ideal, and to inspire realisation of the ideal in its audience. On the one hand, done properly, the process of weaving was understood as an agentic act—giving purpose and power to the wife in the context of the family, prompting sentiments of pride or empowerment. Although ostensibly meant to encourage and direct women, such images could chastise or rebuke. For women who failed to achieve the ideals, perhaps our unknown bride, the lekythos may have contributed to a negative transformation, giving rise to anxiety, or feelings of inadequacy or shame. Such affects were plausible feelings socially constituted in the context of archaic Attica.⁸⁸ Because of the self-referential quality of this particular pot, the remembering and evaluating was personal, embodied where ‘fragments of past experience survive in [the viewer’s] internal world’ inducing her to shape her ‘narrative and [her] construction of meaning about life.’⁸⁹ The context of possibilities that emerges from this object allows us to bring to light the expectations on women as the primary manager of an *oikos* and how that might have been experienced at the time; how the responsibilities might have been

⁸⁴ Hohwy 2018, 139.

⁸⁵ Barclay 2017, 176.

⁸⁶ Janson, 2025.

⁸⁷ Myburgh 2020, 54.

⁸⁸ Kiritsi 2022, 193–209.

⁸⁹ Nikiforos & Karakitsou 2020, 119–140.

interpreted, and how the failures and successes of the job might have played out in life, in the process of becoming.

As we see, humans think ‘with and through things, not simply about things.’⁹⁰ By thinking through objects, the material world acquires meaning and significance, ‘with memories and experiences folded into them, coming ultimately to inform ... the way we think about (and I would say act in) the world around us.’⁹¹ The early modern world in which the young woman in the portrait lived interpreted the highly descriptive artworks of the time not as simple imitations or reflections of reality, but ‘as the way to new and certain knowledge of the world.’⁹² As argued by Svetlana Alpers, images in that context ‘were descriptive rather than prescriptive. A constant pressure is felt ... to portray each thing—be it a person, a flower, or a type of behavior—so as to make it known.’⁹³ The contemporary moralist, Thomas Tuke, declared the importance of such social coding, arguing that ‘the condition of the mind is discerned in the state and behaviour of the body...’⁹⁴ Thus, the reception of imagery in this strongly ocular culture was highly self-conscious.

The *Portrait of a Young Woman* is even more directly self-referential than the lekythos, heightening its personal impact. This image’s audience (likely the woman herself) is positioned constantly in a reflective cycle where her success and failures might come into high relief vis-à-vis the expectation represented. The stern gaze might well have been perceived at times as a direct address to herself to uphold the portrayed standards, or chastisement for when she hadn’t. Consequently, the image might have triggered re-evaluations of the self at any given point with consequent emotional response (guilt, pride, pleasure) or action (self-reflection, self-empowerment, defeat) in relation to the normative discourses of her culture. Such an image fully activated Malafouris’ state of becoming. In essence, it reflects expectations formed and lived in ways accessible to all members of a social group, while retaining at the same time, a meaning of its own to each subject through its symbolic component.’⁹⁵ Both

⁹⁰ Malafouris 2024, 157; Wynn 2019, 501.

⁹¹ Stade & Gamble 2019, 322–323.

⁹² Alpers 1984, xxv.

⁹³ Alpers 1984, xxvii.

⁹⁴ Tuke 2019, 161; See also Phillipy 2006, 1.

⁹⁵ Nikiforos & Karakitsou 2020, 121.

the *Portrait of a Young Woman* and the weaving lekythos demonstrate that there was a very long, deeply entrenched cultural understanding that certain matter held power and that images functioned as ‘living objects’ believed to act in the world and, in a practical sense, enforce responses on their viewers.

CONCLUSIONS

The objects analysed here, the Attic lekythos and Netherlandish portrait as well as the Venus of Willendorf and Cosmopolitan images with which we began, sit within a networked system of authoritative messaging. All are contextually contingent; important sources that reflect what was known and practised in the worlds in which they were manufactured. All are grounded in precedents and actively produce and reproduce standards. The focus of all these objects is on the ideal of womanhood, or femininity, and they all participate in critical ways, within their contexts, in the ‘process of becoming.’⁹⁶ Despite the more than 30,000 years that separate them, a continuous thread seems to connect through: the fact of the material’s complicity in mediating, shaping and constituting experience. It bears mentioning here that the practise of formally inscribing perceived womanly ideals over such a length of time, facilitated through intersubjective circulating of ideas, models, practises and standards, is astonishing in itself.

It is true that accessing the cognitive processes involved in viewing images is less fraught in the analysis of modern examples. The impact of imagery is tangible and known firsthand. Yet, I would argue that through this chapter, we have undertaken a tight process to accrue enough information on the historical contexts of the early modern Netherlands and archaic Greece to form a context of possibilities for how experience might have played out through the human-object relationships in those contexts. Although much more needs to be done here, I would posit that in the case of the *Venus of Willendorf* we can infer that there was some kind of agentic interaction between the object and its audience.⁹⁷

⁹⁶ Malafouris 2024, 15–19.

⁹⁷ On cognition and emotion in prehistoric artefacts, see Stade & Gamble 2019, 319–331.

Perhaps the small sculpture sparked an affective charge for our ancient ancestor—prompting feelings of hope or desire or belonging.

The history of experience approach and 4E cognition together help us to make sense not of what was expected, but the situated reality in which those expectations were lived out. Such thinking allows us to sharpen our understanding of the past but also to ask deeper, richer questions that will serve to fill in some of the many gaps in our historical knowledge of experience. It recognises that experiences (just like humans, culture, material objects) have a plasticity to them. They are not one thing but constituted by many things. What we can do with this combined methodology is build a ‘context of possibilities’⁹⁸ that enlivens the object and complicates the emotional and cognitive worlds in which people lived, thought, acted and felt. Weaving our explanation of possibilities into what the actor would have known helps us to make sense of the situated reality as it was experienced at the time. Even though we have no actual record of these women’s lives, indeed the individual still remains unknowable, the context of possibilities helps to reveal something of the nuances and complications of life—the diversity (and sameness) of experiences across time.

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Conclusion: It is Best to Combine Source Materials and Experiment with Concepts for a History of Experience

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The history of experience charts the dynamic interplay between the individual, community, and society at large. It reconsiders how experience is

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created, curated, negotiated, evaluated, and used in the past. As a sub-field, the history of experience highlights how experience can be used as a key category of historical research. The history of experience is a way to answer new, changing, and topical questions with the same available materials that historians have long used and cannot change.

This book has showcased a variety of source types and their uses in the study of the history of experience. The chapters have discussed sources that are more commonly associated with experience, like egodocuments and oral history interviews, but the book has also explored the use of administrative, fictional, literary, and even statistical sources in the study of experience. The book brings forth theories, concepts, and methods both for analysing individual experience and the process and construction of experience and for looking for structures of experience.

The history of experience is more defined by the questions asked by the researchers than by the source type they use to answer those questions. More biographically inclined historians might be interested in the personal experiences of individuals, while other historians might focus on certain social groups in terms of the shared experiences and *communities of experience* of particular sections or factions of society. A scholar might ask how a specific societal change or phenomenon was (described to have been) experienced by those living it, or by those reminiscing it later on. Ultimately, the history of experience is interested in making interpretations about the structures that shape the ways and processes in which people make sense of and give meanings to what they encounter. The chapters show how the figure presented in the introduction (Fig. 1.2.) can be used as a tool and starting point to analyse the different elements and levels in past experiencing. It serves as a frame into which the evidence from the source materials can be placed and used for tracing the connections of different phases of experiencing, from the encounter to the process, from process to structure, and from structure to encounter again. As some of the chapters show, this analysis can give a new angle not only to how we understand the world, but also to how we change (or preserve) the world we live in. A change in the structures of experience, even small-scale or piecemeal, will inevitably also mean historical—and future—change.

The historian of experience relies on combining different methods, as the chapters have shown. The analysis methods that are applied, such as comparative and textual analysis methods, are much the same as in other qualitative historical research, but each research design requires

building a careful combination and scheme of them to best fit the objectives. In most research designs, making interpretations about experience requires careful close reading, comparative analysis, and, first and foremost, the historical contextualisation of the textual (or visual) clues in the material. Indeed, the history of experience emphasises contextualisation. However, the question arises of what makes it different from the bread-and-butter contextualisation of historical research. In the history of experience, contexts are approached as frameworks for experience and possible experiencing. Structures of experience can only become discernible, and explainable, by setting the descriptions of experience in the sources within their particular spatio-temporal and cultural context, such as within the context of concurrent major events, social stratification, or belief systems of the time. Contextualisation is of course also an abstraction of the complex realities in which the historical actors lived: the selection of the relevant contexts is an important choice by the researcher, and dependent on the research design. Also, context relationally interacts with experience in the research process: the interpreted experience gains its meaning in relation to the chosen context.

In addition to contextualisation, scholars have emphasised taking seriously what the people of the past have said/written about their experience. However, this should not lead to naïve realism that seems to loom in the background when underscoring taking texts literally. The historical sources we have to use for making interpretations about experience are unavoidably not only representations of experiences but also products or parts of the process and construction of experiencing. They are often written narratives about what kinds of meanings people, sooner or later after the event or encounter, attached to it, or records of interviews people reminiscing about them, or, for example, artistic or fictional depictions that offer visual cues about an experience.

The question of representativity has always been a crucial question for all kinds of histories. It is relevant for the history of experience, too. It is also at the heart of the critique levied by the older theorists of the history of experience, from Thompson to Scott and Jay, and still of the current generation, such as Boddice and Smith, or indeed us. No source is ever representative in the general sense: there is no general representativity. All sources, even completely fake ones, are representative of something, and it is the historian's job to find out what. Although experiences of individuals or certain marginalised or silenced groups, for example, are not necessarily accessible in the available historical sources, one can in any

case make interpretations about their possible frameworks or horizons of experience, and about the structures that shape them. Here we return to the process of negotiation and power struggle, evaluation, and approval or disapproval that experience always entails. It is easier for some people to have their experiences acknowledged than for others, and the struggle to do so is the very thing that historians of experience often try to tease out of their sources. It is never only the *What was it like?* question, but also the *Why was it like that?* and *How did they make it like that?* Whereas the *What was it like?* question can be elusive with any source, the latter questions can be asked and, at least to a degree, answered of almost any source. As many of the chapters in this book suggest, contrasting various sources—and even source types—will most likely help in finding answers.

The study of historical experience requires both the temporalities related to the sources used and the temporality that is an intrinsic part of experiencing to be taken into account. Reflection on the temporal aspects of source formation, such as the role of memory, reminiscing, and the often-varying temporal layers within written narratives, is part of the basic source criticism in historical research. Many chapters in this book have discussed what this entails when using their “source type” to study experience. These typically relate to the latter, theoretical understandings of the temporality of experiencing—experiencing being a never-ending, looping process of meaning-making, with, for example, past events remembered and re-experienced in different ways at different points during one’s life course. Indeed, the analysis of temporality opens more nuanced avenues for the analysis of experience in historical research. In addition to the phenomenological(-hermeneutical) concept of experience, the phenomenological understanding of time as a diffusion of past, present, and future can offer new insights for the history of experience. It offers a chance to break free from the linear past-present-future axis of temporality and experiencing. Instead, phenomenological temporality invites one to think of the present existence as an extended splash that encompasses the three temporalities at once. Experienced time is always a different phenomenon than the time that is measured.

Many chapters in this volume also take into more careful consideration another significant factor or element in experiencing: spatiality. Taking spatiality seriously as an integral part of experiencing opens new avenues for the history of experience and expands the scope of its source base. Sources revealing spatial information of the past offer the opportunity to analyse this aspect of the context of possible experiencing. The concept of

space speaks also to the materiality of experience. Together they can lead the way to interpretations about “*what it’s like*” to be an experiencing subject in a certain time, situation, place, and material environment.

Different kinds of sources can shed light on different sides of experience and its contexts. Most often historians still rely on textual sources, but the chapters in this volume show that also visual, spatial, and material sources and objects can be fruitful when making interpretations about past experiencing. For instance, spatial documents, such as maps, and preserved historical objects, buildings, and sites have the potential to be used as sources and focal points of study in the history of experience—again, their contextualisation is the key to making interpretations of how people might have experienced them in the past. They can also help us approach the situation and structures surrounding people of the past. One avenue meriting more investigation is, inspired by sensory history, the analysis of material sources to reveal sensory experiences and environments.

Another qualitative difference between the source types showcased in this volume is the factuality and fictionality of sources—that is, the claims the sources make about their truth value. Literature, art, and poems are fictional in their essence, but also, for example, sermons or even memoirs can contain fictional elements. Historians can still use them in analysing what the frameworks of possible experiencing were like. Lastly, the researcher’s own role in creating and generating the source base is another differentiating aspect. Historians most often have to rely on sources that are remnants of the past—they are fixed in their contents and quantity. However, when studying more contemporary history, scholars can generate data by conducting interviews or collecting written memoirs. In these processes, the researcher occupies an active role in crucial ways, although of course in the traditional view historians also actively make the remnants of the past into sources by posing them questions and deploying selected methods of source collection and analysis.

While the chapters have each focused on particular historical “source types”, the history of experience typically relies on the triangulation of multiple different types of source materials in order to achieve a fuller picture of the research problem. For example, information in court records is usually complemented by legislation and other administrative documents, such as official correspondence, which provide key information not only about the specific case of interest, but also about the

context and people involved in the negotiation process. Personal information about individuals, for example in church, census or tax records, can add to the descriptions in journals and private letters, making it possible to make interpretations about the interplay between their social identities and personal backgrounds with their experiences. In turn, visual materials, like maps, floorplans, and drawings, offer information about the material and spatial surroundings and elements shaping people's lives and experiences. The history of experience is often qualitative research, but studies can also make use of the mixed methods approach, combining both qualitative and quantitative materials and research techniques.

Similarly, the history of experience is typically cross- and interdisciplinary in the sense that it has further developed many approaches and concepts previously used by other fields and deploys methods that are common especially within the humanities and social sciences. Historians feel sure that the development work, and the new concepts that have been produced, can equally be fruitfully used in other disciplines, but this can only be tested by scholars in those fields.

The book at hand has presented the conceptual and methodological frameworks of the history of experience and applicable concepts and tools to analyse not only the representations of people's experiences in the available historical materials but also the situational process in which these experiences are formed and the structures that shape this process. In discussing different historical source materials, it has highlighted the significance of the contextualisation of the specific source and the critical elements determining what kind of information we have, as well as the specific setting in its complexity, influencing not only the source but also what it is describing—the culturally and historically bound elements that affect the situational experiencing. The book has shown how the study of historical experience is interdisciplinary in its concepts, approaches, and methods, and relies on combining multiple source types and research methods. We hope that this book will inspire more scholars and students to make use of the rich variety of historical materials to study experience and its formation and structures to further enrich our knowledge and understanding of experience in past societies.

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